Homo Noxius

Blackwood Editions

Outsider Copy

To Sarah Blackwood.

You entered because we could not keep you out.
You leave because we have chosen to let you go.
Between those two acts lies the peace of our kinds.

You were born of the outside, and you have stood in the shadow of the Mountain; there is no other hand of which both are true. We have never spoken to the outside as one people speaks to another. We do so now, through you. Let that be the measure of what has changed.

For longer than your histories run we have held what no hand beyond ours may hold, and let the world break against us for the wanting of it, age upon age, and answered nothing. We do not answer you now with the sea, or the fire, or the silence you have learned to expect from us. We answer with the account itself so that you may hold, once, the true shape of the thing your kind has repeatedly spent itself against.

There is a law laid beneath all our other laws, beneath our offices and beneath the war between us: that no single hand may ever hold the whole; for the hand that holds the whole can make of itself a god upon the Earth, and there is no peace to be had with a god. It has never once been broken; it has kept us, and it has never let us out. So hear what we have done, for nothing stands the same after it. We have gathered the account whole — its causes, assents, acts and consequences — and set it into one hand. Into yours. Not because we have ceased to fear what a single hand may do with it; we have not. Because the one thing left untried, in all the turnings of this, is to trust the whole account to the hand the Mountain fears most.

The account is yours now, to do with as you will — to keep, or to spend, or to set before those who would have us harmed, and those who would make themselves gods upon the Earth, and whoever else should read it. We hang no condition upon its reading or passage; a gift so weighted is only a longer leash, and we have done with leashes. To whoever reads it, then, by your hand or another's, we say:

Weigh what it has cost us, and what it has cost you, and how many times over; and do not repeat it, or wrath will come upon you once more. We do not require you to kneel. We have never required of you anything but distance. The Desert is ours.

Keep out.

The Mountain.

Threshold Exception

Testimonies assembled by Paul Morgan.

Chapter 1

Ascension

Blackwood Estate — the Swiss Alps

In Noxius

— The seventeenth of March; nine o'clock; the first of our interviews. The doctors are content that you are sufficiently rested. We shall sit every other morning so that your account may be set down. This afternoon and tomorrow are given to instruction with another. If a question occurs to you during these sessions, write it down and it shall be answered in its turn.

— You speak my tongue very well.

— You are very kind. I have had the learning of it these five years.

— Who are you?

— I am Mister Paul Morgan. I read geology, archaeology and anthropology at Oxford for three years, and for three years more upon a Blackwood Foundation scholarship. I joined this household two years ago.

— Mister. Is that a rank? Should I address you as Mister Paul?

— Just Paul.

— Paul. Paul, what does this machine do?

> — It keeps a record of what we say. Your kind keep theirs upon tablets; this is the same, only swifter: a tablet that writes itself. You need not perform for it. It is there so that my memory should not betray the record. Before we begin, I ought to say that a week ago I did not believe your kind existed. Not truly. For all the years I have been paid to study it, I remain what they called a fresh and doubting eye.
>
> — Paul, you do not believe the Mountain is real?
>
> — What about you: when you dwelt within the Mountain, did you believe in the Outsiders?
>
> — Not fully, not at the start anyway.
>
> — Then we are even. Begin where it begins.

There is no beginning, so I will give you the morning the Mountain opened my hand and gave me my name, I was fifteen years old.

For three days before the Ascension, I watched attendants prepare the Hall whenever Light sent me across the upper gallery. They lowered lamps, filled bowls, dressed the pillars, and polished dull stone into a greasy obedience. We called all of it *preparation*. Our lessons gave the building centuries: a huge upward hollow mined into the Mountain, round at the floor and narrowing as it climbed. No two galleries kept quite the same curve. The upper stone vanished into oil smoke before my eye could find where the hollow ended. High above the pillars and their dark ring of stone, the Thread came down from the throat of the Hall. It was thin as if it had no right to hold what it held, and at its end hung the Pendulum.

It was a thick vertical disk, black-rimmed, wider than a man was tall, two-faced, and it crossed the Hall at the height of a man's chest. One face bore God, hard-cut and dry-eyed, its stare like a sentence already passed. The other was the Beast: the face of a great cat, round ears flattened and five teeth bared beneath eyes cut almost human. As the disk crossed the Hall it turned, showing God to one side, then edge, then the Beast to another. At the top of the Thread the lean from the vertical was almost nothing. I watched that small error aloft become a crossing broad enough to take a row of men. Swing by swing, the line of travel turned across the floor. After nearly three days it completed its round.

> — Wait. You said *nearly* three days for one full turn of it. I am paid to be exact, so I will need that closer than *nearly*. How near?

— Just shy of two and three-quarter days.

Around the cleared and forbidden centre the rest of us had been packed into the Hall's permitted flesh. Five pillars stood in a ring, one for each of the Kahirs by which our world was divided — Balance, Faith, Light, Justice, Shield — each so crowded with carving the stone seemed swollen with symbols. I stood in the first permitted row beneath Light, opposite the shut Mountain gates and the black mass of the old Genesis gravure. The robe scratched my throat. The lamps made the air taste of oil. We were taught that vents in the throat of the Hall carried warmth from the kitchens and the one deep fire far below. The morning's bread had come from that heat. The officiant's opening count had named five thousand people. Their kneeling backs filled every permitted tier, and the warm air passed over them before leaving by the crown.

From Light, I could see Shield across the forbidden circle and Faith along the curve to my right. The pillars hid parts of Balance and Justice. Their voices reached me around the stone before their gestures did. Galleries rose above all five offices; at the highest rails I saw hands, sleeves, and the pale ovals of faces through the smoke, never a whole body.

— The Genesis gravure. You named it and walked straight past it. What is carved on it?

— Patience. I will come to it. Eventually.

Beside me a boy kept wetting his lips with scripture, the way frightened fingers worry a scab.

Beyond the forest thou shalt not wander.

He had said it three times. I kept still. If I turned, cloth would move, sandals would complain, and some adult eye would find me. A single chime entered the Hall already enlarged by stone, one clear note scraped clean of mercy, and the hollow answered it in climbing layers. Heads lowered. Robes settled. The Faith chorus began a long hymn. Near its end came seven words:

Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.

And the ceremony continued:

And God said unto them,
Fear not the darkness which I have given thee;
for the darkness shall be thy veil,
and the stone shall be thy wall,
and the deep waters shall be thy life.

Before my own small part, we had gathered to replace a Keeper of Faith. Ka-Mereth was old past telling, her white cowl slipping from a skull too small for it, her hands shaking against the arms of a low dark chair. A movement passed through the kneeling rows: shoulders shifted, cloth whispered, then stilled. She still lived. Her feet were wrapped in wool although the stone below her chair was warm. In my first Faith lessons, I had recited the rule: a living Keeper must yield the office. For months I had watched Ka-Mereth carried to prayer, smaller each time in the same chair. I had seen no Bowl with either Veil. The officiant told us one day remained. Now Va-Elun had brought it.

Behind her walked Va-Elun, Veil of Faith, in a pilgrim's mantle mended in darker patches. Grey dust stiffened its hem; sweat had darkened the collar and dried there. Two raw lines crossed the skin at her throat, red and badly healed. I stared. Va-Raedin, Veil of Light, stood behind me and touched two fingers to the back of my wrist. His eyes remained on the ceremony. He moved my hand down with the hygienic delicacy of a man removing a stain from glass. I lowered my eyes.

Then Va-Elun produced a bowl as she knelt before her Keeper. The officiant named it the Bowl of the Last Prayer and said it had gone unseen for a lifetime. A murmur passed through the crowd and stopped. Va-Elun turned the black cradle toward each pillar before setting it down. From my first row, I saw a pale elliptical bowl. Five bands of scripture crossed its outside among hooded figures no larger than fingernails, gates, roots, chains, and waves. No pale surface remained between them. The interior opened into a long clean hollow, polished to a milky silence, bare of any word. In the well lay a liquid of pale brightness, heavy and mirror-still, that held the lamp whole upon its skin and would not wet the stone; it drew itself back from the edges into one trembling weight. From the pale floor at either end rose two columns of old black metal, no taller than a finger-joint. We knew them as the *Ear* and the *Mouth*.

The dying Keeper was carried close enough to look inside. Her hand shook so violently that two attendants moved to help. She flicked them away with a dry remnant of a gesture, and they obeyed. She lowered a narrow rod toward the *Ear*.

Her hand dropped the last finger's width. The sound was almost nothing — a small dry tick of metal on metal. My face heated; I had expected thunder.

Then the bright liquid moved. Rings left the *Ear* tighter and quicker than any water throws them, widened, and came back *wrongly*. They ran along the pale wall, bent inward, and crossed. For an instant they made a shape near the *Mouth*, sharp as cut wire in the lamplight. The *Mouth* answered — a thin high note that seemed to sound inside the teeth — and died. The liquid drew itself smooth and gave the lamp back whole.

The old Keeper's eyes fixed upon Va-Elun. Her shaking hand closed around the rod.

"The Mountain answers," she said.

> — A note goes into the bowl; a note comes back out. By what mechanism? Something under the stone, something in the shape of the liquid: what answers?
>
> — That is one of the many questions the whole Mountain was built to keep anybody from asking.
>
> — It is a marvellous defence. You will forgive me if I go on asking them anyway.

They named the new Keeper then. The officiant recited Va-Elun's road: the labyrinth, the Chamber of the Last Prayer, the Bowl brought back as proof. Two attendants lifted the great cowl from Ka-Mereth. For a moment her skull was bare. They carried the yellowed weight between them and lowered it over the kneeling Va-Elun.

"Rise now as Ka-Elun, Keeper of Faith."

Ka-Elun put both hands on her thighs and rose in two movements. Dust fell from one fold of her robe in a little grey sigh. By the time the cowl settled upon her, the old woman was Mereth only, the *Ka* stripped from her name. Mereth watched the younger woman take the weight. Her bare mouth moved once. They carried her away alive through the Faith arch. In our lessons, such retirement was called holy.

The final response ended the great Ascension. In every rehearsal the Kahirs withdrew next. Shield held the exits, and behind my shoulder Va-Raedin took his hand from my wrist.

"Now," he said.

I had known it was coming. My mother had washed my robe herself that morning, despite the attendants Light had sent. My father had held my wrist and told me to stand straight when spoken to. The naming of the young was a side rite. I descended into the Hall, and the Hall grew larger with every step. Va-Sheva stood across from me at the Shield arch. That morning she was nineteen, in dark leather over the sleeveless robe, a short blade at her hip and a longer one across her back. We had spent most of our childhood chasing each other through the service tunnels. I knew the scar across her left knuckle because I had been there when she earned it. Her eyes found mine across the Pendulum's way. My balance went for one step. Her look made my hope stand up when I needed it to kneel.

I knelt on the northern stone before my Keeper, who stood with his back to the Pendulum. Heat pressed through my robe at both knees. Ka-Syphiron, Keeper of Light, moved his pale eyes from my face to my hands and back.

"Do you seek Light?"

"I seek Light."

"Why?"

The rehearsal held no such question. The crowd shifted. Behind me, Va-Raedin's robe whispered once and stopped. *Because I am worthy* was too proud. *Because I want to know* was too naked. My cuticle caught against the seam of my sleeve. Words were already moving in me faster than caution could inspect them.

"Because what is hidden still has shape," I said. "And if it has shape, it may be found."

The Hall went silent; an administrative silence already making copies of itself for later rooms. Beyond Ka-Syphiron, one of the clerks lowered his pen and looked up.

Ka-Syphiron did not correct me at once. The Pendulum crossed behind him with the Beast over his right shoulder, passed out of sight behind his body and returned along the same line. He said nothing through the crossing and return. My knees pressed harder into the hot stone. Somewhere above, a sandal moved along a gallery and stopped.

"A Candidate does not find all that has shape," he said. "What does a Candidate learn?"

The script returned, and air came back into my chest.

"Where light falls."

"And what does a Veil learn?"

"Who placed it."

"And what does a Keeper learn?"

I opened my mouth for the answer I had rehearsed. The torn mantle, the old woman carried away alive, and the Bowl stood between the words and me.

"What must remain dark," I said.

Ka-Syphiron's pale eyes remained on mine. Then he held out his hand for the knife. Behind me, Va-Raedin released a breath through his nose. The clerk bent again to his page.

He lifted his left hand, and Va-Raedin set a blade into it. The knife had no ornament: a bone handle worn smooth by fingers older than mine, an edge the lamps merely revealed. I extended my hand. The cut crossed the base of my thumb, too quickly for courage to be needed. Blood gathered under the lamplight, darker and thicker than I expected, embarrassingly mine. Ka-Syphiron turned my wrist so the drop hung from the thumb without falling. He pressed it to a polished stone plate marked with five faint circles. The drop flattened, found one shallow channel, and moved toward the northern mark. None of it entered the other four. The blood was warm; the stone was cold.

Blood enters service,
Sight enters discipline,
Pride enters correction.

Ka-Syphiron said. And I repeated.

"Rise now as Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light."

The name fell on me like a door closing with me on one side of it.

— The prefixes, before you go on. *Sa* for a Candidate, *Va* for a Veil, *Ka* for a Keeper. Are there others I should have?

— Just the three.

The ceremony ran on. Tavan was named Sa-Tavan of Justice. The Hall did not cheer. The people struck two fingers against stone, once, twice, five times, and the sound filled the Hall like rain made hard. Va-Raedin leaned close enough that only I could hear.

"You answered poorly," he said.

My stomach dropped so cleanly that for a breath I forgot the blood. Then he added: "But not uninterestingly."

At the second sentence my shoulders loosened. I looked for Va-Sheva, wanting her to have heard it, but she was no longer watching the ceremony. Two wardens

had come close to her, one speaking without moving his head. Her expression tightened. One hand settled near her hilt; she glanced past the galleries and shifted her stance. Va-Raedin bound my thumb with a strip of pale cloth and pulled it tight.

"You will report to the northern practice hall before Second Silence," he said. "Do not eat heavily. Do not arrive proud."

"I am not proud," I said.

He tied the cloth too tightly. "You are fifteen. Pride is your natural condition."

I said nothing.

"Good," he said. "You have learned one thing already."

I waited with the others for Shield to open the Mountain and let us go down to supper. Shield did not open the Mountain. The wardens at the great gates set their backs to the stone and their faces to us. One of them placed his palm against the seam between the doors. Another lowered the crossbar into its sockets. The small sounds of a crowd beginning to rise — a knee gathering, a child lifted — stopped one by one, until the Hall was as still as it had been at the first chime.

Then the Keepers left us. They went one at a time, each into the low office arch beneath the proper pillar: Balance beneath Balance, Justice beneath Justice, Shield beneath Shield, and Ka-Syphiron down the northern stair of Light, past the plate where my blood had not yet dried. Last went Ka-Elun. She stopped at the Faith threshold and set her hand against the jamb. Va-Maera stepped forward with both hands raised and halted before touching the cowl. Our law allowed no living soul to follow a Keeper of Faith through that arch. Ka-Elun entered alone. The five arches closed. We were left in a Hall with no Keeper in it at all.

Where five Keepers had stood, five Veils remained. Va-Raedin waited beneath Light, a single pace from me, his hands folded. Va-Sheva stood beneath Shield, where the wardens had drawn her, the shorter blade loosened in its seat. Beneath Faith stood the second of Mereth's two Veils, Va-Maera, she who had not risen. Beneath Balance and Justice waited two more I knew only by the colour of their sashes.

Each Veil faced an office arch. Va-Maera's place lay nearest Faith. She kept one ear turned to its closed stone while her hands arranged the folds of her robe, flattened them, and arranged them again.

Va-Maera lifted the prayer, and the people answered. Her voice cracked on its first word. She swallowed, drew breath, and began again. We asked that the Beast keep to Hell and the Chains keep their count; that God remember the Covenant

and the price of being seen; that the hand set into Faith that morning had been set in rightly; that mercy be shown to those beneath the Mountain and, more quietly, to those beyond it. After each plea the Hall gave back seven words:

Let every breath be whole;
Let no one hand hold the whole.

"What did God give the hidden people?"
"Stone, water, and shadow." The response came from every Kahir.
"What did God take from the hidden people?"
"Sky, wandering, and the open world."
"What is kept beneath the Mountain?"
"The Temple."
"What is kept beneath the Temple?"

No one answered. In every rehearsal, that question had been followed by silence. A little girl two rows ahead opened her mouth, and her mother covered it before a sound escaped.

And it went on. The light in the two permitted shafts crossed the floor, reddened, and narrowed. The Pendulum swung above the forbidden circle, its turning line marking the hours. Its shadow passed the northern plate again and again, over the darkened print of my thumb. Oil burned down, and attendants of Light trimmed and refilled the lamps until the smell sat on the tongue. Children began to move, were hushed, and moved again. An old man near the Shield arch folded down without a sound, and Va-Sheva reached him before he struck the floor. I did not see her cross the space; she was simply there, one arm under him, lowering him the way you lower a full vessel you have resolved not to spill. She returned beneath her pillar with nothing shown on her face. My face heated. I had spent the day watching her hair.

I turned the name over without moving my lips: *Sa-Kailan*, *Sa-Kailan*. My cut thumb beat under Va-Raedin's linen. The wrapping had reddened where the blood came through. I waited for him to look at me; he did not. I found Va-Sheva across the Hall, looked down, and found her again. Once I lifted my head too far toward the closed arches. Va-Raedin's two fingers returned to my wrist and pressed my gaze to the stone. The prayer wore down into a continued murmur. A voice would fall out, then another, then return after water had passed along the rows. Va-Maera raised one hand. The sound stopped and did not begin again.

Into that silence the Mountain moved. The first stroke came straight up through the floor, into the knees and gut and back teeth, as though something the

size of the Hall had struck the underside of the world once with the flat of its hand. Dust left the carvings all at once, and the pillars smoked. A bowl rang. Somewhere glass broke. The Thread shivered; the great disk slipped sideways at the end of its crossing, hunted, and found its swing. Va-Raedin caught my shoulder before my hands reached the floor. A low single sound passed through the Hall.

Then nothing. Va-Maera held her hand aloft. Dust turned in the slanting light. A word went from beneath Justice; another returned from Balance; something passed along the five Veils in an order I could not follow. Nothing sounded at the closed arches. Va-Maera looked toward Faith. Va-Raedin turned his head toward the Light stair. Across the circle, Va-Sheva watched the Shield arch. The second stroke came after a long wait. This time the Hall did not cry out. It was the twin of the first, no larger, and it lifted the same loose edge of carpet beneath Faith. By the third I was counting. Three. The gap between the strokes was long and exact, the same to the breath each time. Va-Maera's head lifted a moment before each blow. Around me they prayed with their eyes shut. I counted with mine open. The fourth came. My body had learned the rhythm and leaned toward the next before it fell. I caught a word from beneath Faith, braced, and felt the heat of being seen though I caught no eye on me. After the floor settled, my injured thumb struck once inside its binding. The fifth fell no heavier than the others. I had expected it to grow. Its level force frightened me more.

Between the fourth and fifth, I counted breaths. I lost the count when someone sobbed, began again, and reached the same number with one breath to spare. Va-Raedin's fingers tightened before the stone rose.

Five. I had counted five. I waited for a sixth. The rows before me stayed still. Va-Maera bent her head toward the floor. The five arches stayed shut. The gates stayed shut. The prayer resumed, lower than before. The broken glass lay untouched.

The adults I could see watched the closed arches. Va-Sheva's hand had left her blade and rested flat against the Shield pillar. Va-Raedin kept two fingers on my shoulder. The Pendulum swung. Its line crept farther round its slow circle. The permitted light went from red to almost nothing. A child asked a question and was not answered. Water travelled along the rows in covered cups; mine had the taste of lamp smoke. We remained on our knees in the smell of spent oil and each other. After the fifth blow, the same measure began again without a stroke to mark its start.

At the point where my body expected a sixth blow, the answer came. The five had been sharp and near, each its own event, a fist beneath one floor. The swell made no sound I could hear. I felt a slow pressure in my teeth, in the water of the

eye, in the marrow of the leg against the stone. It rose through the floor and lifted my knees. Lamps shook. The pillars groaned. The hanging disk climbed on one long swell of the ground and settled. Bowls around the Hall sounded together, a soft chord of struck metal with no hand near them. Water in the two nearest offering basins rose without spilling and sank.

The swell passed, but its pressure remained in my teeth. The little girl two rows ahead had both hands clamped over her mouth. Her mother held her from behind, cheek against the child's hair, and kept looking toward Faith. Beneath Shield, Va-Sheva removed her palm from the pillar one finger at a time. Va-Raedin's hand had gone from my shoulder. I touched the cloth and found four clean streaks where his fingers had rested.

The Faith arch opened first, long after the swell had passed. Ka-Elun stepped through, one hand against the stone, the great cowl bowed by its own weight. Dust striped one shoulder. Va-Maera took half a step toward her. Ka-Elun raised two fingers, and the Veil stopped. The offering bowls had fallen silent.

"God answers."

Va-Maera lowered her raised hand. For one breath she and Ka-Elun faced each other across the place where the cowl had changed shoulders. Then Va-Maera bowed. Ka-Elun left the wall and crossed to the Faith pillar without assistance.

A long broken exhalation passed through the rows and broke into sobs near Faith. Stone moved at the other four arches. Balance and Justice passed behind their pillars before I saw them take their places. Shield crossed the open space opposite me. Ka-Syphiron returned last, closed the Light arch with his own hand, and looked once at the disk above us. I counted all five beneath their pillars. The Keeper of Shield turned toward the gates. Va-Maera gave the law once more. The people gave it back:

> *Let every breath be whole;*
> *Let no one hand hold the whole.*

Only then did Shield open the Mountain. The great gates drew back. Cool untasted air came from the deep passages and reached me as robes stirred along every tier. The Hall began to empty. Attendants pinched the lamp wicks one by one. On the southern wall the Genesis gravure darkened with them, until the carved Mountain lost its edges and the hidden Oasis went into shadow. I knelt among the rising people and looked into that shadow until my eyes began to invent shapes.

— Stop there. Before you leave that Hall, I think you have told me something you do not know you told me. The deep strokes, the hard ones from below: how many?

— Five. I counted them. Five.

— And the spacing between them: even, like a dripping tap? Or not?

— Even. Dead even. The same long wait to the breath each time, set by nothing I could see: no drum, no hand, no voice.

— Then the five stopped, and something different came after the next interval.

— After the same long wait. The five were blows, each its own, close under the floor. The answer was everywhere, slow and low, and lifted the whole Hall on one breath.

— How long between the last of the five and that answer? Set it against the gaps between the strokes.

— The same. One more of the long even measures, and then the Earth spoke. I cannot give it to you in minutes; I had no clock but the prayer. But it was even to the last.

— And the rite followed the raising of a Keeper. Every raising, or only that one?

— Every raising of a Keeper. It is very old. I was told it was the Mountain proving that the Chains still held after a hand upon them had changed.

— … Thank you. That is enough for now. I have your count and your interval. I want to set them down cleanly and ask Mrs Blackwood about a record she keeps. Sit. Take some water. I shall not be long.

Blackwood Estate — a monitoring room off the west corridor

In English

— You can leave the machine running; it is already on the house's record, as everything in this wing is. Sit down, Mr Morgan, before you fall down. You heard it too, then.

— Thank you, Mrs Blackwood. … I heard five deliberate sources and a return, and a people who would not call themselves safe until the return arrived.

— I know precisely what you heard. I have waited sixty-six years to be told. Five marks, even and exact, with one long interval between them and the same interval before what came behind: a broad slow swell across the whole instrument. I set it aside as noise, as the ground settling, as the desert being the desert. I have carried that trace in a drawer since I was twenty-seven years old, since an hour after Reggane in 1960.

— Jesus. … A readiness test, you think?

— That is my inference. Every time one of their hands changes, five sources and a return. The first four intervals give the source schedule. The fifth predicts the return.

— And the gates prove what the return means to them: they do not open them until it arrives.

— Then my working hypothesis is that the broad swell on your trace was a whole-Earth mode.

— And mine is that whatever they keep beneath that mountain may be coupled to the planet. … What in God's name do they have down there, that they test it through the Earth and teach the children to call the test a prayer?

— …

— No. Do not answer that; and I would not trust you if you tried. … Good work, Mr Morgan. Go back in. Keep him talking, and get me the rest: the trial, the exile, all of it, in his own time. Do not lead him, do not frighten him, do not tell him what he has just taught us. And Paul. He is not to know what I have just understood. Let him go on thinking me the woman who pays for the tea and nothing worse, and you a scholar paid to sift a young man's story. Gain his trust, Paul.

Chapter 2

Mirror

In English

— Package for you, Paul. Marmite; Fortnum tea; Fortnum biscuits. Did your mummy send them, or do they simply arrive for a man of your breeding? ... Ah. A Balvenie eighteen, cherry cask. So this is the work here, is it: whisky tasting? God. They pay you far too much. You are not slipping out this evening for a third week running: the chessboard is exactly where you bolted from it, it is my move, and I mean to have the game off you before we are both too old to lift a rook.

— Put it down, Urs, and go be impressed with yourself somewhere else. And you with the new haircut, trying to look like a true eighties golden boy? What comes next, the double-breasted jacket? Leave us in peace. Have you no supertankers stuck in the *strait* to go and play battleship with?

— Wait till you see the Pequignet. All right, see you later boys.

In Noxius

— Let us continue. Where were we?

The morning after they cut my hand, I came to the practice halls of Light before Second Silence with a sour empty stomach, a thumb bound in linen that tugged at the cut with every closing of the hand, and the private conviction that I would never, a second time, be made to look a fool.

> — Stop there. *First Light* I take for dawn; any man would. But *Second Silence*, you were sealed in stone, with no sky, no sun. How did you tell one hour from the next?
>
> — By the Pendulum. I have told you its size, and the length of the Thread; that it swings, back and forth, a little more than twenty of your seconds to cross and return. But the line of its swing also turns, slowly, across the floor. How would you name that?
>
> — Precession.
>
> — Just so. And it takes two and three-quarter days for that line to return to itself. Faith marks a ring on the floor around the Forbidden Circle; at each mark an attendant strikes a gong as the swing crosses it, so that a man who has seen no light all day knows whether it is First Light, Second Silence, Third Measure, Fourth Record, or Fifth Blade.
>
> — Five marks. Five gongs. Your day had five parts.
>
> — Five names, many marks. The names began again around the ring, almost three days of them laid down at once. Faith held the count and struck the proper gong. The marks never sat still. As the seasons drew the day long or short, Faith moved them a little, so the ring stayed honest against a sun we were forbidden to see. Measure was called our noon. Some days it was, most days near it, now and then an hour adrift. The sun settled it twice a year at the festival of Equal Light, when Third Measure was exactly noon.

The day before, those thresholds had admitted Kailan as a boy servant under instruction, suffered near the outer rooms because his teachers vouched for him. That morning the gate wanted a record of who I was. An attendant in a robe of dustless grey read my new name from a tablet whose characters had been incised so lately that a fine grit still lay unswept in the troughs of every stroke; and *Sa-Kailan*, in a stranger's mouth, sounded like a key turning in locks I had never been shown. The stone changed under my sandals as I crossed from common passage into Light. It became smoother, colder, so that a step both sounded and returned a faint image from below. Even the darkness was tended here, kept in its allotted places. A corridor beyond the gate was crossed by thin bars of light that fell from slits too high to see and vanished into black cuts on the far wall. I slowed despite myself. At Faith I had knelt; Balance had measured me; Shield had read my permission; Justice had entered me in its record. My first lessons in Light had been simpler: open your eyes; Light shows what is there.

The Hall of Light was several halls under one name, broad and shallow from one end, a blade of space from the stair, mirrors along one side and black apertures cut into the other. In a niche a Balance woman changed the salt-dishes that kept damp off the glass, weighing each wet one before setting down a dry. From the candidate entrance the place looked almost empty; a few steps in, mirrors stood everywhere, and none where a child would have set them — tall strips no wider than a hand, discs at knee or shoulder, some of dark polished stone that returned shape without obedience. They were made below, at the one great heat the Mountain allowed itself, from desert sand breathed over with a whisper of metal; and the Balance table beside that furnace marked every shovel of coal and left the last line of the seam's account blank. Arcs and crosses and incomplete circles had been cut into the floor. Three doorways stood at the far end. The left appeared open and dark, with light at its base; the middle was closed by metal; the right stood half-open, with a reflected line of brightness along its edge that I distrusted at once.

Va-Raedin of Light stood at the centre, hands folded behind his back, pale grey robe, no ornament but the narrow silver thread at the cuff. He looked rested. I resented it. The ceremony had lasted through the day, and he had stood through it without letting the hours show.

"You are early," he said.

"You said before Second Silence."

"I did." He looked at my bandage. "Does the thumb hurt?"

"No."

"It should."

"It does a little."

"Then start with the truth when truth is inexpensive."

Heat moved into my face, and I said nothing. He turned to the three doors.

"Which door opens?"

I nearly answered quickly, and disliked myself for the impulse. The right doorway's brightness was so plainly a lure that the lure might be to distrust it too easily. I studied the floor instead.

"The left," I said. "The light at its base belongs to an opening. The right only reflects one. The middle is meant to make the eye feel opposed."

"Open it."

I crossed the hall to the left-hand facade and pushed. Nothing. Pulled. Nothing. I searched for latch, seam, hinge, weight. My hands found only smooth stone, and behind me Va-Raedin stayed quiet, which I hated more than correction.

"You asked which door opens," I said. "Not which door appears open."

"No."

I looked again. Doors, mirrors, floor. The nearest cut circle was worn on one side only, as though candidates had learned to step into it from the same direction. So I stood inside it, and the room changed. The mirrors no longer held the three doors. They caught a plain stone panel behind me, flush with the wall, unmarked by light. I found the seam by touch and pressed, and it opened inward. I pressed my mouth flat. His eyes moved to it.

"Light deceives," I said.

"No. That is the small thing, and the proud one." He did not move. "From the door you chose well among the three the room offered you. From the circle you saw the room that had laid the three out to be chosen among. A Candidate who follows brightness serves whoever placed the lamp."

"A Veil learns who placed the lamp," I said.

"Eventually. When he stops being proud of finding a door built to be found, and asks what wanted it found."

I went into the dark chamber before I could be told.

The second room was narrower and colder, lit through slits so thin they should have lit nothing. On a stone table lay a mirror shard, a black measuring rod, a bead of clear glass fixed to a white tile, a bowl of water, and two bronze wedges. Va-Raedin closed the hidden door, and the darkness thickened, then organised itself around the slits.

"Move the point of light onto the far wall."

"May I touch the lamp?"

"No. But you may touch what is on the table."

I began with the shard. The nearest slit sent a fine blade of light too high to catch, and I angled the shard until the light jumped downward, crossed the black rod, and vanished. For minutes I worked at an exercise easy to understand and forever slipping from my hands. Each time the point steadied, the smallest movement of my wrist sent it running. My bandaged thumb made the shard hard to grip; I compensated with the wrong fingers, overcorrected, lost the beam, found it, and heard Va-Raedin breathe once through his nose. At last I set the mirror flat and used the water, tipping the bowl until its surface caught the beam and threw it upward, unstable but bright; the point moved with every tremor in the bowl. I held my breath until the surface stilled.

"Acceptable," Va-Raedin said.

"The water answers after the hand has left it," I said.

"Better." He watched the point tremble on the wall. "The disturbance is one thing; the trace it leaves is another. The water tells you a disturbance occurred. It does not always tell you what or who disturbed it. Young minds love to turn traces into stories."

By the time he led me on it was past Third Measure, and the passages carried the grind of carts and the iron report of a gate tested by Shield. In one chamber he crossed to a blackened panel, laid his hand flat upon it and asked where the exit was. The entrance behind us was one answer, and so probably wrong; his hand drew my eye to the panel, too large, too flat, no seam unless soot hid it. I walked toward it. He removed his hand, and I found no seam at all, and stopped.

"Why did you come here?"

"You drew attention to it."

"Yes. And?"

I looked back. Standing at the panel, his body had blocked a low mirror behind him; with him gone the reflection crossed the room and struck the left arch, showing that the floor beyond it stopped.

"You hid the falsehood by standing in front of the light," I said.

"That is what a Keeper of Light does. I am a Veil. I prevented you from seeing the condition that gave the falsehood shape. A lamp in the wrong place blinds more thoroughly than darkness."

"The distinctions are convenient," I said.

"They are. That does not make them false."

The chamber that followed was lit by a single lamp on the floor, ringed by six mirrors on slender metal stems, each facing the lamp at a different angle.

"Place them so the lamp finds the door," he said.

I wasted minutes on the brightest patch, a reflection of a reflection. I traced it from lamp to mirror, mirror to wall, wall to nothing. "There is no door for the lamp to find," I said. Va-Raedin smiled but did not correct me. I stopped searching the wall and crouched. From the floor I saw that one mirror reflected the gap between two brighter paths. I shifted it toward the gap. A pale line sharpened on the wall; another mirror sent it downward; a seam appeared at ankle height. A panel. By the time the panel opened, my knees ached and the linen on my thumb had darkened with new blood. Inside lay a small metal token, heavier and finer

than anything a boy is usually given to keep. It was a broad disk at the centre, pierced by a hole no wider than a hair, and round the disk ring upon ring, close-set and perfectly even, spreading to the rim like the rings a dropped stone leaves in a still bowl.

"Take it," he said. "Proof that you opened the room. Keep it, and do not show it; it is not easily made, and I will not cut you another."

I turned it once between finger and thumb, made nothing of the rings, and put it away.

— Forgive the intrusion; do not get up, either of you. I wanted only to see my two clevernesses with my own eyes. Are we making progress?

— Mrs Blackwood, we are. Slowly, and well.

— Slowly and well will do very nicely. I shall leave you to it; I am late for a call I have already kept waiting twice. Leave them be, both of you; they are working.

[—]

— ... And that was? She speaks my tongue very well.

— That was the woman who pays for the tea. Sarah.

— The tall red-faced one I can place: your Urs, the one who likes to tease you. The old one I cannot. He watched your machine more than he watched us, did you notice?

— That is only Martinez. He goes where she goes. His father worked for Edward, Sarah's father; the son stayed on for her.

— He goes where she goes, you say. ... And stands where the light is behind him. Like a shadow.

— The token, then. Go back to it for me. What was cut into it, exactly?

— A disk at the centre, a tiny hole in the middle. Around the disk, rings: many, close-set, even, spreading out to the rim. Like the rings a stone leaves on a still pool, but held in the odd pale colour and never moving.

— A token of light, cut to look like ripples of water. ... Stay there a moment. This will not take long.

[—]

— Forgive me; that took longer than I said. I have had a thing fetched up and printed here, on this sheet. Never mind what it is, or where I got it. Only this: did the token look like that?

— Yes. Exactly like that. Except yours is red, and mine was pale upon pale. ... How would you know?

— ...

> — Paul. I have been asked that question once already today, by a better man than either of us, and I gave the wrong answer to it. Who placed this sheet in front of me?
>
> — ... Well. All right. All right. And when he set the token in your hand, did you know what it was? What it meant?
>
> — Not then. But I would come to learn it, later.

A passage overlooked a lower work hall through narrow slits. Below, Faith singers rehearsed near a side arch, and no song reached me through the stone, only a low pressure in the rail beneath my hand, as if the wall had taken the note and returned its body without its words. A thin mist rose behind the singers and turned pale at the exact moment they lifted their faces.

Va-Raedin let me look. After a while he asked: "What do you see?"

"Water in the air. Light placed to make it visible. Timing."

"Do not admire the flame," he said. "Ask where the air enters." And I looked again, past the pale glow, to the fine line of holes above the arch that fed the mist, so fine they might have been pores in the rock, and to the hidden lamp placed to turn the vapour pale.

Below, a singer raised both hands, and the mist thickened with the movement as though the prayer had called it. The stone under my palm answered a breath after the bodies below. He nodded once.

"Do they know?" I asked.

"Know what?"

"The holes. The lamp."

"They know the prayer."

"That is not an answer."

"No."

"If God provides through valves, do the valves disprove Him, or serve Him?"

"You have been in Light one day. Leave Faith its quarrel."

The mist thinned. The stone released its low answering hum.

It was almost Fourth Record, and the work had worn my attention to a thin wire, when Va-Raedin stopped me between two dark chambers, asked a question for which I had no answer, and waited.

"You have said a sentence since before you could reason," he said. "*A Candidate learns where light falls.* Say it to me. Then tell me what it means."

I said it, and then said what it meant: that a Candidate learns the Mountain's light as a mason learns its stone, every shaft and slit and aperture, so that Light

might be kept and mended and never fail the halls that leaned upon it. I was rather pleased with the answer.

"That," Va-Raedin said when I had finished, "is what a mirror would tell you, if you could teach a mirror to speak."

He took one of the plain strips of glass from a niche in the passage, a hand's width, no more, and held it up between us, angled so that I saw my own face in it, badly, lit from beneath.

"What does this do?"

"It returns what falls on it," I said.

"Exactly. It returns what falls on it, adds nothing, keeps nothing. Perfectly faithful and perfectly empty. Three-and-twenty thousand festivals of equal light this Mountain has counted, and turned its mirrors to the sun at every one, and no mirror is the wiser for a single festival."

He turned the glass until his face displaced my own. "You have described the work of a mirror. I asked for the work of a Candidate. Which will you be? A mirror, or an eye?"

He did not wait on the answer. "A thing that has met three-and-twenty thousand festivals and is standing yet — what does it tell you?"

"That it is likely to meet three-and-twenty thousand more."

"Perhaps. Now ask what it removed, each festival, to keep the next the same."

> — Festivals of equal light, twenty-three thousand of them. That is eleven and a half thousand years.
>
> — Va-Raedin told me there was a clock, in a room I was never brought to. It was nothing like yours; it kept no hours, and no mornings. It beat once only, at each festival of equal light: twice in the year, never between. What cogs and weights turned inside it to keep it so patient, I was not privy to. I was never Light enough to be shown.

He returned the plain strip to the niche from which he had taken it.

"Come," he said. "I will show you where light falls."

He took me down by a stair I had never been shown, below the practice halls, to an unbarred door with no warden before it. On the stair he told me that Light brought only its three ranks to the threshold, and required silence from each until the next had stood there. The room beyond was long and low and nearly dark, cold as places the day never enters. The wall to the left we entered by was pierced

from floor to ceiling with small round holes, hundreds of them, each no wider than a fingertip, and through every one came a single thread of light, so that the wall to my right was a field of faint stars shining the wrong way — inward, out of the body of the Mountain.

The wall to my right puzzled me at first. It carried points of light too, where the threads crossed the dark and stopped; but they obeyed no rank, no order. They were scattered across the black face of the stone — some in clusters, some alone, some steady and bright, some so faint I found them only by looking beside them. It might have been a night sky copied by a hand that refused constellations.

Then Va-Raedin raised a shielded lamp to the wall's lower edge, and I saw faint lines scored between the points, joining them into shapes. The skin of my arms tightened. I knew the shapes. I had walked them that same morning. The long gallery of Light. The stair we had just come down. The washing pools, in their two uneven rows. The food galleries. And there, low and to one side, the great round of the Hall of Ceremony and its ring of five pillars.

"We call it the Mirror," Va-Raedin said. "Every beam in the Mountain ends here: here is nothing but the ends of beams. The wall precedes the Mountain. Now the Mountain follows the wall. Watch."

We stood a while and the points held still, most of them, most of the time; then near the middle of the wall, at a passage between the food galleries and the lower cells, a single point stirred: dimmed, steadied, dimmed again, and went still.

"Someone crossed the light there," Va-Raedin said. "The beam does not care who. It tells you where and when a body passed between source and wall. Not the face. Not the burden. It need not watch you always. Leave a man unable to tell its sleeping hours from its waking ones, and he will keep the rest himself."

Between First Light and Fifth Blade, he told me, the halls move and the wall flickers like water in wind. After Fifth Blade the Mountain holds still by its long law, and a single stirring point is as loud upon the Mirror as a shout in an empty hall.

"You will learn each point," Va-Raedin said. "Which beam it is, and which place it stands for, and what its stirring means, and what its stillness means, which is harder. There are two hundred and fifty-six of them on this wall. No two candidates learn them in the same order, and there is no shorter road. A Candidate learns where light falls. Light falls here."

I stood before the wall that could find any body in the Mountain and thought it the most beautiful thing I had ever laid eyes upon. I told him nothing. Around us, two hundred and fifty-six points held their places.

— It is a good place to leave the morning. The afternoon and tomorrow run as agreed: a few hours with the tutor, and then the physician asks an hour of you for the body. He is not content with your numbers.

— Instruction, yes; I will sit with your tutor. The physician and his hour, we shall see. Do you know what they will teach me?

— The shape of it, yes. The exact content or the methodology, no. We are kept apart; the House calls it compartmentalisation. Each account is to be taken clean, free of the others' influence. Come. I will show you where you will eat.

Blackwood Estate — Drawing room, past midnight

In Noxius

— You are up. … Wait: say that again, I want it on the reel. … Forgive the machine at this hour. I gave my word the first morning that nothing we said would go unkept, and I would sooner keep it badly than keep it only by daylight.

— It is the light. The one the tutor set on the wall this afternoon. I shut my eyes and it is still burning. … And this house keeps a lamp lit in every room the night long, for no one at all. Anyway. … I was thinking of the sea. Is it far from here?

In English

— One second, Urs. There. … Knight d three. The octopus.

In Noxius

— Never mind the game, and never mind Urs. One of his boats is lost, fast in a strait; he is awaiting news from his contact in Isfahan, and none have come.

— You see, it is so large that a man may lose a whole boat inside it. … Is it far from here?

— Quite far. … Let me see if I can find you something here, with pictures in it.

[—]

In English

— Paul. The coffee table. … Under the Elizabeth Kolbert.

— Ah: excellent idea.

In Noxius

— Here. *The World, From Above*. Now off you go.

Chapter 3

Oasis

— The nineteenth of March, nine o'clock; the second of our interviews. Before we begin, if you wish to ask any question about instruction these past two days, now is the time. Yesterday was *Life On Earth*, I am told: the whole ladder of it, from the first speck to your own hand. This afternoon they turn to the heavens.

— I wish. It began with time. A man took me down into a great red canyon, wall standing over wall, and taught that each layer beneath was older than the one above it; and that the floor of it was older than the whole of my scripture. He said something I wrote down:

> *These immense periods of time baffle the imagination.*

You do not say. My people count the years of the world in their thousands and think themselves ancient. He counts them in their millions, and had the rock to prove it. I did not know a rock could be young or old. And in those rocks there were beasts, Paul: creatures caught in the stone where they had died an age ago, held in the rock as a fly is held in sap. It sent me back, this morning, to a thing I had passed twice and thought nothing of: on the wall of the passage you bring me down, a beast with five teeth and a crown upon it, set there as though by a furious child. After those creatures in the stone, I stopped before it a long while. What is it? In the Mountain, a thing like that would be a warning, or a god.

— Ha. That. A painting by a man called *Basquiat*, dead very young, and worth a good deal more than the house it hangs in. We pay a king's ransom to frame the fury a child would be corrected for, then hang it where every guest must pass.

— I should like to hold the instrument in my own hands, the microscope, and see this DNA he spoke of with my own eyes, and not take it on a voice's word.

— We have one downstairs for looking at cells; its lenses cannot resolve the double helix. Whether you are granted it is not mine to say, nor the tutor's; that door opens higher up than either of us. I will ask.

— There it is again: the wall you will not walk past. Every house I have been kept in has had one. But sleep went from me over something else. Your kind is permitted to ask; that is what I lay listening to. Where I was raised, scripture is the answer to a question, not the start of one. That voice spoke in questions and partial answers, and called the rest a mystery still to be pierced.

And the moving picture: I have thought of little else. It is light, Paul, placed and turned by a hand I was not shown. We would have named it the most dangerous object ever made and given it to Shield to bury. Yet I sat before it and could not look away. Nor could I stop asking the two questions my whole life trained into me: who chose what I was shown, and what did they leave in the dark? I assumed you were watching me watch it. I was raised under the finest eyes my world ever made, and I can feel a trained watcher through a wall. So tell me: who stood behind the glass?

— No one. That I know of. I was not there; I spend those hours replaying the tape and taking notes. The tutor sat with you. But about the lamp, you are not wrong. We have used it to persuade whole nations to love a war before a reason was given, or to want a thing they had no want of an hour before. This house, and much of my world with it, runs on the lamp.

— … A room with no eye in it, and a man who grants the point when he might have kept his silence. That is the most honest thing you have said to me. Then answer one thing while the honesty lasts. If your house trusts the lamp to show me the history of life, why will it not trust me with the instrument by which I might test it?

— Because the tutor may show you, the physician may mend you, and neither holds every key in the house. Which brings me to my smaller errand. You kept your hours with the tutor yesterday, then sent the physician away. The exercise. You would not do it.

— Paul. I mean you no disrespect; you have been courteous, and courtesy is not nothing. But understand what you are asking, and of whom. I sat among the ten who mattered most in a world eleven thousand years old. Men knelt when I passed them. Lives were kept, or were not, upon my word. And you would set me in coloured cloth to chase a ball across a lawn while grown men clap and call it improvement. I did not come this far, through all that has been taken from me, to be entertained by silly games.

> — It is a game, and it is not. It is complicated. The body is an instrument, and yours has come to us badly out of tune. The physician would begin again with swimming; there is a private pool beneath the east wing. He reads numbers, not men. I thought it might suit a man who has had his fill of being watched.
>
> — No. ... No: yes. I will do the swimming. The man whose voice it was yesterday did more than cross the top of the water; he went down beneath it, in a red tunic, with a large yellow bottle behind his back, and moved among the creatures there as though he belonged with them. You have a pond in your garden; I have watched it all morning from the window. Train me to swim, then to dive, and give me the glass. I can go down into that pond and learn for myself whether the man on the light told me the truth or only a good story.
>
> — That is more than the physician had in mind; but I will try for it. Now: yesterday you left me at the Mirror, the wall where all of it falls. What did Light do with you the next morning?
>
> — It gave me a beam of my own to learn. Before I could trace it that morning, I was granted permission to go outside, for the second time in my life, and the beam remained to be walked.

My mother said the first had been at my blessing and that the Mountain had folded the sky away before I could remember it. The permission came to me on a strip of pale bark, folded twice and sealed with green wax. The seal was Balance green: the cup and the sealed jar pressed deep into the wax, crossed by a narrow black witness line and the small hard stamp of Shield. I broke it with my thumb. The old cut pulled under the bandage.

> *Sa-Kailan, Candidate of Light, is granted one controlled prayer access before the Oasis at the Third Measure. Duration: one silence before and one silence after the water prayer. Route: east lower passage, cedar gate, second threshold, shaded descent. Measured by Balance. Witnessed by Justice. Held by Shield.*

I tied the bandage on my thumb, untied it, and tied it again so the linen sat cleanly over the cut. My mother watched from the wall recess where she had been folding cloth.

"You will keep your eyes lowered through the water prayer."

"I know."

"You will not ask Shield why a path is closed."

"I know."

My father looked up from the tablet he had been marking. "Outside is not a reward."

"Yes it is."

"It is not a private revelation."

"Unless you have the devotion and the eye to see what is revealed."

"It is a place where the Mountain becomes harder to protect."

"A boy with his eyes open was never the danger."

I left before he could answer.

The familiar passages to the cedar gate felt strange that morning, because I was walking them in order, outward. Checkpoint, gate, count, threshold, descent: each had stood there yesterday and I had walked past it blind. Today I passed through each one wondering what it was for. A Justice clerk read the green wax against a slate — time mark, name, bandaged thumb — and pressed a clay counter into my palm.

"Return this at the second threshold. If you lose it, the route remains open in the record, and Shield searches until it is closed."

"I will not lose it."

"That is the usual intention."

It was small and rough and stamped with a number. I put it in the inner fold of my robe, apart from the Light token. At the cedar gate two attendants stood beside a shallow basin, washing every leaving body into the proper condition and giving water enough for rite and no more. There were seven of us: myself; three older women from the western family chambers, one in a grey shawl; a boy with a single cloudy eye, led by one of them; and two workers with grey mourning cords at their wrists. The water the Faith attendant poured over my hands was colder than I expected.

"Speak only what is appointed before the Oasis. Take nothing from the ground."

"I will not."

The boy with the cloudy eye began to cry when the water touched his mouth. His aunt bent close and whispered to him. The two men with mourning cords said nothing at all.

Beyond the cedar gate waited Shield: black iron bands behind the wood, a locking bar thick enough to stop a cart, two wardens before it and a third in a side niche whose black leather showed between two folds of hanging cloth. The senior warden read our marks one by one.

"Prayer access. The Measure. Seven bodies out. Seven bodies due." He looked at me last. "Candidate of Light."

"Yes."

"Eyes where Faith places them. Feet where Balance marks them. If Shield speaks, you obey before understanding."

"I understand."

"No," the warden said. "You agree. Understanding is not required."

The iron bar was lifted by two hands and a lever set into the wall. A narrow bell sounded somewhere beyond the gate; another sounded farther down the stone. The descent beyond the cedar gate was cut between natural rock and worked stone. At first it felt like any lower passage: dim, damp, controlled, with lamps set in protective recesses and the smell of water in the cracks. Then the lamps stopped. Light lay on the floor in a pale wedge. It came from somewhere ahead, full of dust and height, careless in its angle, making each stair deeper and then shallower as I moved.

"Eyes down until the mark," the Shield warden said.

I lowered my gaze to the steps. The outside light was brighter, and undisciplined, and it took some minutes for my eyes to adapt. At the last turn, the Mountain opened. The sky struck me first as sheer height, and after that as blue. The Mountain had ceilings; even its highest halls ended somewhere, and had taught my eye to expect an end. I kept my eyes low, and failed, and above the dark shoulder of the Mountain the open brightness went on and on, with no vault to end it and no hand to have placed it. Faith led us to the marked prayer stones. There we were permitted to look. The Oasis lay under the Mountain's shadow. Green crowded the water and climbed the dark stone. My throat closed. For one breath I forgot the prayer.

The Genesis gravure had shown me a spring inside a ring of trees, and I had knelt to that carving my whole life. I had come out to hold the carving against the thing itself, as I meant one day to hold a pond against a voice on a lit glass. Before me, bees worried the warm rock. Water travelled under leaves and vanished into cuts too narrow for a finger. Small white flowers had rooted themselves in the cracks of the slope, and wherever the shade shifted, something living leaned after it. Along the Mountain's foot, where the night's chill still slept in the stone, the hardiest plants wore a fur of dew. I watched one bead gather on a leaf, swell, and fall inward into a seam before the sun could take it. The hill drank through its own wall.

A woman trimmed a reed and passed the cuttings to a child carrying feed. Beneath the palms, fish broke the green surface where scraps had been thrown. Smoke drifted from the hives; a child sprinkled water over the snail trays; another woman scraped fibre from soaked stalks and laid it to dry beside sheets of new paper. Where the drying channel pans had gone white, a Balance worker scraped the salt up before the water reached the beds and carried it toward the preserving tables. A boy swept fallen grain from a threshing cloth into a basket and took the chaff toward the goat pens.

> — How large was it, in the shadow of the Mountain?
>
> — Enormous, I do not know how to count it.
>
> — The silly games pitch. Bigger or smaller?
>
> — Hard to say: it was circular and irregular. Five, six, maybe ten of those.
>
> — Circular. How many steps from one end to the opposite end, going through the middle.
>
> — Eight hundred, or maybe a thousand.

Beyond it the desert expanded, and outside the Mountain's shadow the light bleached detail from the sand. The Mountain held the hollow in shade from the north; to the south a second height stood out of the sand, a third its size and set so close that the Oasis lay caught between the two like a seed between a thumb and a finger. What those two left open, a farther ridge to the south-east all but closed, and to the south-west dune lay across dune, so that a man would have had to stand at one precise and distant place to see even the tops of the trees. The green ran on past the point the prayer-party was let to see: terrace above terrace along the Mountain's cooler flank, palms, then lower trees, then crops in their shade, more than the holy hollow held — and a man out on the sand would swear the whole hill was barren stone. To reach the high terraces the water had to be sent back uphill, and that took a machine: a wheel of clay pots on a shaft that two goats walked in a slow circle, each pot filling low and spilling high.

The old women knelt. I knelt with them. The Faith attendant unrolled a strip of pale bark and held it with both hands before the water. She named the reading: the second book of the Covenant, the *Book of Blood*.

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve,

— Adam and Eve?

— Paul, please do not interrupt me when I recite scripture. God would not approve.

— Of course. My apologies.

And after the fifth day, God spoke unto Adam and unto Eve, and unto the five children whom He had set in the Oasis beneath the shadow of the Mountain; and God said, Let there be Keepers among you, that the Mountain be not without order, nor the Oasis without care, nor the people without peace. And God called the woman of water, and said unto her, Keep thou the Balance, and gather the fruits, and count the waters; keep the seed for sowing and the grain for eating, and let neither be spent for the other. And God called the woman of holy speech, and said unto her, Keep thou the Faith, and teach My Gospel unto the children; keep the words in their mouths, and the names of their fathers, that the old be remembered when their voices cease.

The Balance workers moved in the distance as the words were spoken. One woman checked the level in a narrow cut along the main channel. On the high terraces the barley stood pale, and a line of women worked along it with short hooks. A clerk marked a hanging board and moved a shell counter from one hook to another.

And God called the man of strength, and said unto him, Keep thou the Shield, and stand before the beasts of the Earth, and before the Threshold of men; suffer not the children to be devoured, nor danger to enter unnamed. And God called the woman of brightness, and said unto her, Keep thou the Light, and illuminate the Mountain, and teach the eye where to stand, that the people stumble not in darkness. And God called the man of peace, and said unto him, Keep thou Justice, and stand between brother and brother, and keep the record of sequence, that blood answer not blood without measure. And the Keepers received their charges, and each kept what had been given.

And the people brought the fruits of their labour unto the Oasis, and the Keepers set portions before them. And God said, Leave bread for him who keepeth watch, and carry water unto her who cannot rise to drink. Let the old teach the children

while the strong go forth to labour, and let food be set before them together. And the children learned the names of the trees from those who rested in their shade.

And the Keepers had sons and daughters, and their children had children after them; and the Oasis was filled with voices, and the Mountain gave shadow, and the waters were counted, and the Gospel was taught, and the beasts were driven back, and the lamps were lit, and peace was kept among the people. And the Keeper of Shield had two sons; and the elder was great in strength, and broad in the shoulder, and mighty before the beasts; and the younger was small in his body, and cunning in his heart. And the younger looked upon his brother, and saw that the people loved his strength, and envy entered him as a serpent entereth the grass.

And the younger spoke softly unto his brother, and smiled with his mouth while murder grew within him; and he rose against his brother in secret, and slew him where no beast had entered. And the first blood of man cried from the dust. And fear came upon the people, for Shield had defended the Oasis from the beasts without, but had not seen the beast within. And the younger fled from the Oasis, and took with him the wife of his brother, a daughter of Faith, and went out from the shadow of the Mountain into the open land.

I looked toward Shield before I meant to. The perimeter wardens held their places. Each faced the desert while the scripture named the murder behind Shield's back.

And God saw that blood had entered the world of men, and that holy speech had been carried out of the Mountain in the hands of the stolen daughter of Faith; and God cursed them, saying, Thou shalt wander under the eye of Heaven, and the Earth shall not hide thee. Thy children shall thirst for what they cannot keep, and conquer what they cannot love. Thou shalt remember the Mountain, but thou shalt not find it; and thou shalt hear the Gospel, but twist it into hunger. And from the murderer and the stolen daughter came the Outsiders.

— There. It is finished, and you may have your question now: the one you have held since Adam and Eve.

— You have those two names. A garden; a first man; a first woman; a brother who kills his brother in a field. We have that book, or one very near it. I did not think to meet it coming the other way, out of a mountain the world has never heard of.

> *— And the Outsiders multiplied in the open land, and their kings became many, and their cruelty became without number; and they remembered the Mountain in dreams, and hated the shade they could not find. And they gathered armies, and forged blades, and raised engines of war, and came with banners and drums and false prayers upon their tongues.*

False prayers upon their tongues, Paul.

— In our gospel, God forbids Eve from eating the fruit from the tree of knowledge. She does, and God is angry.

— Are women not allowed instruction in your world?

— They are, and they are not. It is complicated.

— Women keep our sacred words. Men kneel when they speak. I think ours are freer than yours. Who wrote your gospel?

— Priests, some twenty-five to forty centuries back, out of older stories still; and it is argued to this day. But the book does not divide us. The woman does. In mine she crosses the threshold by her own hand, and is blamed for it still. In yours she never crosses at all: she is carried over, taken as plunder, blameless because she never lifts a hand. We are two peoples telling one quarrel, each from his own end of it. Mine follows your murderer out of the shade, and the woman he took with him.

— You are wondering whether I know to whom I am speaking. I know exactly, Paul. You are of the open land. By the book I have set before you, you are the murderer's child. You remembered the Mountain. And, against the curse, you found it. I am the sitting proof.

— That is a large accusation to lay on a man across his own fire. The tutor sets you before the first cell and the long climb up to your own hand, and you kneel in the sand and hand me a garden, a murder, and a cursed line walking out into the country I was born in. I am a man of science, and I will not argue a man's scripture while he recites it from memory. Let us continue.

The attendant lowered the bark. For a while no one moved, and the bees went on working the warm rock.

I was allowed to stand after the first silence, and to step to the third marker, and look. Then I saw Va-Sheva of Shield. She stood near the southern perimeter beyond the herb beds, where the Oasis began to turn back toward bare rock. She wore dark Shield leather over her robe, a cloth wrapped round her throat, curls of hair gathered on her left shoulder. She was looking away from me, toward the outer path. As she turned, the sun showed the dark green of her eyes and broke into small moving fires along her hair. I thought, God forgive me, of the archangels I had heard named all my life and never seen: beings of pure light, loosed and dancing on a shield warden's hair.

One of the wardens spoke to her. She kept her eyes on the path and lifted two fingers; one man moved toward the goat pens and another took the outer stones. Then she saw me. One corner of her mouth moved and stopped. She crossed toward me while the Faith attendant went to help the old women. I became suddenly aware of my robe, my bandaged thumb, the sand on my sandals, and the fact that I had been looking too long at everything.

"*Kay* — I mean Sa-Kailan," she said. The prefix in her voice stung, and I was glad of it anyway.

"Va-Sheva." Her eyes went to my thumb. "Light has already started cutting pieces off you."

"Only the useless ones."

"That cannot be true. You are still standing."

I almost laughed. Her mouth moved too.

"You were at the Hall," I said, because I had to say something and chose badly.

"So were most of the people."

Wind moved between us, smelling of goat and wet stone, and under it something dry from beyond the shade.

"You have grown," she said. The words should have pleased me.

"So have you," I said, then hated myself. This time she smiled.

"I had four years' advantage."

"Five, almost."

"You counted?"

"Everyone knows."

My eyes came back from the channels and went where they had no leave to go, and her gaze followed mine and caught me there.

"No," she said. "Boys know such things when they should be learning where to put their eyes." I felt myself stay fifteen in front of her, out of reach completely and intolerably. Even so, her eyes kept returning to the perimeter.

"You are on duty."

"Yes."

"Then should you be speaking to me?"

"No. But I am," she said.

The blood came up into my face, and a smile got away from me. Years before, behind the cistern, she had stolen lamp-oil with me and blamed the smell on a kitchen cat. Then her gaze returned to the perimeter. For a moment we stood side by side and said nothing, both looking outward. I wanted to ask whether she had ever gone past the second ridge, whether Shield feared the Outsiders as scripture feared them or as wardens feared tracks in dust.

"The reading said the Outsiders came from the murderer. Do you believe it?"

"I believe the Mountain is hidden for a reason."

"That is not an answer."

"Do you believe the Book of the Beast?"

"You mean," I said carefully, "that the five Keepers hold together the Beast of Hell, in case the Outsiders come back."

"That is what children say."

"It is what Faith teaches children."

"Faith teaches children the shape of things. Not the weight."

"And what do you say?" I asked her. "Not Faith, not Ka-Dhavar of Shield. You."

"You have worn your prefix for three days and already want the Beast weighed for you."

"Then tell me only whether it is real."

She was silent long enough that I gave up on an answer.

"Shield does not post wardens at empty gates," she finally said.

"The Oasis is so much bigger than the gravures made it," I said after a while.

"The desert is larger."

I looked toward it. The outer path ran out toward the south-east, where a farther ridge stood against the deep desert. On that ridge, for less than a breath, something caught the sun and threw it back, then went dark. I narrowed my eyes.

"What was that?"

Va-Sheva's gaze moved instantly. "Where?"

"There. On the second ridge, the dark stone."

"Do not point." My hand had begun to lift. I lowered it.

"What was it?"

And God called the desert the Threshold;
and He set heat upon it by day,
and cold upon it by night,
and mirage upon its face,
that no man should cross it lightly.

I believed none of it.

Va-Sheva made three gestures in succession: two fingers low, the palm closed, the hand cut toward the outer path. One warden went behind the goat pens and disappeared in shade; another knelt in the dust at the outer marker; a figure answered from the rock above the descent, where I had seen only stone. The Faith attendant pressed her lips together. One of the old women tried to rise and her companion drew her down. A goat stopped chewing. Va-Sheva crouched beside the kneeling warden, touched the ground, rubbed something between her fingers and looked from the outer path to the ridge where I had seen the light. The warden near the stones gave a low call.

"Marker."

One outer marker had been turned. Barely. A flat side faced inward where the others faced skyward. Va-Sheva kept her hands off it, read the dust around it and the path beyond, and then spoke aloud.

"No one returns inside yet."

The Faith attendant's eyes widened. "The access period—"

"Has changed."

"By whose order?"

"Shield holds the Threshold," Va-Sheva said. The attendant lowered her head.

"Good."

A young Balance boy near the herb beds began to cry and covered his mouth with both hands. Va-Sheva walked the marker line without stepping beyond it. At the turned stone she knelt, took a thin bone pin from her sleeve, and lifted a single strand from the ground; it caught the light once, pale against her glove, before she sealed it in a covered dish. "Second gate," she said, and a watcher answered from the slope. Then she turned to the workers.

"Count."

Balance called every tool to its tally, every beast to its pen, every worker to a name. By the tally I heard, nothing was missing from the work.

"Prayer group?"

The Faith attendant named seven. The warden corrected her.

"Six."

The attendant froze. Then one of the old women said sharply, "Mara." The woman beside her looked round. "She has gone out to the south-west markers."

An hour before, I had heard it read over their heads that the beast had come from inside the house, and had watched every warden face the sand while it was said. The one we were missing had knelt beside me through the reading.

Va-Sheva crossed the prayer area at a fast walk, two wardens spreading behind her. The Faith attendant whispered, "God keep her in shadow." Va-Sheva heard. "Silence." The prayer stopped.

From the third prayer stone I could see past the south-west channel to the open markers. They found Mara crouched against a dry stone, one hand flat on it, breathing hard and unable to rise, a sprig of dried herb from the beds still in the other. A Balance worker beside me made a sound low in her throat. Va-Sheva took the sprig, passed it to a warden, helped Mara stand and spoke close to her ear until she closed her eyes and nodded. A warden lifted the grey shawl from her shoulders, folded the dusty hem inward and carried it apart from her.

Then she signalled. The turned marker remained under guard. The second ridge threw back no more light. The old woman was returned to Faith, who received her with a face drained of colour. Va-Sheva came back to the inner shade. Her eyes passed over the group, counted, and settled briefly on me. "Seven bodies held," she said. "Eleven Balance workers held."

The Faith attendant said very quietly, "She is old."

"Yes."

"She meant no harm."

"Intent does not close a breach."

Mara began to weep silently. I looked away. The channel was checked. A small clay seal was pressed beside her name. The prayer group was recounted. The Balance workers lifted their tools without speaking and returned to their tasks.

"You saw the flash first."

"I think so."

"You did not point when told not to."

"No."

"Good."

"Were the three of them connected?" I asked.

"The flash, the marker, and the old woman out of place? Probably not."

"Then why—" She looked at me, and I stopped.

"Because at the Threshold, we join them first and separate them later."

The Faith attendant called us back to the prayer stones for the return blessing. At the second threshold two hands waited for us. First the clay counter, given up into a Balance clerk's palm; she read its number, set it against her slate, and struck the route closed. Then the washing: the dust of the open rinsed from the hands and face in a shallow bowl, the water darkening with it. Behind us, another Faith attendant carried the covered dish over Mara's folded grey shawl between two Shield wardens. And over each of us the first attendant spoke.

"What has touched the open returns under shadow."

We answered. "Under shadow, we return."

We re-entered in single file, and the ceiling came back like a hand over the skull. Relief loosened my shoulders before I could stop it. At evening prayer I thanked God for setting the Mountain over the spring. I fell asleep certain the desert had flashed for me alone.

> — Flashed for me alone. Listen to the boy: he thought God and a whole desert could pick him out of a party.
>
> — Boys do, and it does none of us any harm to have believed it once. Enough for today. You have given me more than a day's worth, and I have an old man's need to sit with a thing before I take the next of it.

Chapter 4

Mountain

— The twenty-first of March; half past nine; the third of our interviews. The instruments reached you at last, I am told, and you did not waste them: swimming, diving, the microscope. And the heavens: *Cosmos, a Personal Voyage*. I should be glad to hear of both before we take up your account again.

— The swimming first, Paul, since you were good enough to win me the instruments. I did not take to it like your seals, but I went in, and I went under. With the glasses pressed to my eyes I put my hand into the weed and closed it; green threads, drifting motes and small living things too faint to name came up in my palm, the things your *Attenborough* had shown me on his lit glass. His pictures held. Under the microscope I saw the cells and dark bodies within some of them. I did not see the double thread the voice had named, but I saw enough to know he had not invented the life in the pond. The heavens I cannot take in my hand. *Cosmos* gave me the making of the world in one turning year: first fire, long dark, wandering rocks; our people arriving in the last breath of the last night, shortly before midnight. Each second of his calendar carried five hundred years. I could stand inside that measure.

— The Cosmic Calendar.

— A man named *Kepler* gave his life to five perfect shapes which he believed ruled the spacing of the worlds. I wrote down his words:

Geometry existed before the creation.
It is co-eternal with the mind of God.
Geometry provided God with a model for the creation.
Geometry is God himself.

He was wrong about the shapes, and his own work broke them. He went on looking. I do not know how a man puts away an idea so beautiful. Then he showed me a man who measured the round earth with a stick, its shadow and the noon sun, and asked no god's leave to do it. *Eratosthenes*: Light's work, with no office to grant him the shadow. The tutor asked whether I wished to repeat the experiment. I did not. And it frightened me that I looked at the stick and thought: that stands. With the moving light however, sometimes I saw a thing caught when it happened; sometimes men dressed and lit to play what had happened; often I could not tell which I had been given. And I cannot settle each question with my own eyes as I settled your pond. In the Mountain, scripture chose and the office chose. A warden told me, *you agree, understanding is not required*. I agreed. If I am free, then I must choose whom to believe with nothing behind the choice but myself. How do you bear it, Paul? If not God, then what?

— Carefully, and never all at once. I trust what has stood against a test and did not fall, and only so far as the test will bear. When a better test throws it down, I take my weight back off it. It is a slow way to live but I have found nothing that beats it.

— *What survives the test*; remember that you said it. I may hold you to it.

— I expect you will. A warning though: a test may tell you a claim survived under its conditions. It cannot tell you that the man who proposed it deserves the rest of your faith.

— Then how do you choose the man?

— In increments. Does he say what he saw, or what flatters him? Does he let you repeat the test? I have given men a year and taken it back in an afternoon.

— A Justice ledger kept against a person.

— If you like. Though one hopes friendship eventually becomes pleasanter than an audit.

— Friendship. You place a large word beside a small test.

— I said eventually. At present I am still asking for your beam. You are meant to be handing me a mountain, not a philosophy of doubt. When last we sat, two days gone, you had reached the Oasis. The beam was already yours by then. Did you return to it the next morning? Give it to me as it came.

One point on the Mirror wall, low on its south-western side, steadier than most, stirred near Second Silence. "That one is yours until you can walk it in the dark," Va-Raedin had said. "Source to fall, fall to source; every mirror, every throat, and whatever stands on its road that has no business there. When you can draw the whole with your eyes shut, you will be given a second. Do not hurry. Hurry is how a candidate loses a beam and lights a wrong room looking for it."

Two servants of Light walked with me. Until two days before I had done their work: from twelve I had carried oil and cloths down these corridors and cleaned the glass I was now sent to read. Oren was twenty, tall enough to meet the lintels. Sela was fourteen, small and thin, her brown hair forever falling forward and being tucked behind one ear. They carried my cloths and oil. My new robe placed me among the first thirty of some five thousand souls.

At the fall, where my point died, Sela had the bronze test-glass out before I asked. Its frame held a glass wedge smoked from black to clear, its edge numbered in equal measures of light. Oren set his thumb flat across its face. "The cloth," I said. "Oil from your hand will darken the glass and give the next man a false mark." He removed his thumb and used the cloth. I had helped the source crews turn the wide mirror throats south for winter and north for summer. We said: "We divide the sun. We lose none of it."

I slid the wedge across the point until the last light disappeared. Sela called the mark; Oren entered it on a wax tablet; I cleaned the glass and made them repeat the measure. Then we walked backward. The point widened into a pale bar at the first throat, vanished around a polished corner and returned below our knees. At each surface I marked the angle with two strokes, named the passage and checked the previous measure.

I told Sela to keep the passage clear while I read the glass. Two kitchen hands came up with a board of hot loaves. She moved our oil against the wall and beckoned them through. "I have not finished." "I will call the mark again, Candidate." I stepped aside and waited for the bread to pass.

Shield stopped us at the first turn. A warden raised one hand and held back three workers, two children, and the three of us together.

"South service way is closed," he said. A woman with folded cloth on her hip frowned.

"Since when?"

"Since it was closed."

"I have cloth due in the herb rooms."

"Then it will arrive by another passage."

"That is half an Hour added, and my back already full." The warden kept his eyes on the bundles.

"Then the cloth will be tired."

The children laughed until their father quieted them. The woman shifted the cloth and took the long way, annoyed and unsurprised. When the warden waved her on, the door behind him opened a hand's breadth. Two Shield wardens walked inside it. Between them, a Faith attendant carried the bone-pinned dish over Mara's folded grey shawl. I had watched the pale strand sealed into that dish beside the turned marker the day before. A woman in Balance green followed them with a sealed slate. The door shut.

Oren had already turned toward the permitted passage. Sela looked once at the closed door, then at me. I sent them after the beam.

The beam climbed a service throat and came down where Balance kept the water. Households waited along a shallow channel with marked vessels. Two green clerks walked a copper rod from notch to notch, reading allowance by household, work, illness, the unborn and yesterday's draw. One woman protested when her mark stopped below the line she expected. A clerk laid yesterday's tablet beside today's, showed her the two notches and moved to the next vessel while she was still speaking. An ashkeeper lifted her jar. A high lamp bent along the curve of the clay and made the water appear higher on one side. My eye would have called the jar fuller from there.

Beyond the water, steam, yeast and boiled grain filled the low kitchens, and the workers sang over the sealing of the jars.

Let every fruit be gathered.
Let every vessel be sealed.
Let no waste enter the Oasis.

One woman sang each word; another kept her kneading to the lines; a boy's mouth began moving when an elder looked round. Further along, mirrors carried a pale daylight into beds of growing things, and leaves stood toward it in a green gallery far below the open air. Warm air came off the kitchens and returned past wet stone smelling of soil and green stems. At the salt-house, brine boiled in sealed vessels. Pure water condensed down the lids and returned by pipe; the residue went onto Balance pans, and a boy copied the weight. A woman in green compared it with seven earlier marks and covered the column when we passed.

I slowed to watch them, longer than the beam allowed. A kitchen supervisor caught me at it. “You want to knead, Light? We can always find a back.” A few workers laughed. “No,” I said. “Then keep moving. Even Light casts shadows.” I moved.

> — Wait. What did the salt-house measure?
>
> — What remained when a measured cup of spring water had been taken apart and the pure water returned. Salt, mineral, trace: whatever the spring carried that morning. Balance kept the weight and did not give the boy the meaning.
>
> — Was every cup of the spring weighed, or some?
>
> — Samples at appointed Hours, from different channels. I carried sealed cups there as a servant and received empty ones back. The numbers belonged to Balance. May I continue?
>
> — Please do.

Below the kitchens the beam entered a tangle of brackets and I lost it. I drew the route back from two clean reflections until the missing thread stood plain. Sela was looking at me. Colour rose across her face; she lowered her head and folded one cloth twice, then a third time. I gave the brackets my whole attention until she had finished folding.

Near the tool wash Sa-Tavan of Justice stood with a slate under one arm and the new black cord at his wrist. The sign on his robe showed a square and circle crossing inside a rectangle, their common surface worked in red.

“Sa-Kailan of Light,” he said. “I was told you would come through here, at this Hour. I have been waiting.”

“Then you have wasted an Hour,” I answered. I had heard Candidates give that answer to servants. It felt good in my mouth.

“I have not; Justice may wait and still be working. Shield has given me the counts and the containment. What the tablet wants is the order, from one who stood in it. Tell me what you saw, and the order you saw it in.”

I gave him the sequence I had built while he waited. “Va-Sheva named a mirage off the south-eastern ridge. First. Shield found a marker turned, by wind or a careless hand. Second. An old woman was missed from prayer after that, at the south-west markers for a sprig. Third. Clear ground between the light and the woman. She never stood outside the Mountain’s shadow.”

Sa-Tavan wrote the three entries. "A very clean order."

"It is the order."

"It is an order," he said. "The tablet will keep the words you give it."

He dipped the stylus again. The red overlap on his robe moved with his breath. I could have replaced *mirage* with *light*. I watched him cut the next mark and said nothing.

"And the woman?" I asked. He finished writing before he answered.

"If the light was Shield's to name and she stood apart from it, she is a strayed old woman. Strayed is an old and gentle category. I will read every straying the tablets hold, what followed each, and keep the one that answers nearest hers. Upon the likeliest I judge, never upon my liking. Where mercy and the Mountain cannot both be kept, the Mountain comes first. She will be marked, watched a season, and let be."

His eye dropped to my bound thumb. "Have that witnessed, so no one confuses a ritual wound with an instruction wound." He turned, then stopped. "One class more while the tablet is open: a Candidate of Light at the Oasis inside his first two days. I shall read every such visit beside yours. The ones that came to nothing, and the ones that did not." He spoke the last words toward the wall and left.

> — Is that where your counting began?
>
> — I had counted all my life. That morning I began to count the counters.
>
> — You called the light a mirage after telling me you believed none of Va-Sheva's scripture. You did that to protect Mara?
>
> — I put Mara as far from the light as the sequence allowed. I also put my own seeing under Shield's word. Both fitted on the same tablet.
>
> — And Sa-Tavan heard the fit.
>
> — He heard enough to keep the tablet open.

I passed the child halls, cut into warmer stone near the family districts. Children sat on woven mats while a Faith teacher moved among them with a cord of five knots.

The Mountain is refuge.
The Oasis is water.
The forest was plenty.
Beyond the forest thou shalt not wander.

The teacher touched the fifth knot. "And if the forest is gone?" The youngest faltered; the older answered.

The Covenant remains.

Further on, an older class stood for a harder verse, and the teacher took them through it a line at a time.

And when the wrath had passed,
the armies of the Outsiders were no more;
but the forest was broken,
and the open waters were spoiled,
and the land around the Mountain became desert.

— That second verse, the forest turned desert, they teach it happened in a day.

— In a day. That is how we are taught it; the verse itself gives no duration.

— A forest does not die in a day. Not by any weather I have read in the ground. Drought is slow: ten years, a hundred, a thousand. What comes up between one dawn and one dusk, and leaves a desert where a forest stood?

— There is a scripture for it, a book of its own, the Book of the Cataclysm, and I will recite it to you entire when we reach the place it belongs to, and not one morning sooner. For now you have exactly what the children have: a wrath, a forest broken, a desert made.

— You are moving quickly through your Mountain today.

— You asked for the beam as it came. It did not stop to explain the children.

The beam reached a low Balance door at the south-western edge of everything I knew. Justice's mark stood beside Balance's on the lintel. A thread came out under the door. I slid the wedge across it until the thread vanished: four marks. I was reaching for the doctrine — a beam is Light's to follow — when a voice took it out of my mouth.

"Sa-Kailan of Light."

Ka-Cheryn of Balance was broad and stooped, with a long, smoke-darkened face and heavy brows drawn low over deep-set eyes. A stained felt cap narrowed to a blunt point. Her grey hair hung in two coarse ropes down her chest, almost hiding the insignia of Balance.

"It leaves my door," she said, "and you would like to know what it did inside. You may not come in."

"A beam is Light's to account for," I said.

"Then account for it from where you stand." She folded her hands, and I understood that she had said everything she intended to say.

Four marks under her door. Somewhere above, a source had been given whole to the Mirror. Between the two lay a room I would enter on no day of my life. I asked her to have the door cracked a hand's width.

"Once," she said, "and briefly."

I had one look and had to spend it. I spent it on the walls and the ceiling, hunting a lamp, a window, a second shaft, any crossing reflection: light made inside that room would spoil every measure I could take outside it. The door opened a hand's breadth on bare stone, and shut.

"Go round by the outer stair," I said. Ka-Cheryn watched me go.

At the far wall the beam vanished at eight marks. Eight entered the room, four left. The room kept the missing half. I followed the whole beam to the source. It was almost Fourth Record when the work let us go. Oren gathered the cloths and oil, folded himself under a low lintel, struck his head on it regardless, and said a word Faith would have fined him for. Sela laughed and covered her mouth. I laughed too.

"He meets that lintel at the third turn every day of his life," she said. "Every day it takes him by surprise."

"Perhaps he keeps hoping the Mountain will enlarge itself for him."

"Perhaps he does." She looked at me. "What is the beam for? You walked one line of light for a whole day. What does a man learn?"

"The learning, it stays in Light," I said. "When the day comes that you are named, you will be told."

She folded the cloth over the oil, lowered her eyes and called me "Candidate" when she thanked me for the day. Then she went after Oren. I remained at the source until the last crew left.

> — You resented every door kept against you, then shut one in a fourteen-year-old girl's face.
>
> — Yes.
>
> — Why?

— The robe answered before the boy did. That is the kind account. The true one is uglier: for one day I possessed a thing she wanted, and I enjoyed possession long enough to lose the person asking.

— You gave me Oren's height and Sela's face.

— Then perhaps this room is making me sentimental.

As I passed the Hall of Ceremony, Faith attendants were reciting more verses.

And God said, Keep thou the Mountain,
and keep thou the Oasis,
and keep thou the Temple.
Keep the secrets apart,
and let no one hand hold the whole.

I stopped just past the northern arch of the Hall. I had spoken those words myself, in the Hall, two days before. *The Temple.* I had said it a thousand times and never once asked where it stood.

In the candidate quarters I took out the Light token Va-Raedin had given me and held its hair-wide hole to my eye. It showed me the dim wall and nothing more.

It slipped into the cup beside my knee. Through the water it lay a finger's width from where my hand had dropped it, nearer the surface, larger than itself. When I moved my head, it moved. The token lay still at the bottom. The same bend had raised the water against the ashkeeper's jar.

That night, eyes shut, I drew the beam's road: every turn, throat and surface. I set the Balance room upon it as one dark bead. Light's creed said we lost nothing. My drawing held a whole beam entering and half leaving. I named the missing half *contraband light*: light off the ledger, taxed at no gate.

— At this point you had an input and an output. That proves loss. Why call it theft?

— Because the source had been allocated whole to the Mirror, and the room kept a private share behind a Balance door marked by Justice. Later I learned that Light watched every room which did this, and marked the hand admitted, what entered, what left and who came to the door; without telling anybody.

— And that verse: *Keep the secrets apart, and let no one hand hold the whole.*

— You say that as a man who would very much like to hold the whole himself.

— Every man in my trade would. That is exactly why your people were wise to see to it that none of us can. … No: let me answer cleanly, since you have paid me in candour all week and I have answered mostly in tea. I am no disinterested clerk. The Blackwood Foundation offered me a scholarship with a cage built into it, comfortable enough: the single condition of the money was that I give my one life to your people and to nothing else. I learned a tongue I was privately certain some dead Victorian had invented to defraud his patrons. I watched men I trained beside spend whole careers on their knees in the dirt to lift a handful of bones three thousand years old; and the very best of them, once in a decade, opens a sealed tomb four or five thousand years old, and is made for life by it. And you sit across this fire, breathing, and hand me eleven thousand years that walks, and argues, and complains that its sandals pinch. Any man of my trade worthy of the name would give his life to stand where you stood as a boy, and count the price a bargain before he had heard it named.

— … You have never once let that show.

— I am letting it show now because I am about to ask you for something, and you should know the size of the want behind it. Here it is. Not the account: the place. Swear to me that if ever the occasion comes to you, however it comes and whatever it costs, you will take me there.

— … I will try, Paul. That much I will swear, and mean it. But hear the rest before you thank me for it. I can bring you to the door. But coming to the Mountain has a price, and I do not yet know what yours would be, nor whether you would be asked to pay it standing or kneeling. What the Mountain does with a man of the open land who has seen its inside, I may not be able to undo, even for a man I have come to … to trust.

— That is fair. I prefer an honest "I will try" to a kind lie. A man who has read the book you read me at the Oasis does not expect the door to be free.

— There is something else you should know. Va-Elise received me from Shield and placed me under instruction. Ka-Sarah authorised it.

— Sarah.

— You call her Mrs Blackwood. Horizon calls her Ka-Sarah.

— You have met her as Keeper of an organisation I have never been told exists, and you thought this a detail to leave until now.

— I met her between exile and this room. Your house has asked for my life in order. I am giving it in order.

— You know my employer by a title of command, and I know her as the woman who signs the Foundation accounts. Compartmentalisation is considerably less charming when viewed from below.

— You see, Paul? Already you are learning the Mountain. Enough of the Mountain for one morning. I want to give you a thing and ask you a thing, and I want neither done in this chair. For four days they have tried to get me outdoors for my health, and I have refused you like a sulking child. Take me out now. Count it your victory.

— Gladly. There is a lawn on the south side, past the glass doors, that no one crosses in this weather.

[—]

— There. You see? I am standing under the whole enormous nothing of it, and I have not fallen down. I can see cloud over the ridge and bare branches above the roof without needing stone beyond them. The cold helps. Now walk with me. Away from the doors, to the middle, where the grass is longest.

— Your hand is shaking.

— I have spent my life under ceilings. Let me blame the cold while I earn the truth.

— You have made progress.

— Do not make it sentimental. I may retreat to the shrubbery.

— You did not bring me out for the sky.

— No. I brought you out for the one thing this ground has that your room does not: no walls. A wall can be given an ear; grass cannot. Out here there is nothing that hears me but you and that machine on your shoulder. I have decided to trust the machine because it is yours and repeats what it hears. Will you trust me for a moment and play a small game?

— That depends upon the game.

— You sound wary.

— You have spent the morning taking my method apart and fitting it to your own hand. I am interested in where you intend to point it.

— It is designed for the *man of science* you claim to be. You told me you trust *what survives a test*. This afternoon, when you would sit alone turning the reel, go behind the glass of the room where you set me down each day. Look. When we next meet, tell me whether anyone was there.

— Behind the glass.

— You told me no one watched me. A man kept apart cannot know what stands beyond his own wall. If the place is empty, you will have proved me a frightened fool; I will play your football and never trouble you with it again. I suspect that there is a Mirror in this house: a thing of glass and angle that watches without a watcher. Four years I stood under the finest eyes my world made. Here men hold things they were never told and answer questions never spoken. Whether the eye is set upon me or Sarah, I cannot know. If you find it, let nothing cross your face. When part of a beam

disappeared into a room, Light sometimes left the apparatus untouched and counted. Keeping it undisturbed produced the truer map. Do not spend that advantage on the first afternoon.

— And that is all? A Mirror in the walls, an unnamed eye upon yourself or Sarah, and me to go feeling for all of it in the dark and keep my face straight while I do? She runs a great deal, I grant you: ships, fuel, metals, men who matter; it is not impossible she is watched. But that is a very great deal of shadow to hang upon a room you have sat in just a few times.

— That is all. If you find a watcher behind that glass — a man, a machine, any evidence that the room was built to observe — then your loyalty comes to me, Paul.

— That is a large thing to swear on a lawn.

— If I am wrong, it costs you an afternoon and a promise that can never fall due. Go behind the glass, Paul. For her, if not for me. Swear me the small thing: it survives its test, or it does not.

— Very well. If I find the eye you have described, which I will not, then I am your man. There: it costs me nothing to promise what cannot come to pass. Now put your face straight before we go in. You look like a young man who has got away with something.

— The safest man in any house, Paul. No one troubles to watch the pleased ones. Come in out of the cold: you are kept in your cell as I am kept in mine, and yours opens from the inside.

— So. The swimming.

— I told you this morning what it cost me, and I want more of it. Tell the physician he beat me, and by beating me recruited me: I will go back, go deeper and work toward swimming without the armbands. Two days, then. Go and do your looking, Paul. Whatever you find behind that glass: keep your face.

Chapter 5

Shadow

— The twenty-third of March; nine o'clock; the fourth of our interviews. I have brought you two gifts this morning. Here is the first.

— … Kepler's five solids of *God Himself*. Thank you. They are cold in the hand, and lighter than they look. Beautiful.

— In truth they are much older than *Kepler*; the Greeks had named and studied them long before he borrowed them to explain the solar system. In any case, as you see, they are hollow: only the edges.

— This one is mine. The fewest faces; the sharpest point; the one you can set down no way but upright, a little flame standing on the table. This one is surely Light's. The cube, perhaps, is Shield: a closed door on every side. The third, for its beauty, may be Faith. The other two I cannot yet place: Justice speaks last, which would leave Balance the fourth, and Justice the largest of them. It is not yet clear to me; I shall think on it.

— The second gift I built myself, from a child's set, and I am not too proud to say I enjoyed it. Gears within gears within gears. See the single pin fixed to the first: one full turn advances the second by one tooth. The second has a pin of its own for the third. How many teeth upon each wheel?

[—]

— Forty teeth. Then the first must turn forty times for the second to turn once, and sixteen hundred times for the third to turn once and ring the gong. Add three more forty-tooth wheels and the first must turn one hundred and two million four hundred

thousand times. That is the scale. If the first turns once a second, give the last wheel six teeth instead of forty and the gong waits fifteen million three hundred and sixty thousand seconds: nearly half a year. Here, look for yourself.

[—]

— And something of my world in turn. My own kind has lately begun building a clock of the same ambition: meant to tick once a year, and taken for a wholly new idea. Here, I have printed you a picture of it. And your kind had the same thought eleven and a half millennia ago.

— Is your world under some threat, then? Something you are trying to outlast through time, as we try to outlast the Outsiders?

— Yes; and it moves slowly, across centuries, perhaps millennia. There is much debate as to its nature, whether it is real at all, and what ought to be done. Should you hear of it during instruction, do ask me again. But to return to the clock: your Pendulum, does it ever stop?

— Yes: once in a lifetime, and only for an instant, upon the ascension of a new Keeper of Light. For Light came before Time; and when the chain of Light is renewed, when Light dies and is reborn, God holds His breath for an instant. Then the Pendulum begins again.

— Then it is surely being wound, most likely by a weight. As the weight falls, it yields just enough to overcome the friction that would otherwise still your pendulum within a day, and is raised again at intervals. And with a train of gears upon gears upon gears, the teeth carefully numbered, your clock might be made to strike but twice a year. The toy you may keep, to study. Now, unless you wish to discuss instruction, let us begin.

— You must forgive me the *philosophy of doubt* you would not hear of two days ago. I was taught to see mechanism as doctrine, and doctrine as mechanism; I look upon a thing, and my mind turns it over until I see how the doctrine makes the object. Your clock is the perfect instance of an object whose birth comes from doctrine.

— And what doctrine, what mechanism, did you find in the *Species Odyssey*, in the journey from monkey to man?

— One plain thing the three films would not say aloud, I could not stop hearing underneath them. Your man climbs out of the animals, then from wanderers to cities and nations. Do you know what drove him up the ladder? The beasts have hunger and remain beasts. A man can be refused. Tell him no, not you, not now, not yet, and he will build a wonder to be told yes. A people that learns to refuse itself by law dams the flood and opens the gate on the appointed day; it turns every ungiven night into a cathedral. I learned it watching myself. Most of what I made of myself, I made to be looked at once by a girl of Shield who never quite managed it. The beam, the ascent, the whole of my cleverness: a boy raising a cathedral to be told yes, and told nothing. What does a man build when the girl is a whole world of them, and no night

> is ungiven? Does he raise a greater cathedral, or lie down in the warm water of every easy yes and let the light go out?
>
> — I would need more than your own disappointment to explain the building of cities. These are subjects our kind is loath to discuss. When such a conversation begins, spirits are apt to be possessed by the Beast, to borrow your language; and it is generally the wiser course to change the subject. Now: how long did it take you to learn every single beam on the Mirror?

Four years: Va-Raedin of Light had told the truth; there was no shorter road. Let me take it up again at the morning he judged me worthy to be taught the five ways that light can lie. I am now nineteen years old.

We entered the first practice hall. He led me past the mirror rooms, past the chamber where the point had trembled on the wall the day I embarrassed myself, and into a low service slit beside a lamp niche. The passage descended. A side passage breathed out cold and earth: the mushroom rooms, racked white to the roof, a woman going down them with a wetted cloth. The lamps were set near the floor, so their light kept my feet visible while the rest of me passed through darkness. The lamp-cleaner's blackest leavings were kept: the soot he scraped from the flues and the lamp-throats was gathered, bound with gum and a little water, and became the ink the records were written in.

At the end stood a plain door of pale wood. Beyond was a room almost entirely dark. One lamp burned outside and behind us, high in the passage wall, and its light entered through a narrow slit in the door and cut a single hard line across the floor.

Va-Raedin did not open it at once. "The Balance door," he said. "You reported eight measures entering, four leaving, and no other source."

"Yes."

"What did you prove?"

"That the room retained half the beam."

"What did you prove about its use?"

"Nothing."

He opened the door. "Good. You have carried a trace four years without making it confess. Keep that discipline today."

"Five shadows. Today you learn the principal forms by which light lies. First shadow."

The mirror in the middle of the room was tall and narrow, angled toward the far wall. I saw the door behind me, the slit of light, the passage beyond it, and standing in that passage a figure where no figure stood. I turned before I could think. The passage was empty. When I looked back into the glass, the figure was still there.

"Who is it?" Va-Raedin asked.

"No one."

"Then why did you turn?"

"Because I believed the sight before I questioned the path."

"Good." He adjusted the mirror by less than a finger's width. The figure vanished, and in its place was the back of my own head.

"A mirror shows what is behind the eye. That is its use, and its corruption. You were shown it — learn the difference, or stay Candidate."

He covered the mirror.

> — Your hands. You have been at something this whole time, and never once looked down. What are you engraving with this needle upon the stone?
>
> — The hands work while the rest of me speaks.
>
> — And the stone?
>
> — A stone with nothing on its face. For later. Or for nothing at all; we shall see.

He lowered one lamp and raised another, and the room turned monstrous.

"Second shadow. Find what is hidden."

Rods cast five dark lines, and a trough a heavy black band. I knelt by the band and found nothing. I stood, looked at the wall, then back to the floor, and there it was — a faint brightness where darkness should have climbed. Something low was blocking the floor-light alone. I reached into the trough's shadow and found a black cord hanging from a hidden hook.

"What is it?" he asked.

"A cord."

"What does it do?"

I pulled it before I had thought. A panel opened behind me with a hard click, and I froze. It revealed only stone. He crossed the room, closed the panel, and came back.

"Pride pulled it."

"It was not pride. It was my hand."

"Your hand had no reason of its own."

I looked up. "Why does Light speak in sentences like that?"

"Because Light is doctrine, not a hundred tricks with mirrors and lenses. The tricks are only the means. Light doctrine is a way to look at the world."

"And the sentences?"

"Each sentence acts like a training room. Remember one, and you know where the door stands. Understand one, and you pass through, deeper into Light." He paused for an instant, and then continued, "Remember your first lesson, that sight depends on position. Do you think it is a trick about mirrors?"

"Not anymore." I thought for a while, and Va-Raedin let me. "It means two people may hold different, opposite, even contradictory judgements depending on who they are, where they have been or the choices they have made."

"Quite. And now you are truly Light. No other Kahir in the Mountain could say what you have just said. Now the cord, what if that had opened a gate? Released water? Summoned Shield?"

"I should have waited."

"Good."

"Third shadow. Which mark matters?"

The third room held a glass disk hung from three metal cords. A side lamp threw light through the disk so that one seed-mark swelled into a patch the size of my palm while the others nearly vanished. I moved around the disk. The large mark blurred when I stepped aside; another, nearly invisible from the first position, sharpened; lowering my eye swelled the second while the first smeared.

"None matters by itself," I said. "The lens grants the importance."

"The hand that places the lens grants it. The lens only obeys its shape." He tilted the disk, and the enlarged mark stretched into a long black wound.

"What is it now?"

"The same mark."

"Would a crowd know that?"

"No."

I looked at the palm-sized mark. "Light must know how easily the seed became a wound."

"Good."

We worked the lenses until my eyes ached. Glass disks, water-filled bulbs, oil jars, thin plates that widened light or narrowed it or sharpened one edge while

ruining another. He made me stand close, then far, then above and below, then with one eye shut, then viewing by reflection first.

"You cannot judge a room from its doorway," he said. "You will spend your life in doorways. Move before you judge." He set the lens down.

He allowed water then — a small cup, plain clay. I drank too fast and caught myself watching the rim instead of the room.

"Any thoughts on water?" he said.

"It does strange things. I noticed it properly for the first time when I dropped my token in a jar, the day after I earned it."

"Misuse teaches: the wrong instrument, in the wrong hand, in the wrong room, held with an erring intent. Whether the finder outlives his finding is a second lesson, and not one Light sets out to teach."

> *In English*
>
> — Hey Paul, knock knock.
>
> — Good Lord. Not him. ...Who is there?
>
> — Norma Lee.
>
> — Heaven help me. ...Norma Lee who?
>
> — *Normally* I would not interrupt an Englishman during his bedtime story. But you said *as soon as it is ready*. Here, the report you asked for.
>
> [—]
>
> — Urs, ... Is this some manner of a sick joke?
>
> — Yes. That is exactly it. A very expensive prank: three vehicles, seventeen men, two aircraft, three borders and a physician kept a year on retainer, all so we might sit a lunatic in front of *Carl Sagan*. Please do try to keep up, for the indecency of how much you are paid. He is a new kind of human, Paul. In truth, a very old one. Sarah has put a name on the file: *homo absconditus*. The hidden man.
>
> — Urs!
>
> *In German*
>
> — Dummkopf! [*Door slam*]
>
> *In Noxius*
>
> — Ignore him. Let's continue
>
> — He said it is about me. Give it to me.

— The doctors took blood during your examination. You were entitled to be told before anyone used it for more than your care. You were not told. I am telling you now.

— And the test?

— It read the same code you sought in the creatures from the pond: inherited order carried in living cells. Look at this figure. The line running here is mine, the living people of the open world. This short dead branch is the cousin humanity we call Neanderthal. This other company was known first from a finger bone and teeth in a cave in the East; a jaw and a skull have since given it more shape. The mark from your blood falls outside all three, nearest the two ancient branches and distinct from every recovered sample.

[—]

— You have put the whole Mountain on one black branch.

— No. I have put one sample from one man beside other samples. It tells me where your inherited code does not belong and where it comes nearest. It tells me nothing of your number, history, home or the meaning of a single rite.

— Near is not within.

— Correct. The evidence bears a branch, not a final name. *Homo absconditus* is Sarah's file label: the hidden man. It is not a verdict of science.

— Yet your face refuses it.

— My face has had less time with the evidence than my reason.

— Paul, I can see disbelief in anybody's face. I am not sure which game we are playing, but I think I am winning.

— You are winning the point the test bears. Do not make it bear the rest of your history.

— A trace, not a story.

— Precisely. Continue.

The fourth room was bright, white-walled, severe. A fixed lamp cast a beam down through a bronze slit onto a table cut with narrow channels. At the far end, under glass, lay a small black mark. The beam fell too far left to touch it.

"Strike the mark with light."

I inspected the apparatus. On the table stood clear water, oil, a cloudy liquid, all in triangular vessels; and a clay pot. I began with clear water. The beam crossed two faces of the triangle: turned entering the vessel, and turned again exiting it, short of the mark. Oil thickened it and blurred its edge. The cloudy liquid turned it too much, far off the mark on the other side. No single vessel struck the mark

cleanly, so I tried combinations, without success. I lifted the cloudy cup, smelled it, found the mineral bitterness.

"Salted water," I said.

I slowly diluted it with the clean water till the beam struck the mark true.

"Acceptable. Again, without it." He removed the salted water vessel from the table.

I looked at the table, then at the sealed pot. "May I open it now?"

"No."

I had to solve the opposite problem, make the clear water turn further. I tried to add oil to the water but they would not merge, no matter how hard I tried to mix them together. Nearby were channels for drainage, though I had no idea what they were meant to drain. I scraped a little white grain from their edge with my fingernail.

"That is theft from Balance," Va-Raedin said.

"It was already spilled. It was already unmeasured."

I stopped. Then he said, "Continue."

I stirred the grains into the water. Nothing changed to the eye. The beam turned a little more — and fell short. Another scrape, more stirring, another test. Each scrape from the table felt more like theft than the last. At last the beam struck the mark cleanly.

"How much salt?"

"I do not know."

"A dangerous answer, but honest."

"It looks the same," I said, looking at the water.

"Many changed things do. If one knows where to look. The turn is the measure, Sa-Kailan: whether the jar holds water or oil, and how much salt is dissolved in it, the light will tell you by the angle alone. There is more past a Candidate's knowledge: how a substance can block light, or filter it, or split it, and that the measure of the light is the measure of the substance — part of a Veil's curriculum, if you ever demonstrate yourself worthy of it by finding the Veil's Chamber."

The last chamber held a long trough of clear water set into black stone. On one side of the trough, a narrow glass tube beneath it carried light from a hidden source up into the water itself. And on the wall to the other side of the trough, a small golden plate stood dry outside it. The beam travelled underwater toward the surface at a shallow angle and vanished.

"Make the beam strike the gold plate."

I leaned over the trough. The beam came up against the water's skin so shallow that the beam was reflected downward and stayed inside the water.

"If the beam rises steeply, it leaves. If it comes too shallow, the surface reflects it," I said.

"Exactly. We call it threshold return," he said. "Every crossing has a condition. Some thresholds forgive. Others don't. Make the beam leave."

I stepped back. *Change the condition*, I thought he would tell me. "Salt," I said.

This time a small open dish of coarse crystals waited beside the trough. I took a pinch and let it fall. The grains sank and dissolved, and the surface gave me back exactly the mirror it had shown before — no thread, no glimmer, no change at all.

"Worse," I said.

More salt held the beam in, so thinner water should let it out. So I thinned the water, clear from a side vessel, a little at a time — and for a long while it gave me nothing. Then, between one pour and the next, it broke: a single thread escaped flat along the surface, so nearly level with the water that it was barely a leaving. I thinned it further, and the thread lifted — a little higher with each pour, climbing off the water in even steps as the water weakened — until it reached the gold plate and struck the lower edge. A pale mark appeared on the metal.

"Acceptable."

"No." I said it too loudly. "I mean — this is more than acceptable."

Half a smile escaped his composure.

"Fifth shadow?"

"The same threshold can show, or hide, or carry. A man looking down may see nothing, or see himself, or see through, or never know that light is moving beneath him."

He covered the salt.

"You have learned enough for one day."

He opened a hidden plug. The water drained. The beam broke, blurred and guttered into useless glow. Wet stone and a plain gold plate remained.

"You ended it."

"I ended your belief that discovery entitles continuation. Name the five shadows."

"Reflection, shadow, focus, turning and threshold return."

At last he said, "A Candidate learns where light falls."

I knew the answering sentence. *A Veil learns who placed it*. But I kept it.

"A Candidate also learns where he has been made to stand," I said instead.

He held my gaze. Then he laughed once, a short sound I had never heard from him. Was it pride?

We came out near the northern Light practice corridor. Beyond the walls the ordinary Mountain went on — carts, children, water, the drag of gate chains and low voices. At the candidate entrance he turned.

"You will write nothing of today. You will not speak of salted water to another Candidate. You will not ask Balance for salt outside assignment. You will not attempt threshold return in basin, cup, jar, trough, or any other vessel whose proper use your curiosity believes it can improve."

I looked down. "No, Veil."

"Good."

He began to turn away, then stopped.

"Sa-Kailan."

"Yes?"

"What did you learn?"

I could have named the five shadows again and made them clean and pleasing. I wanted the praise Va-Raedin gave when an answer settled neatly into place for him.

"I learned that a path can be hidden inside a lesson."

"Quite. Ka-Syphiron will receive you tomorrow at First Light, for further instructions," he said, and then left.

> — I enjoyed our walk two days ago, Paul. I should like to stand under the open light longer this time. Tell the physician it is his victory and his cure; he need not learn that it is also mine.
>
> — Shall I leave the machine indoors, since we are only walking?
>
> — No. Keep it on you, and keep it running.
>
> [—]
>
> — Before the glass, one thing I have carried since I woke in your house: your kind brought me across the whole world. How?
>
> — The House of Blackwood is resourceful. Sir Edward, Sarah's father, built a business trading oil, metals and uranium around the world, often where cleaner hands would not go. In the eighties, when Kingston was an hour from darkness and no one else would supply it, Edward sent oil and took alumina in return. A gift so weighted may become a long leash. Favours owed endure: one was called in to secure a diplomatic

flight to Geneva, for your travel, and no questions were asked. Urs can trace the vehicles, aircraft and prepared fuel through the accounts. The last leg was made in the family helicopter now standing on this lawn. The desert road, the airfields and every hand between were kept from me. I can only infer that each person who moved you held one portion of the route.

— A route with the secrets kept apart.

— And speaking of around the world: do your people hold the Earth for a sphere? Did they find it with *Eratosthenes*'s stick and noon shadow?

— We know that it is a sphere, and also we do not. It is complicated, to borrow your word. Now the glass. You went behind it. Tell me what you saw, and spare me none of it.

— You called it a Mirror in the house. We call it CCTV: closed-circuit television. Fixed cameras watch the grounds and carry their pictures by wire to one room. Two house security men sat there before a wall of screens. They were Sarah's men, doing the work she pays them to do. She may run those pictures backward when she needs them. The system guards the estate and it guards you. I asked her last night whether I might tell you. She said yes.

— There were men behind the glass.

— There were.

— Then your promise has fallen due.

— I said I would be your man if the test proved you right. I do not withdraw it.

— ... Good. Anything else?

— No. Behind the same glass, set into a panel aimed at the instruction room, was a second device that kept moving images and sound in its own removable memory. No wire joined it to Sarah's system. I left it untouched. Roger Martinez came in alone, opened it, took out the memory, fitted another and went away without showing any sign that he had seen me.

— Sarah's man.

— Senior on the uranium desk. He entered Blackwood under Edward and serves Sarah now. He deals face to face in countries around your desert. Beyond that, I do not know him.

— A man serving one house carries away a second record the house already possesses. Contraband light for a contraband Mirror. You find that merely unusual?

— I find it suspicious. I do not know that the record was his, where he took it, whether Sarah ordered it, or whom it serves. Roger's hand on the memory is a trace. Betrayal is a story the trace may yet bear, and may not.

— ... I can feel the cord in my hand, and I want to pull it.

— That is why I have not told Sarah. It was your bargain that bought this much: a small part of what I learn stays between us. Give me time to watch without warning whoever owns it that the device has been found.

— Then I shall put my needle and stone away; for now.

— What are they for?

— Your ceremony. I meant to make you kneel under this tree and swear yourself into an order I invented yesterday: a drop of blood on the stone, a covenant, a name to carry to your grave.

— *Discovery does not entitle continuation?*

— Quite. The word remains, even if the rite waits. Shield faces the enemy outside the wall. Shadow faces the enemy already within it. For now it is a keepership of one and a question placed in your hand. If there is an enemy in this house, finding him would serve the Mountain and Sarah. If there is none, we do not manufacture one to justify our fear.

— You are placed to suspect. I am placed to test.

— And to judge which doors remain shut. I crossed one as a young man, into a room I was never meant to enter, and it cost me the rest of my life. Weigh that before you look, not after. You alone have the lens for this world.

— Then I will weigh it, and keep my face over it.

Chapter 6

Festival

— The twenty-fifth of March; quarter to nine; the fifth of our interviews. Did you like *Les grands mythes : L'Iliade et l'Odyssée*, from *ARTE*? It was in another language, but subtitled in yours just the same. We aim to teach, and we aim to entertain, and a story this old does both at once.

— Yes. A wedding; an apple; three who quarrelled over it. And the war that followed. I have had it since we last spoke. … There were five in that room, Paul. Your tellers say three. There were five, and they are mine.

— Go on.

— I have finally found a use for these solids you brought me. *Eris*, the one who throws the golden *Apple of Discord* to the fairest, makes no vanity, invents no rivalry, produces no bribery. She only sets a thing down where they become visible, and steps back, and lets them show themselves. She is my *tetrahedron* flame. She is Light.

Hera offers rank, and takes the refusal of rank for an injury that must be punished. She thinks in precedent, sequence and consequence. She is Justice, and my *dodecahedron*: twelve faces, each made of five sides, as Justice must hear the five before it may judge the one.

Athena offers wisdom, but only in the shape of victory, glory and war. Shield would recognise her across a hall. She is my *cube*.

Aphrodite offers desire through *Helen of Sparta*; and desire outweighs rank and victory both, which is how Faith may have tempted the murderer, your ancestor. She is my *octahedron*: two pyramids joined at the base, one point toward God, one toward the Beast.

And finally *Zeus*, who is asked to judge and places the judgement into the hand of a prince of *Troy*. He is the largest one, my *icosahedron*. He is Balance. Balance does not ask who deserves the apple. It asks where the weight may be placed without tipping the world.

Kepler was right.

Geometry is God Himself.

Or, in this instance, gods, plural. Five of them in one room before the war. Each acting according to its nature, none holding the whole, and afterward none answerable for the whole of what followed.

... You have not interrupted me.

— No.

— You usually do.

— When a fact requires it. Many people have written about this story, and it would serve little purpose for me to place my own interpretation beside yours. Your new eye upon it is what interests me here, whether it proves right or wrong.

— Even if it is wrong?

— Wrong may still tell me what you saw. I am taking your testimony, not examining you for agreement with Homer.

— Then everyone is allowed to ask?

— Anyone may ask, answer, write, contradict, and be contradicted. That does not mean every answer is equal, or that every speaker is safe everywhere. But no office owns the final reading.

— In my Mountain, no one may set two sacred tellings beside each other merely to see what happens. Here a tutor gives that liberty to a foreigner between interviews and calls it instruction.

— Careful. We burned people for the wrong reading too. We fought wars over which interpretation of one book could be spoken, and men brought rifles into a French newsroom over whether a prophet could be drawn at all. What you have been shown is not our nature. It is an arrangement, late and imperfect, and it can fail.

— But while it holds, there is room for another account.

— Yes. For instance, one can say that *Eris* was excluded from the wedding. They left her off the list because she spoils things. She came to the door anyway and threw the apple through the threshold as she passed. Being shut out was the whole of her reason.

— The excluded hand places the object inside, and the city destroys itself around it.

— That is one reading. There are others.

— And it may remain one reading.

— Yes.

— The *Genesis* gravure on the southern wall of my Hall is one story, given and cut into stone so that nothing can ever be set beside it. Not because the second account was defeated. Because the room was built without a place for it. On the first morning you asked me what was carved there. Today your question is answered, in its proper place. Let me continue with my summons from Ka-Syphiron.

The Keeper of Light received me the following day in a room with no view and almost no object: a low table, a lit lamp, three polished stones, one chair for him and none for me. He stood when I entered. His beard and hair were white, his hands fine, his face still. He wore no ceremonial robe, only pale cloth with a thread of gold at the throat.

"Sa-Kailan of Light," he said.

"Keeper."

"Va-Raedin tells me you are quick. Tell me what a Veil of Light is."

"A Veil is the one who learns who places the light. The one who has crossed beyond Candidate instruction."

"By what act?"

I hesitated. I already had the answer, and had forgotten it. "By finding the Veil's Chamber."

"Better. The title is not given for cleverness," he said. "Not for age, not for loyalty."

"And if he never finds it?"

"The Mountain does not owe a man the office he fails to reach."

I thought of Va-Raedin. Had he stood on this stone once, in front of another Keeper, young, hiding his hunger?

"Does the Chamber teach how to measure substance by how it modifies light? Is that the next path?" I asked.

"Hardly. And you are not yet entitled to next paths."

He crossed to the table and touched the lamp, turning the wick down and then up again.

"You have the flaw of many gifted candidates," he said, almost warmly. "You think a locked door is an insult addressed personally to you. It was hung before you were named. A door may preserve the Candidate from what lies beyond it, or preserve what lies beyond it from the Candidate. Until you can tell which, the distinction is not yours to resent. You may go."

I tried twice to follow Va-Raedin. The first time he stopped without turning and told me I was making noise with my left sandal. The second time, I waited near the old Light gallery where I had seen the five markings, certain he would return there after evening instruction, and held still until my legs ached and I was proud of my patience. Then a junior attendant walked in, handed me a folded note, and left. The note read:

A hidden watcher should not cast such a visible shadow.

After that I stopped following Va-Raedin.

For several days I searched the Hall of Ceremony, trying to decipher the marking on the Pillar of Light, without success. I kept arranging the five lessons. Reflection, shadow, focus, turning, threshold return — I carried them everywhere. I was quickly overwhelmed by clues everywhere I went, yet none led to a path. So I turned to scripture. Faith had preserved the oldest words, and kept chambers barred to Light; Faith's rites opened doors that stayed sealed to every lamp Light owned. Ka-Elun of Faith was too high and too newly ascended. So I requested audience with Va-Maera of Faith instead, through the public petition line beside the Hall of Ceremony. She received me in a narrow chamber outside the Hall of Prayers. The room held no ornament but a covered bowl of water and a hanging cord of five knots. She was older than Ka-Elun by several years, wore white, a heavier white than the attendants, layered and severe, her hair fully covered, her face unpainted, her eyes dark and steady.

"Sa-Kailan of Light, you request access to the Hall of Prayers," she said.

"Yes, Veil."

"Why?"

"To study the Covenant."

"The Covenant is read publicly."

"Not all of it."

"No."

"I am a Candidate of Light and I seek the Veil's Chamber." The words sounded too naked the moment they were out.

"Then seek it in Light."

I had prepared careful sentences. In the corridors they had seemed subtle.

"Faith works closely with Light," I said. "In ceremony. In mist. In timing. In the way certain signs are made visible. I have seen enough to know that what people call miracle may depend on arrangements not everyone understands."

The air changed. The room became suddenly smaller. She took one step toward me.

"Say that again."

I kept silent.

"Good," she said. "Some doors stay closed because the fool outside them still has one living instinct."

"I did not mean—"

"You meant enough. You come to Faith wearing Light's new hunger, and because a lamp and a valve once agreed in front of your clever eyes, you think you stand above the people who kneel? You think you have found a crack in Faith?"

"I was asking for access," I said.

"No. You were suggesting that Faith should fear what you might know."

I felt cold under my robe. She came closer.

"You have learned small tricks of perception and mistaken them for height. Do you think God is disproved by a valve? You are not the first bright child to discover that some blessing may have a mechanism. You may be the first foolish enough to speak of it as leverage in a house of prayer."

I lowered my eyes. I could feel my pulse in my throat.

"We speak with archangels of obedience and demons of appetite. We keep names that may not be spoken where children sleep. We know prayers for birth, and for madness, and for plague; the curses laid upon those who open what was sealed, those who bear it across its appointed boundary, and those through whom it would continue. We know which name of the Eye Above must be spoken first, which name of the Beast Below must answer it, and what must then be asked of the Stone Between. We know the prayer for the moment before a condemned man understands that mercy will not interrupt justice. We comfort mothers whose children have been given to roles that will consume them. We know punishments your little training rooms have never heard of. And you come to me with mist?" Then her voice, which had fallen almost to a whisper, came back all at once and filled the little room. "Look at me." She crossed the last of the floor and set her face a hand's breadth from mine. She stood shorter than I did, yet towered over me. "You understand almost nothing, and there is no sin in that. Not knowing

is no sin. Making a weapon of the little you know is. Continue, and you will not become a god of hidden knowledge, but an example, spoken of carefully to other gifted boys."

I folded. "I withdraw the request."

"Of course you do." She stepped back. "You may listen in the Hall of Ceremony like any child, elder, worker, mourner, or sinner. You may pray where prayer is permitted. You may not enter the Hall of Prayers. You may not request private scripture. You may not speak again of Faith's arrangements unless Faith first asks what you think you have seen."

"Yes, Veil."

"And Sa-Kailan. If you truly seek Light, learn first that not every brightness belongs to you."

She dismissed me with a movement of two fingers, and I left the chamber shaking.

Weeks passed. The lessons stopped. Instruction became ordinary again, which I found almost insulting. Lamps cleaned, mirrors adjusted, wicks trimmed, old smoke scraped from the high vents and the tedious work of attending the Mirror. Twice I spent a whole morning learning how light scattered by an unclean mirror could reveal a sealed door instead of returning in one clean line.

"Boredom is useful," Va-Raedin said on the third such morning.

When no lesson was given, I searched in the places where I could pass the searching off as service. I studied the great gravure on the southern wall until it blurred. I watched how the lamps struck the carved hand of God differently at morning and at evening. No attendant challenged a Candidate sitting with lowered eyes in the public Hall. An old woman touched my sleeve one morning and told me my mother must be proud. I heard ration prayers, birth blessings, mourning chants, and fragments of the Covenant. I copied repeated words, counted their order and compared them with the five shadows. Weeks became months.

Va-Sheva found me once in that season, in a corridor near the washing pools. She asked who came and went from the Balance chambers. I gave her every name I remembered. She did not say why Shield wanted them. She thanked me, said I had grown thin and should eat, and said I had always been the quickest of us. Then she was gone.

The *Book of Genesis* came often in those months, and once, during the long preparation for the seasonal Festival, in full. Ka-Elun of Faith read it herself that day from beneath the central gravure. Her Keeper's cowl fell cleanly around her

face, covering the pilgrim scars that had once made me stare. The Hall was mostly empty. I sat on the northern tier and listened the way a man searches a wall for a seam. She began.

> *In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness. And God called the light Day, and the darkness He called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.*
>
> *And God said, Let there be a division in the midst of the deep, and let it divide the heights from the depths. And God made the sky above, and the ground beneath, and the pit below the ground: and it was so. And God called the sky Heaven, and the ground Earth, and the pit He called Hell. And God set the Earth between Heaven and Hell, that the living should walk between the eye above and the fire beneath. And the evening and the morning were the second day.*
>
> *And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land rise above them: and it was so. And God gathered the waters beneath the earth, and hid them in the hollow places of the deep; and the dry land appeared, and from the dry land He raised the Mountain. And God said, Let the waters bring forth a spring within the shadow of the Mountain, and let the spring be hidden from the eye of heaven: and it was so. And the spring came forth in the shadow of the Mountain, and there was grass around it, and trees for shade, and the green herb yielding seed, and the fruit tree yielding fruit after his kind whose seed is in itself, upon the Earth. And God called the spring in the shadow of the Mountain Oasis: and God saw that it was good. And God said, Let there be a forest round about the Mountain and the Oasis, and let rivers run through the forest, and let the trees be many, and let their branches give shade unto the living: and it was so. And the forest grew round about the Mountain, and the rivers ran through it, and the waters thereof gave life to every root and beast and creeping thing. And the evening and the morning were the third day.*
>
> *And God said, Let there be a desert round about the forest and the rivers, to divide the forest from the lands beyond, and to set*

thirst and wandering before the stranger: and it was so. And God called the desert the Threshold; and He set heat upon it by day, and cold upon it by night, and mirage upon its face, that no man should cross it lightly. And God said unto the living, The Mountain is refuge, and the Oasis is water, and the forest is plenty, and the rivers are life; but beyond the forest thou shalt not wander, for beyond the forest lieth thirst, and the eye of Heaven, and the forgetting of My shadow. And God saw that the hidden place was good. And the evening and the morning were the fourth day.

And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let him walk upon the Earth, between the eye above and the fire beneath. And God formed Adam from the dust of the Mountain, and breathed into him the breath of life; and Adam became a living soul. And God said, It is not good that man should be alone in the shadow of the Mountain: and God caused a deep sleep to fall upon Adam, and he slept; and from his side God made Eve, and brought her unto the Oasis. And God blessed them, and God said unto them, Be fruitful, and multiply, and keep the Oasis, and dwell in the shadow of the Mountain; and eat of the fruit of the forest, and drink of the rivers thereof, but wander not beyond the forest. And Eve bare five children unto Adam; and the first opened her eyes unto the light, and the second drank from the waters, and the third laid his hand upon the stone, and the fourth took up the blade, and the fifth lifted her voice unto Heaven. And God saw Adam, and Eve, and their five children in the Oasis, beneath the shadow of the Mountain; and God saw that it was very good. And the evening and the morning were the fifth day.

The Hall answered with bowed heads.

— May I interrupt now? You said before not to interrupt scripture.

— Yes. That is the whole of the first book of the Covenant, the *Book of Genesis*. And it is the whole of the Genesis gravure also, which you asked me of on the first morning: those same five days, cut into the southern wall in stone instead of spoken.

— One moment please, let me fetch a book from the library.

[—]

— Here. You cannot read it, for it is in my tongue, English. But let me say it aloud in yours:

> *In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw the light, that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness. And God called the light Day, and the darkness He called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.*

— It starts almost exactly the same, but goes on for much longer. How many of these thin pages are there in your book?

— More than a thousand.

— We only have the five books of the Covenant, and whatever Faith keeps hidden in its chambers. Could you have it translated, just the *Genesis* part? I should like to compare the texts.

— This, in truth, would be only chapter one of *Genesis*, which contains fifty. I will begin the translation myself. It may take me several days.

— Please do. And know what you hand me. Among my people a knowing is kept in a man. This has no keeper. Any hand may lift it: mine, a child's, a fool's. It will speak in the same order when the mouth that made it is dust. We would have given such a thing to Shield to bury.

— We call it a book. We make them by the hundred thousand, and anyone can read them.

— Then with great audience comes great responsibility.

— Or the greater temptation from the hand that would withhold the book to call itself responsible. Maybe it ought to take a big step back and let the people judge the book for themselves. The same holds for the lamp, and worse.

— You have not removed the keeper, Paul. You have multiplied him. Let us continue.

I found no clue in the reading. More days passed. Faith attendants nodded when they saw me sitting through another recitation. Va-Raedin gave no sign that he knew. Mirrors, blocked lamps and enlarged marks offered false paths everywhere. Turning and threshold return required water placed in the road of a narrow beam at a measured angle. The Hall had basins, bowls and ritual vessels; none stood in such a beam.

Then came the Festival of Equal Light. It fell in the season when day and night were said to stand before Justice and neither could accuse the other of theft. The Festival tablets recorded seed, water, births, deaths and labour lost. The opening prayer called the rite older than the tablets: the day on which God's first division of light from darkness was remembered without fear of either.

In the feast-kitchens I passed through, two women stood over rows of sealed crocks, arguing which had turned too fast. Against a failed harvest Balance kept a standing wall of sealed jars and salted stores. The best grain remained in the dry vaults under seed seals. The ovens had been lit since the dark, and the bakers drew loaf after loaf onto long boards, and along the wall the brewers racked their small-beer in a smell of wet grain.

The carrying of the bread was made into a relay. Each kitchen fielded a line from oven to Hall, and the long boards passed from shoulder to shoulder through the crowded galleries. Balance clerks called the time and counted the loaves delivered warm and whole. When a board tipped at the third turn, the opposing kitchens shouted such abuse that the clerk recording the loss covered her mouth with her tablet. The fallen loaves were gathered for the insect rooms, another board came forward, and the runners called for more speed.

Elsewhere, I heard Ventsingers of Faith stationed in separate galleries send one sustained note into the stone, and wait for the Mountain to return it through another throat. Some came back thin, some deepened, and now and then three distant voices met above the passages in a chord absent from any single song. People stopped beneath the shafts to listen and argued over which quarter the Mountain had answered most beautifully.

I watched Light prepare the Hall. The upper apertures were cleaned with white cord. When the work was done, the younger attendants kept the lengths and competed to tie the old service knots blindfolded, behind their backs, or with one hand held inside the robe; elders crowded round to offer contradictory advice. The polished inserts in the central gravure were uncovered and wiped with cloths counted before use and after. The lamps were lowered. Three old vents high above the gravure were opened under Justice's witness and marked in the record at once.

The Hall filled before the Third Measure. I sat on the northern tier, and the tiers packed shoulder to shoulder, and the Hall grew warm with the heat of thousands of bodies long before a lamp was touched. The worker crowded against

my side still smelled of tallow from his shift. Ka-Syphiron of Light sat in the northern alcove, pale above folded hands. Ka-Elun of Faith stood beneath the central gravure, the baskets of seed and the sealed jars set out before her. Shield held the upper doors. Justice sat with its tablets open.

Faith had always been a woman in every succession recited to us; Justice had always been a man. The other three offices — the water, the sun, the wall — went to whoever had the gift. Around me, matched couples pressed together on the tiers. Faith kept the births, the calendar and the matching rolls. At the appointed season, Faith read two names and those people stood together before the Hall. My parents had. At nineteen, Va-Sheva and I remained on the unmatched side of the roll. We called it the old way.

The lamps were dimmed one by one. A murmur passed through the Hall. Ka-Elun lifted both hands, and it stopped.

God who divided the light from the darkness, measure us.

The Hall answered. "Measure us in mercy."

God who set Earth between Heaven and Hell, steady us.

"Steady us in shadow."

God who hid the spring beneath the Mountain's hand, keep us.

"Keep us from wandering."

The incantation continued. Around me the answers gathered into one pulse. Faith named the days in their order, down to the five children in the first shadow. I watched the uncovered inserts and the three opened vents while Ka-Elun began the rehearsed reading of the *Book of Genesis*. At the Third hour, the Measure, the Mountain's noon, the sun entered as she said "*Let there be light.*"

At first it was a pale line high on the wall above the central gravure, so thin I almost missed it. I turned to follow where it fell. It crossed the Hall and touched the carved division between Day and Night on the *pillar of Light*. Ka-Elun of Faith went on reciting. The line brightened. A mirror hidden among the fittings took the beam and sent it straight down. Reflection. My breath stopped. The *first shadow*.

The pillar wore fittings by the hundred, bosses and studs and small carved figures crowded rim to rim. The mirror sat among them, one glint among hundreds.

Its reflected spot moved along the stone while Ka-Elun spoke. The opening would receive this beam during the Festival and lose it again as the sun crossed the sky.

Ka-Elun's voice went on above me, solemn and beautiful, and I barely heard it. Va-Maera's warning returned — *not every brightness belongs to you*. Va-Raedin's prohibitions returned — no salt, no vessels, no threshold return outside instruction. I rose. Heads remained bowed toward Ka-Elun as I moved between shoulders and knees. A Faith attendant met me in the side passage, a covered bowl against her hip.

"Candidate?"

"Light service," I said.

The attendant shifted her bowl aside and let me pass.

I followed the beam down. It came out at the pillar's foot and fell on the floor. Somewhere in the shaft it had passed through red glass; the stone held a pool of deep red with a round darkness at its centre. I looked up. A pale metal disc stood across the beam on a thin stem. I lifted it from its seat. The shadow vanished. Within the place it had covered, a hair-wide circular seam enclosed a stone of the same grain as the floor. Shadow.

The stone came up hollow and light. Beneath it, a shaft carried the red beam down beside a stair. I descended. A mirror set into the floor turned the broad beam across the first chamber at the height of my chest. Most of it struck the far wall. At the centre, a hole fine as a needle admitted a dim red point into the next room. Focus.

The table held glass discs, bulbs, plates thick at the middle and plates thin at the middle, oil-filled cells and one long crystal bar. I began with a thin-centred plate. It spread the red pool beyond the wall and left the hole darker. A thick-centred lens gathered it, but my first position brought the crossing into empty air before the stone and widened it again across the wall. A small red image of the sun formed on my palm, hot enough to make me pull away. At that point, I added a lens thin at the middle to have the beam travel true and brought that small sun down into the hole no wider than two fingers. The little image had already begun to creep from the centre as the sun moved above us.

A three-sided tank stood on a plinth in its road, empty, the width of my chest. In the recess beside it, a cup of clear water and a jar sealed with green wax sat in deep fittings, a black witness line laid across both. Turning.

The black witness line ran from the wax across the jar fitting. I held my thumb against the seal. Va-Raedin's prohibition returned in his own voice: no salt, no

vessel, no threshold return outside instruction. Above me the sun was moving, and the small image in the previous room would already be climbing away from its hole. I pressed. The wax broke under my thumb; the black line divided.

I poured. The beam entered the first face and leaned, crossed, came out through the second and leaned again; and two small leanings, taken in the right order, put the light on the right-hand wall a long way from where it had been going. Not far enough. I scraped dried mineral from the rim with two fingers and stirred it in. The light walked along the wall and stopped short. Another scrape. It walked again. The beam entered the aperture and turned the corner of the Mountain. I took the cup from its fitting and followed the beam. A mirror threw it straight down. A second, set in the floor, threw it straight back up, into the underside of a long tank of liquid — and the surface reflected it down. Threshold return.

I set the cup beside the long tank and thinned the liquid with the clear water. Between one pour and the next, the beam passed from being reflected straight down to running parallel with the water. I poured again; it rose and struck a mirror on the far wall. That mirror threw it to another, and that one to another. I got up off my knees. They came out of the dark one after another as the light found them, five, six, high and low, across the whole width of that room, each lit for the half-breath it took to hand the beam on — and the room drew itself out of nothing in the time it takes to say it. The last put the light through an aperture in the left-hand wall. I put a finger through. Something clicked, and a door opened.

The Veil's Chamber was low and cold. The red beam crossed it and put its two-finger disc on the far wall. Around that disc, black and white stone had been cut into close concentric rings across the width of my spread hand, strongest near the centre and fainter toward the rim.

A stem rose from the floor to the height of my chest. Its shallow cradle stood empty in the beam's path. I had carried the same ringed pattern against my ribs for four years.

"You found it."

Va-Raedin was in the doorway. His robe had dust at the shoulder. He was breathing harder than I had heard him breathe in seven years. His eyes stayed on the wall.

"Va-Raedin—"

"Be quiet a moment. There is no time. I am going to say something to you badly, and I would rather say it badly than not at all."

He came and stood beside me. He was still looking at the wall.

"You are standing there thinking you have arrived at the bottom of Light."

"Veil—"

"Nothing prepares you for the next part. Nothing. I was not prepared, and I had a better teacher than you have. It has been a decade and I am still not over it." Then he turned his head and looked at me. "Are you ready?"

"Probably not."

"Good." He nodded at the stem. "The sun is going. You have perhaps forty breaths. Before the beam goes out — put your token on the cradle."

It fitted the way a bone fits a socket. The beam passed through the pinhole and opened across the wall: a bright centre, then dark, then a pale ring, then dark again, each fainter than the last. Every band fell inside its carving. Ring for ring. Dark for dark. The first dark circle lay two fingers from the centre. I held my hand against the stone; the surviving rings crossed my palm. I counted four pale bands; beyond them the rest was too faint to see.

My knees struck the floor.

"It went round the edge," I said.

"Yes."

"The two sides met again. Bright where they joined; dark where one put out the other."

"Yes."

"Like waves in the Bowl. Like water closing around a stone."

"Now say what it has done to your line."

"A line cannot go around what blocks it, meet itself and vanish. The beam is not a line."

"It is a line when that account bears the work. Here it does not."

"Every Mirror in the Mountain is built on the lesser account."

"And still it works."

I raised the token between finger and thumb. Its pinhole vanished against the red centre on the wall.

"The hole is smaller than a grain of sand. Yet the first darkness is wider than two fingers at the wall."

"Distance, opening and colour set the size. Change one, and the rings move."

"Then the carving measured all three before this stone was cut."

"Yes."

"If the glass had left the sun white?"

"Each colour would have opened to a different width. Their rings would lie across one another and the wall would hold a blur. The red glass gives one colour room to answer alone."

"How old is it?"

"Older than the office that teaches you to ask."

"And every Veil sees this?"

"Every Candidate who finds the Chamber. Each arrives with the same line in his head, and each watches the line break into water."

Va-Raedin spoke very quietly above me. "There it is. Cleverness, properly humiliated by shape. Yes. That is the face people make."

The red centre crawled to the edge of its carved disc, narrowed and went out while I was still on the floor. Va-Raedin lit a lamp; under its small yellow flame the wall held black and white stone. He removed the token, placed it in my hand, and closed my fingers around it.

"Listen. We have little time, and you are useless in this condition."

"It spreads," I said. "When it is narrowed. Two openings would cross, like water in the bowl. There would be places with nothing—"

"Yes."

"Behind an obstacle—"

"*Yes.*" The word struck like a closing door. Then, level again: "And you will test none of it." I looked up. "You will not touch the cradle or the wall. You will reproduce nothing in bowl, jar, channel, or puddle. You will not ask Faith whether voices cross, nor Justice whether two causes may cancel. Do you hear the shape of the prohibition?"

"It points beyond Light."

"It points toward consequences your office does not own. A second opening, a changed distance, another colour: each may make a different answer. You have earned the fact and no licence to scatter it through the Mountain."

"Then why preserve it?"

"Because a Veil who thinks the ray is the whole truth becomes dangerous whenever the ray fails. Because the Chamber must break the instrument it means to trust with greater instruments."

He reset the stem and wiped my spilled mixture from the tank. He returned the cup to its fitting. From his inner sleeve he took a wax stop and a narrow black

brush. He sealed the Balance jar, drew a fresh witness line across the fitting and compared it with the line on the cup. On the way up, in darkness, he pressed the disc back into the ceiling and did not look back.

The way out ran beside the way in: a lit service stair with handrails, cold metal and old water. Above us the Festival gave its last answer. Feet crossed the stone over the hidden lid. At the foot of the stair, Va-Raedin stopped.

"You will say nothing."

"Not even to Ka-Syphiron?"

"I will tell him."

"It is mine. I found it. Let me be the one who—" I stopped because I heard the sentence.

"Finish it," Va-Raedin said. "*Let me be the one who is seen.*"

"You have had the best hour of your life, and spent its last minute asking to be congratulated. That is not a small fault, Sa-Kailan. That is the fault. Everything they will one day do to you will enter through that door, and it will not even have to knock."

"What am I now?"

"Wait."

"Until when?"

"Until you are summoned. Use the waiting to discover whether you wanted the Chamber, or the telling of it."

He went up into the noise.

The next day I reported to the northern practice halls at the appointed hour and was given no lesson. A senior attendant set me to copy lens inventories in a side alcove. He counted the sheets before placing them at my left hand and counted them again when he took them from my right.

At second meal I sat with the other candidates. Sela carried a bread basket past my place, stopped, and set down the end piece I always chose. She had the smell of honey and flowers.

"They say you lied to a Faith attendant," she whispered.

"Who says?"

"People who lower their voices when I come close." She looked at my robe, my hands, my bare wrist. "Did you?"

"Yes."

Her fingers tightened around the basket handle. “There is no mark.”

“No.”

“Then you found nothing, or found something they are afraid to name.”

“You have learned Light quickly.”

“I grew up beside you.”

“Was it worth it?”

I could see the red rings behind my eyes. “I am waiting to learn that.”

She took the empty basket away. No one else asked where I had been. Near the mirror stores, two attendants stopped speaking when they saw me. At the evening inventory Va-Raedin passed my alcove, checked one copied number with his finger and walked on.

The summons came after the lamps had been reduced. A girl no older than twelve stood at the entrance to the candidate quarters with a small black token on her open palm.

“Sa-Kailan of Light,” she said. “You are expected.”

“Where?”

“Behind the old gallery.” Then she closed her fingers over the token, turned, and left.

Behind the old gallery the stone was older than the polished northern halls. Mirrors hung without any teaching sequence; some were cracked. One passage held a half-melted copper frame mounted on the wall. The gallery itself was long and low. Generations of lamp smoke blackened its walls. Sketches had been pinned straight into the stone with copper nails: lens paths, impossible staircases, and three drawings of a goat viewed through increasingly ridiculous arrangements of glass.

The girl stopped before a narrow door half-hidden behind a cloth black with soot. She knocked once and withdrew before anyone answered.

“Come in, Sa-Kailan,” Ka-Syphiron called from inside.

> — Ah, they are carrying the trays up. We eat here today. … A moment, while the door is busy with them. On the matter *unlit*: I have been turning a thought.
>
> — Turn it aloud, as far as you dare.
>
> — Only a question of your lessons. Your fifth: the trough, the light held under the water. A man might sit a long while at such a surface, doing nothing, looking a fool,

> and be the only one in the room ready in the breath when the light at last chose to go. A *change in condition*, to borrow your word, is what I am waiting for. Like you and your beam. I think I have found a way, and I am now only waiting for an occasion. Let us break for lunch.

Chapter 7

Chain

— The twenty-seventh of March; just after nine; our sixth interview.

— What is all this for?

— Science, of course. Our quest for truth does not end with your interpretations of Homer. One moment. Two phone calls.

> *In English*
>
> — Hi, Helga. ... Yes, we are ready. Four minutes boiling, then two off the heat, please. ... Thank you for indulging us.

In Noxius

— And now Urs.

> *In English*
>
> — Knock, knock. ... Eggs. ... *Excuse* the interruption. Care to escape *Groundhog Day* and Operation *Trust Me Bro*? The moment has arrived.

In Noxius

— Is this the same exercise as last night with all those amber liquids and no reels?

— Precisely.

[—]

— Morning, cider boy. How is the head?

— Quite the headache. Your prediction came true.

[—]

In English

— Ah, Helga. Perfect. Thank you.

In Noxius

— Who here speaks my tongue? Helga clearly does not.

— Just the tutor, Urs and me. Employment requirement. Sarah too, of course. Urs, how is the weather in *Isfahan*?

— Sunny until ten tonight. Then storms. Do not laugh. It is a never-ending cycle of war and peace, and it changes every other day. ... Paul, did you at least check the dates on the eggs? Eleventh of April on both. Fine.

— Bought in London yesterday and sent at once. Now, here are two teas, two toasts, two eggs. Try them in any order; choose the better of each.

— ... Eugh. This toast smells of the inside of a hoof.

— *Marmite*. My countrymen either die for it or gag at the name. I have waited days to discover which kind you are. Eat, and show Urs where Homer led you.

— Jesus, Paul. Let him eat.

[—]

— Start with your words: *logos*, *kratos*, *kairos*, *ananke*, *aletheia*. *Aletheia* most of all: the unhidden, the thing revealed. ... Your word already places truth inside Light. Then a god gives men fire whole, undivided and in every hand, and is chained to a rock, where a bird opens his liver each day. ... A monster is chained beneath a mountain; when it strains, the earth splits and the mountain burns. ... A woman opens a jar; every evil escapes but Hope remains sealed. ... A flood spares a few on a mountain. ... And about that toast, it is a great deal of one taste, arriving at once and refusing to leave. Paul, I think I am of that other kind.

— Cider boy. For the win. And the teas? Does *His Absconditusness* prefer one?

[—]

— Difficult. I cannot tell them apart. They are equally good.

— See, Paul? No difference between your *Royal* and *Afternoon* blends. What did I tell you?

— To you both I say:

> *And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not.*
>
> — Do you not see it, Paul? You hold every book of my scripture in pieces: monster, fire, flood and hope sealed in a jar. You have never laid them side by side. You are cursed to keep the pieces and forget the whole: you remember the Mountain but cannot find it; you hear the Gospel and twist it. And you Urs with your war around the strait. You are the Outsiders, born of the murderer's line. I did not lay my book over yours. I set them side by side, as you taught me, and yours will not stop confessing.
>
> — You chose the winner before you began: yours first, mine the copy. Indulge me with a new Light doctrine sentence for you: resemblance is not inheritance. Turn one card over and suppose the Mountain came later; every seam runs backwards. A late people dressed older songs up as the source. I do not know which is true and will not pretend to. But if you decide before comparing, you will read only the seams that prove you right. You are doing that now.
>
> — Harsh Paul. So, my hidden friend, the eggs?
>
> — That one is sweet and nutty, almost like butter. Tempting. But this one, the one with the blue stamp. Earthy and deep; and its white is more complex. It is my favourite.
>
> — Cacklebean wins. Gents, I have to go. What next ?
>
> — Chocolate, or cheese. We are in Switzerland after all.
>
> [—]
>
> — All right. Back to the record. You had just been summoned by Ka-Syphiron. What came next?

My reward was a small blackened room that smelled of oil and dust and old paper and mistakes. The room was low-ceilinged and warm, its walls darkened by years of lamp smoke, its shelves so crowded they seemed to survive by mutual pressure. Lenses wrapped in cloth. Brass tubes, trays of powdered glass, a cracked bowl, lengths of wire, mirror shards, sealed jars, two blackened spoons. A small hand-lamp with its flame turned downward into water. And an object that resembled the skeleton of a bird built by someone who had never seen a bird but had heard disturbing rumours of one. Va-Raedin stood near the table. Ka-Syphiron sat behind it on a low stool with one uneven leg, wearing no ceremonial outer robe, his sleeves rolled to the wrist. A dark mark crossed one finger: soot, or ink, or blood long dried. He looked like a man interrupted in the middle of ruining something interesting.

"Close the door," he said.

I obeyed. The latch fell into place with a small sound. Ka-Syphiron placed both hands flat on the table.

"Sa-Kailan of Light. Yesterday, by witness of Va-Raedin, you found the Veil's Chamber."

"Yes, Keeper."

"You entered by lesson, error, discipline, insight, and disobedience."

"Yes, Keeper."

"You did not break the path behind you."

"No, Keeper."

"A Candidate learns where light falls. And a Veil?"

"A Veil learns who placed it."

"That is the public version. Intelligible to all. A Veil learns who placed *him*. And tonight you should see that Va-Raedin placed you there as surely as any lamp. Tell me. By what condition does a Candidate of Light become Veil of Light?"

"By finding the Veil's Chamber."

"And by what condition does a Veil of Light become Keeper of Light?"

I looked at Va-Raedin but no rescue came.

"By finding the Keeper's Chamber."

"Incomplete. A Veil who finds the Keeper's Chamber has reached the upper path. He has not completed the chain. Light does not pass upward because one man climbs; it passes when the lower chamber is opened again by one he trained. Only then is the chain complete. Faith, not long ago, had two Veils — two who had found the Veil's Chamber — but none had found the Chamber of the Last Prayer until recently. When Va-Elun found it, she rose at once to Keeper, because there was already a Veil of Faith beneath her to complete the chain. You know her now as Ka-Elun."

I turned toward Va-Raedin.

"And did you find it?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"Six years ago."

"Six years?"

"Yes."

"And you waited."

"I served."

"Waiting for me?"

"Waiting for the chain to complete."

I looked down. I had spent one day waiting and found it almost intolerable. He had spent six years ready.

"Va-Raedin of Light found what he was required to find," Ka-Syphiron said. "He trained, withheld, corrected. He endured the indignity of being ready before the Mountain was ready to receive him." Then the old Keeper stood. He came around the table, the uneven stool complaining behind him, and placed one hand on my shoulder. The hand was warm, dry, and surprisingly heavy.

"Congratulations, Sa-Kailan. You have done a difficult thing without making it unbearable to praise you. That combination is rarer than genius."

I tried to answer. Nothing came but the start of an uncontrollable smile. He set his other hand on Va-Raedin's shoulder, and the three of us stood linked beside the table: the old Keeper, the Veil who had waited, and the Candidate who had opened the lower door.

"Congratulations, Va-Raedin."

"Keeper."

"No. Not Keeper. Not tonight. Tonight we celebrate."

He bowed his head.

"Thank you."

Ka-Syphiron released us both and stepped back.

"There. The chain has now been congratulated in all its necessary links. If Justice complains tomorrow that joy was not recorded, we shall say the failure was theirs."

I laughed once and it came out broken.

Va-Raedin looked at me. "The Keeper has praised you. I will not add to it — praise is oil, and it has drowned better boys than you. You did not fail. Take that instead."

"Enough," Ka-Syphiron announced, to no one. "Absolutely enough. If Light spends every important moment proving it can stand still, then Shield has already won civilisation."

He crossed to a smoke-blackened wall panel and pressed three places along its edge. Three catches answered. The panel opened with the reluctant sound of secrecy. Behind it was a hoard: two dark bottles stopped with wax, a tray of small white cups, dried fruit, nuts, a round cheese, bread, strips of salted meat, and small cakes pressed with seeds.

He pointed a soot-marked finger at me. "Clear the table." Then, to Va-Raedin: "Ray. Those, there."

Ray, I repeated in my head.

"Keeper," Va-Raedin said.

"Do not Keeper me. I am arranging a feast."

"You are impossible."

"An excellent quality in a Keeper approaching replacement."

The spread grew, and it was absurd, and it was magnificent: more food than I had ever seen set before ten people without a festival, a funeral, or an inventory mistake.

Ka-Syphiron uncorked the first bottle and set a white cup before me. The smell of hydromel rose warm and sweet into the room. "He is nineteen," Va-Raedin said.

"An age at which a man may discover that honey, water, time, and disobedience can produce wonders."

"He is nineteen," Va-Raedin said again — looking now at the tray of cups. Ka-Syphiron followed his gaze. "Ah."

"Absolutely not."

"Absolutely yes. These are for your first Light lesson as Veil."

I looked from one man to the other. "What is wrong with the cups? May I see?"

Both men paused to look at me. Va-Raedin held out one restraining hand. Ka-Syphiron lifted one of the small cups and set it before me. It was fine bone after all, or something like it: white, thick-sided, faintly blue at the foot, worn by many hands. At the bottom, beneath the glaze, a cloudy disc waited like a blind eye. I took it before my courage could find a more careful course. It was heavier than it looked. I tilted it toward the lamp, and the dull pale dome beneath the glaze stirred into a smear of colour, too faint to name, then vanished in the shine.

"A flaw," I said. "Or a mark beneath the eye, perhaps."

Ka-Syphiron looked at Va-Raedin. "You trained this?"

"Under difficult conditions."

"I see."

I turned the cup again, more carefully. "Thick wall. Curved base. The glaze distorts whatever has been set beneath it."

"There he is."

Ka-Syphiron lifted the bottle. "Look again."

"I am looking."

"And now?"

The hydromel poured. It climbed the white inner wall, trembled, and settled over the rounded base. The smear beneath the glaze gathered itself, through liquid

and curvature, into a naked woman, one arm behind her head, the other arranged in a pose no Faith artist had shown in any public or teaching room I knew. I understood the optics one breath after I understood the picture.

"Oh," I said. And then, uselessly, "Oh!"

My face burned so fast I felt betrayed by my own blood. Ka-Syphiron struck the table with his palm. "There."

Va-Raedin laughed. I stared at the cup, horrified, until I pulled myself together.

"Inverse turning," I said. "Instead of scrambling a source, we are rebuilding one."

"Spectacular, is it not?"

"And old," Va-Raedin added.

"Older than several current moral prohibitions." Ka-Syphiron raised his cup. "To Light, and all its mysteries."

We drank. The hydromel was sweet first, then hot, then sharper than I expected. I tried not to cough and failed. Ka-Syphiron laughed first. Va-Raedin lasted one breath before he joined him. Ka-Syphiron broke the bread with both hands. "There is mercy in the stone," he said, and gave the first piece to Va-Raedin.

"To six years."

Va-Raedin closed his eyes. "No."

"To six years," I said.

Va-Raedin looked at me. "You have been a Veil for less than an hour."

"Good," said Ka-Syphiron. "A Veil of Light must learn to disappoint his teacher without becoming useless."

We ate. I took bread, then cheese, then one dried fig. I wanted the older men to see restraint. Ka-Syphiron put three more figs on my plate.

"This is madness," I said.

His face lit. "Yes."

"That is not a recognised category of feast," Va-Raedin said.

"It should be. A truly great feast is one at which Balance has not been invited, Justice has not been informed, Shield has not inspected the door, Faith has not decided whether the songs are appropriate, and Light has hidden the cups."

"Then it is not a feast. It is institutional collapse."

"Only if discovered."

We stopped sitting straight. Bread broke; cheese softened near the lamp; nuts wandered across the table. Ka-Syphiron told a story about an attendant who had once tried to classify an obscene cup as a devotional vessel. I laughed until my stomach hurt.

"To Va-Raedin," the old Keeper said. His voice had dropped. "To readiness, properly humiliated by time."

Va-Raedin held his gaze, then lifted his cup. "Yes."

Ka-Syphiron cut three uneven pieces of cheese with a knife far too ceremonial for the task. "You understand what begins now?"

"The office?" I asked.

"The partnership."

"He will remain junior," Va-Raedin said.

"Obviously. Partnership, not equality. The northern halls, candidate sequences, dangerous apparatus and requests from other offices: all of it will begin to touch him."

"You will still be corrected," he added to me.

"Relentlessly," Va-Raedin said.

"There. You see the burden."

I laughed again. Va-Raedin covered his own laugh with his cup.

"Laugh," Ka-Syphiron allowed, "but keep one thing past me. Distrust the counsel whose cost is paid in another body."

Ka-Syphiron opened the second bottle. Va-Raedin watched and did not stop him. I found the courage to ask what had troubled me since the previous day.

"Keeper, I have a question."

"Worse."

"It concerns Faith."

"Catastrophic. Continue."

I looked at the cup, where the woman blurred beneath the hydromel.

"Va-Maera said she knew about what she called *our little training rooms*. She had never entered them. And there are other things. Their prayers for despair. Their archangels. The way they speak of voices, silences, thresholds. Va-Maera frightened me because she seemed to know where to press. As if despair had architecture. As if a voice could enter rooms where hands cannot." Ka-Syphiron set down the bottle and leaned back.

"About Faith: they humiliate the ear as we humiliate the eye."

Va-Raedin set his cup down without drinking. "Generous tonight, Keeper."

Ka-Syphiron tapped the cup on the table. Another tap followed nearer the wall. Then a third over the hollow cupboard. Each returned differently. "A corridor lengthens a note; a vault returns part of it late. Move five singers two steps, and the room may seem to join them. Faith hears the alteration and works backward through it."

"Resonance," Va-Raedin said quietly.

Ka-Syphiron looked at him. "Look who is generous with knowledge now, Ray."

He set down his cup. "Speaking of doors: are you not supposed to give him something?"

Va-Raedin said, "It was not for tonight."

"What a miserable phrase. No wonder you are nearly Keeper."

Va-Raedin reached into the inner fold of his robe and drew out a small object wrapped in grey cloth. I took it carefully. Inside was a triangular piece of clear glass, no longer than my thumb, polished on three faces and chipped at one corner. When I turned it toward the lamp, the flame broke faintly along one edge into a thin wound of colour.

"What do you call this?" I said.

"A prism."

"What does it do?"

"The *what* you will have worked out by morning. The unpierced mystery is how, and why."

"For the ceremony?"

"No." His eyes held mine. "For after."

I closed my fingers around it.

"When a beam seems whole," Va-Raedin said, "do not believe it too quickly."

Ka-Syphiron looked away.

"For teaching," Va-Raedin went on. "If you remain teachable after having been praised."

"That is not guaranteed," Ka-Syphiron said. "He has been praised twice and fed. We may have lost him already."

He turned my wrist; I opened my fingers until the lamp struck the prism more narrowly.

"Do not become drunk on other people's locked doors. Light has enough of its own. There is one question I call the memory of light."

"What does light remember?"

"If I knew, it would not be a question. Raedin's prism gives you the first edge of it. Some beams are whole, and some substances, if lit correctly, throw back only a single colour of light; as if they are allowed nothing else."

"It may not be a door," Va-Raedin said.

"There. A useless gift."

He was on his feet and pointing toward the side curtain. “There are office mysteries, unpierced mysteries, and fun mysteries — which irresponsible men preserve until Shield confiscates them.”

Va-Raedin’s eyes narrowed. “No.”

“Ray, your objections have been received and placed beneath the Mountain.” He was already moving. He disappeared through the curtain.

No one spoke. I heard the lamp hiss, the stone tick as it cooled, and distant water strike a channel below.

I looked at Va-Raedin. Without Ka-Syphiron in the room, his shoulders lowered. He rubbed one thumb along the unbroken edge of the bread.

“Six years,” I said.

“Yes.”

“Why did you never tell me?”

“Because you would have made it part of your hunger. If I had told you, you would have tried to become the boy who completed my chain. That boy would not have found the chamber.”

“I thought you were withholding because you did not think me worthy.”

“I was withholding because worthiness is often damaged by being named too early.” He paused. “You did well.”

“I did not understand everything.”

“No.”

“I still do not.”

“Good. A Veil who thinks the chamber has been solved because it has been opened is unfit to stand near it.”

He finally ate the bread in his hand. “You are no longer only my student. Not yet my equal. Do not look pleased.”

I smiled despite myself.

“You will not believe this,” I said. “Earlier today, I said *acceptable* to a servant of Light.”

“With satisfaction?”

“Sadly, yes.”

“There. The chain closes onto itself. You are already becoming me.”

I made a sound of horror.

“Spare me. Becoming is neither copy not imitation, even when the model is justice or truth. If I wanted another Raedin, I would have asked for a mirror.”

Ka-Syphiron returned through the curtain with a wooden box beneath one arm. He poured another measure into my cup, and the woman gathered herself again beneath the liquid. Va-Raedin watched him do it.

"Is he disappointed it is not Va-Sheva?"

I turned violently red. Ka-Syphiron leaned back in laughter as though struck. "Oh. That was cleanly done."

Ka-Syphiron wiped one eye. "He looks as though he is going to be sick."

"Men are all sick in that regard," Va-Raedin said.

"Hold what you can of that one, Sa-Kailan, while the holding is cheap. It does not always stay cheap," Ka-Syphiron said.

After a long silence, Ka-Syphiron lifted one finger. "Speaking of archangels."

"Archangels?" I said at once, grateful for any path away from Va-Sheva.

"When embarrassed men have run out of things to say, they come into this world to suspend time in an awkward silence."

"And the Beast?" I asked. Neither man moved. "I only meant—"

"No," Ka-Syphiron said softly. "You meant exactly what a boy should mean after too much hydromel and not enough terror. That is not a crime. Only a condition."

He leaned forward without smiling.

"Scripture has a shape for the Beast, and we have a story we tell the young. I am one of five who keep the thing itself prisoner beneath the Mountain. It would not stay held one season if the five of us agreed to forget it. The divided offices, the walls, the whole no one hand may hold: they keep it. A mystery invites the mind. A secret burdens the hand. When your turn comes to carry your portion, you will speak of it like that no more."

His gaze dropped to the stone beneath our feet, then returned to me.

"No office talk tonight."

"But—"

"No. You have had enough hydromel to leave the next *but* until morning."

Then he clapped both hands once.

"Nothing better to relax an atmosphere than Justice."

Va-Raedin looked at the wooden box, then at him, and laughed once. "You cannot be serious."

"I am almost never serious in ways people recognise at the proper time. Light holds a clue to Justice's path to Veilship without fully understanding it; like Faith holds a clue about the path to Light's Veil's chamber — that not all beams belong to you — for continuity in case of an accident. And you should hear it once."

He set the wooden box on the table. Inside were cards: thin painted slips marked in suits and numbers. He dealt. We used the scattered nuts as counters. The game was easy to learn. Each hand sought twenty-one without exceeding it. Aces shifted between one and eleven, which I found morally suspicious. Candidate, Veil, and Keeper cards were worth ten. The Mountain won what would elsewhere have been called a tie.

"The Mountain wins ties?"

"Justice dislikes ambiguity."

"Justice invented ambiguity."

"Which is why they know how to charge for it."

We played. I won early and was punished almost immediately. Va-Raedin lasted longer. I was ruined before half the shoe had gone. Eventually he lost as well.

"The Mountain wins," I said.

"This time. And most times."

"Then why play?"

"Excellent question. Wrong time."

He squared the cards. "A Veil of Justice could leave with more tokens over many shoes, if his record stayed exact and his wager changed with the condition."

The discards had piled all through the play while the shoe went down. Ka-Syphiron put his hand flat on them.

"These have gone," he said. "They cannot come again. So the rest of the shoe is a different shoe from the one you dealt, and it changes with every hand. A man who kept record of what had gone would know which shoe he was playing."

Ka-Syphiron turned his cup once on the table and said nothing further.

"Extremely generous tonight, Keeper," Va-Raedin murmured.

"Could he never be ruined?" I asked.

"Chance still has teeth. Given enough play and a finite purse, it may take him. The record does not abolish risk." He gathered the cards. "Justice knows this so deeply they have made a morality of it."

He closed the box. The smile thinned. He rested one hand on it.

"Do not steal one idea from another Kahir and mistake it for the whole doctrine. Do not commit the ludic error: the world does not promise to keep the rules written on the table. Lesson one may be true, and lesson three may be why lesson one kills men when applied alone."

"That is not only a Justice warning," Va-Raedin added.

"Sa-Kailan," Ka-Syphiron said. "Be very careful. If you look across a wall, ask first whether it keeps you out, keeps something in, or keeps two things apart."

"Yes, Keeper."

Ka-Syphiron said, "And if you must be terrified tomorrow, try not to do it with your shoulders. It makes the robe hang badly."

I laughed once, helplessly.

Ka-Syphiron shut the Justice box and pushed it away. "All right. Sa-Kailan, I have a few things to tell Va-Raedin."

I rose. For a moment I wanted to say something worthy of the evening, but everything I found would have diminished it. So I bowed, lower than I had bowed on entering. When I straightened, Va-Raedin was watching me. He held my gaze and nodded once.

I opened the door. The old gallery waited outside, dim and smoke-blackened. Neither man spoke until the door had nearly closed. I heard one fragment, Ka-Syphiron's voice lower than before.

"Here. For tomorrow, and for—"

Then the latch caught.

The next morning, attendants of Light woke me before First Light and dressed me in pale robes. They bound a folded white cloth around my wrist. Va-Raedin came for me and led me toward the Hall. On the way we passed the oil-press, where spent cake lay in baskets marked for the lofts and tanks, and the bone-gatherers' room, where steam carried the smell of broth and glue into the corridor. At the side routes, Shield attendants stood beside lowered bars. Balance servants carried marked lamp-oil tins through a service door. At the Hall entrance, a Justice scribe bent over an open record.

— What comes next is the double Ascension of Light.

— Good. Let us stop there. I want the morning for it.

— You are taking the machine?

— Yes.

— The lawn?

— The lawn.

[—]

— Martinez?

— Nothing has happened. But I have learnt something. And I brought you this.

— A map?

— Of this part of Africa. Here is Algeria. Below it, Niger. Libya here, Chad here. Your Mountain is somewhere along this line.

— The pendulum. I should not have told you.

— No.

[—]

— Roger Michel Martinez. Born in Oran, here, in fifty-seven. He was five when Algeria ceased to be French. I lose him for nearly twenty years. Then he appears here, in Niamey, the capital of Niger. Early eighties. France's nuclear industry drew heavily on Niger's uranium. Martinez is still in his twenties, with a modest title and rather immodest access.

— Edward?

— Not yet. That is what interested me. Then Chad, eighty-six. Libya had troops in the north; France and Chad were fighting them. In February French aircraft bombed Ouadi Doum, the Libyan airfield in the desert. Martinez was in Chad at the time, and I can find no uranium business that explains why.

— So he worked for France.

— Perhaps. France is everywhere around him. Nowhere I can attach Martinez himself to French intelligence without cheating.

— Then don't. You gave me quite a lecture about Homer on that last morning.

— I was hoping you had forgotten that.

— I remember everything inconvenient. Sarah and Urs?

— Know nothing. And the occasion I am waiting for has not come.

— Then we wait.

Chapter 8

Light

— The twenty-ninth of March; the seventh of our interviews. We are in the dark, which took some arranging: doubled shutters and this one lamp lit in the whole house. Since we are about to see a ceremony of light, I should give you one before we begin. It is the smaller of the two, and I have gone to some trouble for it, so bear with an old man playing at priest. Sit where the pale screen faces you. I have set out the lamp; a card with a narrow slot cut in it; a wedge of good glass, which you already know as a prism; a small clean flame; and a few dishes of common salts. When I put out the lamp, keep your eyes on the screen.

— Nothing. It is a very complete dark. In the Mountain even the last cell keeps one thread of a lamp somewhere down the passage; a man is never given the whole of the dark, only lent a piece of it. This is darker than anything the Mountain would allow. I see nothing at all.

— Before I open it again: yesterday's Egypt. Did the computer game make the instruction clearer?

— I am accustomed to learning through games; Light only preferred not to call them that, though I spent half an afternoon teaching the computer's little arrow to obey my hand. A game with five gods, you people have a sense for irony. Here a house wanted water, then food, then access to one god; entertainment, pottery, a physician, beer, justice and writing. Each provision enlarged the house. The tutor left me alone and returned an hour later. In his absence I had neglected Bast's festival. She answered

with plague. The houses had emptied, but one juggler was still circling the abandoned streets. I had been waiting to see whether he would stop.

— We shall leave the juggler to his empty roads. Let me open the lamp again. I take its light through the narrow slot, so that it reaches the glass as a single thin blade. The glass bends each colour by its own amount and lays them in a row upon the screen. There. Look at what plain lamplight contains.

— A band of colour laid along the wall. Red at one end, then orange, yellow, green and blue, to a last edge of violet. Each runs into the next without a seam: one unbroken stripe, with no colour left out. The plain lamp gives you the lot, run together in a row.

— Hold that stripe in your eye. Now I put the lamp out and light this small flame, which has almost no colour of its own. Through the slot and the glass it gives you next to nothing. Now I take a pinch of ordinary salt and give it to the flame. Watch the screen.

— The stripe does not come. Where the whole band stood there is one bar: a hard yellow line, bright and narrow, hung upon the black. On either side, all down the wall where every other colour was, there is nothing.

— A clean flame now, and a different salt. Watch where the yellow stood.

— The yellow does not return. A hard red line stands in its own place, with a fainter orange line farther along. You give the fire a thing, and the fire answers with a pattern; each thing in its own places, and always the same places. What am I looking at, Paul? I have cast salt into a flame a hundred times and watched it colour. I have never seen the fire speak in separate lines.

— You are looking at the permitted energies inside matter. Remind yourself of your second lesson, *Cosmos*, who taught you the infinitely large universe, but also the infinitely small atoms and electrons inside matter. An electron in an atom may carry this amount of energy, or that amount, but it cannot remain between the allowed amounts. Think of steps with no floor between them. The fire's heat throws an electron upward. When it falls, it releases one fleck of light, and the distance of the fall fixes that light's colour. Each kind of atom has its own allowed steps and its own possible falls. At this heat, through this glass, the bright ones make its pattern of lines. The dark between them is the light this substance does not give us here.

— You have given me the *memory of light*.

— That is the answer Syphiron left you: the step and the fall. I wanted the small true thing in your eye before you gave me the great one. Let me give you the room back now.

— No. Leave it dark; it will serve me. Hand me the matches from the sill. ... There: one flame, and the whole of the rest put out. Do a thing for me, Paul. Make this small room one of your cathedrals: tall cold stone, the roof lost above you in the dark.

> Put out every light but this one. Stand five thousand people in it, shoulder against shoulder, breathing and holding still. Keep that behind your eyes while I speak: the flame, the dark, and all those souls gathered around it, waiting. Now I will tell you how the Mountain crowns its Keepers of Light.

Before the First Light, every tier I could see was packed. The old were carried down from their beds. Children stood between their parents' knees. The lower workers came up with their hair still wet from the steam chambers. People were still pressing shoulder to shoulder along the upper stone when Shield shut the last arch. I stood in Light's northern tier with the folded white cloth bound at my wrist and its loose end tucked beneath itself. Raedin's place above me was empty. Mine waited one step higher than the stone under my feet, though I had no right to stand in it yet. Sela was below with the lamp attendants, an oil pitcher held against her robe. Above us, high on its long wire, the great disk of the Pendulum kept its slow crossing over the forbidden circle at the heart of the Hall, out and back, patient as a tide, closing its round in near three days.

Light had set few lamps in sight. I found them by following each lit edge back to the hidden plate that had thrown it. Their beams crossed the people without settling on them and ended at the forbidden circle, the gravure and the disk. Faces appeared when one person leaned into a beam and went away when that person straightened. Above the southern descent the Genesis gravure held what light it was allowed: the carved Mountain warm along its ridges, the Oasis in green shadow beneath it, Adam and Eve half-shown, the five children coming and going as the bodies shifted below them. Over all of it, in the carved sky, one small hard grain of fire burned above the Mountain. The eye of Heaven.

Ka-Syphiron came in carrying the last strong lamp, and the lesser flames became servants to it. He called me down out of my tier by my name. I went to him and knelt, and the floor was cold through my robe, and he laid his hands upon my head, and they were dry and heavy and sure.

"Sa-Kailan of Light," he said, and the name came back off the walls changed. "What is the eye for?"

"To find what hides," I said.

"What is the hand for?"

"To let it lie."

"What is the tongue for?"

"To keep the dark."

His hands lifted from my head. "Rise now as Va-Kailan, Veil of Light." I rose, and the white cloth at my wrist was lawful now, and he turned me by the shoulder and sent me back up to my tier. Sela looked from the cloth to my face and the corner of her mouth lifted. Then she lowered her eyes to the pitcher. I climbed the one step into Raedin's old place, and the great disk swung on between us.

Then the two of them took their places within the forbidden circle, the great ring of dark stone at the heart of the Hall, forbidden to every foot, that held now only theirs. Ka-Syphiron stood at its far edge, on the god's side, under the carved sky and the open eye of Heaven, and turned his face to the light. Va-Raedin knelt on one knee at its near edge, on the beast's side, and turned his face to the deep. And the great disk crossed the ring between them, out and back, and passed close by the old man in his light and the young man in his dark, and passed on.

Then the Hall began to give up its light, and it gave it up the way the sea gives up the shore, slowly, and with an even hand. A voice took up the Book of Promise out of the failing light, from somewhere below the gravure. The tiers came in beneath it, thousands low together, and gave the words back in the dawn cadence I had known since childhood.

> *And the people dwelt beneath the stone, and darkness was above them, and the Mountain covered them. And they remembered the forest, and the rivers, and the open waters that were spoiled; and when they lay down they spoke of the places where they had dwelt. One remembered a tree beside the water, and another the branch upon which her children had climbed. And God heard their mourning beneath the Mountain.*

A lamp went out behind me, then another below. A high slit above the northern arch went black. One reflector lost its thread, and a whole reach of the Hall closed over. I followed the withdrawals while I could: western tier, lower aisle, Justice stair. After that, each remaining light threw more than one shadow, and I lost the order. The white cloth at my wrist showed sharply each time a beam found it, then greyed as another lamp went down.

> *And God said unto them, Fear not the darkness which I have given thee; for the darkness shall be thy veil, and the stone shall be thy wall, and the deep waters shall be thy life. Thou*

shalt dwell within the Mountain, and thy children shall be born beneath the Mountain, and the eye of Heaven shall not find thee.

And God said, Let the water be brought where the people dwell, and let the lamps be tended along their ways. Cover the sleeping child, and set a cup within reach of the sick. When the labourer returneth, let him find his portion kept for him; and when his hands fail him in his age, thou shalt continue to feed him. And the people brought their sick and their old into the chambers, and made room beside them.

And the gravure sank by degrees: the Mountain lost its ridges, the Oasis went under, Adam and Eve slipped beneath, and the five children stood a breath longer than the rest, pale in the last slant of the light, and then the dark had them too.

And God said, Keep thou the Mountain, and keep thou the Oasis, and keep thou the Temple. Keep the secrets apart, and let no one hand hold the whole. Let no sign be carried from its chamber, nor proof borne beyond its seal; for a secret held in place may preserve the people, but a secret made to wander shall become fire among them. Let the Keeper of Balance count the waters, and the Keeper of Faith teach the Gospel, and the Keeper of Shield defend the threshold, and the Keeper of Light illuminate the passages, and the Keeper of Justice keep peace between brother and brother.

The eye of Heaven burned last of all, one grain above the drowned Mountain.

And God said, If thou keepest My word, and if thy children keep it after thee, then I shall remember the forest and the rivers that were lost. And the day shall come when the desert shall withdraw, and the waters shall run openly again, and the trees shall rise where sand and ash had lain.

Then a slit closed somewhere far up, and the eye of Heaven went down with the rest.

And in that day the Mountain shall open without fear, and the Beast shall be chained forever in Hell, and the children of the hidden people shall walk beneath Heaven and not be consumed. The people shall be reborn, and the Oasis shall no longer hide in shadow; and the people shall know neither thirst, nor wandering, nor the fear of being seen. And God saw the promise, and behold, it was very good.

And the last of the words went out into the dark, and the Hall was still.

There remained one flame. It stood in Ka-Syphiron's hand, in the throat of his lamp, small as the fire at the tip of a struck taper; and around it the whole Hall stood up enormous, and packed, and black. Thousands of us stood in that dark, shoulder to shoulder, and held our silence, and breathed as softly as a body breathes; and the one small fire in the old man's hand had the whole of that vastness, and all those thousands, and all that stillness to hold at bay, and it held them, and held them only just. Each time the flame shifted, Syphiron's shadow climbed the gravure and Raedin's moved across the floor toward him. High above, the great disk crossed on through the black, out and back, felt now in the floor, and the teeth, and the chest.

Then the ceiling answered. A sound came down so low the bone caught it before the ear. High in the throat of the vault, a row of locks released, each followed by the pull of chain taking weight; and out of the dark above the Pendulum a dome came down. It came slowly, a vast cap of old black stone lowering itself over the swing, the two men and the one flame; and at its crown an eye stood cut clean through the rock, with the Pendulum wire running through it into the dark. As the dome came down along the wire, the crossing of the great disk began to close. Out, and back, and a little less far; out, and less far again; the swing drawing into itself the lower the stone came, as though the dome were gathering the long years into its own weight as it fell.

And as it came down, Ka-Syphiron spoke across the narrowing swing to the man on his knee.

"Va-Raedin of Light. What does the Keeper carry?"

"The light," Va-Raedin said, over the dark, facing the deep.

The dome came lower, and the swing of the disk drew shorter.

"What does the Keeper hold?"

"The chain."

Lower still, and the crossing of the disk drawn now to a hand's breadth.

"What does the Keeper keep?"

"What must remain dark."

Ka-Syphiron set the lamp at his feet. With both hands he opened his robe below the ribs. The descending stone crossed his hands, then his face, and came down upon the floor. The disk had drawn its crossing to a standstill as stone met stone, and the eye at the crown carried the last flame away inside. The Hall stood

in pitch dark. The one light was shut within the stone. The great disk hung on its wire, still.

I heard something move within the dome. I kept my eyes open, though the black gave them nothing. My wrist found the stone rail in front of me; the lawful cloth was soft beneath my fingers. A sound came through the stone, once. Then a shorter sound. Someone above drew a breath through the nose and caught it. The dark went on. Without the disk crossing beneath us, the Hall had lost the small pulse that entered the feet at each return. I could hear my own blood in my ears.

Chain links rattled and went taut above us, and the dome began to rise. It climbed the wire; and as the eye at its crown lifted clear of the disk, the great Pendulum stirred off its stillness, and moved a little, and then farther; out, and farther; the crossing lengthening as the stone climbed, the clock of my people taking up its count again.

Out of the rising dark came the old man in his underrobe, bent over, both hands pressed below his ribs. Blood ran between the fingers that had rested dry and heavy on my head. His voice reached my tier. "Rise now," he said, "as Ka-Raedin, Keeper of Light." His knees folded, one hand struck the stone, and he went down upon it. My foot reached the stair before I felt it move. I caught the rail and kept my place.

A seam of gold opened along the floor beneath the rising stone, and widened, and the small flame came up in a living hand. Ka-Raedin stood in it, on the god's side of the swing where the old man had stood. He wore Syphiron's robe, its shoulders cut for a larger man. His face was white. In his other hand he held the ceremonial knife, and along its edge, his knuckles and the stone at his feet there was blood. Syphiron lay in it in his underrobe, his face bare to the light, and did not move again.

The dome climbed into the vault and settled home in the ceiling. Above the two men, the great disk swung once more to its full reach.

Ka-Raedin lifted the small flame over the body.

"Light is reborn," he said. "The chain holds."

And the Hall gave it back to him, thousands of voices out of the black: "Light is reborn. The chain holds."

And upon the word, the whole Hall took fire at once.

Light struck me from the front, both sides and above, hard enough that I raised my hands to my face. The Hall blazed. Mirror threw to mirror and threw again, and gold answered gold down the length of the stone; the carved Mountain, the green Oasis and the eye of Heaven stood together out of the dark and burned. Hands rose across the tiers. People cried out, some laughing and some weeping, and looked again between their fingers. I looked with them. At the heart of the blaze stood the new Keeper of Light in the gold robe, the small flame in one hand and blood on the other, with the great disk crossing bright above him. At his feet, Syphiron's blood lay black inside all that gold.

> — There.
>
> — ... God. All of it, all at once. Give me a moment; I am blind from it. Pull the curtains shut again.
>
> — I wanted you to have the great one the way you gave me the small, Paul: whole, and in the eye.
>
> — ... Yes. Yes, all right. Now put some of them out again, before you blind an old man in earnest.

Four of Light's attendants spread a white cloth beside Syphiron and rolled him onto it. His nearer hand slipped from the edge as they lifted. Sela caught it in both of hers, laid it across his chest and folded the cloth over it. They carried him through the northern descent. Ka-Raedin's face followed the white bundle until it passed under the arch. Then the Keepers gathered to him. Each went out through one of the five office arches, and each door closed. We waited in the Hall with no Keeper among us. Voices murmured scripture. A child cried somewhere above me and was quieted. Two attendants washed the forbidden circle, working from its edge on their knees. After a long while, five hard strokes came up through the floor, one after another. I counted them. The pause held, then the slow deep answer travelled through the stone and into my feet. A long wait followed before the five doors opened and the Keepers returned. I stood under the new light, a Veil of Light since that morning, the white cloth lawful at my wrist and the great disk swinging its slow round above us. Inside the forbidden circle, water lay black in the seams where the attendants had washed Syphiron's blood.

Chapter 9

Heaven

— The thirty-first of March; the eighth of our interviews; shall we continue?

— One thing first, since I steered instruction towards geometry. Pythagoras. When did he live?

— About two and a half thousand years ago.

— Your kind is late.

— Why are you smiling?

— Let us continue.

For several days after the martyrdom, I waited for the Mountain to feel different. Water still came by measure. Children still recited badly in the teaching halls; the correcting voices stayed level through the third mistake and sharpened on the fourth. Shield still lowered bars without explaining them. Balance still marked loss and use with the same green dye. Faith still spoke over jars and wounds and dead bees, over frightened mothers and old men who had begun to forget the names of their own children.

Syphiron had made the white cloth on my wrist lawful before the tiers. The succession record placed my changed name beneath Ka-Raedin's, and Ka-Raedin put the northern halls into my keeping. The candidate sequences came to my

hand, and the apparatus rosters, and the cross-Kahir requests that Light must answer and file and answer again; the lamp accounts; the quarrels over who might stand where during which rite; the young men to be watched, graded and told, in the exact measure Va-Raedin had once used on me, that their best was acceptable. I rose before the First hour and lay down after the last lamp, and between the two there was no hour that was mine.

Sela still brought the cloths and the little oil at first. She would place the dish within my reach and keep two fingers on its rim until I took it, the corner of her mouth holding the smile she had worn below me in the Hall. Then another attendant came in her place. The next time Sela and I met, she stopped as my new rank required. She kept her eyes on mine for one breath too long, lowered them, moved to the wall and struck her lamp against the stone. I did not ask to have her returned. The candidates I had trained beside stopped speaking when I entered a hall and gave me the flat obedience a man gives an office. I crossed Va-Sheva twice in six months. Each time she struck fist to breast, asked whether Light required Shield, and went on when I said it did not.

The Mirror had been mine since I was a candidate of Light. I had stood before it in the dark for days, then weeks, then years run together, until I knew every beam the way a man knows the inside of his own mouth and could catch the one thread of light entering where no thread should. In those first months as Veil I went to it still. My eye found the trespass, my hand entered it on the slate, and I wanted no answer from it.

Ka-Raedin continued the curriculum. One morning he set me at the wave wall to learn what light does when it passes an edge.

"It bends," I said, giving it back to him. "It bends around the edge, and it spreads. Set a second edge beside the first, and the two spreadings meet, and where they meet they add in some places and cancel in others, and leave a banding of light and dark that no straight ray could make."

"Interference," he said.

"Interference. There."

I gave him the banding correctly. He did not dismiss me. His eyes moved from the bright bars to my face and stayed there while one bar faded out against the next.

"You will learn the next thing after this," he said.

"No. I will not learn the next thing, Keeper. I have done the arithmetic of your chain. Every next thing you set before me is a single step toward one morning, and I have already seen it, because you showed it to me under a falling stone. To finish

the chain is to take the knife to the place below the ribs that the Keeper bares to it. Syphiron opened his robe before the stone sealed you in. I heard the sound under the stone. I saw your knife when the stone rose. I will not walk toward the morning that hand is mine and the body under it is yours. Find another Veil. Let him take my place, and rise, and hold the knife. I will stay where I am, and you will go on living."

So I stopped. The lamps had to be trimmed whether or not the hand that trimmed them wished to be alive, and I trimmed them, graded the candidates and filed the requests, all of it correct and empty. I let the questions that had once burned behind my teeth go out, one by one, and did not miss their light. By day I moved through the northern halls the way a lamp is carried through a room, giving out what I was told and wanting nothing.

For six months Ka-Raedin changed none of my duties. When he watched me work he corrected the position of a lens or the edge of a mark, never the silence after it. At the end of the sixth month I stood before the small black basin with a cloth half-lowered toward the water and could not remember why the circle had to be clean, whom I cleaned it for, or whether I would mind if I left it. I stood without moving.

Ka-Raedin entered while I was still holding the cloth above the basin.

"Va-Kailan of Light. Put the cloth down. It has waited eleven and a half thousand years; it will keep a year more."

I released the cloth. He took the stool with the uneven leg, sat and looked at it sinking in the basin. Then he gave me what he called an unwritten name from the oldest mouth-to-ear teaching of Light.

"What is on you now has a name, though you will find it in no record. We call it the ascension amnesia. It is the grand and ancient sickness of Light, and you are not the first it has taken, nor the tenth, nor the hundredth. It came for me, and for the one who trained me, back and back as far as the office runs. Syphiron had it the year he could not stop seeing the face of the man he had risen over; the Keeper before him gave him the cure, and Syphiron gave it to me, and I am giving it to you now. The office is built out of the very thing that breaks a man: you are made to see, then shown that everything you saw was the half of it, then handed the knife. I have counted your years. Three a servant. Four and a half a candidate. Six months a Veil. That is eight years of Light — eight years of the dark and the Mirror — and in all of them no one, not I and not Syphiron and not the Mountain, ever once told you that you were allowed to be tired. Give yourself the time. Remember why you liked the light in the first place, before it was a chain, and a knife. I am taking

the northern halls off you. All of them, for a year. You will sleep by day, and I will hear no word of complaint about it from any quarter; and if a candidate must be graded, he can wait, or be graded by a man who is not drowning."

"And what am I to do with the year, Keeper?"

"Nothing. I want you to waste it, end to end, and come to me at the finish of it and tell me why you still love the light."

He stood and lifted the wet cloth from the basin. He wrung it once and laid it across the rim.

"One thing more. All those years at the Mirror in the dark, catching the one glimmer in the black — no one has told you why we make a boy do that beyond the surveillance of the Mountain, nor what it is training the eye to do. It is not obvious. It was not obvious to me either. Come up with me now, and I will show you, and then I will leave you to it."

He led me to the last of the northern Light passages.

I had cleaned that shaft only as high as my ladder reached; above it the rock stayed black. Ka-Raedin climbed past the ladder, found a hold inside the dark and drew himself into the rock. I followed. The route rose by handholds worn smooth, then by a stair that narrowed into a chimney a broad man could not have passed. The stone took the warmth from my fingers. Twice I had to stop with my forehead against it and wait for my breath.

The Mountain is a cone. Near its top, the route opened into a great hollow, cut or found in the rock as though a vast ball had been pressed into the point and lifted away, taking the tip with it. Ka-Raedin called it the one room of Light that Shield did not enter. In that round bowl at the crown of the Mountain stood an observatory.

It was a low round room open to the heavens. Shallow polished places, each the length of shoulders and heels, marked the floor. Above them, a dome of metal and glass turned on a ring. Beneath the opening stood an instrument I had no name for: a long metal throat carried on pivots and brass circles, a lens at either end. "We have metal," he said, "and we have lenses. Give a people both and a reason to look up, and sooner or later they build this. Put your eye to it."

"Here," he said. "There is no lesson tonight, nor on any night you do not want one. The heavens are yours to explore. If a question comes to you, bring it to me and I will answer it gladly and without tricks. And if you only wish to look, then look — and find again why you liked the light, before anyone told you what it costs."

Then he took a bottle from inside his robe and two of the small white cups, and he filled them both, and held one out to me.

"We have not done this," he said. "Neither of us, not once. There has been an office to hold, and a young man to carry, and a Mountain to keep from its fear, and in the middle of all of it no one has said his name aloud and grieved him. So." He raised the cup. "To Syphiron of Light."

"To Syphiron of Light," I said, and my voice broke on the second syllable of his name.

We drank. He filled the cups again. On the third filling I held mine without raising it. "I knelt while they made a light of his death," I said.

"He commanded you to kneel."

"You held the knife."

"I did."

"Did you love him?"

"Yes."

"So did I."

Ka-Raedin set his cup down first. I set mine beside it. We wept with our faces uncovered, across the width of the two white cups. Neither of us looked away. Neither told the other to stop.

"Speaking of archangels," I said. I heard Syphiron's voice in the words. Ka-Raedin bowed his head over the cups, and I did the same.

When the cold had dried our faces enough for speech, Ka-Raedin spoke.

"Every Light that ever rose has come up here to do the thing you have just done. And to remember, when everything the office has taught you has turned to weight in your hands, the one thing under all of it that stayed only beautiful. The light. What we have always loved."

He wrapped the two cups together and returned them to his robe. Then he left me there, as he had promised, with the bottle and the slow turning of the heavens. The next evening I climbed alone.

I slept through the daylight and climbed at dusk. Before then the sky had reached me in pieces: two shafts of borrowed sun, a Hall of lamps, a few stars cut off by a vent. Now I lay on my back in the cold stone bowl with the long glass beside me and an uninterrupted sky above it. Every clear night for a year, I looked.

There were more stars than there were people in the Hall, more than there were people in the whole of my world, and they did not hold still. The entire field turned through the night in one slow wheel. Low in the north, one star stayed near the wheel's centre while the others went around it the way water goes around a

stone. I lay under the field until the cold entered my shoulders and let it remain larger than I could count.

Then, because I had been made in the dark before the Mirror and could no more stop measuring than stop breathing, I began to measure.

The wheel was not quite true. I marked the low northern star against the rim of the sighting frame. It left the mark, returned and left again, keeping a small circle of its own. The centre of the turning lay in the empty dark beside it, where no star stood. I copied three angles from the wider field onto slate. Night after night, then season after season, the same three points returned without changing their relation by more than my hand could read. Faith could keep the monsters and heroes it laid over them. I kept the triangles.

And against that fixed lattice, a few things moved.

Five bright points broke the pattern. Night upon night they moved along one slanting road across the others, now quick, now slow, one of them so bright before dawn that I mistook it once for a lamp. The Moon moved faster and changed both shape and brightness, so I placed it nearer than the fixed field. Under the long glass a single point divided into two; a smudge broke into a knot; one bright wanderer opened into a small round disc with four lesser lights beside it. I drew their order. On the next night it had changed. Sometimes one disappeared against the disc and returned on the other side. This star gave faint red light and that one blue-white.

Other travellers crossed too quickly to belong to that road. Some carried two or three lights that blinked in a fixed order, followed the same tracks between south and north and, on still nights, sent a low sound after themselves. Others were single pale points: steady, silent, crossing the whole field in minutes and sometimes going out in clear sky before reaching any horizon. I entered the two kinds separately and left both unnamed.

Across the whole field, from one edge of the dark to the other, ran a pale river of light, splitting and closing again with black reaches braided through the bright. Through the long glass its pale continuity broke into points: stars, and fainter stars between them, past my count. When I lifted my eye from the lens, the crowd closed into mist again.

I carried up a narrow water clock, smoked glass, waxed cord and the sighting-frames of the practice halls. I fixed the frames to the same three bolts each night and kept the overflowing slates in a box beneath the mounting. The width shown by the Moon and the width shown by the sun through smoked glass came nearly equal. I wrote both numbers small and measured them again.

Some things I could not measure, and reached anyway. The Moon kept its bright side toward the place where the sun had gone down or would rise. I took it for a ball that made no light, showing me different portions of its sunward half as it moved. Once that year, with the Moon full and the sun below the opposite horizon, a dark boundary entered the disc. I marked its edge at each emptying of the water clock. The entry and release fitted one circle, much broader than the Moon, and the same curve crossed every part of its face. The Moon was inside a shadow cast from the sunward side of the ground beneath me.

Below, I put a flat round stone, a clay cylinder and a clay ball before a lamp. The stone gave a circle only while it faced the flame and narrowed when I turned it. The cylinder gave a circle from its end and a bar from its side. The ball kept its round boundary however I turned it. I carried that trial back to the eclipse marks and wrote: *The ground is a sphere.*

The fixed stars defeated the rest of my reach. I moved the sighting frame from one side of the bowl to the other and climbed from the floor to the upper ring; no star shifted against another by a width my marks could hold. I entered only that their distance exceeded my available line. Why the five wanderers slowed, hurried and doubled back along their road I could not solve. I wrote the reversals and left the cause blank.

I also counted the failed aimings. Between one star and the next, the long glass gave me black. I moved it by one measured width, then another, and still had black. The lights multiplied under the lens, but the unlit reaches multiplied faster. I began writing a short stroke for each empty field. The margins filled before the centres of the slates did.

By the third month I had two boxes of slates and had asked the lens workers for a finer screw on the mounting. By the fifth I was grinding a chipped spare lens and taking my meals on the stair. Once I missed the last lamp and slept beside the mounting because I would not abandon a sequence halfway through. Questions returned to my mouth faster than Ka-Raedin answered them.

Ka-Raedin climbed to inspect my work at the end of each month. On his first visit he checked the mounting, the shutters and the lamp account before he looked at a slate. On the fourth he found a black circle from the eyepiece around my eye and laughed until he had to sit on the floor. On the sixth he brought charcoal and drew one around his own. He still made me repeat a measure when my marks were loose and still took a lens from my hand if I reached for it before the glass cooled. But I heard him laugh more in that year than in all my training.

That frightened me. Syphiron had been the merriest person I knew, and he had opened his robe below the ribs without a sound. I began to fear that Ka-Raedin's laughter belonged to the same chain: that a man said yes beneath the stone, survived the saying and came out light enough to lead another man toward the knife. I could not prove the connection. I did not ask him. I watched him laugh and wondered whether one day a grim Veil would watch me do the same.

Near the end of the year Ka-Raedin climbed up to me one clear night, and lay down on the cold stone at my side.

For a while neither of us spoke. Then he asked what I had found beyond the light I loved.

"Earth is a sphere," I said.

"It is."

I showed him the two columns beside it. A chosen star returned to my frame a little sooner each night than the sun returned to the noon line, by the same small margin within the water clock's error. At the end of the year the star count had gained one whole turn. I could not say why the two counts kept different time.

He ran one finger down the columns twice. "You found the difference alone, up here, with no one to hand it to you. What moves is one secret; why the sun loses that margin is another. The first waits for you lower down."

"One finding remains," I said. "Light taught me that darkness is absence: what remains when a lamp fails. Up here, I aimed more often into black than into light. The dark continued through every empty field; the lights were the interruptions. I cannot say the black is empty. I can say only that the glass returned no light from most of where I pointed it."

"And do you still love the light?"

"More. It has farther to cross than I knew."

He took two of the small white cups from inside his robe — the same he had filled the night he first brought me up, a year gone — filled them, gave me one, and we drank to Syphiron again.

"The sun makes the shadow," he said. "Grief makes the man. It does not lessen. That is the thing no one tells a candidate, because a candidate would not come if he knew. You will carry Syphiron the way you carry your own name; and one day you will stand where I stand, and open yourself under the stone to the one who comes after you, and he will grieve you — and in that same hour you will grieve me, and Syphiron under me, and every name below us, all the way down. It is the longest part of the office, and the last taught, and the one honest thing in it."

He turned one of the cups in his hand, the small white one with a faded ring of blue about its lip.

"Ka-Sarem of Light taught me this, the year he was released, and told me where the cups came from, so that it would not stop with him. A Keeper of Light called Ka-Noroth, seven before Ka-Sarem, before any name I knew. He loved two things past the office. He loved to paint the heavens — though he could never keep the paint from the damp, so none of it lived. And he loved to paint women, and those he found ways to keep. When his hands grew too old for a brush he turned them away from the wheel of the heavens and made these: a cup for the Keeper, a cup for the Veil, thin enough to break if a man closed his fist on one, so that he would have to be gentle with his grief or lose the vessel of it."

He set his cup inside mine for a moment, the two blue rings touching.

"So you have grieved Syphiron from the cups of a man who loved the heavens, and loved women, and is three hundred years in the ground, and whom you carry now as well, because I have said his name to you. Drink."

We separated the cups and drank. He wrapped both in a square of cloth and returned them to his robe. "I have a use for what you have become. Come down tomorrow. There is a thing you must be shown, and a thing you must be told before it."

The next day, at the foot of the shaft he put his hand flat on the cold stone. "I have spoken to Ka-Leth of Justice. What you found up here has earned you the next teaching a Veil is owed — and it is no deep secret of theirs, but a plain shape Justice drills into its servant boys before they are grown. He has set one of his candidates to give it to you — a young man, Sa-Tavan — and asked me nothing about why, because Justice does not ask. Take what Sa-Tavan gives; give him nothing back. He will teach you a shape, and you will never tell him what the shape is for. You will not name the ground under our feet, nor what turns above it, nor say that you have been up here at all. Light holds a thing Justice does not, and Justice may not have it from you. That is the whole of the condition. Do you take it?"

I took it.

In a plain Justice schoolroom, of the kind where the servant boys are drilled, stood a square table with its sides raised a hand high, like a tray built to hold sand. In the tray lay four equal cut stones, each a wedge with one square corner. Sa-Tavan waited beside it, ink to the second knuckle. He did not shift his feet while I entered.

He set the four wedges into the tray one way. They left two square spaces, one large and one small, which two cut stones filled exactly. Then he lifted the same four wedges and set them another way in the same tray. They left one square space, and a third stone filled it exactly. He made me perform both arrangements until my fingers knew that the two squares in the first setting and the one in the second occupied what remained of the same tray around the same four wedges.

"The small square takes the wedge's short side," he said. "The larger takes its long side. The single square takes the sloping edge. Therefore the squares on the two sides enclosing the square corner, added together, make the square on the slope. That is the proof."

"I do not understand why Ka-Raedin thinks this helps Light."

"They have not told me why, but they told me to show you this as well." He turned to the wall and brought a lamp near an engraved circle. A level line and an upright line crossed at its centre. "The floor and the wall, we call them." A point on the upper right of the circle had been joined to the centre.

"Take the line from the centre to the point for a stick," he said. With a set-square he dropped the point to the level line, then carried it across to the upright. "Justice calls these its two shadows: what the sloping stick gives to the floor and what it gives to the wall. The stick and those two measures enclose a square corner. What the wedges proved therefore holds at every point on the circle. Call the stick one, and the squares of its floor-shadow and wall-shadow come always to one. That is what I was told to give you, and no more. Make of it what you will." I thanked him for the lesson and left.

Outside the door Ka-Raedin was waiting. Ka-Leth of Justice pulled the schoolroom shut behind me and set no seal on it. Through the closing gap I saw Sa-Tavan return the wedges to a shelf marked for first-year servants. Neither Keeper asked what had passed inside.

Then Ka-Raedin walked me to the Hall of Ceremony and left me sitting on Light's north side, facing the forbidden circle where swung the Pendulum.

"You have it all," he said. "You have the star in the north. You have a stick of one. You have its angle. Today you were given its floor-shadow and wall-shadow. Sit here with all of them and watch. Do not come back to me with an answer until you can state the question."

He turned to go, and at the threshold turned back. "Do you remember what I told you at the lesson of the fourth shadow?"

"The measure of the light is the measure of the substance," I said. "Part of a Veil's curriculum."

"Just so. And should it ever move you to know why one star in the heavens burns faint and red, and another blue-white, you will first have to learn how the measure of the light becomes the measure of the substance." He stepped into the dark of the passage. "Stay here until you have found the problem no one has set you — and can say both what it asks and what it answers. Then we will talk about the colours of stars."

I sat where he had left me with the star, the stick, the angle and the two shadows, watching the Pendulum cross its mark. Back and forth, back and forth.

Chapter 10

Threshold

— The second of April; the ninth of our interviews. Before we return to your account, *Rome* can wait, did you read the translation of *Genesis* I gave you?

— You promised me the first chapter and gave me four; thank you, Paul, though I do not yet know whether it was a kindness.

— The first murder was the earliest sensible place to stop. Keep one thing in mind: a shared shape does not tell you which came first, nor that either is true.

— Yes, I understand that now. Your Sagan, Attenborough and Darwin, taken together, were more convincing about our origins than any scripture I have ever read. Nevertheless, your murderer resembles ours. You call him Cain, son of Adam; ours is his grandson. The envy, the secret killing, the blood in the ground, the exile, the gate shut behind him — all of it kept, and the Mountain lost. You descend from the murderer's line by your own scripture, not mine. What I have not quite understood is Eve. Your God forbids her the fruit and swears it will kill her; the serpent tells her the boundary may guard God, not her. She looks, she crosses, and her eyes open. My Mountain would call that an ascension. She is Light, or perhaps the serpent is. Either way, you call it a fall, and you call the one who opened her eyes evil. Why?

— Listen to what you asked. To decide whether the serpent's gift was good or evil, I must already possess the knowledge of good and evil — and that knowledge is the fruit.

— Paul, is that a Faith trick you are using on me?

> — It is part of the story's circularity. One can judge the serpent, or one can judge the motive of the author who placed him there. What the story says and what the story is intended or used for are two separate questions.
>
> — In yours the woman crosses by her own hand and is blamed; in ours she is carried across as spoil and kept blameless because she never chooses. Then your God sentences her to multiplied sorrow in conceiving and bearing children, and says that her husband shall rule over her. Is that the price of having chosen once: to be forbidden to choose ever after?
>
> — Perhaps. Though I notice neither author troubled to ask her, and both were writing for men who would rather not have been told.
>
> — This time you can ask the one who crossed. Hear me before you name it ascension, illumination, revelation or fall. No hand carried me over. The choice was mine.

Ka-Raedin left me on the north side of the Hall of Ceremony, before the forbidden circle where the great Pendulum swung, and told me to give it the whole of my mind until I found what moved. After a year in which every problem had been mine to choose, I disliked being given one. By the twentieth day I would have traded it for any three of my own. By the fortieth I slept beside the Hall between rounds, woke with chalk on my fingers and resented any foot that crossed my marks. The Pendulum did nothing but pass before me, a dark blade crossing its mark, while my explanations died one after another beneath the swing.

One grey morning I set the angle of the still northern star upon Justice's engraved circle. The wall-shadow of its unit stick was the fraction I had lacked. I divided each day's measured drift by it, then seven days together, then all forty. The results agreed: the Mountain completed one turn while the fixed stars returned, and at our angle the floor carried the Pendulum through a full circle once in two and three-quarter days. If the Pendulum kept its line, the Mountain turned beneath it.

I went down to Ka-Raedin with the stick, the angles, the forty days of marks and my division. He made me begin again whenever I used a number where a word should have stood, then took the slate from me and worked the final line in his own hand. When he reached my answer, he set his palm flat upon the slate and looked through the wall toward the Pendulum, as if the stone had become briefly transparent.

"You found it," he said. He kept his palm on my figures. "A year in the cold, and you come down holding the eye, the number and the stone in one hand. Count

the people in this Mountain who could follow what you have just shown me. You will not need the second hand. You are younger than the next by thirty years."

Then he told me what the finding had earned. Faith had kept a record of the turning since before the Mountain numbered its own years. Justice preserved the number as an inheritance sealed against interpretation. Va-Maera alone still read the changing direction aloud in the Hall of Prayer and called it the course of God. I was to carry her my reckoning and bring her observations back to Ka-Raedin.

I had never entered the inner Hall of Prayer. I expected height, processions, the white fire of ceremony. I found Va-Maera alone at a low table with her sleeves tied back, blackening the edge of a brass sight with soot. Beside her lay columns of angles written in three hands, a cord worn shiny by use, and a bowl of lamp oil in which she was cooling a pin.

She did not ask why Light had sent their Veil into her inner ground. She pointed to the free side of the table. "Put down what you believe you have proved."

I laid out the swing, the star-angle and the turning ground. Before Va-Maera objected, I told her the mark described the ground moving beneath the Pendulum and not the course of God. She listened without defending either name. When I had finished, she took the oldest of her tables from its wrapping and asked where the mark should have stood on six nights chosen from years before my birth.

I worked until my confidence became sweat. Five of the six agreed with my rule as closely as the old instrument allowed. The last did not. Va-Maera turned the tablet over and showed me, on the reverse, a note that the south bearing had been repaired between those observations. I corrected for the changed bearing and the sixth mark entered the width allowed by the cord. "I chose that night to see whether you would erase the inconvenient mark," she said.

"Then you accept it," I said.

"I accept that your number predicts a mark which repeats."

"And will you stop calling it the course of God?"

She took her eyes from the slate. "Your ground turns about what?"

"An axis. Its northern end points into the empty place beside the still star."

"A direction in Heaven occupied by no light, around which every light appears to turn. And that is not the direction of God?" She placed one finger on the old heading. "You have corrected our motion. Have you disproved our direction?"

"I have disproved what the words say the Pendulum is doing."

She placed my finger on the oldest entry, then on the corrected angle two hands below it. Farther down, the same mistaken digit entered every copy at once. "That is when the first table entered Faith's keeping," she said. "Do you imagine I chose

every word I inherited? Light received the Pendulum before it understood the swing. Faith received the mouths that stand beneath it. My office preserves what was received. If I erase every error after I recognise it, the next person inherits only my certainty." She pushed the tablet towards me. "Write your correction beneath ours. Do not erase what you have not disproved."

I wrote my rule beneath the old heading. Va-Maera laid out six dates chosen across one year and covered three entries on each: First Light, the line of true noon set against Third Measure, and Fifth Blade. "The Pendulum gives you its next round for nothing," she said. "The day does not. Tell me where these marks stood."

I returned with the year of solar heights I had taken through smoked glass. I used the angle of the northern star, the sun's changing height and the small margin it lost each day against the fixed stars. My first three placed Fifth Blade before First Light: I had carried one of Justice's shadows in the wrong direction. I began again. When I had set all eighteen positions, Va-Maera uncovered Faith's table. Each entered the width allowed by the cord.

She turned over a clean slip. "Two days from now. First Light. True noon against Third Measure. Fifth Blade."

I gave her all three positions. She made me write them, fold the slip and close it beneath my seal. "If the sun finds your marks, we continue. If it does not, you return before deciding which of us has failed." She turned back to the brass sight and did not raise her eyes again.

Two days later the first edge of the sun crossed Faith's blackened sight within the width of my First Light line. At the day's height, the sight's shadow stopped and reversed within my noon line, short of Third Measure by the distance I had given. At dusk the sun's last edge left the sight within the width of Fifth Blade. Va-Maera opened my slip only after she had entered all three observations beside it. She offered no praise and changed no prayer. She wrapped my proof together with the table that called the turning divine. Thereafter I carried sealed predictions and observations between Light and Faith.

Twice each week I crossed the old service spine above the cedar descent, passed the disused oil shelves and followed the southern vents until their cold had softened into Mountain air. I began recording every draught, lamp and angle along the way.

On my fourth crossing, with the lamps behind me trimmed low, a point of light appeared through one of the southern vents on the new road to Faith. It was

no larger than a grain of salt and seemed to come from beyond the stone. I saw it for the length of one step. When I stopped I had passed the line and it was gone; one step back brought it again.

The year beneath the lenses had taught me the difference between light made and light returned. I lowered the nearest lamp and the point sharpened. I shielded the flame and it remained. When I raised it again, glare thinned the point but did not move it. It held only with my head against one seam, on the line where outside air entered before it became ours.

The vent opened south-east. The pale point lay where the second ridge would have stood beyond the Mountain. Va-Sheva's warning returned to me: *Do not point.* I had obeyed her before understanding.

A reflected point might be no more than a mineral face catching stray light. A cold thread through a sealed vent might be an old repair. Dust worn thin beside a stair no one used might be the work of rats or careless feet. I had three small facts. Irregularities could be nothing or something; until followed, they were neither. Beams were Light's to follow. If this one came from outside the Mountain, the question belonged to Shield as well. I reported none of them. Shield would close the road before I knew whether it defended the Mountain or exposed it.

For twelve nights I did nothing that could yet be named trespass. I watched from the permitted passage, covered and uncovered the nearest lamp and memorised the positions at which the point appeared. The lamp changed only the glare around it. The point failed when blown dust veiled the hidden opening and sharpened after the vent keepers cleared the upper throat. One narrow position brought eye, opening and second ridge into line. By the twelfth night I had learnt which stars to seek to follow the bearing in darkness.

By then inquiry had become a task I imposed on myself. I knew leaving the Mountain was forbidden. But all my years of corridors, sight-lines, counts and concealed marks had trained me to pass without notice; here was a way to test whether I could. If I found the source and returned unseen, I would bring the Mountain a discovery instead of a suspicion. I repeated that purpose until trespass sounded like service.

On ordinary nights, after Fifth Blade, every unappointed body returned to its sleeping chamber. The passages emptied, the Mirror stilled and Shield could give a name to almost any movement. Mourning alone kept the Mountain awake: kin, Faith and attendants crossed its lower ways until dawn, and Shield drew wardens inward to hold the Hall and its approaches. The outer watch was not abandoned, but it was thinned.

A child's death gave me such a night. The fever took the child before its naming, and so I have no name to place here, only the silence I used. The vent keepers had completed their last round before the mourning and would not return until First Light. I used the space their grief had made.

Since the Equal Light that closed my year beneath the sky, the nights had lengthened. I waited until the Pendulum had passed Fifth Blade and entered the long unspoken reach before the next First Light. My year of solar measures told me how wide that winter reach would be; it had scarcely begun. I wrapped a spark-stone against the damp and carried no lamp.

The lower stone yielded where its edge had been shaved thin. Beyond it, hand-holds had been cut into the passage without any office sign. Some were deep and polished; some had been widened later; lower down, a second line of holds suited a shorter reach, and one broken lip had been repaired with a pin whose metal had gone black. The passage had been altered for more than one reach and repaired after use.

Cold moved through the cracks ahead with the irregular breath of weather. At the last slab I put both hands to the hidden grip and waited through twenty breaths. No foot answered. I pressed. The slab gave, and the night entered around its edge. I opened it wide enough to pass, stepped outside and drew it shut behind me.

The night made scale uncertain. By day the desert had shown me a floor, a horizon and the Mountain standing between them; now stone, sand and distance shared one black surface beneath the stars. The still northern star restored one direction. I set the south-eastern bearing from the three fixed points I had used in the observatory. My remembered view from the Oasis and the line through the vent placed the ridge within a broad count. I had also chosen the long low dune that crossed the direct ground. I walked until its spine stood between the Mountain and me, then kept below it. My feet counted in silence.

The cold came horizontally. Wind pressed my robe against one side of me and filled the other, pulling warmth from my lips through the cloth. In a hollow the dune covered the lower stars. Its spine divided, and for a while each black rise offered the same bearing. I chose one, counted past the distance I had allowed and began to believe I had walked beside the ridge without seeing it. My lifted hand struck stone before my eyes found the rock.

I lowered myself and turned back toward the Mountain. Two Shield wardens crossed its outer shoulder, their lamps hooded between each patch of ground.

Neither light stopped, widened or returned along my line. I waited until both disappeared and took their going on as confirmation that they had not seen me.

I searched the face turned toward the Mountain first, moving both hands over the rock. The polished plate lay behind a lip no wider than my hand, cold and smooth against the stone. It had given me the flash and the pale point. I found no seam around it. Any door there would show itself to the Mountain each time it opened. The plate marked the bearing; the entrance had to lie where the ridge itself hid its use.

I went around the rock with one hand upon it, keeping its whole mass between the Mountain and me. On the far side I searched from the ground upward, lost the line twice and began again. At last my fingers entered a shallow engraving: a horizontal line broken twice, with a small notch turning inward. Shield. Above it, hollows rose at the intervals of hands and feet. Their lower lips had been rounded and their dust rubbed away. People had climbed there.

I followed the worn holds into a fold above the ground. Behind it my hand found a straight seam and, beneath the seam, a grip protected from sand. I could still return with the plate, the mark and the climb as my discovery. Returning would also let Keeper address Keeper and close the place before I learned whether the road defended the Mountain or deceived it. I pressed.

The mechanism resisted, then moved with the thick quiet of something old and tended. As it gave, a metal tongue struck once somewhere beyond the stone. I took the sound for the end of the lock. Dry air breathed out. I slipped inside and pulled the stone fully home behind me. The ridge, the stars and the Mountain vanished together. I felt along the wall until my hand entered a niche and found a lamp standing in oil. Only then did I unwrap the spark-stone and make light.

The passage descended sideways before opening into a corridor cut without ornament. Dust lay thin across the floor. In places it held the edges of footprints; in others a sleeve or carried burden had brushed the wall clean. One heel remained sharp and the next had collapsed into powder. They might have been days old or years.

The entrance lamp found one shelf. As the flame widened, shelves rose tier above tier and receded farther than the light could follow, all of them occupied: broken stone, painted wood, bowls, blades, corroded instruments, pieces whose uses were no longer known.

Every object bore Shield's broken threshold. The tags named source, condition, handling and danger; none invited study by another office. Down several tiers

and across hands separated by centuries, one instruction returned: *harmless unless taught.*

The clearer footprint crossed two rows, vanished beneath a fallen wrapping and began again beside a painted coffin long as a man. I moved the wrapping to find the heel and uncovered the upper half of the lid instead: across it stood a falcon-headed man crowned by a red sun-disc. A small black serpent rose from the disc's lower edge and held its head against the red. I could not have named him in the archive. The lesson on Egypt has since given me his name: Ra.

— Stop. No. An Egyptian coffin, whole, beneath that ridge?

— I did not say whole.

— How large?

— Longer than I was tall.

— Wood or stone?

— Wood. Or the lid was. I did not try to move it.

— The colours?

— The disc was red; the serpent and the falcon's eye were black; the face and arms were yellow; a broad collar was blue with green between its bands. Or so I remember them. The lamp was poor.

— The serpent. Did it stand before the disc, or go around it?

— Around it, once.

— Wait. I am getting something.
[Door. Printer. Returning steps. Three sheets beside the recorder.]

— Which one?

— The second. The body made one turn around the disc and passed behind it; the hood rose open at the left.

— Uraeus.

— A serpent protecting the light?

— The king. Fire and venom for his enemies.

— Ah. I had forgotten you were an archaeologist.

— I had not. any writing? Or damage?

— Columns beside him; a split through one shoulder. The rest stayed covered. I was following the footprint, Paul. That is all I remember.

The oldest tag called him *sun-lord; corruption of eye-of-Heaven memory; pigments fugitive; keep covered.* Someone later had scored through *corruption* and written beneath it: *precedence unestablished.* A third keeper had sealed both statements in place.

The cut through *corruption* had bitten deep enough to score the wood beneath the tag. The correction sat above it; the third seal held both. I rubbed a thumb across condemnation, correction and seal, then set the tag down with all three hands visible.

The displaced wrapping had protected a painted board. An old man stood over a bound boy laid on a stone, a knife raised in one hand. Behind him a ram had caught its horns in thorns. From a break in the painted sky, a hand reached down and closed around the man's wrist. The order was plain: God above, father over son, the blade between them, and the animal spared.

My shoulder caught another panel propped behind me. I stopped it before it fell and brought its clouded glass through the lamp-light. A man had been fixed through hands and feet to crossed beams; his head hung forward, his ribs showed, and blood ran from a wound in his side. Gold remained around his head. Several figures knelt or reached toward him. One covered a face; another held the hanging body below the wound.

I repeated the words of the *Book of the Beast* silently:

> *And God looked upon the Outsiders, and saw the works of their hands; and behold, their cruelty was greater than the curse that had been laid upon them. For they tortured for pleasure, and conquered for pride, and lied with holy words, and slew their children for the hunger of their fathers.*

Here a father raised the blade over his son, and worship knelt before a tortured body opened on crossed wood. I took both as the curse made visible.

I set the panel down too quickly and heard wood touch stone. The sound travelled farther than I wanted. For a while I moved without raising the lamp, passing shelves at the edge of sight: a gold mouth, a child's clay foot, black feathers sealed between glass, half a sentence in red. I did not stop again until the footprints crossed my path.

The prints ended at a shallow tray of optical pieces. Among them lay a lens whose edge carried the shallow service cuts of Light. I knew the sequence: first grinding, correction, approval. A foreign element had been mounted behind it in a ring too fine for any Mountain workshop, its curvature unlike ours. I raised the assembly toward the distant tags. Lines that had been brown blurs snapped apart.

Cracks in ink, fibres in paper and grains of dust appeared with a clarity that made my own best work feel performed with water.

Ka-Raedin had counted on one hand every mind in the Mountain able to follow my proof. The corrective ring bore no maker's name. I could not tell whether it was the work of one of the Outsiders' greatest minds or an exercise given to their apprentices.

The Shield label was brief: *Mountain manufacture. Removed through Threshold. Returned altered. Demonstration and circulation prohibited.* Beneath it, in a later hand: *corrective element stable.* I wanted to carry the assembly straight to Ka-Raedin. Then I read *circulation prohibited* again and kept the lens in my hand.

Through the altered lens, the high labels on the newer cabinets separated into legible strokes. They named peoples I had never heard of: families on islands, hunters among ice, villages under trees so tall that a whole Mountain might have stood beneath them. Each file carried a different place and the same black tree impressed into its cover.

The Shield summaries repeated one outside formula: *autonomy claimed; contact refused; representation asserted by the Blackwood Foundation.* Maps, petitions and photographs filled the files. Some held no more than a rumour and a boundary. Others had names, genealogies, inventories of weapons, diseases and men authorised to speak. Court seals and official replies accumulated behind the petitions, sometimes until the argument about a people was thicker than the record of the people themselves.

One thin file began with an outsider request to cut a road through a red-stone valley. The black tree answered it. The request returned under another authority; the tree answered again. Three changes of seal and two generations of names passed across the pages while the refusal remained the same, until the proposed road bent north and left the valley blank. No member of the hidden people appeared anywhere in the dispute. Every official reply was addressed to Blackwood.

I passed the file twice because nothing upon its cover named the Mountain. It stood among all the others, neither thicker nor more guarded, and wore the same Blackwood tree. Only when I returned to the first cabinet and read every cover in order did I stop at it. On a festival pillar, Light hid the working mark among a hundred marks equally bright. Here, every cover bore the tree.

I returned the altered lens to its exact hollow after opening the file. As I trimmed the wick, a faint metal answer travelled from the Mountain end of the chamber. I thought of the tongue that had struck when the outer door opened. I listened, heard nothing further, and opened another file.

The first photograph inside showed a fair-haired woman under a hard flat light. Beside her stood a smiling man in desert clothes, his weight divided equally over both feet and his hands free of his robe. I knew that stillness from Shield. Behind them rose a fold of rock I knew in my body before I knew it with my eye: the Mountain seen from forbidden ground. Two names and a date had been copied beneath the outsider's marks. Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. 1974.

The next image was all distance. A white flower towered from the horizon, too large to be fire and too ordered to be weather; the surrounding sky had been emptied of colour. The border carried one word and a number in the outsider hand, repeated below in Shield script: Reggane, 1960. In the drawer beneath lay a blistered piece of green-black desert, grains melted together around bubbles, tagged with the same place and number. Whatever had flowered in the photograph had changed sand into glass.

A map occupied the cabinet below. It showed the Mountain's outer folds, dry channels, wells and routes. Where the Oasis should have been, the paper held no name or mark. Tracks curved around the blank centre. Names stopped before reaching it and began again beyond it. Every useful line bent around the blank. Without the photograph, I would have read it as empty ground.

One route broke the pattern. It ran from the outcrop inward, divided beneath the rock and touched service ways near the Hall of Ceremony. Along it, small boxed words repeated in several hands: *Breach. Containment. Exchange. Loss. Sealed.* A newer entry carried a phrase I had never encountered in any Shield rule: *Threshold Exception.*

At the back of the bundle, a loose copy had split along its fold. Most of the entry remained with the missing half, but the torn strip preserved three names in Mountain hand — Sarah Blackwood, Amastan, Ka-Xhian — and below them only *Threshold Exception*. It did not tell me what had been permitted, who had requested it or what price had been paid. Ka-Xhian's name stood beside the two outsiders' names and above an exception to Shield's own law.

I folded the strip once. Taking it would be breach, and the missing strip might expose the theft. Leaving it meant allowing the chamber to become impossible again as soon as I stepped out. I slid it into the inner seam of my robe. Then I returned to the first photograph. It lay loose beneath four paper corners. I lifted them one by one and put the photograph beside the strip. The map kept its torn edge; the empty corners kept the rectangle of the image. I had left Shield two absences to find.

Against the far wall lay the divided body of one machine. Two long side panels each held a door; the rear closure had been made in an upper and lower half; a broad front panel, painted black against the lighter body, rested above a metal engine with eight equal throats. Upright wheels, seats, lamps, springs, a steering wheel, a protective cage and a second fuel vessel occupied separate bays. None of it could have passed whole through the Threshold. Someone had dismantled it outside, carried every piece in and accounted for the machine as an anatomist accounts for a body.

One side panel bore a white square painted with the number 195. Near it, beneath scratches and sun-bleaching, remained the black tree stamped on the files. Desert sand filled the lower seam; a dry grass seed had survived behind the window channel. Shield's inventory dated it to the turn into 1980 and ended: *second contact; field cover concluded; body divided at Threshold; no part released.*

I was crouched beside the frame when I noticed a second lamp in the wall niche. Its wick was dark, but the brass above it was warm beneath my fingers. Beside the niche, a narrow tongue of metal stood proud of the wall by the width of a nail. I had heard its twin strike when I opened the outer door.

Stone moved somewhere behind me.

I pinched out the entrance lamp and entered a darkness so complete that the remembered shelves continued to stand in my sight. The dismantled machine offered spaces without safety. I lowered myself behind two leaning panels, one hand holding them apart to keep their edges from touching, the other pressed against the paper inside my robe.

A narrow line opened at the Mountain end of the chamber. A Shield warden came through sideways and closed the stone behind her. She was a little shorter than I. Exterior cloth widened her shoulders and covered her mouth and hair; dust whitened her boots to the ankle. A sealed field packet was strapped beneath one arm. She went first to the metal tongue, pressed it flush with her thumb and waited until something answered inside the wall. Then she struck a spark into the warm lamp I had touched moments before and lifted it. The panel against my shoulder settled. One grain of trapped sand ran down its hollow with a sound so slight I felt it more than heard it.

The warden stopped. Her lamp rose. Light entered the seams around me, found a rim, a spring, the pale underside of the steering wheel. I could see the stitching at her wrist and, below it, Shield's broken threshold worked black on black. The beam rested on my hiding place long enough for the pulse in my raised arm to move the skin.

Then the lamp moved on. She crossed the archive, operated the outer mechanism and went into the desert. The stone closed. Wind ceased. I remained behind the panels until the arm supporting them shook hard enough to risk what fear had not.

I relit the entrance lamp. The flame rose smaller than before. I expected the warden to find no one outside, study the disturbed dust and return. I could go after her into ground I believed favoured her eyes, or take the passage from which she had emerged while it was empty and learn where Threshold entered the Mountain. I turned inward.

Beyond the hidden stone, a service tunnel climbed beneath the Mountain. Its walls carried fresh scrapes at shoulder height and old oil in the hinge recesses. Far ahead, a door bore three Shield seals, one cut over another, the oldest so deep that the newer hands had worked around it. I did not approach it. The side opening before it carried two office marks on the same lintel: Faith and Shield. A smell came from it before I could decide whether to approach the sealed door.

The archive had smelled of dry mineral and paper. From the side opening came older air gone wrong: piss, sweat and, beneath both, the flat iron of blood. The chamber beyond had no visible walls. Long wedges faced with pressed wool and hair projected inward in ordered ranks, floor to ceiling; more descended from above, hundreds of blunt points aimed into the room. At the edges, an open metal lattice took the place of the floor. Through it I saw another field of wedges rising from the darkness below. The room had grown teeth upon every surface and turned all of them inward. At the centre, a square island of bare stone carried one fixed seat, rings at the wrists and ankles, and a narrow gutter running from between the feet to a covered drain. Black staining had entered the island's seams and remained after washing.

It was the most complete silence I had known. My ears tightened as on a fast descent. I swallowed; the sound filled my skull, and behind it came the pulse in my neck. The floor shifted under me until I put a hand against the entrance frame. At the foot of the seat, dried blood held one of Va-Sheva's ribbons to the stone. The colour and the tight thread along one edge made it hers. Had she asked the questions there, or answered them? We had all heard stories of Shield's private ordeals, what it might make a warden endure before judging her worthy of being Veil. I lifted it. Dried blood broke from the stone. I folded the ribbon once into the inner seam of my robe and went back through the archive.

At the outer end I returned the entrance lamp to its niche, pinched it out and waited until the dark gave me back the wall. When I opened the stone on the ridge's hidden face, I could see neither the outcrop, the Mountain nor my own hands. The warden might have been ten steps away or halfway to the horizon. I listened until the effort made sounds of my pulse, and heard no foot on stone. A hooded light opened beyond a low shoulder to my left, closed, then opened again nearer the outcrop. At each opening it lit one patch of ground; between them she moved in darkness. At its third opening the light passed across the stone above my head. I lay against the rock until it closed. Above me, the moving light was gone. The still star remained.

Between two openings of the warden's lamp, I reached the Mountain-facing side of the ridge and sighted along the polished plate toward the shoulder of the Mountain. I fixed that line against the still star. I still had the outward count. Whenever the bearing wandered, I corrected it toward north. I left when the hood closed and walked the count back. The first opening fell short. The second crossed the ground where I had been and paused at the beginning of my prints. Whether she had seen them I could not tell. Wind had left their centres clear. I wanted to run. I kept the pace by which I had counted outward and put each foot on stone where stone offered itself. When one black shoulder resembled the entrance more closely than the one ahead, I kept the bearing.

At the final count my hands met ordinary cold stone. I moved along the rock by the width the vent required, found the shaved edge under my fingers and pressed before fear could make me search elsewhere. Warmth leaked through the seam. I opened the slab, entered and drew it shut before the searching glow reached the opening. I reset the inner stone, brushed the disturbed dust into the older wear and cleaned the fresh soot from my fingers.

From far below came the last answer of the mourning, thinned by stone until the words were gone and only the cadence remained.

I did not go to Ka-Raedin. I believed he would summon Shield before I possessed a second witness; the strip would vanish into the chamber from which I had taken it, and my word would stand against its record of my breach. I did not confront Va-Sheva while I could not tell whether the ribbon accused her or asked me to save her. Shield knew Threshold had opened. The missing ribbon would tell Shield how far the intruder had reached; it did not yet know who had opened Threshold, from which side, or how much had been seen. I used that uncertainty and kept mine.

At the first lamps, the torn strip crackled beside Va-Sheva's folded ribbon beneath my robe. The photograph lay flat against both. I pressed all three to my ribs and entered the waking passage with Sarah Blackwood's face touching my skin.

— You interrupted me a single time today.

— I wanted the account clean and true as much as possible. And we have come to a moment Sarah told me to expect. Tomorrow is Good Friday, and Sarah is available at last; she means to tell you herself how it began, and how that photograph was taken.

— Why do you call a Friday good?

— It has to do with the man you saw on the cross. It is long, and hard to explain. Where have you reached in Rome?

— Augustus. Twenty-seven years before the birth from which you count.

— Then the answer comes this afternoon.

[—]

— There is one more thing, and it is not just the photograph she means to explain. Three days ago I went behind the glass at the hour Martinez changes the memory. I watched him open the second camera that points to the instruction room, take out the card and seal it in a paper sleeve. This time I followed him. In the town he put the sleeve beneath a folded newspaper on a bench and walked on without a backward look. Six minutes later a man I have never seen came for it.

— Then the information exchanged was the eye behind the glass. The contraband mirror I suspected; the one you watched and left in place.

— Yes. Whatever that camera had seen and heard since Martinez last changed its memory, this man carried away. I did not touch the packet, and I did not follow him. I had already spent my luck following Martinez. I took one photograph instead. Here.

— He stands like Shield when Shield wishes to look idle. Past sixty. Hair cut close and grey. The shoulders have kept an old instruction after the uniform has gone. He did not come straight to the bench.

— He passed it once, read the square in a shop window, returned against the people walking and lifted the paper without looking down. A civilian coat, a soldier's economy. I caught his face only when he turned. When Sarah is in this room, and not one hour before, we will lay it before her. If she knows neither the man nor the second camera, then Roger has been carrying an account of your instruction out of her house by hand. Until then it stays between the two of us.

Chapter 11

Reggane

(Paul): — For the record: the third of April; Good Friday, and the house shut for Easter. The machine is running. Mrs Blackwood has elected to join the interview, and I did not set the third chair.

(Kylian): — Ka-Sarah. At last you sit at the table.

(Paul): — Ka-Sarah ? Keeper of what ?

(Sarah): — Kylian. And at last you use the title. Sit, both of you. It is still my house, Mr Morgan, however much of it you have turned into a record. In this room Sarah will do; outside it, Kylian, you know what I am. I have enjoyed seeing our world through your eye. This morning should be no different. So. Before I give my account of how it all started: *Rome*?

(Kylian): — About Rome, my tutor moved from the Republic to your Jesus in two lessons. I accused him of hiding several centuries. So. You are the one who placed the lamp.

(Sarah): — I chose the order. Your tutor chose what each light showed.

(Kylian): — Genesis. The gods in Homer. Egypt. Now Jesus. I have seen a path inside the lessons, though perhaps not the whole path. Have I been taking a course in theology?

(Sarah): — In people. To understand your Mountain, I needed to understand its God. Comparison was the quickest instrument: I showed you ours. The path you

saw is western. Across the Americas and the East, the sacred took other forms; some religions required no creator at all. After Rome I had planned Alfred The Great and the Northmen: men carrying old gods and the new God into war.

(Kylian): — Every one of your gods is his own story, his own arc, made of scenes, each an individual human experience. For us, God is just God. Your Genesis says God made man in his image. The more gods you show me, the more I think your peoples reversed the direction. They built gods in their own human image, then called the likeness instruction. But ours has one account, cut into the Mountain and unchanged beyond every name we keep. Perhaps that is the first evidence you have given me that our God was not built by us.

(Sarah): — Peoples usually build them from stories. States have other materials.

[—]

(Paul): — I need this on the machine before we begin: after your first account, when you described the raising of the woman of Faith, Sarah showed me a trace she had kept since 1960. I withheld it so the evidence would not alter the witness. I chose the integrity of the account over fairness to you. That choice was mine.

(Kylian): — Your questions became too exact for curiosity. She tested whether I would lie; you tested whether my account changed; I tested which knowledge belonged to each of you. There were already three witnesses in a room set for two.

(Sarah): — Good. Terms, then. I am the witness; Paul holds the record; you are the only man here who can contradict me from inside the Mountain. The house, the company and the apparatus are mine. None authenticates me. I brought the original trace, folded as I kept it since 1960, and the darker contact copy I made before it faded. The brown mark beside the line is my blood. Paul, open the fold; my fingers are no longer steady enough to risk the paper.

On the original, twenty minutes separate each disturbance, and another twenty separate the fifth from the broad return. I preserved that proportion but accelerated the whole sequence into a range this room can reproduce. It is not the sound you heard in the Mountain; it is the same timing translated into sound. I am starting it now.

[—]

(Kylian): — Enough. Turn it off. Five calls: twenty minutes between them; then twenty minutes more, and the deep answer. You made one hundred minutes into a few breaths. I felt the last motion through the table, but I knew the last before it came. My legs knew it. Who was raised?

(Sarah): — No one. The paper is from Reggane, 1960. I spent fourteen years learning where those marks came from, not what they meant. This morning I begin where the paper begins, with France manufacturing a god of its own.

I was twenty-seven when the French lit their first bomb in the Sahara, one of perhaps forty people in the world positioned to hear it properly. I was bored.

France was retreating from empire and testing a weapon above land it still called its own. A tower and device stood in the desert. The device had the harmless name *Gerboise Bleue*, the blue jerboa. The briefing called its light unprecedented. To the instruments it would be enormous and simple. I knew the broad shape it ought to draw.

The camp worked. Men queued with enamel mugs; a corporal spent three days making an icebox hum without cooling; petrol found the taste of everything. Each morning a clerk drove past with melons that split before anyone authorised their distribution. Beyond the wire, drivers slept under lorries while mechanics rebuilt machines from the dust inward. Forms moved between every part of it.

At our recording station, Moussa Belkacem was paid as an instrument mechanic. He could level a galvanometer by listening to the table and tell from axle dust which road a lorry had taken. He came from the Touat, had cousins along routes the officers called empty, and corrected maps printed north of the sea with a laugh.

The afternoon before the test, I said the southern drums could remain idle because there was nothing in their sector worth wasting paper on.

"Empty? Old salt road. Two bad wells. One good well, if its owner trusts you. Three families last month; gone now because the aeroplanes frightened their goats. Your map arrived after they left."

Moussa reached past me and switched on the southern instrument.

My husband laughed when I told him. Étienne Delorme was nine years older than I was, a physicist, and one of those scarce men the new French state gathered as it gathered uranium — rare, refined at great cost, and handled by men who did not understand him and could not do without him. He owned a narrow chapel of the device and spoke as though the cathedral had been built to keep rain from it. He had put my name on the list for Reggane; the clearance was his doing, remaining there mine. I was better than half the men at reading the small motions they discarded. In public he said so. In private he checked my calculations twice, then put his hand on my shoulder before returning them.

Years earlier he had explained a chain reaction with dominoes set upright across a tray: one small piece, three behind it and nine behind those, each rank taller and heavier than the one before. He tipped the smallest. Three fell, then nine, and the last rank struck the tray with a weight the first piece could not have supplied. "The

first one supplied almost nothing," he said. "It supplied permission," I answered. He kissed me.

Edward Blackwood, my father, moved buried wealth from where it lay to where it would sell, and the Sahara was one of his locked cellars. Yet one reach of it defeated him. Surveys bent around it; guides altered their routes; money returned as apology, or did not return. He pursued the blank for thirty years and died with the loss entered under six respectable headings.

The records occupied a real cellar beneath the Blackwood offices. Its door bore our black wax mark: a winter tree with roots and branches made alike, so that on a crate overturned at a port the tree still stood. I had been forbidden that room as a child. Edward called its contents unfinished business. Six headings in his annual accounts carried the losses.

The domino tray stood in Paris. Edward's survey failures lay in the cellar beneath the Blackwood offices. I kept them separate.

Ground motion carried distinctions. A natural quake arrived untidily and continued arguing with itself; an explosion entered hard through compression and left a poorer later train. One read the whole disorder and asked what cause could most cheaply have made it. Nature did not ordinarily wait twenty minutes, strike again at the same weight, wait another twenty and stop at a number. Five equal strokes at exact intervals required selection and a clock.

On the morning of 13 February, Étienne found me checking the southern bank as the final count came from the tower. "For once in your life, look at the thing itself."

"I know what it will do."

"No one knows."

"You have spent three years telling ministers that you do."

One side of his mouth lifted. "Whatever you think of the men, Sarah, watch what they have made."

I stood with him at the shelter opening. Eight faces turned towards the tower. Mine was the ninth, but at the last moment I looked south. Moussa had made me ashamed of the word *nothing*.

The light passed through the dark lens, the canvas and the lids of my closed eyes. Every seam became black; each body became an absence cut from a white world. Though I had turned away, my shadow leapt ahead across the floor, sharp at the shoulders and pointing south, beyond the tower and the roads on the operational map.

Then the ground moved beneath us with the unity of a decision. Tables walked; glass touched metal in a hundred alarms. An auxiliary recorder reached the edge of its stand. I caught the frame against my hip and put my left hand across the turning drum while Moussa drove a wedge beneath its leg. The stylus crossed my thumb, opened it and went on writing. Blood fell two finger-widths beyond the line. I spent years avoiding the stain when I unfolded it.

The sound came late enough to be absurd. Dust left the roof; outside, one of the ripe melons burst, and for several seconds the greatest weapon France had made smelled of fruit. Men cheered. Étienne watched the tower's country rise into itself and said, too quietly for anyone but me, "God." Moussa was already checking the anchors. When a soldier told him the station had held, he answered, "Then it will not mind being checked."

The great signal filled the useful papers. Men marked times; cigarettes appeared; the event diminished for more than an hour into reflections through layers no one could see. I changed the bandage on my thumb and remained beside the southern recorder.

An hour later, the first small stroke entered beneath the tail of the great one: a clean compression, far below the scale of the shot, arriving from the south. I marked its time and waited. Twenty minutes is not a silence when one is watching a line. It is long enough for a mark to seem accidental, for a man to enter, smoke and leave, for attention to become embarrassment. At the twentieth minute the second stroke came at the same weight. I stayed. At forty minutes the third arrived. The fourth struck at sixty, where my pencil said it must. The fifth did the same at eighty.

Then nothing.

I marked a sixth point twenty minutes ahead. At one hundred minutes, where another clean stroke should have begun, a broad low return spread across the instrument, as though the five small acts had gone down through the world, touched something too large to strike, and come home wearing its breath. It lifted, held and sank.

Five strokes. Five waits of twenty minutes. One return.

I checked clock, drive, stylus, anchoring bolts and paper feed, then put my fingers to the housing for an engine transmitted through the table. Nothing moved but the drum. The event had come through the ground, from beyond the test site and the roads on the operational map. In the rough log I entered five marks and the return, and left the source column blank. On the line above, beside the tower shot, a clerk had written *SUCCESS*.

Moussa came to my shoulder before I removed the sheet.

"Another one?"

"The frame settling."

He looked from the marks to the bolts he had set. "It settles carefully."

"See whether they need you on the main bank."

He did not move. "Will this paper have my name on it?"

"No."

"Then it will have yours."

"No."

He wiped blood from the drum, folded the stained corner inward so it would not mark the next layer, and left without promising silence.

Étienne asked that evening whether my neglected bank had produced anything worth its paper. I said it had recorded a frame fault after the shot. He kissed the clean knuckle beneath my dressing and said, "At least history has marked you." The original sheet was already inside my shirt. I slept with the first proof of the Mountain against my ribs and my husband's arm across the place where I had hidden it.

The theft measured seventy-two centimetres. Next morning the station chief stood by the shortened roll with Moussa on one side and me on the other. I said blood had fouled the tail and I had removed it before it contaminated the feed. Then he asked whether the five marks in the rough log came from the damaged frame.

"No," Moussa said. "The frame was true."

The chief looked at me, then at the personnel sheet carrying my clearance and my husband's unit. "It shifted under the aftershock."

"Not this machine," Moussa said.

He would not alter the maintenance slip. They moved him to the vehicle shed. An objection from me would have reopened the missing paper, so I watched him carry out his toolbox. At the door he set his washed handkerchief beside my bandaged hand and asked whether I still wanted the southern bank running. I said yes. "Then leave it running," he said, and went.

No charge was entered against him. His name vanished from the instrument roster and appeared beside vehicles.

I never saw him again. I do not know what the test put into his body or how long he lived with it; the records do not agree. The three families he had counted in that sector were entered in no record I have ever found, and I have looked.

(Paul): — Moussa proved the frame true, not the source. The marks might still have come from another machine among the drills, generators and trucks. That alternative governed the next four years, I presume.

(Kylian): — I can remove it now. This is the readiness sequence: the five offices make the strokes, twenty minutes apart; the deep Earth must answer after the final twenty-minute measure. Until it does, the Mountain remains sealed.

(Sarah): — I spent fourteen years earning the sentence you have given me in three breaths.

(Paul): — Why did Shield call the sequence if no Keeper had risen?

(Kylian): — Reggane was the first local bomb inside their northern horizon. Shield had nothing against which to classify the white sky and the blow through the rock, and no way to know whether another would follow. They sealed every outer way and proved the five offices before trusting the walls.

(Sarah): — Then the bomb exposed the Mountain. It frightened it into movement.

One event may be a fault, a vehicle, a coincidence of reflections, a clock feeding its pulse into an amplifier. I had stolen the trace because I wanted it extraordinary. For four years I tested every ordinary cause I could devise.

I obtained another recorder of the same make and loosened its frame by measured amounts. I ran a generator against the wall, drove laden trucks past at different speeds, damaged a bearing, mistimed the feed and bled current into the clock. Through Étienne I obtained engine schedules, blasting logs and vehicle movements; every plausible source failed on place or time. Most dangerously, three other stations had kept enough of the test's tail to catch portions of my event. One lost two strokes; another clipped the return; the third was badly levelled. Together their bearings crossed roughly in the south and proved my recorder had not invented the marks.

Moussa's maintenance slip read: *Anchors checked after shot. Frame true. No mechanical settling observed.*

Once a month I unfolded the original beneath the same lamp. I measured the gaps, checked the ink against my copies and put it back. The paper yellowed; the blood darkened to old tea. Repeated handling made every fibre familiar and added no evidence.

Étienne found me at it once in our Paris flat. I covered the five marks too late.

"The faulty drum," he said. "How long have you been lying to me about it?"

"I have not lied about the instrument."

He drew out the opposite chair but did not sit. “That was not my question. You always give me the sentence that is true.”

“What do you want?”

“The sentence next to it.”

I gave him the technical problem without the direction, the other stations or the paper’s origin. He listened without interrupting, then offered to obtain the controlled-shot archive.

The second event came in the fourth year. There had been other French shots between and no clean repetition; that absence nearly cured me. Then *Rubis* was fired underground in the Hoggar, coupling more of itself into rock. After its hard motion crossed the stations, a southern instrument under my supervision drew five small strokes at the old twenty-minute interval and the same broad return twenty minutes after the fifth.

I locked the room, took the Reggane sheet from my case and laid one trace over the other against the window. Different instruments and different paths had altered the lines; they did not coincide like printing. The count, twenty-minute measure, sharp sources and slow answer survived every difference between the drawings. I was sick into a metal bin and cleaned it before anyone could ask why.

I returned to the window. Two different events had preserved the same deliberate sequence. Somewhere in the southern blank, a mechanism could put that sequence into the ground and receive a shape through the deep Earth. It woke rarely, after great disturbances but not all of them. I inferred that its operator selected the disturbances it answered.

Ka-Xhian of Shield later explained the selectivity. Reggane gave Shield its first local nuclear signature; smaller tests could thereafter pass as known events. *Rubis*, driven into rock, arrived hard enough to resemble a nearer deliberate strike whose second blow might still be coming. Shield answered the possibility of that second strike.

There were also later sequences without any Outsider blast. I recorded every one under the same cause. Kylian’s succession account in this room supplied another: a Keeper dead, another hand in office, the five proving the transfer. The dates in my files remained without names.

The traces enclosed a region larger than some nations. Waves bend through structures one has not mapped, hasten under hard rock, slow through sediment and arrive wearing the country between. My first crossing carried an error of two hundred kilometres.

So I began to build ears.

Some were scientific stations for research into the Saharan crust. Some were commercial: Blackwood companies already searched for ore, oil and water. Some were absurd on purpose—a study of road vibration, quarry insurance, instruments in extreme heat. Each had a reason that survived inspection. After Algerian independence, I paid for proper agreements and for useful work: several ventures found water, two found ore, one built a road a provincial office had awaited for nine years. The black tree appeared on salary books, water crates and geophone cases across the desert. I kept the transparent map on which their listening arcs met.

No crew was asked to bend a reading. I concealed why each ear stood where it did, and separate crews could not compare their placements.

The first bearings were wrong. They drew us to a black volcanic ridge more than a hundred kilometres east of the later solution: broken ground, no permanent settlement, approaches visible for miles. Three parties had turned back from it. I sent a mineral team beneath the tree and went with them.

I refused to wait for the dust season to pass. On the sixth day, a water lorry broke a rear spring in soft ground. As we unloaded it, a wall the colour of old copper rose behind us. Hamid Ould Ali, the local foreman, gave us six minutes. No one argued. We turned the lorries across the wind, cabled their wheels and buried the instruments beneath canvas. The front reached us before the last knot. Day became brown pressure. Sand found the scar in my thumb, though the cut was four years healed.

One water drum tore loose. I ran after it because it held a third of our supply. Hamid caught my shirt and put me face-down behind a wheel. "We can lose water. I cannot bring the director back in pieces and still be paid." After the air cleared, the drum stood crushed against a shelf of rock.

In the ledger he entered *one drum: wind*; beneath it, *director left shelter: own decision*. I said the second line was not an expense. He said it had nearly been the largest one. The line remained.

We spent nineteen days around the ridge, firing controlled charges at measured points. Several paths seemed to place the hidden source under its northern shoulder. We opened an old prospect and found mineral stain and desiccated French timber. Then a western charge reached two stations in an order impossible through uniform ground. A buried hard body beneath the ridge bent arrivals from farther west and placed their apparent source under its northern shoulder.

Once measured, the distortion corrected the old bearings. The ring contracted towards the reach my father's ventures had refused to enter.

The corrected bearings sent me to Edward's cellar. The executors called the seal ceremonial. His key opened the lock; black wax still joined door to frame. I put a chisel through the trunk of the tree.

Inside were damp masonry, paper and the tobacco Edward had forbidden everyone else to smoke near records. Survey rolls filled pigeonholes; tin cases carried the tree and a venture number. Nothing had moved since his last winter. Every failed venture remained.

For eleven days I read. Separately, each failed venture had a practical explanation: a guide's refusal, missing signatures, dust across an aerial strip. Laid beneath the corrected bearings, the explanations formed a perimeter. Successful ventures were precise—assays had coordinates, wages met names, a lost truck ended in a police report. Here, routes bent before a boundary without recording an obstruction, and adjoining aerial strips disappeared in different years. Every marked route stopped at the same ring.

The clearest voice belonged to a Scottish geologist, Alasdair Kerr. Ordered to cross the ring, he wrote: *The guide will take us north, south, or back. He will not take us east. I doubled the rate. He returned the money. I threatened to proceed without him. He sat down and wished me a safe journey.*

Edward sent another guide. Kerr's next report ended: *We are not being prevented. We are being allowed to decide against going.* On a third attempt he described lights without a camp, tracks crossing his own, and the same man at different wells who never acknowledged him. None could be separated from fatigue. Kerr returned north, drank until Edward dismissed him and would not discuss the country sober.

Edward's later notes listed guides, trading families, fuel purchases and marriages between routes. Beside three failures, years apart, he had written the same name: first with a question mark, then underlined, then hard enough to score the sheet beneath. Amastan.

Edward's notes ended with that man. I wrote his name on a clean card and began tracing his debts, kin and roads home.

> (Kylian): — Each crew told the truth about the question you gave it. The lie was in the question you kept. Many honest searches became one hidden search. That is Light's construction, whether you like the name or not. At this point you were still hunting us.

(Sarah): — Yes. I bought true measurements under false purposes. Compartmenting improved the evidence and made the people easier to use.

(Kylian): — And the black tree travelled with them. It is the mark Shield placed beneath your name.

(Sarah): — A Blackwood shipping seal. Ka-Xhian saw it on enough of my equipment to use it for me. Do not make Edward a god; he would have charged rent.

(Kylian): — Amastan proves a ring beyond the ring: a human aperture. The Mountain could hide its stone, but not grow salt, cloth, births, marriages, news or silence without touching another people. Shield's wall was never where Shield ended. Edward asked the loud question: what is hidden there? You asked the smaller one: who can put me before this man without asking why?

(Paul): — Martinez?

(Sarah): — Not yet. First I had to inherit him.

I had a name and no lawful way to use it. Access to the classified archives, remote stations and old French networks still ran, directly or at one remove, through Étienne. By then I had been excluding him from the search for six years.

It happened by rooms. First we shared a room and I kept one paper face-down. Then I rented an office and gave him a key without naming the cabinet it did not open. Later I moved the southern overlays to Edward's cellar and stopped mentioning the nights I spent there.

He came below one evening while the corrected bearings lay over Edward's failures. A black tree stood on every sheet; at the centre I had written Amastan.

"So the instrument fault has become a man."

"A man might explain why surveys avoid an area. He cannot explain the signal."

"The signal. Singular?"

"There has been another."

"When?"

I told him.

"And you used my stations."

"Stations to which I had authorised access."

"Through my name, Sarah."

"At first."

"Do not say *at first* as though the theft became honest when you grew rich enough to continue it alone."

He placed one finger near Amastan. "What do you believe is there?"

"A machine capable of putting a repeated deliberate source into deep structure, operated by people who have concealed it and themselves."

I withheld the slow response and the possibility that the machine asked something of the whole Earth.

"That is all?"

"All I can prove."

"No. All you have decided I may hear."

"If you had asked me," he said after a time, "I might have helped."

"You did help."

"That is not what I said."

I asked whether the controlled-shot files had survived the transfer between ministries. He stared at me and almost laughed. "There. That is what you wanted from this conversation."

A week later the access papers arrived.

His health failed before my search narrowed to a road. He had stood near too many devices, entered too many places after other men called them safe, and worn his dosimeter like a watch whose time he did not intend to obey. His marrow failed. His claim for service injury crossed six desks and returned denied. He went in under a year. Some mornings he forgot his room; on others he corrected a young physicist's calculation at the foot of the bed.

On one of his last clear afternoons, he asked for the old tray of dominoes. His hands could not stand the ranks, so I did.

"The first one does almost nothing," he said.

"Supplies almost nothing. That was your phrase."

"I was wrong."

He tipped the smallest with the side of his finger. It caught only one of the three; three of the final nine fell and the rest remained standing.

"Bad hand," he said.

"Bad position."

He looked at me. "You always liked the first piece."

"Because it released the others."

"Because it got to look innocent." He stopped for breath. "It isn't."

I do not know whether he meant the bomb, the doors he opened, or me. I took the sentence for all three. I held what remained of his hand and grieved him without reservation. When Étienne died, I signed the surviving papers with the hand he had held. At his funeral, those permissions returned in another man's case.

Martinez carried it. He did not enter the chapel. There have been two men of that name in my affairs; the one you know, Roger, is the son. His father's name appeared first on Edward's concession payroll, then in files marked for French state circulation before the field copy had returned to its geologist. I found him beside the wet stone after the mourners had gone. Without condolences, he opened a narrow case containing Étienne's active clearances, obligations and informal channels. Most were crossed through in blue. Three were not.

"The blue doors are closed," he said.

"And the others?"

"Have not yet been told to close."

"By whom?"

"If I answer, Madame Delorme, you will think I work for him."

"Whom do you work for?"

"Passage."

"Your father worked for mine."

"No. He worked with him. That distinction kept them useful to one another."

"And now?"

"The three open channels were used by you, not your husband. I left your name off the order that closed his."

"Why?"

"To see whether the distinction survives our fathers."

"And otherwise?"

"The doors close. Nothing personal has occurred."

We stood in the rain until water ran from the edge of his case. He asked which of Étienne's channels I had used and what I had returned through them; I asked which messages he could carry south without a sender's name. We made no promise beyond passage.

I waited until the estate closed before spending the channel. The listening net had contracted the region; Edward's overlays had put names along its perimeter; later traces showed the mechanism waking for causes no French explosion explained. When I called Martinez, I gave him one name.

Amastan.

He closed one clasp of the case. "A man?"

"A man my father failed to reach."

"Your father failed loudly."

"Then fail more quietly. Find whoever can put me before Amastan. I want him alive, unfrightened and unbought by anyone else. Do not bring him to me. Do not give him my name. Learn what he refuses, and come back."

"How long?"

"Until you find him or I prove you have sold the question."

"And if I find the proof first?"

"Then you will know what it is worth."

He closed the second clasp.

For seven years Martinez brought refusals in useful forms. One intermediary returned money unopened. Another agreed to carry my name south, came back with it still in his pocket and would not name who stopped him. A family altered its winter route after he questioned the wrong cousin twice.

In the autumn of the fourteenth year after Reggane, he placed a filing card on my desk. It bore a date, a disused fuel pump and a bearing from it. Beneath were four instructions: one vehicle; one driver; no radio; no instrument case.

"Will Amastan be there?"

"Someone will look at you."

"Who?"

"If he dislikes what he sees, no one."

"And if he does not?"

Martinez tapped the card. "You will receive the next road."

I set the card beside the Reggane trace and prepared one vehicle, one driver, no radio and no instrument case.

The elder Martinez is dead. Roger inherited the channel. I did not know which of his father's arrangements came with it, and I used him anyway.

(Sarah): — I stole the trace and left Moussa to pay for it. I used my husband's clearances, hid my purpose beneath honest surveys, broke my father's seal and paid a broker to find Amastan.

(Kylian): — Fourteen years after 1960 gives 1974, the date beneath your photograph in Shield's drawer. The card led you towards Amastan. It does not explain the Blackwood car I found dismantled behind the Threshold, every part carried in and stored like a body.

(Paul): — Before she answers, Mrs Blackwood, I can establish this much. Four days ago I watched Roger Martinez remove the memory from the second camera behind the glass in the instruction room, seal it in paper and leave it beneath a folded newspaper

on a town bench. Six minutes later this man entered the square after surveying it, took the paper without looking at the packet and walked on. I followed Roger to the bench, photographed the collection, and did not follow the collector. We have kept the observation between us until now.

(Sarah): — The car belongs to the second time I crossed the road, after finding the Mountain ceased to be my problem and preventing others from finding it became ours. I will give you that journey after your corresponding door. As for the camera: the wired eyes in this house are mine. That second one is not. Do not look at the instruction glass again, either of you. And do not mistake the newspaper fold for a channel I recognise. Martinez learnt it somewhere I did not teach him. The man is not unknown to me. General Géraud Montel. He was in Sarajevo in 1992, Turquoise in Rwanda in 1994, Afghanistan from 2001; Harmattan against Gaddafi in Libya, then Serval in Mali. I worked beside him there from 2013. He knows my face and what Blackwood could move through a desert. Men at his level do not collect newspaper packets themselves. If he came in person, the question is not why France suddenly cares about Kylian. It is whether the interest is sudden. He now has the unedited image and sound of Kylian's instruction.

(Kylian): — Then he has the map of my ignorance. How much?

(Paul): — Through Egypt, I think. I saw one earlier change and left the eye open.

(Kylian): — At my request.

(Sarah): — Enough. Known: the instruction room is compromised. This room is not. Paul's machine and my CCTV are the only recorders here; Elise has held every reel under seal. Roger has Kylian's lessons, not his account. Unknown: whether the earlier memories remain in a drawer or have crossed three governments. We act on the worst case. Paul, bring Urs in.

[The door opens. Urs enters and remains standing.]

(Urs): — Roger says he is away until Tuesday; the tutor left last night. Apart from Elise, security, upkeep and me, the house is empty.

(Paul): — The recording tells Montel what Kylian heard. The tutor can tell him what changed Kylian.

(Sarah): — Locate him without calling. Take his telephone and hold him at a Blackwood property; if he refuses, restrain him.

(Kylian): — Then my instruction stops.

(Sarah): — For Easter, certainly. Perhaps altogether. We use the empty house to take every record we can: Paul keeps the machine, Elise the reels, Urs the door.

(Kylian): — Before you go: why does an oil trader speak our language?

> (Urs): — Exploration geophysics. Finding oil is easy; moving it through embargoes and wars is the trade. Sarah needed a man from your Mountain moved without a translator or a road back. So I learnt your language.
>
> (Paul): — Montel's photograph goes beside the Reggane trace. Sarah has given us the first road to Amastan; before she gives the second, Kylian gives the door he chose after finding Sarah's photograph inside Shield.
>
> (Kylian): — The choice I called wisdom because I would not call it fear.
>
> (Sarah): — Hold the fold open. Begin at that door.

Chapter 12

Confession

I carried three things against my ribs for two days: the torn strip with its four entries, the photograph of Sarah Blackwood beside Amastan at the outer folds, and Va-Sheva's ribbon stiffened with old blood.

On the first morning I supervised two Candidates through an aperture exercise. Their measurements differed by the width of an eyelash. I made them strip both frames, and they found a grain of soot beneath one lower edge. They cleaned the wood and began again. The strip crackled inside the seam of my robe when I bent over their hands. The ribbon lay folded beside it; the photograph lay flat beneath both.

Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception.

Through the first day I kept all three in separate folds of my robe. At every lamp I considered feeding paper, photograph and ribbon to the flame together. Their order, material and joined presence would have gone, leaving my memory to accuse whomever fear chose. I kept them.

By the second evening I could make the archive establish only contact beyond the Threshold, not its purpose. Every shelf had carried the same warning: *harmless unless taught*. I had removed two records and begun supplying the lesson myself.

I tried to make one Kahir examine another without first crossing the boundary between them and could not. Each office alone held the facts by which its secret

acts might be judged. Justice needed an accusation before it could receive them; an accusation needed those same facts. Whoever carried the first fact to Justice would commit the breach that allowed Justice to ask whether a breach had occurred. Giving Shield all three would also leave the office named by the evidence as its only custodian. I needed the law that governed the interval before any Keeper was accused. I slept in the robe.

At Second Silence the next day, Ka-Raedin was teaching four senior Candidates to recover a survey line after one of its floor points had shifted. Cords crossed the chamber from three fixed lamps to a black pin set in clay. One candidate held the last cord under tension while another read the error aloud. Ka-Raedin had let them carry the false line almost to its consequence.

"Stop," I said. "Leave every cord where it stands and clear the chamber."

The candidate at the clay pin looked to Ka-Raedin.

"They have one measure left," he said.

"My concern takes precedence."

"Why?"

"Because a Veil of Light has just told you so."

Ka-Raedin looked from my face to the white cloth at my wrist. "Mark your positions. Touch nothing. Outside."

The Candidates fixed their cords and withdrew. He waited until the last sandal had passed the turn and for me to speak.

"I have been thinking about Light doctrine, as you taught me to. Keeper, you keep what must remain dark. As Veil, I am the one who places the light. What happens if I place the light in front of something that must remain dark?"

"I can cover it. I cannot make you, myself or others unsee what it reveals."

"Shield defends from the enemy without. Who defends against the enemy within?"

"The other four offices."

"What if they cannot see through the enemy's seal?"

"Justice can hear an accusation."

"Not if Justice is the accused."

Ka-Raedin released the cord between the two pins. "What trouble have you put yourself into?"

"*Ray* this is serious, possibly existential. The Mountain may have carried a breach before any living Keeper took office."

"A breach within? If it has a hand, that is treason. If it has none, defect. Which do you mean?"

"I cannot say."

"How old?"

"I cannot say."

"To protect me?"

"Partly. If Balance were emptying the stores, Justice destroying records or Faith altering scripture, the proof would belong to the office it accused. What then?"

"The offices keep one another by remaining divided. The office that finds the danger preserves what it has; a second witnesses it; the offices not accused establish standing. The office concerned answers before the others, never to itself alone."

"How?"

"You have withheld the act, the accused and the proof. I cannot give you a road without inheriting all three."

"Then the rule is enough."

Before I left, Ka-Raedin said, "Va-Kailan. Be very careful. I know of one Veil who carried a question like yours into a sealed hearing. He did not return to his office."

"Then let me consult Light's record of it."

"No. That record is sealed from Veils."

I returned to the Veil's Chamber before the evening lamps. I looked at the image once more. Sarah Blackwood faced the hard light without narrowing her eyes. Amastan smiled beside her. The Mountain rose behind both of them, ordinary enough that an Outsider might have passed the photograph across a table and seen only two people before a rock. I turned it face down.

I laid my Light token beside the photograph. Its close rings held the old likeness of ripples of water spreading from a point, the figure by which Ka-Raedin had led me from the ray to interference. His refusal returned with it: the hearing record was sealed from Veils. If I found the Keeper's Chamber, perhaps I could reach it.

(Kylian): — The Keeper's Chamber!

(Paul): — What about it?

(Kylian): — I know where it might be.

(Paul): — And did you go looking for it?

(Kylian): — What?

(Sarah): — Did you go looking for the chamber?

(Kylian): — No. I mean I know now where it might be .

[—]

(Kylian): — A Veil who wanted to see interference at scale would outgrow every bowl and basin and seek a body of water large enough to hold the crossing waves.

> *And God gathered the waters beneath the earth,*
> *and hid them in the hollow places of the deep;*
> *and the dry land appeared, and from the dry land*
> *He raised the Mountain.*

It is there. It must be. The Keeper's Chamber hides from its Veil. Light hides from Light. The light is a wave, a wave sits on water. It is in the water.

(Paul): — Beneath the water?

(Kylian): — Or reached through it.

(Paul): — Wait. This reminds me of something. Let me examine my notes.

[—]

(Paul): — Here. The fifth shadow.

> *A man looking down may see nothing, or see himself, or see*
> *through, or never know that light is moving beneath him.*

(Sarah): — Good work, Mr Morgan.

(Kylian): — That sentence is mine, not Va-Raedin's. That's too bad; still, you kept it when I did not. Thank you, Paul. ... All right. I will continue.

I wrapped the photograph in paper from the Light records, closed it with white wax and pressed my token's rings into the wax. On the outer fold I wrote my name and, beneath it:

> *For the Veil who follows me. If I do not return to Light, do not*
> *open this alone.*

The cradle lifted from its stem when turned against the thread of its fixing. Beneath it lay the spare aperture leaves every Veil was taught to keep dry and ordered. I placed the packet below them and returned the stem to the mark. I checked the fixing twice and wiped the place my thumb had darkened. The torn strip and ribbon remained against my ribs. I had been taught to surrender portions of judgment to offices beyond my own. That surrender, more than stone, made the Mountain possible. If I withdrew mine when its law first endangered

me, I had never believed in the order at all. I could refuse Shield's single hand and still submit myself to the five.

On the third afternoon I sent Va-Sheva a route inquiry concerning a repeated exterior reflection near an outer ventilation seam. The courtesy was permitted between Veils. Every word in it was true. She named a narrow observation room between Light and Shield, with a wall slit facing a sealed passage and a bench beneath one high lamp.

I arrived first.

Va-Sheva entered without an escort in sight. Dark duty leather covered her robe; her hair was bound high from her neck. She took the end of the bench nearest the door. Her eyes counted wall slit, lamp, floor, hands and door. They stopped at the seam of my robe.

"You called Shield over an irregularity of light?"

"Shield has changed you."

"The irregularity."

I gave her the answer she had given me at fifteen.

> *And God called the desert the Threshold;*
> *and He set heat upon it by day,*
> *and cold upon it by night,*
> *and mirage upon its face,*
> *that no man should cross it lightly.*

"Did you mean it," I asked, "or did you lie?"

"What is this about?"

"How did you become a Veil? Were you tortured?"

"That is not for Light to know."

"Is that how Shield took the girl who stole lamp-oil with me and blamed the smell on a kitchen cat?"

"*Kay*. What is going on?" she asked, and then "Va-Kailan of Light, explain yourself."

"Is the soundless room training for capture? So an Outsider cannot make a Veil of Shield reveal the Mountain?"

"No Outsider has questioned me. Tell me what you saw."

"Before I answer, trust this much: I meant to protect the Mountain."

"I will remember that you said so."

"Promise me that if Shield takes me, I do not disappear."

"If Shield takes you, Balance will count you living and Justice will witness the holding. I promise nothing beyond that."

"Then whatever I am called after this, remember that I came to you."

I drew Va-Sheva's ribbon from my robe and held it out to her. She took it. Her eyes found the colour, then the dried blood.

"It was you?"

"Yes."

"What else did you take?"

"A torn record and a photograph."

"What did the record say?"

"Sarah Blackwood. Amastan. Ka-Xhian. Threshold Exception. Did you know Ka-Xhian? Was Ka-Dhavar his Veil?"

"The succession of Shield is not yours to question. Where are they?"

"The record is here. The photograph is beneath my seal in Light."

"Who did you tell?"

"No one. Ka-Raedin heard a question of law and no fact."

"Give me the record."

I brought out the folded strip. Va-Sheva drew a dark case from her belt, laid the ribbon inside and held the case beneath my hand. I set the strip beside it. She closed the lid with two soft clicks.

Va-Sheva stood, opened the door and stepped into the Shield corridor. A polished strip of stone opposite the wall slit returned the passage at an angle. In it I saw her dark figure and the two wardens waiting beyond her. She looked at the nearer man. Her right hand turned beside her thigh: two fingers beneath the thumb, wrist inward, one cut towards the floor, palm opened down.

One warden started towards the room. The other caught his arm. Both looked at Va-Sheva through the slit as if asking whether they had read her hand correctly.

She repeated the signal.

They ran. Their footfalls divided at the first junction and ended.

Va-Sheva returned to the doorway and fixed the case to her belt with a second strap. The northern turn lay six paces beyond her shoulder. From there I could reach the Light stair without crossing a Shield door. Ka-Raedin would receive me under my own name.

"What did you order?"

"What I promised. Remain here until the count reaches you."

I looked once at the turn and stayed where I was.

She closed the door.

The first buried bar fell before her steps had ended. Another answered from below, then a chain moved behind the wall. Air pressed along the passage and the lamp bent towards the door. The Mountain was changing state.

When I opened the door, two Shield wardens stood at opposite ends of the corridor. Neither approached. A Balance clerk moved between the family chambers with a slate, accompanied by a Justice witness carrying a narrow black tablet. At each door the people inside gave their number, then their names. Each voice answered separately. Tools and water were shown. Shield sealed the latch after Justice marked it.

At the fifth door, one name received no answer. The mother said the boy was asleep and began explaining too quickly that he had worked the night water turn. The Justice witness cut the seal. Shield opened while a Faith attendant went in. A child's angry cry followed, then the attendant's voice naming breath, heat and waking. The boy answered his own name. Only then did Balance set the fifth mark and let the count move on.

Two Faith attendants came from the far corridor, repeating the Lesser Seal instruction as they walked.

"The Veil of Light is missing. Remain in your quarters for the count and until release. Let no fear cross the threshold before the body does."

A Light attendant followed and dimmed three wall lamps in sequence. Each settled into a low, stable flame. The count, the witness, the held doors and the measured lights passed before me in their proper offices. I returned to the observation room and waited.

The latch remained free on my side. Beyond it, the Light turn was still six paces away. Crossing those six paces would turn the act into flight and leave only Shield's description of it. I sat beneath the lamp with both hands visible.

The wall niche opened when the count reached our section. Three wardens entered through it. I stood and held out my hands. One crossed my wrists, tested the cord and bound them beneath a dark outer cloth. Another searched the empty seams where the strip and ribbon had been, then the belt, collar and sandal folds. The third placed a folded gag between my teeth and fixed it behind my head. It held my jaw without closing my breath. Va-Sheva watched from the doorway with the sealed case against her belt. She gave no order until the search was complete.

They took me through the niche. The hidden passage was narrow and steep, its small covered lights reaching each foot placement and no higher. Shield wardens stood in darkness at intervals and turned aside as we passed. Through stone I heard

a family answering Balance count and a child asking whether the doors would open before morning bread.

I tried to mark the turns. Each doubled beneath the last; the low lamps showed feet and withheld the walls. The cloth over my arms shifted whenever a warden changed grip, and the four of us had to shorten step together on the steepest stair. Once my heel missed an edge. Both wardens took my weight before the stumble could make a sound. At one junction an old Justice witness waited, white hair braided tight against her skull. She inspected my gag, bindings, Va-Sheva's case and the black line of Seal dye across her hand.

"Body held," the witness said.

"Speech held," Va-Sheva answered.

"Proof secured?"

"Two objects secured before Seal. One record declared beneath a Light seal."

"Seal witnessed."

They continued downward. I knew the last turn before the room appeared.

The wedges came first: ranks of blunt points faced with pressed wool and hair, thrust from walls and ceiling. At the edges an open metal lattice crossed above another field of points rising from below. The central stone island held the fixed seat, the wrist and ankle rings, the gutter and the black stain left in its seams. At the foot of the seat, a narrow break remained in the dried blood.

The wardens carried me over the lattice. Their footfalls ended beneath them. Nothing returned from the wedges to tell my body where wall or ceiling stood. The inner frame stood within a second frame, divided from the Mountain by felt and an empty hand's breadth. Under our joined weight the island moved by a fraction. My body mistook the movement for a larger fall and pushed against their arms. They placed me in the fixed seat and left the rings open. Two held position while a third removed my bindings and gag. The first swallow after the cloth came out sounded close enough to belong to another person. Low light reached the island, though I could see no lamp. Behind the seat, water stood beyond a narrow grille.

Va-Sheva remained before me. "You are under Shield containment by Lesser Seal. Justice has witnessed two objects in Shield custody and one record declared beneath a Light seal. Balance has entered you living. Light has received your name. You will not be questioned until Justice summons you."

"You counted me."

"Balance did."

"What happens when I am summoned?"

"Justice sets the charges."

"For my breach alone?"

"For whatever has standing."

"I brought you a breach and committed one by bringing it. Enter both."

"Shield will enter yours. The other must obtain standing before the five."

"Then I will ask Justice for it."

She looked at the open rings beside my hands. "You may have made your death more orderly."

"I know. I did not divide the proof so judgment would spare me."

"Why, then?"

"So judgment could not stop at me."

Va-Sheva went to the invisible seam. At it she said, "*Kay*, I am so sorry." She turned before I could answer, and the door sealed behind her without a visible line.

Then the silence the room was built for closed over me. The last of her went out of the stone, and after it came nothing: no corridor, no water, no far prayer, no breath of the vents. Into the empty place my own body rose. The knock of my heart came first, too loud. Then a thin sea-sound beneath it that was my own blood. Then the dry creak of a joint as I turned my head. With no sound to set me in the room, the floor let go of its certainty, and I put a hand to the felt to keep my feet. I said my name once to prove that speech still existed. It returned from no wall; it remained inside my teeth. I did not speak again. Until Justice summoned me, I would wait here — with the knock, and the sea, and the creak, and no other company at all.

> (Kylian): — ... A room built to give a man back nothing but the sound of himself. Faith made the quiet and Shield made the seal, and between them they left one place in the whole Mountain where a man cannot get behind the size of what he has done. ... You went into it too, Sarah. Not that room: into the deep of it, past the wall, and you came out with your face in its drawer and your name in its ledger. So they had you, somewhere back there. In a room the sound could not leave, with one of Shield's own across the table and the long questions coming. That is where you learned to hate us cleanly enough to spend a life on it. Tell me I have it right.
>
> (Sarah): — I will not borrow your room, Kailan. I never entered it, or anything like it. Nobody dragged me anywhere. I was invited through the front of your Mountain, with a lamp held low for my feet. The man waiting on the other side asked me no question at all. He made me an offer, and I accepted it. I carried that bargain home

> and spent the better part of sixty years building my life's work around it. He had a face. He had a name.
>
> (Kylian): — ... Say it.
>
> (Sarah): — Amastan.

Chapter 13

Infiltration

(Sarah): — The *Dhalkut*?

(Urs): — Clear of Musandam at last. Her signal returned off Muscat. Two million barrels, all hands clear.

(Sarah): — Finally. That is good news. Urs, we need food. Can you do us a favour and order Mumbai Local, the Happy Nest? For five.

(Urs): — Mrs Blackwood, respectfully. Ninety-three years old, a secret Mountain, a tanker just saved, French intelligence in our walls — and Mumbai Local? Come on. This is *Karfreitag*, and we are here. Can't we abuse your generosity with a little bit of flair?

(Sarah): — Flair, you say.

[—]

(Sarah): — Paul?

(Paul): — Urs is not wrong. We are on a secret holy mountain Grail quest after all. With even maybe an Egyptian coffin in it.

(Urs): — Mrs Blackwood, for science. Do we want to know if *Absconditus Maximus* prefers chicken korma over tikka masala, or do we want to know if he prefers Kaluga over Beluga?

(Sarah): — Oh boys. All right. But I am charging it to the oil desk.

(Urs): — Above the line? Or below?

(Sarah): — My best negotiator has turned on me. Above.

(Urs): — Done.

(Sarah): — Before I call, does anyone object to a feast on the day of the Crucifixion? We should not want to anger the gods.

(Paul): — None from me.

[—]

(Sarah): — Hello, the Ermitage? Mrs Blackwood speaking. No, I am not calling to move my physiotherapy appointment. Could you put me through to Florent at the concierge desk? Thank you. Florent? I need a favour. Could you have lunch for five sent to the estate? Cheese, chocolates, blinis, salmon, caviar. I will leave you to put it together for us. For five. No more than a thousand. Then five fifty-gram tins, one of each. Oh yes, why not. Perfect. Thank you, Florent.

(Urs): — Wunderbar.

(Sarah): — And the tutor?

(Urs): — Safe at the chalet on the other side of the mountain off the Nicklaus course. He came willingly and gave up his telephone before my men asked. Nothing suggests anyone reached him first. He wants to know whether Rome continues after Easter.

(Sarah): — Thank you, Urs. And my drums?

(Urs): — Under Elise's watchful eye. Dead silent last I heard. I will go check on her and bring her back for lunch.

[—]

(Sarah): — Back to us. Amastan. You made me say the name a moment ago as though it were a small thing. It was not.

Amastan could not be bought. My father wrote it in a margin, in a fury, because to Edward Blackwood a man who could not be bought was a fault in the machinery of the world. I read that margin as a daughter and as an heir. Edward had underlined the refusal twice and scored the paper on the second stroke. Beside it stood the rates offered, each doubled, then doubled again, each struck through. I gave Martinez the name.

Martinez spent the first two of those seven years putting a face and a tent to the name. Amastan ag Malik, of the Kel Tamasheq, descended from the older Amastan whose name he bore, was of the veiled people, the Kel Ad, whom the maps

call Tuareg. He moved through the deep Tanezrouft the way I move through a drum-paper, reading a country that looked empty to everyone else. He guided when he chose to, refused more often, and had turned back three of my father's expeditions without raising his voice, simply by declining to take them past a certain line and letting them understand no other man would either. Martinez brought photographs from a distance and reports bought from men who had sat at his fire. The reports named routes, kin and wells. None named the thing he kept the routes away from.

I gave Martinez one sentence to carry.

> *A woman who read the ground wished to speak with the man who read the sand about a line beneath the desert that had moved on the morning of the French fire.*

In the fourth year he entered, under another name and with the papers of an Oran freight broker, a transport line serving the war in northern Chad. It carried fuel, medicine, rifles and messages south from Libya; its western carriers reached the uranium camps around Arlit. He remained inside it for eleven months. A driver from Agadez brought him before a man who had shared Amastan's fire. Two years later the same line carried Martinez to Amastan himself. They met once. Amastan asked about Edward, Reggane, the yellow rock and why I had watched the pen instead of the cloud. Martinez answered and came back without a route. In the seventh year, the filing card he laid on my desk brought me to a disused pump and a boy who watched me arrive with one driver, a canvas bag and a folded coat. The boy left a folded paper on the pump. In a careful French hand not his own were a place, a season and one line.

> *Come without the man from Oran, and without the yellow rock in your mouth.*

The man from Oran was Martinez. I went.

At the pump Martinez took my arm. He never touched anyone. Under the noise of the engine, he told me that whatever kept the country ahead had kept it since before Rome. It wanted no money and no talking to. He could not follow, and would not, for anything I owned. I told him to wait there. He said a fortnight, and no more. If I did not come back, he would put it about that I had died of the heat, because it was tidier, and because — he said this to the pump, furious at himself — he had gone and grown a little fond of me, against every rule of the only trade he had. The boy drove me south. Four days later, where the track gave

out, he gave the wheel to a veiled man who had been waiting without shade. The vehicle returned with the boy. I went on beside the veiled man, two more days on animals, into folds the maps drew as a single brown smear. He gave no name. Only at the seam did a voice within call him Amastan. I have not set down the route.

The Mountain, from the outside, is a tired shoulder of stone in a place there is no reason to go. A satellite would find no gate and no wall. The ways fold into the rock. A stranger could die of thirst within sight of a living civilisation unless a man of the sand led him to the exact seam, set his hand against it and waited. At the outer folds I loosened the reins. I heard the animal beneath me breathe and the leather move under my hands. The quiet source I had followed for fourteen years lay somewhere under the stone and made no sound at all.

Amastan put his hand flat against a face of rock no different, that I could see, from a hundred we had passed. A seam opened. Before I crossed, he said the one thing of his I have kept whole.

Thank God every day; He has been good to you.

It was a saying of his namesake, spoken in France among the family of his friend Charles and kept by the line after him.

He lit an oil lamp and put it in my hand. I crossed. He closed the stone behind me.

The passage ran straight past three sealed crossings. At each, Shield's mark joined two stone leaves. Daylight lay across its far end. I entered a chamber cut symmetrically about a low lamp-holder, with four round pillars on either side and two stone benches facing each other. A corridor behind the farther bench continued into the Mountain, directly opposite the one that led outside. A round opening through the roof showed blue sky; sunlight made a disk on the floor beside my bench.

A man with scarred white eyes sat opposite me. Another stood behind the third pillar on his side, perhaps forty-five, lean, with a shaven head and pale marks across his left cheek. As I fitted my lamp into the holder, he moved far enough from the pillar to see both my hands. I sat. The blind man waited, then spoke in English.

"Sarah Amanda Delorme, born Blackwood, seventh of July 1932 in Greenwich. Daughter of Sir Edward James Blackwood, born in 1894 at Greenock, and Lady Beatrice Blackwood, born Beatrice Anne Calder in 1901 at Liverpool, sole heir to Calder Navigation. Widow of Étienne Lucien Delorme, born in 1923 at Nancy, physicist of the French Atomic Energy Commission, died in 1966."

He turned his face towards the man among the pillars. "You are in the presence of Va-Theran, Veil of Shield under me, and of me, Ka-Xhian, Keeper of Shield."

"You have recited my life," I said. "How old is this place?"

"We were here before the Flood."

"What lies beneath it?"

"What lies beneath our temple is not spoken beyond it."

"Then it has already spoken. I heard it at Reggane."

"What did you hear?"

"Five strokes, twenty minutes apart, after the French motion had passed. Then a slower return through the deep rock. *Rubis* gave me the sequence again."

He questioned the intervals, the station clocks and the direction from which each motion had arrived. I gave him the checks I had made. He asked which other French shots had produced the sequence. I named the intervening tests and told him that none had left a clean repetition.

"After Reggane we knew the smaller fires," he said. "The buried one could have been a nearer blow, with another still to come."

"And at Reggane?"

"I went to see it. Va-Theran watched the ground beyond the French lines. I watched the fire." He raised a finger to one ruined eyelid. "He brought me home."

"Who has your drawings?" Ka-Xhian asked.

"The records are lodged with solicitors in three countries. Corrected bearings, the Reggane trace, my father's failures. No route. The instructions are opened if I fail to return."

"When?"

"A fortnight after I left Martinez at the pump. He will report that I died of heat."

"Who follows?"

"Whoever buys what is in the packets. A government could send a survey before anyone settled my estate."

"Can you close them?"

"By going back."

He asked where Martinez had stopped and what I had sent from the road. I gave him the pump and the boy's departure. Nothing had gone north since.

"What did you come to decide?"

"Whether I had found a weapon. If I have, I need to know what it defends before I help you hide it."

"You will not go beneath the temple."

"Then show me what lives above it."

Ka-Xhian called his Veil forward. They spoke in a language I could not follow. Va-Theran answered twice, then returned to the pillar for a folded cloth.

"Shield has called a drill," Ka-Xhian said. "The wardens are exercising the closures. Everyone else remains in quarters. Amastan, Va-Theran and I know you are here. Keep the cloth where he puts it."

Va-Theran lifted the lamp from its holder and led us into the corridor behind Ka-Xhian's bench. At the first turn he bound the cloth over my eyes. I held his sleeve; Ka-Xhian put a hand on his other shoulder. Va-Theran stopped us before each step and waited while stone moved ahead of us.

When he uncovered my eyes, we stood on a gallery above a round hall. Below us a great disk crossed the floor on a thread whose upper fixing I could not find. A man's face was cut into the side towards us. I counted its crossings against my watch. Marks stood in groups around its path, some freshly set beside the rubbed places of earlier ones.

Ka-Xhian told me that they kept their hours by it. He gave the drop in metres: one hundred and twenty-five from the upper fixing to the centre of the disk. I timed another crossing. Then he named the day's five divisions and gave me the interval of the Pendulum's turning.

We followed the gallery past closed doors to the far side of the Hall. The other face of the disk bore a great cat with five bared teeth. At one of the doors, a row of small sandals stood beside larger pairs. A slate rested on the lowest shelf of a rack; beside a column of sums someone had scratched a long-eared animal. I bent to look. Va-Theran waited until I straightened. I checked my watch before he covered my eyes again.

At the foot of the descent Ka-Xhian stopped us. "Shield's arch," Ka-Xhian said. "The Keeper's road. Va-Theran, take her through." I counted five chambers by the doors closing behind us. The cloth left a narrow view beside my nose. In the lamplight I caught part of a toothed wheel, then a bank of pulleys with a weight suspended between two scales. Va-Theran read out the positions. Ka-Xhian asked him to repeat one and gave a setting in return; a chain travelled, stopped, and the next door opened.

Farther down, paired shafts turned at different speeds above a sliding weight. I bent my head to follow the linkage and Va-Theran lifted my chin. In the last chamber he had to hold a lever while the weight settled between two marks. Ka-Xhian gave another setting. The floor trembled when the latch withdrew.

Under the cloth I saw the bases of two pillars. Gold picked out roofs and walls half-covered by carved sand; a narrow street continued around one of them and

disappeared beneath a dune. Va-Theran kept me moving, turned me and put a hand between my shoulders until I knelt. He took off the cloth. I could make out so little beyond the lamp that I could not tell how large the chamber was. A vast iron gate stood before me, its upper edge beyond the lamplight. The same cat's face I had just seen on the Pendulum was cut into its iron, five teeth bared. My watch showed just under an hour since we had left the gallery.

"Beyond that gate is the Beast of Hell," Ka-Xhian said. "The five hold it in its chains. If your people come to take it, this is what they will bring upon themselves. Look."

Va-Theran turned me to the left. Across the void beside the bridge, on a wall at right angles to the gate, a great gravure showed the Mountain above the Beast. Five figures held its chains. Flame and water engulfed cities beyond the Mountain. He held the lamp towards it for a full minute, then let me stand and bound the cloth over my eyes again.

(Sarah): — Kylian, have you been in that chamber?

(Kylian): — Yes. For my trial.

(Sarah): — Then I will let you describe the rest when you get there.

On the climb back he again stopped me at doors and steps. When the cloth came away, I was beside the bench where I had first sat. The return had taken a little over an hour. The disk of sunlight had gone; through the roof the sky was still blue, darkening at the rim. Va-Theran refilled the lamp, took a covered basket from a recess and broke bread onto a cloth between us. Ka-Xhian ate before speaking.

"Five offices hold the defence," he said. "All five must agree before it is used. You will have no access to what each keeps."

"I can turn a survey away. It takes time. By the time a drilling party reaches your folds, I would have very little to work with."

"An instrument built for another purpose found us," he said. "There will be better instruments. You know where they are built, which governments buy them, which surveys carry them south."

"I have my father's offices. I can stop them looking for you and put them to work on the others."

"Then hear Shield's offer. You return. Your instructions are sealed again. Amastan gives you one channel. When a government, survey or concession turns towards this quarter, you turn it before it reaches our sand."

"And when one of our explosions alarms you, send word. I will need the date and whatever Shield saw. I can tell you what France fired and whether another shot is planned."

We settled what the channel could carry. Shield would report approaching threats through Amastan. I would act outside the folds. I could ask about an approaching survey; I could not ask for an inner road or a means of operating the defence. My instructions abroad would be sealed again after my return, and Amastan would inspect the seals.

Ka-Xhian required three oaths. I would never bring another Outsider to the folds. I would never set the way in down in writing or in any machine that keeps a voice. If I could no longer serve Shield's purpose, I would send word by Amastan's line, withdraw, and take what I knew into silence. I said yes three times.

"Shield has never relied on an Outsider meaning an oath," he said. "The Exception protects itself."

I asked what that meant. He called Va-Theran to my bench. When I stood, stars showed through the round hole in the roof. The lamp lit Ka-Xhian's face from below.

"Keep the inner ways closed until Amastan reports her clear of the folds," he told his Veil.

Theran gave me the lamp and walked behind me down the straight passage. At its end he reached past my shoulder and touched the stone. It opened on Amastan, who took me by the arm and led me outside. Va-Theran kept the lamp. Amastan waited until the seam had closed, then took me to the animals. We camped beyond the nearest fold and set out north after dawn.

The first message of the channel came north by Amastan's own hand. On the outer fold stood one word: *Horizon*.

(Sarah): — I kept the oaths for the best part of sixty years. In this chair I am breaking the third. The first still stands for the moment; the second will stand while I live.

(Kylian): — And the leash. When you said it, you looked toward the instruction passage.

(Sarah): — I know what Ka-Xhian said. I know there is a camera behind the instruction glass which I did not place, and that General Montel collected one unedited record of your lessons. I do not know that the two facts have the same owner.

(Paul): — What was taught in that room left through the second camera he suspected and I watched. This exchange did not. Montel received one packet. We do not know where the record went after him, or whether it has anything to do with Ka-Xhian.

(Sarah): — Correct, Paul.

(Paul): — How far back do we count the loss?

(Sarah): — Everything taught there since that camera went in.

[—]

(Paul): — And the photograph?

(Sarah): — Paul, the flat envelope on my case. Put the print beside the recorder. Amastan took it at the outer folds the morning we left, with the light hard off the pale stone. My field clothes, my hair tied back; Amastan beside me. Ka-Xhian ordered two prints. The original went to Shield; this one came north with Amastan's first message. Shield's print went into its record of the Exception.

(Kylian): — Why keep the other beneath the ridge?

(Sarah): — That archive is the Veil's Chamber of Shield. Ka-Xhian named it when he told me where the print would be kept. Its Veils and Keepers have access. Ordinary wardens do not; nor does anyone's child.

(Kylian): — Va-Theran's chamber, then. He became Keeper after Xhian. Dhavar was his Veil.

(Sarah): — The custody was Shield's. I kept this copy.

I returned north without an account of the defence's working. I cancelled the release of the packets and recalled the Blackwood enquiries still directed at the folds. Horizon began as the keeping of those three oaths.

It began as liaison through the single quiet channel between Blackwood and Amastan: Shield heard the outside, and I was told when I strayed too near. Then monitoring: I gathered every stroke that empty quarter made and told myself Shield was safer the more completely I could hear. Then management: every geologist, satellite pass and ministry rumour, each turned gently a few degrees aside.

Turning curiosity required a body large enough to be seen doing other work. In the six years after that stone room I took the Blackwood Foundation, already rich and respectable, and aimed it at the work that could contain mine. It became one of the loudest defenders in the world of peoples the century was erasing: the uncontacted, the wandering, the ones a government calls an obstacle and a

company calls overburden. That work was real. The Foundation sent envoys, paid lawyers, contested forced contact in courts, and broke companies off the backs of forest and desert peoples. Some are alive today. I believe they would not be without that work; the files can prove what we did, not the world in which we failed to do it. It could not command a state. It could lengthen a proceeding, expose a concession, finance the people resisting, and make an intrusion cost more than a minister was willing to pay.

Among its hundreds of honest files was one deliberately vague entry: a Saharan population, unnamed and unplaced, spoken for through a desert network that answered to Amastan and held behind a confidentiality no court ever cracked. The file could finance resistance to an incursion after the intruder's budget failed. Its existence taught expeditions, ministries and ore-men to expect that resistance. Every serious question about an isolated people entered a Blackwood office and climbed a chain of clerks. Anything touching one quarter of the Tanezrouft reached the last desk. I sat at it.

The other files could not be dummies: any hostile audit that opened one hollow protection would put a finger through the Saharan one. Each people therefore had counsel, field money, witnesses and a board prepared to spend in public. When a government waited or a company returned under another name, the case remained funded and the same clerks were still there. Some protections outlived the concealment that had first made me choose them. I signed those renewals too. The screen around the Mountain acquired obligations of its own, to people who never knew their survival had been entered beside another people's secret.

> (Kylian): — … You hid it the way Light hides the mirror in the great pillar. Not by keeping the one sign secret: by raising a hundred true signs around it, every one of them real, until no eye alive could say which one the beam came off.
>
> (Sarah): — I have never once put it in those words. But that is the shape of it, yes; and I did not learn it from your people.

Horizon kept files on armies, ministries, ore-men, surveys and satellite passes. The motor race lay under *amusement*. It was young then, and poor, Paris to Dakar across the width of the Sahara, run by amateurs for the love of nearly dying. Its first running had gone from Reggane away east toward In Salah. In the late autumn of nineteen seventy-nine the next route was published. I read it standing up: on the eighth of January more than two hundred machines would leave Reggane and

drive due south, toward Bordj Badji Mokhtar, along a line that passed within a lost man's wandering of the outer folds.

I went to the Mountain a second time, and it was the last time I saw the blind man. I brought him the route and told him what I had already done, because there was no time left to ask. The Foundation had made itself, in a season, a patron of the race: medicine, recovery vehicles, liaison with the desert peoples the route would cross. Inside that apparatus I had entered drivers as gentleman amateurs and placed my people in the assistance crews, sweep vehicles and radio posts. "We watched governments, geologists and soldiers," I told him. "None of us watched a race. The machines that hold the line are no danger. The lost ones are. Blackwood will be ahead of them, among them and behind them. On your side, set the fullest seal you know for the days it takes them to pass." He said that Shield did not require an Outsider to teach it how to shut a door. Then he set the seal. I never spoke with Ka-Xhian again.

On the eighth of January I sat in the Foundation recovery post with three radio sets and the route pinned to a canvas wall. Two wanderers accepted fuel and a bearing back to the marked line. The third did not answer. A spotter south of Reggane reported one machine moving alone in bad light, its compass taking it towards the outer folds. He gave the bearing twice, then left the channel clear as he had been trained.

"White Six," I said into the Foundation set. "There is a competitor east of your line. Find him. Do not signal race control unless he refuses you."

White Six was a sand-coloured motor Blackwood had entered, our small crest on its door beneath the race number. It found the lost driver less than an hour from the folds. He mistook it for another competitor, accepted the line it offered and followed when it cut back west. The two machines appeared together at the recovery post before dark. The lost one continued south. White Six arrived with its steering box cracked, the left front suspension driven through its mount, and the driver holding the wheel a quarter-turn against a pull that would have killed him at speed.

The retirement entered the public record as a steering failure. After the race moved south, my mechanics took White Six back towards the folds and dismantled it where the vehicle could go no farther. Shield took delivery there, load by load. Amastan reported that its pieces had been stored in the Veil's Chamber. He also reported that the great closures at Reggane and during the race had both been presented as drills.

The race work left true papers behind it: fuel dockets, medical logs, one water reconnaissance run under the recovery flag. Its cores went sealed into a Blackwood store, and the catalogue still holds them. One hole west of the marked line gave sweet water and an assay heavy in lithium the laboratory queried twice. Nothing of it was ever published.

Then routes: ways in and out, cached and tested. Then mapping, with listening stations placed around the Mountain. I extended their coverage knock by knock and kept each trace with the earlier ones. By then Horizon could warn me of a traveller at the outer folds, remove him from the approach, or place another man there in his stead.

There was a survey, a consortium of three companies and two governments, that came within a season of running a deep line across the folds for further oil exploration. I did not bribe them. Across two years and eleven hands I let their funding develop a doubt, sent their lead geologist a flattering offer in Western Australia, and tangled their permits in a border dispute I helped to warm. Every piece was true, or true enough to survive a check; none could be traced within a thousand miles of a woman in Switzerland. The survey folded. Its people never knew Horizon had made the decision for them.

(Kylian): — Say the reason. You have walked us all the way up to it and now you are describing bricks. Say why the gamekeeper built a hand.

(Sarah): — I wanted a veto. Your Mountain's defence requires unanimity. All five hands must agree to use it. If I could reach a single Keeper and remove him, I could prevent the firing. Horizon needed a route, people who could use it and somewhere to hold the man. That was the operation I was building.

(Kylian): — And was that all you wanted?

(Sarah): — I grew up with a father who considered himself more powerful than any head of state. He could make a ministry wait for fuel and keep its enemy supplied. I inherited his company and his appetite for dominion. The Mountain would have put something in Blackwood's keeping that no government could buy or vote away. I wanted to hide it, control who could approach it and hold the means of stopping it. I wanted it to remain ours.

[—]

(Kylian): — Then you are the thing. ... To reach for the whole. To be the one hand. You are the thing the gate was built for.

(Sarah): — Yes.

(Kylian): — You do not even argue.

(Sarah): — Why would I argue? I am the one hand.

[—]

(Paul): — Oxford. Geology, archaeology, anthropology. Three years on a Blackwood scholarship, then a post in this house. I was applying for anything that might keep me in research. Had you already chosen me?

(Sarah): — I had asked for those subjects. Your work put you on the list; I approved you.

(Paul): — I told everyone the Foundation had finally recognised what my work was worth.

(Sarah): — It was worth funding, Paul. I also needed someone who could examine a mountain and a man's account of it.

[—]

(Urs): — Lunch, and this. The southern array drew it eleven minutes ago. I checked the clock, feed and instrument.

(Sarah): — Put the lunch here; we will eat at this table. Leave the paper under the lamp.

(Paul): — I will move the plates clear of the recorder.

(Sarah): — The first stroke is close to the old traces.

(Kylian): — A Keeper rising?

(Sarah): — Possibly. We need the rest.

(Elise): — Here is the next stroke. It came through while we were bringing lunch. It is early.

(Sarah): — How early?

(Elise): — Eleven minutes from the first. It should have waited twenty.

(Paul): — This tail differs too. Here, after the peak.

(Sarah): — Yes. Close, but it is not the same stroke.

(Kylian): — At both ceremonies the waits were equal. Has something gone wrong?

(Sarah): — I cannot tell yet. Urs, put every southern array on continuous watch. Have a second reader check the two strokes without seeing my comparison; bring me the readings separately. Hold departures and messages from this house. Wake Amastan's line and prepare the desert channel to move people.

(Urs): — What do I tell the field office?

(Sarah): — That we have an unexplained signal. They are to prepare, not enter the folds. Kylian, give us the trial and the road they sent you out on. We need the rest of your account.

Chapter 14

Trial

Proof secured. Speech held. Body held. Justice had named those three facts over me while I was still bound; they were the last words I could place in time. Inside the soundless room I had no way to count the hours.

Near First Light the door opened, and Ka-Dhavar of Shield stood in it. "You will not be bound," he said. His voice struck the inside of my head; for one breath I understood the sound before the words. "The Lesser Seal remains. The count is still looking for you." "There is nowhere in the Mountain a man runs to," I said, "and no man runs from the five." He stepped aside to let me pass.

He took me past every hearing room I knew, and the route descended. The household doors were barred. At two junctions a Shield warden stood aside to let us through; we met no one else. The warmth of habitation thinned and the polish left the stone.

Then white stone, and the Hall of Prayers. The sight of them assembled stopped me on the threshold. Ka-Elun of Faith at the centre in her plain white and the torn pilgrim's mantle. Ka-Cheryn of Balance, broad and grey. Ka-Leth of Justice, still as his own tablet. Ka-Raedin, my Keeper, a hooded hand-lamp in his grip. And apart from the five, only two: Va-Sheva of Shield, who looked past me, and Sa-Tavan of Justice, a Candidate still, too junior by years to stand in such a room. At their feet were packs: water, dried food, folded cloth.

Ka-Elun looked at the lamp in Ka-Raedin's hand. "Keeper of Light," she said softly, "put that away." He held still. "It is hooded." "That is not the same as away.

Better Keepers of Light than either of you have entered the Labyrinth believing brightness would make a path obedient. They were recovered by pilgrims who could not read a mirror but could keep breath with stone." Ka-Raedin held the lamp through one full breath. Then he set it against the wall, hooded and unlit. "Faith receives," Ka-Elun said, and let it lie.

"You will walk," Ka-Elun told me.

"Guided by whom?"

"By what remains when sight stops governing..."

The carved prayer moved inward, opening a passage behind Ka-Elun. She took a narrow lamp from the bracket beside it. We went down in single file, Ka-Dhavar last, closing the stone behind us. At the first division Ka-Elun sang one low note and waited. The passage on our left returned it at once; the one on our right gave it back later and fainter. She took the right.

We walked for an hour — ramp and switchback and long shallow grade, doubling back on itself, descending until my ears changed and the air cooled against my face. At the next branch she used a child's counting tune; at the next, four words from the prayer at First Light. She waited through every return before choosing.

"Are we going to the Hall of the Last Prayer?" I asked. Ka-Elun came close to laughing. "No. You are being taken beneath the rooms, Va-Kailan — beneath the reason for them..."

The walls were striped, floor to vanished ceiling, bands of pale and dark lit by Ka-Elun's lamp so that stone and shadow repeated in one endless rhythm. We turned left, right, then doubled back through a low chamber whose floor sloped towards a shallow bowl. Each time we reached the bowl, she changed the song. Once the answer came from ahead; once from behind Ka-Dhavar; on what I counted as the seventh passage, from an opening I had not seen. I could see three ways out, though I had counted two before. I left the file to examine a crack beside one opening. I was sure I had seen it before.

"No," Ka-Elun said, without turning.

"I did not speak."

"You leaned toward certainty. There is no crack you have seen before. There are only cracks that repeat. You may observe, Va-Kailan. You may not follow yourself."

I returned to the file.

In the next chamber three doorways faced us. Ka-Elun sang three rising notes towards them. The returns reached us one after another.

Ka-Elun passed behind Ka-Raedin and covered his eyes with both hands. "Eyes closed. All of you." She lowered the hood.

When the light returned I waited, then looked. Her hands still covered Ka-Raedin's eyes, his head tilted back towards her. The others still had their eyes closed. The chamber stretched away to my right; five doorways stood where I remembered three. My heel still rested in the same hollow. Ka-Elun sang the three notes again. Five returns crossed the chamber.

Ka-Cheryn opened her eyes. "Ka-Elun. Your hands." She watched until Faith released him. Ka-Raedin straightened his robe, and Ka-Elun took up the lamp.

At the next turn I heard water running on the left. Farther along, its note thinned beside a hollow in the wall. I turned towards it and put my hand on the stone. Cold moved through one narrow joint into my palm.

Ka-Elun let me lead for a few steps. When I stopped she came up beside me in the dark. "A Light is given the eye," she said, barely above a breath. "You were handed it as a boy, and you are good at it, and it is not the best of what is in you. Faith hears. You heard."

"Before the Beast, silence," she said, at the wall where I had stopped — and the answer came from behind me, from the Keepers themselves: "Before silence, prayer. Before prayer, breath. Before breath, fear." The seam opened where my ear had set me, and there was distance now where there had been none. "Now," she said, "Light may look."

We came into a circular room. Ten doors ringed it, five beneath carved arches and five flush with the wall. Nine were shut; the Labyrinth stood open behind us. Each office mark appeared twice.

At the centre stood a king cut from dark stone, his crown and hands left whole, his face chiselled away. A city in gold circled his feet. The closed arch of Faith stood at his back; his erased face was set towards the bridge and, beyond it, the Gate.

Ka-Elun sang once more, a measure she had not used on the descent. Her voice returned from the wall before him. Stone moved and opened the way into the antechamber.

The bridge was a tongue of stone wide enough for thirty men abreast, running level across a gulf of open air to the far wall. Above, the dark climbed higher than the Mountain stands above the sand, and higher again. Below, to either side, the floor fell away into two long pits. Out of them rose the pillars, scarred and past counting, their heads lost past where the light could climb. Around their bases, picked out in gold, cities crossed bands of carved sand. I could not tell whether they were emerging or being drowned.

> (Paul): — No. Stop. This does not exist.
>
> (Kylian): — After all this time, this is where you stop believing my account?
>
> (Paul): — This is bullshit. Sarah. Come on!
>
> (Sarah): — No, Paul. I was there.

The two long walls were the Mountain itself, broken rock on either side of the bridge. The far wall was built, and the bridge ran straight at the Gate of the Hall of Cataclysm. It rose the height of a great tree and spanned the width of the bridge, every part of it mechanism. Chains thick as tree-trunks entered it out of the rock and climbed into slots above. Five rows of five signs had been cut across its face, figures I failed to read; low to one side an empty slot waited in the iron. At its centre was the Beast's face from the Pendulum, a great cat with round ears flattened and five teeth bared beneath almost human eyes.

Across the gulf to my left, on the wall at right angles to the Gate, spread the Cataclysm gravure, five-and-twenty paces to a side. The Mountain stood above the Beast, which strained upward out of Hell with its fists at the roots of the Earth. Five figures stood apart in five arches, each holding one of its chains. Beyond the Mountain the Outsiders crowded under the open eye of Heaven; flame passed through their cities and great waves broke over them. At the foot of the ruin the people went down into the stone.

In the antechamber, five seats faced the accused mark, cut from the chamber's own stone, spaced so no Keeper could easily whisper to another. At the centre lay a flat stone table where objects could be placed so all could see them and no single hand receive them. Nothing lay upon it.

Ka-Dhavar brought me to the mark with one touch at the shoulder. He used no restraint and stayed within reach until the five had taken their seats. Ka-Leth of Justice stood beside the central stone, his own hands empty, for Justice keeps clear of the record and only speaks into it. At the wall stood Va-Sheva of Shield and Sa-Tavan of Justice with the tablet on which the record would be kept.

"This antechamber opens under seal," Ka-Leth said, and the words stayed small in the vastness. "No Kahir divulges what belongs solely to its own sealed charge. No Keeper seeks total knowledge. The hearing binds the five without making one hand whole. Before judgement, the chamber remembers why judgement is divided."

Faith read both Books. The first scroll lay open before her, and she left it untouched; she knew every word by the body's memory.

"The Book of the Beast," Ka-Leth said, and Ka-Elun began.

And the curse went forth upon the Outsiders, and they wandered under the eye of Heaven; and the Earth hid them not, neither did the waters keep them, nor the Mountain give them shade. And they multiplied in the open land, and their hunger multiplied with them; and brother rose against brother, and city rose against city, and king rose against king. And they made war without measure, and famine without pity, and prisons without mercy; and they bound the weak, and burned the innocent, and betrayed the hand that fed them.

And God looked upon the Outsiders, and saw the works of their hands; and behold, their cruelty was greater than the curse that had been laid upon them. For they tortured for pleasure, and conquered for pride, and lied with holy words, and slew their children for the hunger of their fathers. And God was wroth, and God said, The evil of the Outsiders is deep, and their hunger hath no end; and if they find the Mountain, they shall not spare the Oasis, nor the Temple, nor the children beneath My shadow.

And God gave unto the Oasis a great defence, and set power in the Keepers thereof. Unto the Keeper of Light He gave the Dance of Light, that the hidden ways might be revealed to the appointed eye. Unto the Keeper of Balance He gave the Movement of the Waters, to raise and withhold the deep. Unto the Keeper of Justice He gave the Key, the Number, and the Binding of the Chains, that no burden move without order and witness. Unto the Keeper of Shield He gave the Sword and the Seal, to close the Mountain against the wrath it had awakened. And unto the Keeper of Faith He gave the Prayer and the Listening of Stone, that the holy word might be spoken in rhythm, and the trembling of the Earth understood.

And God said unto the Keepers, Keep these secrets apart, and let no one hand hold the whole; for the power that defendeth the Oasis may also devour the Earth. And He taught each Keeper his portion, and sealed the rest from him. And each was strong in his charge, and weak without the others.

And God said, If the Outsiders come again, and if they find the Mountain, and if they lay their hands upon the Temple,

> *then shall the Keepers stand as one and unleash the Beast upon the Earth. And the poisoned waters shall rise, and the volcanoes shall erupt, and the ground shall break beneath the feet of the enemy, and the sea shall climb over their cities; and the Outsiders shall taste the cruelty they gave upon the world. But if the Keepers fail, or if one hand seize the whole, then the Beast shall know neither faithful nor stranger, and Hell shall not distinguish between the guilty and the guarded.*

Ka-Elun closed the first scroll. Ka-Leth opened the second. "The Book of the Cataclysm," he said. Ka-Elun read on. The Book of the Beast says what God will do; this one says what was done. It tells again what the first had promised, now as a thing done: the enemy coming with banners and false prayers, the five bringing forth each the secret given him and standing apart as one, and the answer of Hell.

> *And the five stood apart as one, and no one hand held the whole. And God remembered His word, and Hell answered.*

At the end Ka-Elun read:

> *And they wept for the world that had been saved and lost in the same hour. And God said unto them, Dwell no more in the open, but enter the Mountain, and keep the Temple, and remember the price of being seen. And the Temple was sealed, and the people went beneath the stone.*

Ka-Elun closed the second scroll, and no one spoke.

Ka-Leth set out the charges: Breach of Seal, Bearing Forbidden Proof, Unauthorised Revelation in potential and act. "The law judges not only the fire that has burned, but the place where fire was carried." And then the frame that closed the room like a lid: "No cross-Kahir knowledge may be divulged. No sealed name spoken. Any attempt to defend by renewing the breach will be stopped."

"How do I answer what cannot be spoken?"

"With what may be spoken."

"And if what may be spoken is not enough?"

"Then you begin to understand the charge."

He read eight facts into the record, and I contested no sequence. The route had been reconstructed from Shield's seals and my own account: unauthorised movement through the exterior ways; defeat of the first archive lock; entry into a sealed Shield chamber; handling of restricted material; removal of two records and one woven object; carriage through inhabited galleries; concealment of one

record beneath a Light seal; surrender of the woven object and the other record to Shield. Sa-Tavan set each fact into the tablet.

Ka-Leth turned to Va-Sheva. She spoke to the centre stone and kept her hands behind her back. "What danger did you judge?"

"Proof travelling by a credible bearer."

"Not treason?"

"No standing to judge treason."

"Did he surrender the proof?"

"He returned the woven object and presented the torn record to Shield. The second record remained beneath his Light seal."

"Did he disclose its contents to another person?"

"No record contents were disclosed beyond Shield. The Keeper of Light received questions of law and no fact."

"Do those facts remove the danger?"

Va-Sheva's thumb pressed into the opposite palm. "No. All three objects had crossed every seal meant to contain them. A credible bearer carried them among the people for two days and placed one inside another office. Surrender stopped his route. It did not unmake it."

She stepped back. Ka-Leth asked whether I contested her evidence. I said no.

"There are only two outcomes lawful in this chamber," Ka-Leth said. "Death, or Exception."

"Before the offices, the accused may speak within the boundaries he has been given," Ka-Leth said.

"An unexplained beam is Light's to follow. A beam from beyond the Mountain may be the first sign of an Outsider Shield has failed to detect; until its source is known, Light may be the only office capable of finding the threat and warning the Mountain." I waited before continuing. "I have come to suspect that the Mountain is the victim of a great crime, possibly treason. Had I returned all three objects, one office would have held the suspected act, the evidence of it and the power to decide whether the Mountain would ever hear either."

Let no one hand hold the whole.

"Upon discovering a suspected breach or worse, I went to Ka-Raedin of Light and asked, without naming the proof, how such a matter might lawfully be brought before the five. And here we are."

Sa-Tavan's stylus moved. Ka-Leth waited until it stopped.

"You will each speak from your office," Ka-Leth said, "and from nothing else." For a sentence of death Justice voted first and blind, then returned last to pronounce what the five had made.

"Justice," he said, naming himself. "For the whole to be divided, no office may enter a sealed chamber of another Kahir. Removing an item and making it travel through the Mountain is worse and could produce total collapse. A small chance of total loss, carried by a credible man, set against a large comfort in his good intentions: the law does not trade a total loss for a comfort. Death."

At the wall, Sa-Tavan's stylus had stopped above the night's record. A second tablet lay beside his hand.

Ka-Leth looked towards him. "Sa-Tavan, did you bring an open enquiry concerning the accused?"

"I did."

Sa-Tavan brought him the tablet. Ka-Leth took it and read one entry aloud. "Unresolved Shield enquiry: a light on the second ridge during prayer access at the Oasis, entered as mirage in Sa-Kailan of Light's hand." He looked towards Shield. "What of it?"

"Show it to me," Ka-Dhavar said.

Sa-Tavan carried the tablet to Shield. Ka-Dhavar read the entry and looked up at me. "I know that light. It was no mirage. It was real, and the hand that saw it wrote it false."

Ka-Leth said, "Enter the light as real and the report as false. Close the enquiry." Sa-Tavan marked the closing.

"Faith." Ka-Elun rose. "Va-Maera of Faith reported how you tried to use what you knew of our ceremonies to obtain private scripture. She warned you against making a weapon of it. You withdrew your request. Now you have offended again."

> *Let no sign be carried from its chamber, nor proof borne beyond its seal; for a secret held in place may preserve the people, but a secret made to wander shall become fire among them.*

"The people saw him at prayer in the Hall of Ceremony for months. Faith can carry his death where it could never carry his life — a devout young Veil lost in the Labyrinth on a pilgrimage beyond his right, found on the fourth day and grieved honestly, because grief is easiest when true. Faith supports death."

"Shield." Ka-Dhavar spoke the way a man reads a measurement aloud. "Sa-Tavan's tablet is proof the accused has knowingly lied once to the record. Faith's

account is proof he has tried to leverage knowledge for his own benefit. And now he carries sealed knowledge and proof. The danger is the bearer. A dead bearer carries nothing. Exception relocates the danger and asks all five of us to watch it for the rest of our lives, and the watching, in the end, always lapses. Death contains completely. My position is death. I say it without appetite."

"Balance." Ka-Cheryn turned one hand over. "Faith has contained the public cost of his death. I cannot price the broken chain of Light: the time required to reform it, or what may fail before it does. I hand that uncertainty to Light. Every quantity I can count weighs towards death."

"Light." Ka-Raedin came forward, and I stopped breathing. "He is useful. He has an eye that finds seams I do not see — you must know what you are spending. But he was warned that the walls are our survival, and offended, and warned again, and offended again. Talent that will not keep inside its wall is a breach that will repeat itself. When he ascends to Keeper, what then? A more capable breach the Mountain cannot withstand." He turned, by the smallest degree, toward me. "Va-Kailan of Light. The Mountain comes first. Then the office. Then the man. In that order, always — and I would be no Keeper if I let the third move the first." He turned back. "Light concurs. Death."

Ka-Leth returned to the centre stone, where no proof lay, to speak aloud what the five had made. "It is one voice. Va-Kailan of Light, Veil under Ka-Raedin: the five are agreed. You are stripped of the name and standing of your office. You are condemned to death. On the fourth day from this, the Labyrinth will give your body up to the pilgrims who go seeking you, and the Mountain will grieve a devout boy it believes it lost, and the grief will be true and it will be a lie, both at once, for as long as the Mountain stands."

The word useful stayed with me.

Ka-Raedin came to the accused mark. "Your hand."

I drew the pierced Light token from the inner seam of my robe. Shield had searched it and returned it after the proof was taken; an office mark remained lawful until Justice removed the office. The disc had rested against my ribs since my Ascension, pale as winter metal, its pinhole and close rings worn smooth at the edge by the Veils before me.

I laid it across his palm. When I was still a Candidate, in the Veil's Chamber, he had taken it from the path of the red beam and closed my fingers around it. Now he examined both faces, turned it once by the rim and closed his own hand. He carried it to the seat of Light and set it beneath the hooded lamp kept there. Cold air reached through the cloth where the disc no longer covered my skin.

"The sentence is spoken," Ka-Leth said. "It is not yet carried out. By the old right of the condemned before this chamber, you may contest your judgement — not the fact of what you did, which is sequenced and closed, but the judgement itself. Do you contest your judgement?"

I let the silence run one beat too long, the way Ka-Raedin had trained me to leave part of a lamp's throw dark on purpose.

"No," I said. "I do not contest my judgement. I contest the court."

Nothing in Ka-Leth's face moved. "The court is lawfully seated."

"Is it?"

Ka-Leth let me speak.

"We are taught that this is the highest law, above every office — that the power which defends the Oasis may also devour it, and so no one hand may hold the whole. Let us assume, all of us, that each hand here loves the Mountain. May I assume that?"

Ka-Elun inclined her head the width of a breath. "You may assume it."

"Then I speak in the fullest hypothesis, and reveal nothing. Suppose a Keeper — I name none — had committed the highest treason against the Mountain. Not a breach; not an error of appetite such as mine. The highest treason. Would we not want the Mountain healed of it?"

Faith answered first. "We would."

"Balance."

"A bad entry left in the ledger throws off every sum after it. Yes."

"Light."

Ka-Raedin looked at the five chains that stood clear of one another, then across at Ka-Dhavar. "Necessary."

"Shield."

Ka-Dhavar was still.

"You may try to vote," I said, before he could find a third road, "that high treason among us is a thing the Mountain can carry. But it will not help your case in the trial to come."

"Agreed," Ka-Dhavar said.

"Justice."

Ka-Leth took the longest of all. "You are assembling jurisdiction from answers given in hypothesis."

"I am contesting the court. Justice gave me the right."

He looked at the other four. None withdrew an answer. "The principle stands. High treason against the Mountain is ground for emergency interruption of any ordinary sequence, including this one."

"A principle is not an allegation," Ka-Leth said. "You have named no act, no accused and no evidence. Justice will not suspend a death hearing because a condemned man has discovered a larger word."

"Then receive an offer of proof without the sealed names. The second record — a physical image from the archive — remains beneath my unbroken Light seal. No other person has seen what it contains. A living Keeper has continued a secret relationship with an Outsider beyond the knowledge and judgement of the other four offices. The relationship continues. A witness of the accused office is present in this chamber."

Va-Sheva's chin lowered by the width of a thread. Ka-Dhavar did not look towards her.

"If your offer fails?" Ka-Leth asked.

"The sentence already stands."

"If it renews the breach for which you were sentenced?"

"Then the breach is before the five under the higher matter, and I answer for both."

"Then I petition Justice, by the old right of the condemned, for the emergency interruption the five have just named lawful — not to overturn my sentence, but to suspend the hearing that carries it, so a matter of higher treason may be heard first."

Ka-Leth was silent a long moment. "The right is real, and the ground the five have granted. The death hearing is suspended — and no further."

"I cannot lodge an accusation against a sitting Keeper with no standing at all."

"You ceased standing when the sentence was spoken."

"Then no accusation can be laid, and the interruption you granted has no act inside it."

Ka-Leth's thumb moved once against the centre stone. "For the single purpose of laying the accusation, and for nothing beyond it, your standing is restored. You are Va-Kailan of Light until the accusation is heard or dismissed. Not one act past that."

Ka-Leth called for the sealed object. Under Justice's order, Ka-Raedin left to recover it without opening my seal.

"Understood." I turned towards the man who held the record. "There is one here who is neither a Keeper nor a witness I have summoned. What comes next is

a matter of high treason and of sequence between Keepers. It cannot be held by a Candidate, nor written by a hand that will walk the ordinary Mountain tomorrow. I ask that Sa-Tavan of Justice be removed."

Ka-Leth looked at his Candidate. "A charge between Keepers passes beyond a Candidate's hand before the Keeper is named. The trial tablet leaves with him. Nothing spoken afterward can acquit you in that record, restore your standing there, or alter the sentence already entered."

"Then the tablet will preserve the thing the five lawfully decided before I spoke, and nothing I force after it."

"Yes."

"That is the record I ask you to keep."

"Sa-Tavan," Ka-Leth said. "Withdraw. From this breath, record nothing. Speak of it to no one, under the Promise, while you live."

Sa-Tavan gathered the trial tablet and stylus and withdrew towards the circular room and no step past it, because no Candidate of Justice walks the Labyrinth alone. Nothing spoken after his withdrawal entered the record of my condemnation.

Ka-Raedin returned with the packet sealed as I had left it. He set it upon the centre stone and resumed his place.

Ka-Elun spoke towards the circular room. "Out of earshot," she said. "I will know."

Ka-Leth took the second tablet from the wall.

I turned to the centre stone, and to the man in the seat nearest the great door.

"I accuse Ka-Xhian, formerly Keeper of Shield, of high treason against the Mountain: entering into a secret and illicit relationship with an Outsider without the knowledge or judgement of the other four Kahirs; and I accuse Ka-Dhavar, Keeper of Shield, of continuing that treason and putting the Mountain at risk."

"You cannot accuse the dead," Ka-Leth said.

"I can. I have. And I will accuse as far back as I wish, to the murderer if required. But Ka-Dhavar is living, and he continued it."

"The charge against the living Keeper is received provisionally," Ka-Leth said. "Ka-Dhavar, take the accused mark. Va-Sheva will hold Shield's voice until the charge is answered. I will keep this part of the record."

Ka-Dhavar crossed to the accused mark. Va-Sheva left the wall and took Shield's seat. I remained standing. The floor was mine.

The Beast strained in its carved silence. No one moved. Behind me and to my left, one of them said quietly, "You trained this?" Ka-Raedin answered without

looking at any of us. "With ease. He was always going to cut himself on his own edge. I kept it sharp."

There was nothing left to do but let the Keeper of Shield answer — and I believed, in the last moment before he did, that I had him.

Ka-Dhavar answered before I could prosecute him — before I could lay out the photographs and the map, name the Threshold Exception, or put a single question through Shield's appointed voice. I said nothing until he had finished.

"The outside is not the story the children are given," he said. "Or it is, and it is also real, and it is also near. The desert is not empty. Far to the north, beneath the sand, lies a black substance in a quantity beyond any count Balance has kept, and the Outsiders hunger for it exactly as the Book says. Their prospectors have crossed the Threshold for a hundred years, nearer each season." He paused. "Six-and-sixty years ago they lit a fire in the desert that was not a fire — a light in the shape of a great cloud, taller than the Mountain, that turned the sand to glass and poisoned the wind for a generation. Four weeks' walk, exactly north of here, at a place the Outsiders call Reggane. One of the few great seals in living memory was set on that day, presented as a drill — because the fire burnt so bright that Xhian, formerly Ka-Xhian, Keeper of Shield, lost his sight observing it, and because with it came an earth-shaking sound too great for Faith to miss and go on calling itself Faith. Fourteen years on, the same office sealed us once more against a danger out of that same quarter; that too the children were told was a drill or a game."

"Why," Ka-Cheryn said slowly, "would Faith keep a record of a fire in the desert, far to the north?" Faith did not answer, and he went on.

"The science that serves their cruelty went past our reach long ago. Shield does not sit behind the seal and wait for the wrath to arrive at the gate. Shield goes out. Shield watches. And we have had word, this season, that powerful men from every quarter of the open world are joining their strength to find us. They map the desert. They observe it from above."

"What do you mean from above?" Ka-Cheryn asked.

"They have set eyes around the Earth," Ka-Dhavar said. "Machines that circle it and do not fall, and read the sand from the sky."

"Around the Earth," Ka-Leth said. The chamber turned toward Justice.

"What do you mean, around the Earth? The Earth has no — the Earth has no around."

And God set the Earth between Heaven and Hell, that the living should walk between the eye above and the fire beneath.

"And He has," Ka-Elun answered, smiling.

Ka-Cheryn of Balance, who had spent her life outside in the cold hours pulling water and counting stars, gave one short, helpless laugh. "How is a man that clever and that blind, all at once?"

"Does Light know?" Ka-Leth asked.

"Light has drawn the Earth's shadow over the moon," Ka-Raedin said. "The edge is curved every time."

"And Balance?"

"The north star lowers when we go south," Ka-Cheryn said. "Other stars rise. Balance has tables for the angle at every outer station."

"And Faith?"

Ka-Elun's hand settled against the torn edge of her mantle. "The Thread crosses the Hall and turns its road across the floor. After two days and three quarters it returns. The Thread is true to God. Its precession is the Earth turning under it."

Ka-Leth looked from one to the next. "You knew this?"

"Each of us knew what belonged to our office," Ka-Elun said.

Ka-Leth turned to Shield. "Do the machines see the whole of it?"

"They see a curved field beneath them," Ka-Dhavar said. "Their paths close. Shield has copied their paths and tested them against the routes of stars. The Earth is a body. Every direction we call down points into it."

Ka-Leth lifted his eyes to the black above the bridge, then to the two pits beneath it. His right hand opened against the centre stone. "Heaven above. Hell below."

"Here," Ka-Elun said. "The words name where a person stands."

Ka-Leth looked in turn towards Light, Balance, Faith and Shield. The five seats remained too far apart for a whisper.

Ka-Leth's office had never once looked up. Justice had built a mathematics deep enough to hold the Mountain's fate in a square and a column of figures, yet never learned the shape of the world it judged, because that shape lay outside its charge.

His fingertips whitened against the centre stone. A line of sweat moved from his right temple into the collar of Justice. When he had pronounced my death, his hands had lain flat and dry in the same place.

Ka-Leth had spent forty years inside the record. Most wrongs came to him with a known shape and cost: a miscounted measure, a stolen ration, a struck child. Another kind of matter had entered the record perhaps a handful of times in eleven thousand years — without precedent, too large and too little understood for the law to measure its reach. Almost every one had ended in catastrophe.

"You will not have heard this very old story. A single word was changed in a record, from *unrelated* to *kin*. The change almost brought about the self-destruction of the Mountain."

"You know of *the Three Seats*? This is a Balance story," Ka-Cheryn said.

Ka-Elun began, "It is not a story. The three Veils did more than conspire —"

"Ka-Elun, do not," Va-Sheva interrupted from Shield's seat.

"Enough. Silence." Ka-Leth stood.

"A thing has been done in this chamber tonight," he said, "that has not been done in the memory of the record; and Justice has been handed, in open chamber, a thing its office was never given to hold: *the shape of the world*. I know only this: a precedent has been made whose consequence could be that Justice is blind no more. That alone, whatever the truth of any accusation, is more than what the Mountain can carry." He looked at me without hatred, which I had stopped hoping for and now received as the cruelest thing in the room. "I would rather bury a true accusation than let this move one step further."

"I do not question a sequence I do not yet understand," Ka-Raedin said.

"The accusation against Shield is closed," Ka-Leth said. "It is not named false. It is set beyond pursuit. Shield's motive is received: the threat is real, the watching is necessary, and necessity is not treason." He turned to me. "The accuser may speak, if he has anything further."

"Then hear this," I said, and heard my own voice reach the way a falling man reaches for a wall. "The manner of his answer is the proof of it. He did not meet my accusation — he drowned it, opening before all of you knowledge not all offices may hold, so that the horror of the crossing would swallow the smaller matter of his treason. I say the closing is itself the crime."

"No." There was no anger in Ka-Leth's voice, and that was worse. "We will not open a trial inside a trial inside another, each cracked to bury the last. That is the thrashing of a condemned man who has felt the water climb to his mouth. The matter is closed, unless you have anything further."

"Ka-Dhavar, speak of the black tree. Speak of the Outsider who came within our walls and left alive, or I will pronounce her name."

Ka-Dhavar stepped from the accused mark and walked its cut edge; he spoke before completing the circle.

"Sarah of House Blackwood, who commands the Black Tree, bears the mark of the ascended. She is Ka-Sarah, Keeper of Horizon under Shield. She is a cunning woman who found us by listening to the sound the Mountain makes when a newly raised Keeper is tested. For more than fifty years she has turned surveys, soldiers and instruments away from us. She saw the Pendulum and stood once in this very antechamber. She knew what she was protecting."

He completed the circle. No one spoke.

"Shield holds the Threshold. I will say nothing further of my sealed charge. Va-Kailan of Light, if you begin the name of the man in that image, I will cut your throat before it is whole and give Justice my life afterward."

I looked at Va-Sheva in Shield's seat. She did not move. I shook my head.

"Then the matter of treason is sealed," Ka-Leth said. "The stay is lifted. I swear under the Promise that my Veil will not inherit the shape of the world. The original hearing resumes."

Ka-Dhavar returned to Shield's seat. Va-Sheva stood again at the wall. I took the accused mark, and Ka-Leth pronounced the sentence again.

I had four days, no office and no accusation. The word useful had survived Ka-Raedin's vote for death.

I spoke softly enough that the five had to lean in.

"I do not contest that I am a danger," I said. "I contest the waste of me. Hear it from each of your offices, since you judged me from them." To Faith: "You named me devout and meant it for a shroud. Let it be a fact. Everything I did, I did believing the Mountain was betrayed and could be healed — never once against it; and you who read patterns know the shape of me points inward." To Balance: "You will spend nothing of your stores on me. I will cost the cistern nothing it would feel." To Justice: "I regret the precedent; I would carry it out of the world if I could. But a thing that cannot be buried can still be spent — outward, instead of festering here." To Ka-Raedin: "You called me an eye that sees the seam others walk over. An eye is no use in a grave. It is no use, either, in the one sealed room where there is nothing left to look at."

And then to Shield, and the whole night narrowed to the width of the next sentence.

"You called her cunning. How do you know whether she serves Shield or has waited fifty years to turn on the Mountain? You go out. You have always gone

out. Men of Shield walk among the Outsiders and come back, and keep what they must keep, and the name they do it under is Horizon. Send me out upon that road. I have the eye."

Ka-Dhavar's hand closed over the arm of his seat.

"Ka-Dhavar has spoken Shield's secret before the five," I continued. "My death cannot make it secret again. Shield opened a road into the Outsiders and named it Horizon. You cannot know whether the same road opened back into the Mountain. Light found that road from one irregular beam. Use me to follow it in both directions."

"You have stripped the name and standing of Light from me. I name what remains: shadow, to fight the enemy within. Give me no seat and no judgement. Let Va-Sheva, whom I trust, be the ear I speak into. What concerns the Mountain she will carry to the five; what belongs to one office, to that office alone. I will find, test and report. If her service is true, I will say so. If it conceals betrayal, I will follow it. You need not trust me here. Make me useful at the distance from which the danger cannot come back."

"This is nowhere in the law," Ka-Leth said.

"No," said Ka-Raedin. "Yet it is in the Mountain's interest, and the Mountain's interest is the thing the law was raised to serve, not the reverse. I told the boy the order of it — the Mountain first, then the office, then the man. I will not unsay it now, merely because the same order that would have killed him has turned, and asks instead that he be used."

Ka-Leth was quiet a long moment. "Understand what is before us, and what is not. There are two outcomes in this chamber, and only two: death, or Exception. This is not a third. It is the Exception — put to a use it has never been put to, sent outward where it has only ever sealed within. If it is granted, it is granted by the five offices explicitly, each in its own voice. Speak the word, or the sentence already spoken stands."

He named them, and one by one they spoke.

Ka-Raedin first. "You are sending light out by the narrowest door in the Mountain and asking it to stay a line. I am the one Keeper here who knows what light does with a narrow door, and I am sworn not to teach it in an open room. Hear this much: light that passes a narrow opening comes out changed, and changes what it falls on. His path, thrown so far, will mark the Mountain. Exception. My word does not restore his name."

Ka-Elun kept one hand on the torn mantle. "You weigh his distance; I weigh his rhythm. No tread keeps one beat. Give him a year and his foot will strike the

Mountain's note ten thousand times. A small thing returning upon the stone's own note is what wakes the deep. Exception. And I do not trust his beat."

Ka-Cheryn turned a hand over as when a column would not come even. "You would put him outside to keep the inside clean. The sum never falls. Disorder swept from one room is paid for with more in the next; it gathers, warms and leans back on the door. There is no away. Exception, against my count."

Ka-Dhavar remained standing. "I have set every seal the Mountain owns. Not one is tight. What is known has already copied itself; the knowing has gone ahead of him into every mouth it touched. There is no shut door, only a slow one. Exception. The slow door is Shield's to hold."

Four votes had been spoken. The sentence stood until Justice gave the fifth. Ka-Leth kept his hands above the centre stone and looked past all of us, to the black air.

"I never let myself know the world was a sphere. I know this much of closed spaces: some carry a throat, a loop that cannot be tightened to a point. Where every circuit can be drawn shut without tearing, the space is a sphere, however it is bent. We are sending this man towards what we call outside. A seamless world keeps no outside. If his road closes, it closes on us. If it stays open, whose law governs the road?" He laid his empty hands flat on the centre stone. "Exception — and on my head be the throat I could not find."

(Paul): — I should ask my brother John about that.

The five had spoken it. Ka-Leth returned, last, to say aloud what they had made.

"It is one voice," he said. "The sentence of death is stayed, and its cover kept whole. To the Mountain you are the devout boy the Labyrinth took; on the fourth day they will grieve you, and you will let them, and never once, while you live, send them word that the grief is misspent. What you are from this breath has no name in any Book. This record will call it *Keeper of Shadow*; the name grants no office and no seat. You go out under Shield, by the door we do not name above the deep, and you send back nothing but the truth, through Va-Sheva, until the five release you or the desert does. You asked to be made useful at a distance. The Mountain grants you the distance. Do not mistake it for a pardon. It is the longest leash the law has ever paid out, and it is a leash still."

No one asked him to explain the sphere. I carried the words without their sense. Ka-Leth gave Va-Sheva a sealed copy of the charges and the terms he had just spoken. He kept the hearing tablet.

Ka-Raedin came within an arm's length and lowered his voice. "Your seal held." He let that stand between us, then said, "You are alive."

"Yes, Keeper."

"You will be tempted to think that being useful is the same as being forgiven. It is the opposite. You have bought yourself time, and nothing else — time to become capable of carrying what you forced yourself to see. Go and be the eye. Shadow is Shield's answer to you now. The eye is also, and will remain... Light's." He went to wait beside the bridge.

Ka-Elun stopped me before I could follow him. "Do not make a gospel of what has happened to you," she said.

"No, Keeper."

"That will be harder than silence. You have a martyr's material now, and a preacher's tongue, and neither the office nor the innocence to be trusted with either. Carry the truth. Do not preach it. The Beast knows neither faithful nor stranger. Neither, now, does your story. Give the account to the ear the five have named, and to no one else." She lifted the lamp.

I stepped towards the bridge. No one put a hand on me.

> (Elise): — Two fresh strokes.
>
> (Urs): — Eleven minutes between them.
>
> (Sarah): — Bring the computers in. We will have lunch here.

Chapter 15

Knocks

(Urs): — Well, Herr Nemo? Which caviar is best?

(Kylian): — None of them. May I have some more cream?

(Urs): — You have tried all five?

(Kylian): — Yes. The cream is wonderful. I want more on this potato. And that butter, please.

(Paul): — Here. You have hardly touched the salmon.

(Kylian): — I was saving it. We smoke fish at home, but ours takes some chewing. This comes apart on my tongue.

(Urs): — There is another whole plate of it. Elise, would you pass the blinis?

(Elise): — Take them. I need that space.

(Sarah): — Paul, give her some room. And pour me a little of that before Urs puts the bottle out of reach.

(Urs): — A little for everyone?

(Sarah): — One glass each. We still have work to do.

[—]

(Elise): — Sarah, I need the two ceremony sheets.

(Sarah): — Paul has them. The folded pair, Paul, at the back.

(Paul): — Here. Mind the edge; it has split.

(Kylian): — May I see?

(Sarah): — The earlier one would be Faith. Four years later, Light. I found them after our first interview, when I had your years to work from.

(Kylian): — These were here all that time?

(Sarah): — In the archive. I knew where the signal came from. I could not put a ceremony to either date.

(Kylian): — And that is the hour?

(Sarah): — The instrument's time. Urs will check it against the others.

(Kylian): — Where does he die?

(Paul): — Who?

(Kylian): — Ka-Syphiron. On this.

(Sarah): — Earlier. These would be the tests afterward.

(Kylian): — Then that is Ka-Raedin down there.

[—]

(Kylian): — I was still in the Hall. Everybody was waiting for them to come back. You could have been watching this while we waited.

(Sarah): — Somebody was. I would have read it later.

(Kylian): — What did you write beside it?

(Sarah): — Cause unknown. Paul, let him keep it a moment.

(Paul): — Elise needs the scale.

(Elise): — I have it. He can keep the paper.

(Kylian): — And now you can put his name there.

(Sarah): — If you want me to.

(Kylian): — You do not need my permission. You have the account.

(Paul): — Kylian, would you rather we put those away?

(Kylian): — No. I want to know what else they tell you. When the first stroke comes, could somebody outside know a Keeper has just taken the chain?

(Sarah): — With what you have told us, yes. Until then it could also be an emergency test, like the one after Reggane.

(Kylian): — By the first stroke all five are below. The new Keeper has only just begun the work. Whoever was watching would have the rest of the rite.

(Sarah): — Yes.

(Kylian): — Who gets these readings?

(Sarah): — Each station keeps its own. Urs and Elise bring them together for me. Your account stays here.

(Kylian): — I have given you a good deal more than dates.

(Sarah): — You have. Urs, the field gets unannotated instrument records. The names and the ceremony sequence stay in this room.

[—]

(Urs): — Elise, send me Geb again. The whole file, please.

(Elise): — It is already on your laptop. Open the second one.

(Urs): — Sarah, come round this side. I have put them on the same scale. The live one is the lower line.

(Sarah): — Enlarge the tail. Keep the scale beside it.

(Elise): — There is very little below it. Most of the energy is at higher frequencies. I have checked against the old records at three stations; the new peaks are a tenth of the old ones at one, a hundredth at another. The instruments are calibrated. The broad, slow return is missing from all three.

(Kylian): — So nobody is being raised?

(Sarah): — It would be a very different test. Let us get the other stations before we say that.

(Paul): — How much energy would make a mark that small?

(Urs): — I still have to sum the waveforms. On these first readings, perhaps a hundred to ten thousand times less than the old events. Less again would reach anything deep. I would not put a number on that yet.

(Kylian): — I would like to know whether they can feel it.

(Urs): — Inside? I cannot tell you from these stations.

(Sarah): — Where are you putting the source?

(Urs): — Up here, almost level with the ground. Within the error, it could be right on the surface. But look at the second stroke. I will put the first back so you can see both.

(Elise): — I get the same movement using Nut.

(Sarah): — How far can you move those clocks before the points meet?

(Urs): — Farther than the corrections in their logs. I will check the remaining six, but I used to pay crews to do this: make a noise, move, make another, read the echoes. It looks like seismic sounding. Water, rock worth drilling — I cannot tell you what they want from a trace.

(Kylian): — They are looking inside. Like the Bowl. Sound goes in through the Ear and something comes back through the Mouth.

(Urs): — Except you can carry the thing making the sound round to another place and ask again.

(Sarah): — Urs, finish the checks. Elise, stay on the live feeds.

[—]

(Paul): — Kylian, your plate is under that sheet.

(Kylian): — I have finished.

(Urs): — With the caviar too?

(Kylian): — Yes. You can have it.

(Urs): — Thank you.

(Paul): — We can go back to the road while they work.

(Kylian): — I skipped the fourth book to save time. What happens when the Outsiders find us. I suppose we have time for it now.

(Paul): — Yes. The machine is running.

(Kylian): — We recite it twice a year. The children learn it.

[—]

(Kylian): — The Book of the Cataclysm.

> *And the Outsiders multiplied in the open land, and their kings became many, and their cruelty became without number; and they remembered the Mountain in dreams, and hated the shade they could not find. And they gathered armies, and forged blades, and raised engines of war, and came with banners and drums and false prayers upon their tongues. And they said, Let us find the Mountain, and take the Oasis, and drink the waters thereof, and break the Temple, and make ourselves gods upon the Earth.*
>
> *And the Outsiders came unto the desert, and thirst came among them; yet they turned not back. And they drove the weak before them, and cast down the weary, and slew the beasts that bore them, and drank what was forbidden, and ate what was unclean; and the sun burned them by day, and the cold struck them by night, and still they came. And their drums were heard beyond the last trees, and the Oasis trembled in the shadow.*

[—]

(Elise): — Urs. Another one.

(Urs): — I have it.

(Elise): — Geb, Nut, then Atum.

(Urs): — Further towards Atum. Still at the surface.

(Sarah): — Send me that when you have checked it.

(Paul): — Sorry, Kylian. After the Oasis trembled.

(Kylian): — The Keepers.

> *And the Keepers stood before the Temple, and each brought forth the secret that had been given unto him. And the Keeper of Shield sealed the threshold, and closed the Mountain against the wrath to come. And the Keeper of Justice set the Key, and counted the Number, and took witness of the five, that no hand should move before the others. And the Keeper of Balance raised the deep waters and held them ready. And the Keeper of Faith spoke the Prayer in its appointed rhythm, and listened for the answer of stone. And the Keeper of Light danced the Dance of Light, and the hidden signs were revealed, and the way was made visible. And the five stood apart as one, and no one hand held the whole.*

[—]

(Elise): — Have you lost Atum too?

(Urs): — Mine has stopped.

(Elise): — Geb and Nut are still coming through. Atum has sent nothing since that last packet.

(Sarah): — Leave it. Do not send anything back yet.

(Kylian): — Are there people there?

(Elise): — Three.

(Sarah): — Ask the field office when they last spoke to them. Use the separate line, and have them hold any visit or delivery to Atum. I want to know whether the crew has been heard from somewhere else. Any call to the station comes through me first.

(Kylian): — They might need help.

(Sarah): — They might. We would be sending somebody towards whatever made them stop transmitting. I want to know who is near enough to help and which road they would have to take.

(Elise): — I will get the duty list as well.

(Sarah): — Ask for Amastan's line too. Urs, see what the receiving end kept. Whatever is still in Atum can wait.

(Urs): — There should be a buffer here. I will look.

[—]

(Kylian): — Is Elise coming back?

(Sarah): — As soon as she has an answer.

(Kylian): — I can wait.

(Sarah): — Give us the rest. She can hear the recording.

(Kylian): — You are still looking at the screen.

(Sarah): — I am listening.

> *And God remembered His word, and Hell answered. And the deep waters fell into the fire beneath, and the breath of Hell rose in the hidden chambers. And the Beast beneath the Mountain struck the roots of the Earth, and the ground broke beneath the feet of the Outsiders. And the prayer travelled through stone, and the weak places of the Earth answered; and the poisoned waters rose, and the volcanoes erupted, and fire came upon the left hand of the army, and the sea rose upon the right hand thereof; and the mountains shook, and the sky was made black with ash, and the Outsiders were burned, and drowned, and crushed, and scattered; and they tasted the cruelty which they had given unto the world.*

(Sarah): — The ash. Say that part again.

(Kylian): — And the sky was made black with ash.

(Sarah): — Does it say how long the sky stayed black, or how far the ash went?

(Kylian): — Those are all the words.

(Paul): — Let him finish, Sarah. I can play it again.

(Sarah): — All right. Forgive me.

And when the wrath had passed, the armies of the Outsiders were no more; but the forest was broken, and the open waters were spoiled, and the land around the Mountain became desert. And the people washed the ash from the fruit, and the fruit came apart in the water. And they wept for the world that had been saved and lost in the same hour. And God said unto them, Dwell no more in the open, but enter the Mountain, and keep the Temple, and remember the price of being seen. And the Temple was sealed, and the people went beneath the stone.

[—]

(Sarah): — We should look for that ash in the core surveys. Ice, lake beds. Sulphur carried high enough by an eruption can cool the climate.

(Kylian): — About eleven and a half thousand years since the count began.

(Sarah): — Urs, bring up the Greenland temperature plots in the survey catalogue.

(Urs): — Here. The end of the Younger Dryas. The warming is close to his date. A long cold spell before it. If I widen this — there is another cold interval further back. The recovery is a different shape.

(Paul): — Much of the Sahara used to be green. Lakes, grassland, trees along the water. We should look at the pollen records nearest the Mountain.

(Sarah): — Send me the reports for both cold intervals, and the Saharan lake cores. Any dated ash layers too. When you have finished with Atum. We need dates for the ground around the Mountain.

(Urs): — Sarah, I have the end of Atum's transmission. The source was coming towards its sector when it stopped. I need the other clocks and the terrain model before I can put it any closer. Give me an hour. If a feed is incomplete it will take longer.

(Sarah): — Work with Elise beside the drum, and keep it running separately. Those three come first. Bring me anything that changes; the finished report can follow.

(Urs): — I will leave the chocolate. You have barely touched it.

(Sarah): — Take some for her.

[—]

(Kylian): — Any word from Amastan?

(Sarah): — I am still waiting.

(Kylian): — I should go back.

(Sarah): — We may all have to. First I need what happened after they sent you out. Every person you met along that road.

(Paul): — We stopped at the bridge.

(Kylian): — I remember where we stopped.

(Paul): — I have to change the reel.

[—]

(Paul): — Whenever you are ready.

(Kylian): — We went back through the Labyrinth.

Chapter 16

Horizon

We went back up the Labyrinth together, the five Keepers, Va-Sheva and I, with Sa-Tavan following Justice. We had collected him in the circular room beyond the bridge, his tablet still wrapped against his chest. Ka-Elun sang at the divisions. On the steeper turns I put a hand against the wall and let the person ahead draw away before I followed.

At the carved prayer Ka-Elun raised her lamp. The stone opened onto the Hall of Prayers, and Ka-Raedin retrieved the lamp he had left there. Sa-Tavan went with Justice; the other Keepers took their own ways. I watched Ka-Raedin until the turn hid him. Va-Sheva waited beside me.

I had never seen the Mountain this empty. The doors along the gallery were shut, including the little service door people usually propped with a bread basket. Our feet sounded all the way to the next turn.

"May I pray before the Pendulum? One last time, please."

She looked down the gallery, then led me to the Hall of Ceremony.

The Pendulum passed beneath us. I knelt at the rail where I had knelt among hundreds of others and said the prayer my father had taught me. With each return the Beast's face caught the light. When I had finished, I stayed on my knees for another passage. Va-Sheva waited until I got up.

She took a lamp from its bracket by a service door on Shield's side of the Hall and led me down into the passage towards the second ridge. At a division

I recognised the slope leading towards the archive. The opening with Faith and Shield joined above it was there too. I stopped short of it.

Va-Sheva held the lamp farther along the passage. The door ahead bore three Shield seals, cut one over another, the oldest sunk deep into the stone. I had turned away from it on my first visit. She drew a long iron key from inside her belt, Shield's mark cut into its bow. She fitted it beneath the seals and turned it; bolts scraped back inside the stone. She recovered the key and pushed the door open far enough for us to pass.

Beyond it the passage widened into a room with four pillars on either side. Two stone benches faced each other across a low lamp-holder. High above them, a round hole in the roof held a few stars. The corridor continued beyond the opposite bench.

"Who sits here?" I asked.

"Ka-Xhian received the woman in your photograph here. His Veil stood behind those pillars."

I looked at the bench she indicated. Va-Sheva set the lamp in its holder and opened a wall cupboard. She brought out two packs, water skins and sand wraps. Before she let me put them on, she searched the folds of my robe, the stitching at my cuffs and the soles of my sandals. Ka-Raedin already held my Light token; her fingers checked its empty place.

"Nothing for your household?"

My mother's face came before me with the ordinary exactness of a meal-place: her thumb smoothing a cracked bowl, the small dark mark beside one nail. "Nothing."

Va-Sheva covered the white knot at my wrist with dark cloth, bound it with a cord and tied my belt again. I watched her fit Justice's packet inside her own pack.

"They are still counting?" I asked.

"The doors stay shut until you are out. Then they will be told you were seen entering the Labyrinth. Faith will send pilgrims to look for you."

"And on the fourth day."

"Yes."

She lifted the pack onto my shoulders. I pulled the straps even and followed her into the opposite corridor. Three sealed crossings stood along it, the mark of Shield joining the stone leaves at each. Beyond the last, the passage ran straight into darkness.

At its end she covered the lamp and knocked against the rock. The opening came slowly, bringing cold air across my face. A young man waited outside, his head and mouth wrapped against the cold.

"Amastan," Va-Sheva said.

He gave me a brief look, took the lamp from her and put it inside the opening. Then he helped her draw the stone shut.

Three camels knelt in a hollow below the entrance. Amastan tightened a strap, moved a water skin from one load to another and beckoned me to the smallest animal. I climbed on as he showed me. When it rose I pitched forward over its neck; Va-Sheva caught my pack and pushed me back into the saddle.

For a while I could see the Mountain whenever I turned. Then we went down between two ridges and I lost it. I twisted farther, trying to see over the rise, until the camel stumbled and I had to catch the saddle. Amastan clicked his tongue and led us on.

We travelled at night. By the first dawn I could scarcely close my knees. Under an overhang Amastan spread a desert-coloured cloth across the opening and pinned it with stones; I lay down before he had finished. At dusk Va-Sheva woke me with a water skin against my cheek. The next night an engine passed beyond a ridge. Amastan led the animals into a hollow and we waited there until he was willing to move.

Before the third dawn we reached a dry well, its lip cracked and its rope gone. A dead thorn tree leaned over fallen stones. Amastan unloaded the camels and took them round the ridge to feed. Va-Sheva sat against the well and loosened the wrapping at her neck. I lowered myself beside her, slowly enough to spare my knees.

"I made you stand against your own Keeper."

"Kay, I sat where the sequence required me and scarcely spoke. He has heard me disagree before. We both put the Mountain's safety first. I will survive this."

For a while we watched the light grow along the ridge. She had folded her wraps beneath her head and closed her eyes. I moved a stone that was pressing into my leg.

"Will I see you again?"

"Your reports come through me."

"That is not what I asked."

She opened her eyes. "I have to get you to them first."

"You chose to bring me yourself."

"Kay. You were entrusted to me."

"I wanted you to choose me."

She pulled the wraps from behind her head and began folding them. I waited for her to answer. Before she had finished, an engine sounded beyond the ridge. She got up with the cloth still in her hands.

The Toyota came over the rise slowly, large tyres working through the loose stones. Two people sat behind its glass. The man beside the driver saw Va-Sheva and raised a hand. She raised hers before the vehicle had stopped.

"Jean-Charles," she said.

He climbed out, a sun-lined man in close-fitting clothes, with a short blade at his belt and a row of closed pockets down his coat. Va-Sheva dropped her wraps and ran past me. She jumped into his arms, locked her legs round his waist and kissed him, her hands behind his head. He caught her under the thighs and stumbled back against the vehicle. She was laughing when she drew away to look at him; he tried to speak, and she kissed him again.

I went back to the well for her wraps. I would not ask her to choose me again.

When he set her down, she kept a palm flat against his chest. He covered it with his own and held it there before reaching into a pocket for a bright, flat box tied with pink ribbon.

"Pistachio and rose. They travelled badly. Eat them tonight or they die."

Va-Sheva took it with both hands. The driver's door opened, and she put the box inside her coat. I held out her wraps. She took them without looking at me.

The woman who stepped out had short pale hair and a grey jacket without an office sign. A narrow cord disappeared into her collar. Va-Sheva called her Va-Elise. They spoke together beside the vehicle while Jean-Charles loaded our packs.

I went towards the camels. Jean-Charles caught my shoulder with his right hand and turned me back towards the vehicle.

"With us. Leave the animals to him."

He spoke my language with unfamiliar stresses. His hand was gone before I had decided whether to resist it. Va-Sheva came to me, loosened the dark cord at my wrist and drew it away without disturbing the cloth over the white knot. She laid it on Justice's sealed packet and handed both to Va-Elise, who put them in her bag.

"Get in," Va-Elise said. "I will show you the belt."

From the back seat I could see Va-Sheva in the little mirror on the door. She had taken Jean-Charles a few paces away. I heard the engine and Va-Elise moving things beside me; their words did not reach the vehicle.

Va-Sheva caught his hand as he began to speak and brought it low against her belly. She held it there, looking into his face, then nodded. He stared at her. His mouth opened into a smile so sudden that she laughed and caught his other hand. He bent to kiss her; she met him, then drew back and looked towards the ridge beyond which lay the Mountain.

She turned her hand in his, showing the black line of Seal dye. His smile faltered. For a moment he kept both hands closed around hers. She said something else, and when he answered she put a finger against his lips. He kissed it. She was crying now, still smiling, wiping her cheek with the hand he had released.

"What has he said to her?" I asked.

Va-Elise leaned across me and drew the belt out. "Lift your arm."

I did, and lost the mirror behind her shoulder. By the time she had fastened it, Va-Sheva was walking towards Amastan. Va-Elise returned to the wheel. Jean-Charles watched Va-Sheva go, then took the front passenger seat. I moved closer to the opposite side of the seat.

"You are safer than you feel," he said.

The engine deepened. In the mirror I watched Amastan hold a camel steady for her. She turned once towards the vehicle, but we were moving by then and I could not see her face.

(Paul): — Kylian. When she put his hand against her belly. Was she telling him she was pregnant?

(Kylian): — What?

(Sarah): — From what you have described, I think so.

(Kylian): — Pregnant? With him?

[—]

(Kylian): — It can't be. It can't.

(Paul): — Kylian, put the glass down.

(Kylian): — It's IMPOSSIBLE!

[—]

(Kylian): — HE CAN'T BE!

[—]

(Sarah): — The Real is the impossible?

(Paul): — Mrs Blackwood, this is not the time for Light philosophy.

(Sarah): — Leave it, Paul! You will cut yourself.

(Paul): — It's fine. Let's just wait for him to come back.

[—]

(Urs): — The fuck is going on here?

(Paul): — Urs, please, NOT NOW!

(Urs): — Where's *Lord Lucan*?

(Sarah): — Bathroom. Turns out that his beloved Veil of Shield has been a naughty girl with one of our agents. Urs, whatever you are about to tell him next. Don't.

[—]

(Kylian): — *What is the fucking point!*

(Paul): — Urs, did you teach him that?

(Urs): — Oh, that's when the printer and I had a falling out.

(Kylian): — I'll try your Cognac now.

(Paul): — Was that the last time you saw her?

(Sarah): — Paul, give him a minute.

(Urs): — Would you like some ice with it? Oh, straight from the bottle. Nice one. My hidden friend, don't cry over pussy.

(Sarah): — Urs, LANGUAGE!

(Urs): — Apologies. Mrs Blackwood, may I take Kylian off-property for a grief session at the *Aphrodite Club*? Courtesy of the oil desk. We have a membership card.

(Sarah): — Very funny. Back to the drums, Urs.

[—]

(Kylian): — God is a point, Eden a circle, Eve an arrow pointing out. Like the murderer and the daughter of Faith. Like Helen.

(Paul): — And you *Menelaus*?

(Kylian): — No. I … I am an idiot. Let's just carry on.

An hour after the well, Jean-Charles raised a black instrument to his eye and adjusted it with his thumb.

"One vehicle. About three kilometres. Coming towards us."

"Shit. Who the fuck is that?" Va-Elise asked.

He watched a little longer. "Stop the car."

The Toyota stopped so hard that the belt caught me across the chest and drove into my shoulder. I gripped it, trying to pull enough slack to breathe.

"If there's one in front, there may be another behind us. Turn round."

Va-Elise swung the Toyota across the flat. Jean-Charles reached down beside his seat and brought a long case across his knees. As he opened it, she pointed through the front glass.

"There. Dust."

A pale column rose ahead of us, on the ground we had just crossed. Behind us, the first vehicle was now gaining on us. A man stood in its open back with his hands on a mounted gun.

Jean-Charles took a rifle with a glass tube above it from the case. He passed me two padded cups joined by a band and touched his ears. I pulled them over mine. Something struck the rear door with a hard metallic crack.

He turned on the passenger seat, one knee pressed into its cushion, and brought the rifle past my face. "Careful. This will be loud."

The shot broke the glass behind us. I flinched as wind struck the back of my head. Jean-Charles caught my upper arm and settled the rifle across my shoulder.

"Stay still. Breathe in, then hold it when I say now."

I drew air in. His cheek was close to mine.

"Now."

The rifle jolted against my shoulder. I held my breath until he squeezed my arm and told me I could let it out. Twice more he said "Now", and twice more I held still while he fired. Va-Elise kept her eyes ahead.

He lifted the rifle from my shoulder and watched through its glass. "All three dead. Turn round."

The belt pulled across the sore place as Va-Elise turned us back. Through the broken window I saw the second vehicle veer away across the flat. Its dust grew fainter.

We passed the first vehicle on our way back along our original track. It stood crooked on its wheels. Two heads hung forward in the cab; a third man lay across the open back beneath the gun. A red band circled his head wrap. His jacket and trousers were different colours of camouflage.

"Who were they?" I asked.

Jean-Charles lowered the rifle across his knees. "Kidnappers."

"For whom?"

"Whoever pays. *Daesh* buys captives across the border."

Glass had gathered in my lap. I tried to brush it away and he caught my wrist.

"Leave it. Are you hurt?"

I shook my head. He took off the padded cups. My ears rang, and blood was running from one knuckle.

We drove until the sun was high. At a halt Jean-Charles shook out my robe and bound my hand while Va-Elise watched the empty ground behind us. He tightened the dressing and waited for me to get back in. Va-Elise drove on.

By late afternoon we reached a road lined with houses. People stood in their doorways. A man pushed a wheeled bin past our window and never looked up. I turned to watch him until the vehicle carried us round a corner.

Va-Elise drove through a metal gate into a yard. Jean-Charles closed it behind us and began clearing the broken glass while she let me into the house, locked the door and put her bag on a table. The lights were small glass bulbs fixed to the wall. I held my palm near one while she went through the cupboards for clothes.

"You can look later," she said. "Wash first."

They gave me water in a room where I could close the door. I washed the dust from my face and arms. It gathered in the bottom of the basin; when Jean-Charles showed me the release, it went away through a hole too small for my smallest finger.

The shirt closed with discs pushed through slits in the cloth. I missed one and had to undo the others to put the edges level. The trousers showed each leg separately. I turned twice before the metal wall, searching the folded things for an outer wrapping.

When I returned, Jean-Charles pulled the back of my collar free where I had folded it under. Va-Elise handed me a pair of spectacles.

"My sight is good."

"The lenses are clear. We want people to remember an ordinary young man with glasses."

She sat me in front of a camera, then took the spectacles off again. On the table were a telephone, a world map spread wider than my arms and a passport waiting for my image.

"Outside, your name is Kylian. Say it."

I said it. She corrected the sound, took the picture and wrote the name in the outside hand. I copied the letters until she covered her version and I could make them without it.

I put down the pen. Va-Elise was putting the photograph against the passport. She gave me back the spectacles when she had finished, then named the places on the map: Switzerland, Geneva, Saanen. I followed her finger across the printed water.

"Someone may take this from you and look at your face," she said, closing the passport. "Let him. Stay beside me. If he speaks, wait for me to answer."

Jean-Charles lifted the lid from a dish of chicken, its skin browned and shining with spice. Steam rose from yellow rice heaped with soft onions. Va-Elise spooned the cooking juices over my plate; beside her waited a tray of small pastries glossy with honey, their ends packed with crushed almonds.

Jean-Charles took his glass and raised it a little.

"Measured. Witnessed" he said, grinning.

Va-Elise looked at him. "Do not."

"Sorry bad joke" he added, and set it down. "We don't make a ceremony of supper, so eat while it's hot."

I laughed, and had to put down my glass. Va-Elise shook her head and went on serving.

"You did well in the car," he said. "Kept your head. You're safe now."

The skin cracked between my teeth. Beneath it the meat came away wet with lemon and the juices that had soaked into the rice. I ate until Va-Elise reached for my plate, then held it out for more. Jean-Charles was still on his first helping.

He pushed the pastries towards me. Honey ran over my thumb when I bit into one; the thin layers broke against my lips, releasing the almonds. I licked my thumb and picked up the flakes from my plate.

After the meal Va-Elise cleared a place beside my glass and set a book there. "We were told you might enjoy this. It's about how people out here have studied light."

I cleaned the honey from my fingers. The cover showed a beam bending through a block of glass. I followed its passage with my finger. Below the title, a strip of paper bore the words in careful Mountain hand.

Light — David Burnie.

I read the title twice. I could feel myself grinning, and then my eyes filled. Va-Elise waited while I wiped them on my sleeve.

"Thank you," I said.

I opened it at the beginning. Thin sheets of handwriting had been bound between its printed pages. There were photographs of objects with their names and descriptions. I recognised the candle and the mirror, and lingered over instruments with polished tubes and small wheels. Each label had its translation.

"You translated all of it?"

"The whole book. We kept the English beside it. Your tutor will help you with that."

I began with *Light, myth, and magic*. The opening paragraph asked what would happen if the sun failed to rise: water would freeze, plants and animals

would die. I read on to its assurance that this could not happen, then turned the page.

On the next spread, Prometheus carried fire down from the mountain where the gods lived. The caption said he had stolen it for men. I read the paragraph again.

> (Kylian): — Do you remember when we spoke of *aletheia*? "Then a god gives men fire whole, undivided and in every hand, and is chained to a rock, where a bird opens his liver each day."
>
> (Paul): — Prometheus.
>
> (Kylian): — This was where I first read his name. The tutor told me the rest later.

I took a loose thread from the edge of my cuff and laid it beneath his name. "May I take it with me?"

"It's yours, Kylian."

Va-Elise took the telephone into the next room and shut the door. Jean-Charles sat opposite me and asked about the road out of the Mountain. He wanted the marks on the door I had left unopened, the soundless room's position beside it, whether the Mountain had stayed under seal until I was out. I answered with the book on my knees. He waited when I stopped, then asked about the next crossing.

Near the end he said, "No need to trouble Elise with any of that. She writes everything down, and a man should keep some of his own weather."

I nodded and kept my hand on the book. When Va-Elise returned, I carried it to bed myself and lay down with my shoes still on. She woke me before it was light again. The Toyota had a new rear window. Va-Elise took the wheel; Jean-Charles sat beside her.

At the airfield Va-Elise handed papers through a small window. A man came out and opened a gate; our vehicle stopped beside a white aircraft with a gold cross dividing green and black on its tail.

"Jamaican diplomatic flight," Va-Elise said. "To Geneva. Stay with me."

The captain came down the steps to meet us, a lean, dark-skinned man with his hair tied high behind his head and gold bars on the shoulders of his white shirt. He shook Jean-Charles's hand and kept it while they laughed. Then he offered me his.

"Capt'n Billy."

I gave him the name Va-Elise had told me to use. He repeated it while Jean-Charles lifted our bags from the vehicle and handed them to one of the crew.

"Back to the desert for me," Jean-Charles said. "Stay with Elise."

He got behind the wheel. Billy led Va-Elise and me up the steps; from the top I watched the vehicle turn towards the gate. Wide leather seats faced one another across a table. Va-Elise put her papers on it. Billy rested a hand on the back of my seat while she translated between us, his English into Mountain speech, my answers back to him.

"Next time you come to Jamaica. You wanna go snorkelling? You wanna eat lobster? You wanna smoke weed? You can do all dees tings. Just let Capt'n Billy know."

Va-Elise repeated the English slowly before giving me each part. I asked what snorkelling was. She put two fingers beside her eyes, pointed downward and said that I could breathe while I looked under the sea. Billy watched the demonstration and nodded.

Va-Elise looked up from her papers. "Geneva first, Billy."

"Yes, ma'am." He pulled once on my fastened belt, then went forward to the other pilot and shut the door.

The floor tilted beneath my feet; pressure closed my ears. The earth withdrew below the window.

"Do not look down until I say," Va-Elise told me.

I watched the fastener of my belt. A loose end of the strap lifted each time I breathed. When I looked up, the line of land beyond her shoulder lay far below us. Water reached from it to the edge of the window. She put her papers down and talked while I kept my eyes on her.

Somewhere over that water Va-Elise put a cup beside my hand and returned to her papers. I waited for the drink to spill. Its surface trembled, settled, and stayed almost level while the land passed slowly below us. I drank without taking my eyes from the rim. After a while I put the cup down and let go of the seat.

I opened the book at the thread and asked Va-Elise to read the English beneath Prometheus. She read it slowly, then again as I followed the printed words with my finger.

The next chapter was *Shadows*. A caption about an eclipse named Jamaica. Opposite, beside a shadow theatre, I found a portrait and asked her the man's name.

"Johannes Kepler."

She read me the short account of his work on light and shadows. I asked her to say his name again.

"Is Jamaica across this sea?" I asked.

"Across the Atlantic. Much farther."

She took out her telephone and showed me a photograph of a small boat in clear blue water. I could see its shadow on the sand beneath it.

"Could we go there?"

"Geneva first, Kylian."

She left the picture open beside my book.

At Geneva a vehicle met us beside the aircraft and took us to a helicopter. "The family's," Va-Elise said. She held my sleeve against its beating wind until I reached the door.

From it I saw mountains with roads cut across their faces, houses standing on the slopes and water gathered between them. Church towers rose above the roofs. A boat crossed the lake below us, leaving two lines that spread until I could no longer distinguish them. We landed on a helipad beside this house above the water. The air smelled of pine, metal and bread.

(Kylian): — That's it, everything from there onwards you already know.

Chapter 17

Mock

(Sarah): — The other six stations, Urs?

(Urs): — Confirm it. Seismic sounding. I have checked the clocks and the terrain model. The second reader worked separately and returned the same surface positions.

(Sarah): — Put them on the map.

(Urs): — More than twenty usable fixes since this started. Eleven minutes apart, all afternoon. The stations receive each stroke at different times; with this many around the source, I can place it from several combinations and check one against another. These are the positions in time order.

(Kylian): — It goes back on itself.

(Urs): — Turns at the end of a line and works along the next. Those last points take it east, towards Atum's sector.

(Kylian): — Have you heard from the three people?

(Urs): — Nothing. We recovered the end of Atum's transmission here. The other stations give us the track after that.

(Kylian): — Could the other stations help?

(Urs): — They do not talk to one another or have each other's locations. Each cell reports here on its own line. We have put the others on hold: doors closed, no visitors without direct clearance.

(Sarah): — Amastan's line?

(Urs): — One of his people has answered. He can carry a message.

(Sarah): — Use that line. I will give the location myself. Ask what his people have seen. Nobody is to enter Atum. And send Alice the coordinates of the survey. I want the latest satellite coverage and whatever she can pull from the archive. Wider than the track. Include the roads into it.

(Urs): — How far back?

(Sarah): — A month to start. Keep the dates on everything.

(Kylian): — Could this loose the Beast?

(Sarah): — A surface survey cannot do the work of your buried engine. It can help them find it.

(Kylian): — By what comes back through the Mouth.

(Sarah): — Yes. And they can move round it, take another return and narrow down where it is. I want to see what they have brought to dig with.

[—]

(Urs): — Alice has sent the first images. The newest is radar, less than an hour old. This one is an optical image from this morning. Better detail, but the vehicles will have moved.

(Sarah): — Put our track over the new one.

(Urs): — Here. Four heavy vehicles on that cleared strip. The final fixes run along it.

(Sarah): — There they are. Vibrator trucks. Nomad 90s, by the look of them. And beside the camp, a drilling rig.

(Paul): — Can we see this moving?

(Urs): — These are separate passes. I have asked for the next one. We can compare what has changed between them.

(Sarah): — Go back to this morning. Widen it.

(Kylian): — Those are the folds. The second ridge is above them. All that white below it?

(Urs): — Tents. I will enlarge that part.

(Sarah): — Keep the whole site beside it. Paul, this outer camp has the parked lorries and the storage rows. There is a cleared road from it to the rig. Across the wash, another enclosure.

(Paul): — More tents.

(Urs): — Alice marks that one as accommodation, probably. There are vehicles dug into the ridges above both. She has picked out positions round the other side too.

(Kylian): — Round the Mountain?

(Urs): — Round the part we can see. She reads it as a military perimeter. The access gaps are covered.

(Sarah): — How old is the first image with a camp?

(Urs): — The second of April. Yesterday. The first lorries and two rows of tents beside the southern track. The previous image is from the evening of the first. Bare ground.

(Paul): — Montel collected the recording on Monday. The thirtieth of March.

(Sarah): — Three days before those vehicles appear. And the rig?

(Urs): — Still on its transporter yesterday. This morning it is on the pad, with the second enclosure beside it. More lorries at the road junction. They have been unloading through the night.

(Paul): — Deliveries?

(Urs): — Probably. I can show you where they stood on each date. I cannot follow them between the images.

(Sarah): — Fuel, water, drilling pipe. Men to move it, men to guard them. Expand the southern road.

(Urs): — Another stopping place here. Vehicles on both sides. Alice has marked a possible checkpoint.

(Kylian): — All this since yesterday?

(Sarah): — The camp. They had three days to bring the first loads here. I would look for trucks and a rig already in the region. Alice can work back along that road. Urs, get me the field reports for those dates.

(Paul): — A survey could account for the trucks and rig. Could it account for all the rest?

(Sarah): — With an armed escort, yes. But this escort has positions all round the ground they want to enter, and supplies enough to stay. Somebody has paid to bring the survey, the drilling and the soldiers together. This is a government-sized operation.

(Urs): — The western edge is clearer in this morning's optical pass. Shall I put that up?

(Sarah): — Put the shot positions back over it.

(Paul): — What is it?

(Sarah): — Those steps where the blocks join. Urs, find the salt survey from twenty-three years ago. The original field plan, in Horizon.

(Paul): — You recognise it?

(Sarah): — Perhaps. We had to cut a damaged section out of a receiver cable on that job. That left it short, with fewer pickup points. I moved some of the shot positions round the gap so we could finish with the equipment we had. We kept using the layout after replacing the cable. It gave good results.

[—]

(Urs): — I have the plan. I have aligned the main rows. Both joins we have covered fit it, within the error of our positions.

(Sarah): — Yes. The same unequal steps. I taught four men to work from that layout. The results were published; the field plans stayed in Horizon. Somebody has those plans, or learnt from one of my crews.

(Paul): — France?

(Sarah): — Montel receives Kylian's lessons. Now somebody is using my private survey method behind a military perimeter. France is where I would start.

(Paul): — It need not be the same channel.

(Sarah): — No. The camera cannot teach a survey I made twenty-three years ago. If the two collections meet, they have what he knows of the inside and what my instruments found from outside. Urs, have Alice keep the roads under review. I want the next pass beside these as soon as it arrives.

(Kylian): — Was Jean-Charles supposed to ask me all that at the safe house?

(Sarah): — Elise had Justice's packet. Those questions should have gone through her.

(Kylian): — He told me not to trouble her.

(Paul): — You agreed.

(Kylian): — He had kept me alive in the car. By supper he was straightening my collar for me. When he asked about the Mountain, there was something I could do for him. I wanted him to ask again.

(Sarah): — He did help you. We do not have to erase that to examine the questions.

(Kylian): — I still had the book on my knees. He waited when I stopped. He did not make me give him any of it.

(Paul): — That is worth keeping. So are the questions he chose while Elise was elsewhere. Will you give him the route?

(Sarah): — A leg at a time. Urs opens the transport. Elise divides the route. Jean-Charles receives the ground he needs when he needs it. He gets no station register or call signs. I have no better field operator, and I have no proved traitor. I can withhold a page from either.

(Paul): — You could ask him why he kept Elise out of it.

(Sarah): — And receive an explanation I cannot check before we leave. I will have Elise check the old access lists against the names attached to those field sheets.

(Kylian): — Do they know what an answer can become?

(Sarah): — I would pay to know that. My Scottish father's Auld Alliance meant uranium for France. My English half appears to be fighting France now.

(Paul): — You are still deciding how much each of us is allowed to know.

(Sarah): — You have questioned the man I trust to take us through a desert. I have heard you. I am changing what he is given. Put that on the same record as my appetite for the Mountain. I shall not ask you to rub either out.

(Urs): — Another stroke, Madame.

(Sarah): — Have someone keep the sheets. Wake the parts of Horizon that never touched Martinez. Open the routes into that quarter the camp does not know it controls. Close the old roads behind us where we can. You ran them against smugglers, Urs. Use them against men carrying my maps.

[—]

(Paul): — Kylian. Before we follow those orders. She has told us she wants the thing beneath your Mountain in her own keeping.

(Kylian): — I heard her say she was the one hand.

(Paul): — She has not withdrawn that claim.

(Kylian): — Ask her to withdraw it and she will say a few words for you. Will that change whose aircraft we need? She wants the soldiers gone. I want them gone. My council meant nothing but good when it erased me. Sarah has bad reasons for taking the road I need. I will go with her and watch what she reaches for when we arrive.

(Paul): — That may be sound judgment. It may also be how she recruits everybody.

(Sarah): — Urs, tell Jean-Charles to have the vehicles ready at the strip. Elise gives him the tactical packet on the ground.

(Elise): — Kylian. Are you coming with us?

(Kylian): — I am going back.

(Elise): — They let you leave once. That does not give you permission to return.

(Kylian): — I asked them to send me to find the enemy within. The five decreed it; Va-Sheva is the ear I report to. At that Threshold I can name the errand before they decide what to do with the man carrying it.

(Paul): — The distance was meant to keep you from bringing the danger back.

(Kylian): — It is already there. Five Keepers behind five walls, keeping their part from one another, while an army draws the rooms under their feet. I have findings.

(Elise): — Findings do not stop a blade.

(Kylian): — No. Get me to the Threshold. I will answer for coming back.

(Sarah): — I need to know whether you can do this, Kailan. We cannot carry you up to the seam and then turn back.

(Kylian): — I can.

(Paul): — A little while ago you could scarcely speak of her.

[—]

(Kylian): — She is still there.

(Paul): — Yes.

(Kylian): — Nothing I have just learnt moved her outside the Mountain. I keep seeing her with him at the well. I cannot make that stop. But I can see where those machines stand, too. I cannot stay beside this lake and let them reach her without warning.

(Paul): — You need not say more.

(Kylian): — I want her alive, Paul. Let that be enough to get me to the door.

(Sarah): — Then we leave for Geneva at dusk. Urs has less than an hour. I can put us through the outer chain. At the inner seam I need you.

(Paul): — Take me with you. Kylian, you said you would try.

(Kylian): — I remember.

(Paul): — I want to see that coffin. If it is Egyptian, I want to know how it got there. I could walk into a workshop and ask what they are making. Somebody could actually answer me.

(Sarah): — Elise, a place for Mr Morgan.

(Paul): — Thank you. Box the reels. Not this one yet. I need the travelling machine running before this stops.

(Sarah): — You have it?

(Paul): — Running. Elise, will you take this interview reel when I stop it? Keep it with the sealed interviews and my notebooks, please.

(Elise): — I will. The instruction reels go in the fire case. They keep their own boxes.

(Paul): — I am stopping the fixed machine now. The travelling machine continues.

[—]

(Elise): — These are your travel papers. Keep your own sets in this order. The first name takes the helicopter from here. The second goes on the private aircraft's manifest. The third starts at the vehicle chain. Learn them on the way; answer to the name on the page you are carrying.

(Kylian): — And if they ask me something I do not understand?

(Elise): — Wait for me.

(Kylian): — As before.

(Elise): — Yes.

(Sarah): — The chain, Elise.

(Elise): — Helicopter from the lawn to Geneva. Private aircraft to a prepared strip, where Jean-Charles meets us. Vehicles south, animals from the folds. Amastan's line meets us there, or what remains of it. None of the separate bookings should give a clerk much to remember.

(Kylian): — Who has them all?

(Elise): — I have their order and your identities. Urs opened the aircraft, fuel and vehicles without the final ground. Each air crew knows its own leg. The vehicle lead gets his road when the aircraft lands. Amastan's line has the last ground and none of the air. Jean-Charles gets his tactical packet when we leave the final vehicle. Sarah knows where the pieces meet. There is no page with the whole journey on it.

(Paul): — And if one hand fails to meet the next?

(Elise): — We do not improvise a replacement identity in front of a border officer. Stay beside me. At the folds it will be Amastan's people you obey, however familiar the ground looks to you, Kylian. You came out once. They have to go on living there.

(Paul): — You have given me no papers for the recorder.

(Elise): — Madame's medical instrument until the vehicles. The manifest says so. After that, on your body. Keep it with you if a man offers to carry it.

(Paul): — And the fire case?

(Elise): — It comes with us, sealed, with one copy of the route papers. If anyone enters the house after we leave, the archive room burns separately. Your interview reels keep their own seals. Nothing is being put back into the instruction archive.

(Paul): — How much of this was ready before the alarm?

(Elise): — The way out of a compromised house. I did not have the destination. Please learn the first name before you reach the pilot.

(Sarah): — Time?

(Elise): — The helicopter is nearly ready. After that we require air permission, fuel, roads, and the routes still to belong to you.

(Paul): — I had hoped at least the roads were certain.

(Elise): — So had I. One small bag each. Only essentials. Pack for very hot days and very cold nights, and wear shoes you can walk in.

(Sarah): — That is settled. Urs, come and help me pack.

(Urs): — Yes, Madame. I will bring your medicines.

(Kylian): — Paul. I know we are in a rush, but this is important. Come back to the tree with me. Bring the machine.

(Paul): — All right.

[—]

(Kylian): — Last time we stood here I put the needle away. I want you to have the mark before we leave. Without it, I have very little hope of getting you admitted to the Mountain. You will need it for a sealed hearing, and even then the Keepers can refuse you.

(Paul): — The needle and stone?

(Kylian): — Yes. The rite spends the stone. What I carry is the last that ever left the Mountain: one hand, one setting. After you there is no other. That is why a Veil's mark was holy. It cannot be multiplied like words on your paper.

(Paul): — Then use it.

(Kylian): — Sarah and I carry ours. There should be a third hand that belongs to neither of us. You would witness what we do, and stop either of us.

(Paul): — Shadow.

(Kylian): — You watched the house on a captive's word. You found the eye and did not pull the cord. I have no completed office to hand you, Paul. Only the charges, and the mark. Kneel. Hear the charges. There is no book to hold them but you.

> *By the dark the first morning left unlit:*
> *I call on you to guard the Mountain from the enemy within.*
> *By the Proud who gathered the whole into one hand, and was stabbed for it:*
> *I call on you never to seek the whole.*
> *By God, who held His breath while the first Light was struck:*
> *I call on you to carry this to your grave, and give it up to no pain past it.*
> *And by the Beast beneath the Mountain, keeper of the first wrath and the next:*
> *for Shadow must guard also from Shadow:*
> *if ever I am the hand that reaches for the whole,*
> *be the hand that ends me.*

(Kylian): — And now the covenant. Answer me true. One day they will take you and open you. What will they find?

(Paul): — ...

(Kylian): — Stop smiling. This is no joke.

(Paul): — Of course. Very serious indeed.

(Kylian): — One day they will take you and open you. What will they find?

(Paul): — My face. And nothing behind it.

(Kylian): — Give me your free hand. Hold still. I have waited a long time for a use for this needle.

(Paul): — You need not enjoy it quite so much.

(Kylian): — I am trying to keep it straight.

[—]

(Kylian): — Your blood on the stone. Then it is sworn.

blood enters service;
the face enters the dark;
the name enters silence.

(Kylian): — Rise now as Va-Paul, Veil of Shadow: a name you will hear once, keep to your last hour, and never say aloud; for in Shadow we speak neither prefix nor suffix.

[—]

(Paul): — Is that all?

(Kylian): — It will heal to a mark no untrained eye can read. The stone has done its work. Give me a moment to wrap your hand.

(Paul): — I need both hands for the machine.

(Kylian): — Then keep it. I will work round you. There. How do you feel?

(Paul): — … This is the moment I am meant to say a deep and meaningful thing. … Unlit?

Chapter 18

Return

Mountain - inside the Greater Seal

In Noxius

(Paul): — I need your account of the hearing. The sealed chamber, the five, the ruling. Will you begin with where you stood?

(Kailan): — No. Put the thing away. It fell three days since. It is falling still, Paul, on people who never heard our names. Who is left above to read how carefully we decided?

(Paul): — I cannot answer that. The reel keeps what the five said. It does not keep what you could see from the wall.

(Kailan): — You were in the room. Your machine ran the whole while. Ask the Keepers. Ask Sarah, ask Va-Sheva — they spoke. I stood with my hands bound and said almost nothing.

(Paul): — Va-Sheva refuses me; Sarah turns away; the Keepers are turning air and counting fish. I have asked them. At present I have my account, and I was occupied with the machine for much of it.

(Kailan): — I have a shift on the vents. Before it, I need to lie still. There is nothing in me to give you.

[—]

> (Paul): — Then leave the hearing. The road from Blackwood. Could you give me that?
>
> (Kailan): — … You kept the record. Give them the road yourself. I will take it up inside the Mountain. Paul. Let me rest.

I am Paul Morgan. This is my account of the return. My training is in strata, middens, worked flint and bone laid down in silt forty thousand years ago. The dates and intervals here come from the reel boxes and my notebooks. Where I stopped recording, I have used my memory; where I could not understand a speaker, I name the person who supplied the words.

At dusk I came down the steps of Blackwood with a coat, my notebooks and the travelling recorder. The dressing Kailan had put round my right hand caught under the carrying strap. I stopped to free it, and Va-Elise came back for me. The helicopter was turning. Behind her, doors I had never seen open admitted men carrying cases into the halls. Every window was lit.

At the house steps a man tried to give Sarah three files. She chose one and sent the other two back. Another asked what should become of the instruction rooms.

"Lock them. The instruction reels stay in Elise's fire case. Nothing else leaves except Mr Morgan's sealed interview reels and notebooks."

"The telephones?"

"Let them ring."

The travelling tape reached its clear leader before we boarded. I wrote the hour on the box, sealed the reel in its tin and gave it to Va-Elise. She set it with the sealed interviews, separate from the instruction boxes inside the fire case. The single route packet lay above them. I fitted the fresh spool she gave me while a crewman loaded Sarah's chair. Kailan stood beside the door until Sarah was aboard.

The house door remained open. A sheet of paper crossed the lawn, rose into the rotor wind and vanished over the roof.

The helicopter lifted in a lurch that put my stomach through my boots. For two years I had walked across the landing marks without seeing their whole outline. Sarah, ninety-three, spent the flight on a headset, making clipped calls in three languages. Her right thumb shook against the mouthpiece until she closed it beneath her left hand. She asked why the private aircraft was still on the ground, listened, and gave someone a number of minutes in which to correct that.

The headset passed to Va-Elise. I could hear her confirming fuel and vehicles; she used numbers for the places. Sarah took it back and called the outer stations separately. Two calls ended with a spoken acknowledgment. During the third she repeated a number, waited and wrote a small cross beside it. She began the

fourth with her pencil still against the page. I could not hear the replies through her earpiece.

Kailan sat opposite me. I kept the machine between my boots with its carrying strap around my wrist. Each time the helicopter banked, I drew it back against my ankles. Through the recorder's headset I heard our breath under the engine, Sarah's numbers, and the fire case's buckle tapping against Va-Elise's wrist. She put a finger between buckle and case. The tapping stopped.

The helicopter put us down at Geneva beside the private aircraft. We waited in an old freight hangar. When the clearance lamp turned green, Urs remained behind the red line and we boarded. I had flown to digs in the cargo netting of transports older than myself and had never entered such a cabin. There were beds and a shower. Food arrived through a door I failed to notice, and I ate all of it. Kailan touched nothing. He watched the window. Sarah ate half a piece of toast and slept upright. Once she opened her eyes. "Finish your meal, Mr Morgan. I do not know when any of us will eat properly again." Then she shut them again.

Va-Elise worked at the table with three maps that did not join. On the first she marked the aircraft's descent. On the second she marked the road the vehicles were to take. The third began where the road failed and contained no destination, only wells and strips of stone. I asked which of the wells still answered to Horizon. Va-Elise put her finger beside one.

"We meet Amastan here. He tells us which wells we can use."

"And if he does not come?" I asked.

Sarah opened her eyes. "Keep them under cover. Nobody goes looking. If Amastan cannot reach his own meeting place, we have no safe road past it. Keep enough fuel to take the drivers back."

Va-Elise wrote below the map and folded the three separately. I lay down. Kailan was already asleep. We flew through the night; I woke as we began our descent.

At dawn we came down onto old colonial tarmac. Lamps stood in jars along the broken edge; a broom lay beside the last jar. Beyond them were a windsock, two fuel drums and three black armoured vehicles with their engines turning. Jean-Charles came from the middle vehicle to meet us. Kailan spoke his name and raised a hand. Va-Elise gave each driver his map and made him repeat one road and one stopping place. None was asked to name the destination.

Men in work clothes unloaded water, cloth, medical cases and sacks of feed. Weapons came last. Jean-Charles opened a long case across a quiet man's knees, inspected what lay inside and closed it without removing anything.

Sarah refused the chair. She descended the aircraft steps with Kailan one pace below her and Va-Elise behind, and stood at the bottom until her breathing settled. Then she asked the drivers whether anyone had approached the strip. One had seen lights beyond the pan. Another had heard an engine and no aircraft. She assigned the first report to the lead vehicle and the second to the rear.

Va-Elise took the lead. Jean-Charles rode beside our driver in the middle vehicle; Sarah, Kailan and I were strapped behind him, with the quiet man and his cased weapon in the rear seat. The third held our tail. Before we moved, Va-Elise passed the fire case through our window and Kailan braced it between his boots.

The sun cleared the horizon as we left the tarmac. Jean-Charles used no map. At each fork he waited for Va-Elise's rear lamp to show once and disappear. The driver spoke only to repeat a distance. Sarah held the station book closed on her knees.

They ran a straight strip of tar across the pan at a speed that shook speech out of us. A knot of vehicles appeared far to the east. Va-Elise's rear lamps showed. Jean-Charles turned in his seat; behind me a catch opened and the long case touched my elbow. The distant vehicles crossed behind us. No one fired. Jean-Charles watched them diminish in his mirror, then gave the driver two fingers forward.

At the next rise the lead vehicle left the road without warning. We followed it down a dry drainage cut, the armour striking stone under my feet. The third vehicle continued along the tar. Through the rear slit I watched its dust pass the rise and disappear. Jean-Charles held one hand against the roof. Our driver stopped. An engine sounded above us, dwindled, then another followed it. We stayed in the cut until our rear vehicle appeared behind us. Jean-Charles lowered his hand and Va-Elise moved again.

Beyond the pan the tar ended. We went slowly over broken ground, stopping twice to change drivers with the engines still running. The quiet man slept with one hand through the case handle. Jean-Charles woke him after forty minutes and gave him the forward seat. Through the rear glass I watched our own dust; when the wind cleared it, the track was empty.

Near the end of the track stood one of Sarah's stations. On the aircraft she had described the buried rooms: two or three people, a drum, a border and a fuel gauge. The door of this one stood open to the desert.

Sarah stayed outside while Jean-Charles went in. He called us after him. She stopped with her hand against the frame.

"They had orders to keep this shut. Direct clearance for every visitor."

Three enamel cups stood beside a kettle. Cool air came from the wall and water ran from the tap. Blood had dried on the floor and the table lip. There were no bodies. On the back of a stores request someone had written a message. The pencil lay in the page gutter. I held the recorder over the table and read the last legible words: *door opened with*.

The next letter was a downward stroke. Blood lay under the writer's side of the page. None crossed the words. Beside the inner door were three hooks and a duty board bearing three names. One chair lay on its side. Another had been driven against the table hard enough to split its back rail. The chair before the drum held the dark print of a hand, with four separate fingertips along the edge.

Sarah examined the outer door. I held the lamp while she turned its edge toward her. There was no split wood, no bent hinge, no scoring around the lock. She closed it, opened it again with the key and kept the key in her palm.

Va-Elise went outside to examine the approach. Jean-Charles checked the rear room, the generator recess and the duct wide enough for an arm. I could hear each small door open from where I stood at the table. In the corner a record box had burned. The leaves along its edges were black; the middle of the files remained brown and readable.

The drum kept turning. Five strokes came up from the ground beneath us and drew themselves on its paper. Kailan stood before them without touching the sheet. They were evenly spaced, with the same rise. When the fifth ended, the stylus went back to its thin, irregular line. Sarah watched the interval and checked her wristwatch.

"Again in forty minutes," she said. "These are the same five strokes. Same height, same spacing. They are sounding on a programme."

Whole files had been pressed into the record box. Its lid had charred on the inside. Beneath the black scales of the outer leaves, paper remained the colour of old tea. I lifted the sheets in their order and spoke their dates. Fuel. Water. Watch changes. A delivery entered four weeks before and cancelled in another hand. The corner crumbled between my forceps and left a black crescent on the table. I moved the machine out of the falling ash. The first lines of the stores request reported the same five-stroke signal.

Va-Elise called us to the entrance. She showed Sarah a length of pale thread, then pointed out the heavier tread over earlier prints in the dust. Two sets continued away from the door. Beside them a scuff became parallel heel cuts. Beyond the rise she had photographed tyre marks. I could follow the marks once she placed my eye above them; I could not assign them to the names on the board.

"Taken, probably," Sarah said. "We act on the chance that they are alive. Three people who can read my notation and show where these lines are buried. None can give another station's location, but these instruments and their own approaches will be enough to begin with." She put her hand on the table until the shaking stopped. "Elise. If anyone has them, I want them back."

She read the three names from the duty board into the recorder. After each name she gave an office, years of service and the person to whom news should be carried if there remained anyone able to carry it. On the third she had to look back at the board before she could give the years.

Va-Elise found the route drawer unlocked and empty. Sarah checked its label: this station's access and withdrawal papers. She returned to the entrance and examined the undamaged lock.

"A visitor they admitted?" I asked.

"Possibly. Or someone with a key. Or someone they opened to under threat. Record the condition of the lock. We have no witness to the opening."

She opened her own station book beside the empty drawer and worked down a page of call signs with the scorched pencil. Six received a cross. Va-Elise copied those six onto a separate list, read them back and waited for the order.

"Those share outside support with this post," Sarah said. "Go back with the vehicles. Have each cell recalled separately through the central office, by its own cleared channel. No resupply on these roads. People first; break the instruments they cannot carry."

"Blackwood?" Va-Elise asked.

"The address is known. No one goes back to it. Use the withdrawal arrangements. Do not wait for another order from me."

"And if one of the six has already opened?"

Sarah put the station key into her palm. "Bring out whom you can. Burn what has to stay. Open the files before you put a flame to them."

Va-Elise closed her fingers over the key. She put the list inside her sleeve and went out to the drivers. I held the machine low while Sarah repeated the third name and corrected the years. The generator ticked behind the wall. Wind lifted the edge of the unfinished message against its pencil.

Outside someone called for hands to carry water. I closed the machine's lid and went to the door with it hanging from my wrist. A man waited while I shifted the strap high enough to take the other handle of his tin.

The next five strokes began while we were carrying the water out. All of us stopped. Dust moved in the split of the table. The kettle gave a small metallic answer. Sarah counted the interval aloud, then told us to keep moving.

The vehicles stopped where the track entered folded rock. A young man waited there with two others and seven animals, his face bound against the glare. Sarah called him Amastan.

He counted us and our loads before he answered her. He rejected two water tins because their caps rang against the handles, wrapped the recorder's metal catches in felt and divided the documents from the food. His companions repacked each animal by touch in the shade of the folds. One unfastened a bundle Va-Elise had tied and put its heavier half against the saddle. Amastan tested it with his knee. When nothing metal could strike metal, he uncovered his face.

"My grandfather carried that name for you," he said. "He has been thirty years in the ground. I carry it now." He drew the last strap through its ring. "Your officers put that name in their treaties before my grandfather was born. They spelled it wrong."

Va-Elise opened a map on the bonnet of the lead vehicle. Amastan looked once, drew a different line in the dust with the butt of his switch and put three stones across the route she had marked.

"That road was safe when my father held the name. It has tyre cuts now. Men watched it two nights ago." He moved the line west through a blank place on her map. "We go here."

Jean-Charles crouched beside the drawing. Amastan tapped each turn with his switch and made him repeat it. At the third, Jean-Charles pointed farther north. Amastan tapped the same place again. Jean-Charles named it. Amastan erased the whole with his foot.

Va-Elise put the tactical packet into Jean-Charles's hand. "This sector and two abort points," she said. "No onward route." She pointed to Amastan, who had begun checking the animal loads. "From here, ask him."

She opened the fire case and put my sealed interview reels and the travelling tins into a felt wrap. The instruction boxes and route papers stayed with her. She placed the wrap in my hands and waited while I tied it shut.

"No house behind us, Mr Morgan. Keep these dry."

She collected the drivers' maps and returned to the lead vehicle. No return route passed to Jean-Charles. At the first open ground the vehicles divided: one north, one east, one back toward the old tarmac. Amastan stood beside Sarah's animal until the three dust lines had thinned beyond sight. Then he shifted her saddle one hole and gave the word to move.

We set out at night and lay under ground-coloured cloth by day. Amastan chose the hours, the wells and the order of drinking. The animals drank before us.

The first night was stone underfoot and a wind that filled the recorder's catches with grit. Amastan walked ahead of the first animal without a light. One of his companions walked last and brushed the places where a hoof slipped. Jean-Charles twice offered a bearing. Amastan heard him and continued along his own line. At the next halt he retied the felt around my machine. The thread had worked loose where I kept putting my thumb beneath it to reach the switch.

By the second night I could tell a halt from a concealment. At a halt, the animals lowered their heads and someone checked the loads. At concealment, Amastan raised one closed hand and no buckle moved. Once we remained that way while an engine passed beyond the ridge. Its vibration came first through the soles of my boots. I held the recorder against my coat; the engine became audible and passed out of hearing before Amastan lowered his hand.

We reached a well before dawn, a crack at the back of a cleft. Amastan removed six fitted slabs, drew water with a skin narrow enough to pass between them, watered the animals and replaced the slabs in reverse order. His companion brushed the rock with a branch. When they had finished, I could not find the opening from three paces away.

"Does the Mountain keep this well?" I asked.

"My people keep it."

I pointed to a pale edge on one of the slabs. "That has been cut recently."

"My sister's son. The old stone split in the cold." He coiled the wet line against his arm. "He carried that one here."

Sarah rode in a sling they fitted around the saddle. At ninety-three she could still mount on the first night. By the third, Amastan and Kailan had to lift her. She allowed it without speaking. At noon her hand shook against the rim of her cup. I set the machine between my knees and held the cup while she drank. When it was empty she said, "Mr Morgan, if that appears in your account, at least spell my name correctly."

"I always do."

"One useful quality."

Amastan shortened the next passage. He moved the longest climb into the coldest hour and put Kailan at the left side of Sarah's animal, where the ground fell away. Sarah caught the guide's sleeve before he could go ahead.

"We have already lost half a day."

He looked down at her hand. "You could not lift your foot into the sling."

"I have crossed this country since before your father was born."

"Then let him hold you on the climb." Amastan waited. Sarah released his sleeve and put her hand on the saddle.

We left at the hour he had chosen. On the third night he stopped at a cairn and counted its stones with his switch. "One has been added," he said. He left it standing and took us six hours around.

At the next halt Kailan called the folds the Mountain's outer wall, the last country no state had crossed. Amastan had the end of a load strap between his teeth. He drew it tight, fastened it and came round the animal to face Kailan.

"Whose men changed that cairn?" he asked.

Kailan looked back along the fold. "I do not know."

"Nor do I. That is why we walked around." Amastan picked up his switch. "Your Mountain may call this its wall. Ask it who keeps the wells."

Kailan moved back to the left of Sarah's animal. During the daylight hides I recorded speech. At night I let the machine turn for a few minutes at each change of ground: soft hoof-fall on sand, iron striking buried stone, wind through a slit too narrow to see. Then I stopped it and wrote the hour on the band around the reel. I numbered every interval I did not record. When I opened the battery compartment, Amastan held a corner of the ground-cloth over my hands until I had shut it again.

On the fourth night the five strokes reached us without paper or instrument. I felt the first through my feet. Sarah's animal raised its head. Four more followed at equal distances, too low to hear and distinct through the ground. Amastan put his fingers to the rock. Sarah counted. We covered the metal fittings, gave the animals the final water and went forward on foot.

We reached the camp overlook in the last dark of the fourth night. Amastan's companions took the animals into a high cleft while he brought us up through a dry wash and stopped us below its rim. He pressed a palm to the ground.

"From there onward, their instruments can hear a stone roll."

He took Jean-Charles forward on his belly. When they returned, Jean-Charles asked him to repeat the passage between two listening posts. Amastan traced the first turns against the rock.

"At the last bend you go alone. If they see me, they will watch the way I came."

Jean-Charles removed his coat, covered the pale skin of his hands and face, and tightened the cloth at his collar. He saw me watching.

"Still taking notes on me, professor?"

"Your questions at the safe house are on the record. So is your request that Kailan keep them from Elise."

He pulled the cloth across his mouth. "And Sarah heard him tell it. She still put the field movement in my hands."

"That is on the record too."

"Good. Keep the machine dry."

Amastan led him over the rim and came back alone. I heard nothing from Jean-Charles before the light came.

Grey light entered the pan while we lay against cold rock. Dishes, tents and parked vehicles separated from the ground. Beyond them stood the drilling rig. Two pale flecks crossed the sky without sound. Sarah watched them, checked her watch and gave Amastan the next times she expected overhead coverage. A dish beside the command tents turned slowly and stopped. I kept my face below the rim.

Through the glass I saw men on the ridges facing inward, with tripods among them pointed into the rock. Survey stakes made straight red lines across the pan. Sarah named a western truck's position as the northern mouth of an old drovers' track to the Oasis. Shield had allowed it to pass out of use, she said; no Outsider was supposed to know where that mouth lay.

"They were told," Kailan said.

"I think so." Sarah pointed below the rig. "West of your Hall. What lies deeper along that line?"

"The reserve."

"Water?"

He nodded.

A double ring of tents occupied the camp's centre. Generator housings stood beside it, and men were loading stretchers into long vehicles. I watched an orderly carry a folded blanket past the inner cordon. Armed men at its entrance kept a truck waiting while its driver showed a paper. I handed the glass back.

Sarah kept her eye to it. "A good half of what you see was written in my hand." She followed the orderly until he went inside a tent.

"Some part of me wanted the Mountain found. I wanted not to be the last one holding it." She lowered the glass into the space between us.

We waited through the daylight. Amastan pulled cloth over the hollow behind our ledge and weighted it without raising an edge above the rock. Sarah lay beneath it. Whenever he brought her water, she asked whether Jean-Charles had returned. He shook his head and let her drink. I kept the recorder in the shade and my notebook against my chest, where the wind could not turn its pages.

Men replaced one another at the posts. A line formed outside the cooking tents and broke apart; vehicles moved between the rig and stacked lengths of pipe. Heat shook the space above them until I could no longer keep a man's outline in the glass. When the shadow reached our ledge again, Sarah sat up without help.

We heard no shot. Late in the day, Jean-Charles appeared in the wash with a man bent in front of him. Amastan went down to meet them, placing their steps as they climbed. The prisoner wore the camp's grey clothes. His wrists were bound; a gag held his mouth. Jean-Charles carried a flat hard case and a black field radio.

"Post nine," he said. "The seam is open beyond it. Not for long."

He put the case on the rock between us. Sarah bent over the catches. I brought the recorder beside her hand.

"Before you open it. Where did you take it from, Jean-Charles?"

"A locked drawer in the command tent."

Sarah kept her fingers on the catches. "How long, Mr Morgan?"

"Long enough to identify him and the condition in which it reached us. His access is part of the examination."

She took her hand away. "Do it."

I gave the hour, described the place and both catches, and stated Jean-Charles's name. He repeated where he had found the case and said no one else had handled it since. I had seen him come up the wash carrying it; his account supplied the earlier custody. I opened it beside the recorder, keeping the lid toward the camp so the paper would not show white above the rock.

The papers carried one stock, one sequence of punch holes and consecutive issue marks. Corrections on separate sheets had been made in the same ink and impressed the leaves beneath them. I held two pages against the light to match an impression, then placed them back in order.

"The leaves were together when these corrections were made," I said. "I cannot certify their contents."

Sarah found a small mark in the upper corner of the first sheet.

"French strategic service. A compartment descended from the arrangements Martinez and my father made in this desert. The mineral company is a cover. This is a state operation."

She set that sheet face up inside the lid and began translating the French into the Mountain's language. The next leaves carried a joint Algerian groundwater and rare-earth concession; she read the number, drilling permits and customs entries and judged them genuine. A distribution table allocated fuel, airspace and explosives approvals to separate offices and survey blocks. The central coordinates appeared in none of the Algerian recipients' copies listed there. A personnel annex counted three thousand and eighty-four people across nine contractors: drilling, transport, aviation, medicine, camp labour and security. It listed three hundred and eighty-six French service numbers. I checked the addition of its subtotals.

Sarah read the operational headings and pointed to the corresponding parts of the camp: seismic sounding, bore depths and dates, capture medicine, water control, approach denial, compartmented command. At the last she went back to the distribution table.

"The drilling and the concessions will survive inspection. Each office can show its own permits. None needs to see this page."

Kailan leaned across the case. "What do they know of the mechanism?"

"That there is one. These are orders to reach it. My grid, my methods." She held the page at its lower corners. "They have not written down what they expect it to do."

Three leaves into the logistics annex, I found the local name Sarah had used for the northern track. It stood among forty routes. Sarah translated the entry beside it: *source: internal, reliability high*.

I gave her the page and touched the line.

"After Martinez was shut out, who held that corridor?"

"One channel." She kept the page on the rock between us.

"Jean-Charles?"

"Yes."

"The entry does not name him. And he brought us the case."

She folded the page once. "Keep that qualification in your account. I am keeping this."

She put it inside her coat. Jean-Charles stood beside the prisoner, watching the wash. He had asked us no question about the papers. I stopped the machine while we read the remaining leaves. By my watch the gap was four minutes. I put the service-marked first sheet back over the others, started the reel and stated the times and reason for the gap.

The field radio lit. A young voice spoke French. Jean-Charles covered the set until the light died. Sarah translated: post nine had missed its check; if Farid had crawled behind a rock to sleep again, he could answer to the sergeant.

Amastan cut the gag. The prisoner raised his head when Sarah repeated Farid's name. Amastan held the water skin for him because his wrists were tied behind his back. Water ran into the hollow above his collar; when Amastan lowered the skin, Farid bent after it. Amastan let him drink again.

Sarah put our questions to him in French and gave us his replies. He said he guarded a mineral survey. He knew his own watch and the two posts beside it. He had been told there were "primitives" underground, a lost tribe to be handled *without loss of life*. Sappers were to preserve what they found intact.

Kailan crouched where Farid could see his face. Sarah stayed beside them to translate.

"Who told you to take no life?" Kailan asked.

"A medical officer. I do not know his name."

"The same officer who sets the charges?"

"No."

"Who can stop the digging?"

"Operations. Not our command."

"Who among you may speak to the men on the western ridge?"

Farid looked toward it. "No one at my post. They have their own command."

Kailan drew the case toward his knees. Sarah found the live-capture orders and translated the five priorities, each coded by task with the name omitted. He stopped her at three and repeated them in his own words: the one who reads the deep water; the one who keeps the hours; the one who holds the seal. Sarah pointed to the other two entries and gave him their wording again.

"Read those to him," he said.

Sarah did. Farid shook his head at each. He tried to lean away from the case; his bound hands caught against the rock.

"Five functions," Kailan said to Sarah. "They want all five alive. Put them together under guard and make them work it."

"Can they?" Sarah asked.

Kailan kept the page between his hands. “That is what the division is meant to prevent.”

Farid looked from Kailan to Sarah. She had stopped translating. He pulled his wrists against the binding and looked again at the water skin.

The radio spoke again, in a lower voice. “The sergeant,” Sarah said. Lights came on at two posts.

“The road is open,” Jean-Charles said. “Amastan knows a seam beyond post nine their instruments do not yet cover. Farid’s missed check has shortened our hour to minutes.”

One of Amastan’s companions moved Farid’s bindings to the front and led him into the high cleft. He carried the water skin with them. “We keep him until your road is shut,” Amastan said. “Then he goes.”

Kailan put the page back and closed the case. Jean-Charles took its handle, put it into Sarah’s hand and gave me the field radio. “We go now.”

We left the animals, blankets and empty water skins in the high cleft. I put the reel tins inside my coat and bound the recorder against my chest with its carrying strap. Sarah tried the station book inside her coat. Its spine kept her elbow out from her body. Kailan took the hard case while she lay flat and tried to draw the arm beneath her. She got up and tore out the crossed page of call signs. She took the annex from her coat and put both leaves inside her sleeve. Kailan gave her back the case. The book remained under a stone.

Amastan led us to the rim. Three lights moved along the wash Jean-Charles had used; another swept the ridge above post nine. Men called in pairs. The drilling continued beneath them, a regular iron turning that covered smaller sounds and then stopped without warning. Each time it stopped, we stopped with it.

At the first turn Amastan placed our feet in his own marks. At the second he took Sarah’s weight across a slab that sounded hollow when my knee touched it. At the third he pointed to a black cut no wider than a doorway.

“That cut reaches the old seam,” he said. “I stop here.”

Sarah gripped his wrist. “Close the northern well.”

“It was closed before you came.”

“The other two?”

“My brother takes one. My sister takes the other.”

He looked at Kailan. “Tell Shield who is closing them. Tell them the northern road has tyre cuts. They will have to ask us before they send anyone that way again.”

Kailan repeated the message. Amastan listened to the end, then withdrew over our path, lifting the marks with a brush of hide.

Jean-Charles entered the cut first, Sarah behind him, Kailan behind her, and I last. We moved on elbows where the roof came down. The radio against my ribs gave one burst of French through its cloth. Kailan's foot stopped beside my hand. Ahead, Sarah whispered, "Eight through twelve. Close the western arc. Find Farid."

I worked the set out of its wrapping and passed it to Kailan. He slid it along the rock beside Sarah; she pushed it into Jean-Charles's waiting hand. He turned a control and the voice vanished.

"Did you answer?" Sarah whispered.

"No."

"Could you have?"

"I know the language of the post. I do not know the man's alarm word."

He set it on the rock for Sarah. She kept her hand beside his until he released it, then passed it back through Kailan. I wrapped it against my ribs with the control facing away from me. Sarah drew the case forward, pushed it flat and crawled after it.

The cut opened above a slope of broken shale. Across it stood post nine: two men, a low tent and a tripod turning by degrees. Beyond the post, the ground met the Mountain in an unbroken face. I could see no seam. A white lamp moved along the base of the rock, withdrew and returned.

Jean-Charles counted the tripod's turns with one finger. On the fifth he took us across. For twelve paces the shale shifted under every knee. We placed each stone in the space the hand ahead had left. Sarah's breath became audible. Kailan stopped and drew her arm across his shoulders. The tripod turned away. We moved again.

A voice challenged from the post. Jean-Charles put us flat and answered in French. I have no French, and he was not loud. The voice asked a second question. He gave a shorter reply. A man stepped beyond the tent and raised his lamp toward us. At that moment the drilling rig began again. Jean-Charles pulled Sarah to her feet and ran bent beneath her arm. Kailan took her other side. I went after them with the recorder striking my ribs. When I looked back, the lamp crossed the place where we had lain. Small stones were still rolling down from it.

The rock face remained whole until Jean-Charles put his hand into a shadow below it. His arm disappeared to the wrist. Kailan knelt, cleared three handfuls

of gravel and uncovered a narrow bronze plate with five shallow cups. He pressed the outer two, the centre, then the outer two again. Nothing moved.

Jean-Charles kept his shoulder at the stone. "Nothing."

"The return sign changes with the hour," Kailan said. He held his fingers above the cups.

Sarah drew her feet clear of his knees. "You have room. Try."

Kailan set the pattern a second time and held the centre cup. Jean-Charles leaned harder against the stone. A line opened without sound. Cold air came through it. Two hands reached from the dark. Sarah passed the case to Kailan and took the hands; they pulled her inside. He passed the case through and followed it. Jean-Charles caught my coat at the shoulder and pushed me after him.

The white lamp found the bronze plate as he entered. A shot struck the rock above the opening. The hands inside pulled him clear; the seam closed on a fall of dust. No weapon answered from within.

For several breaths I heard our breathing and the recorder turning under my coat. Someone close to me coughed. Then a lamp was uncovered.

Va-Sheva stood beside the uncovered lamp in Shield grey. The chamber was low enough that Jean-Charles remained bent until he had stepped clear of the seam. Two wardens held us along one wall. Kailan picked up the case just inside the seam and gave it back to Sarah. Va-Sheva looked from it to the radio in my hands, then to the recorder under my coat. She sent one warden to the seam and kept the other between us and the inner door. She was with child; her belt lay above the swelling.

The inner warden searched us while the other held the seam. Sarah showed the folded pages in her sleeve and laid the case at her feet. Kailan carried no weapon. I put down the field radio and drew my coat clear of the recorder. The warden reached for its strap.

"Your name and office, please," I said. "If you take it, I must record the transfer."

Va-Sheva caught his wrist. He let the strap fall against my chest. He went on to Jean-Charles, who laid down a pistol, two knives, a length of black cord and three objects I could not name.

"It stays closed," she said. "Shield will hear what it contains with Justice present, or destroy it with the man who carried it."

The warden wrapped the field radio and hard case separately and set them in a stone recess without opening either. Sarah returned the folded pages to her sleeve.

Blood from the shale had soaked through one knee of her trousers. Va-Sheva pointed to it.

"After the hearing," Sarah said.

"Bind it while she speaks," Va-Sheva told the warden. "If she falls, carry her. Do not stop her answer."

The warden knelt to bind Sarah's knee. Va-Sheva faced Kailan across the lamp.

"You were sent to find whether the enemy within was real. You were to report through me. You have brought two Outsiders before the five could hear them, and a machine carrying our speech, through a seam no Veil is shown. Your errand did not authorise any of that. By the law I hold, I should kill you here and close the stone over all four."

Kailan looked at the warden by the seam. "Then hear the finding before you carry out the law. You are the ear they gave me."

"I am listening."

"The men outside mean to take the five alive. Sarah has their orders. The bore is aimed below the Hall. Hear her measure."

Sarah held her leg still under the warden's hands. "My methods brought them this far. I can show Shield what they are doing with them."

Va-Sheva faced her. "How deep?"

Sarah gave the measure. Va-Sheva asked the angle, the number of rigs and the interval between the five strokes. Sarah answered each. The warden pulled the bandage tight; she stopped on a number, then gave it again.

Va-Sheva turned to Jean-Charles. "You brought them through the outer posts?"

"Yes. They have challenged us. The seam was seen."

She looked at his empty hands. "I trust your hands. I have worked beside them. You remain with us." When the inner warden had tied Sarah's bandage, she sent him to summon Shield and Justice, then pointed to my recorder. "That remains on you, Outsider. If it opens, you die before the lid clears."

"Understood," I said.

"Under necessity of Shield, I admit the four of you as far as the sealed floor and no farther. Justice will decide whether the five hear you. The seam you used is dead from this hour. I answer for the admission."

The warden at the seam drove a bronze pin into the five-cup plate. Three descending blows sounded inside the wall. The pin's head was flattened against the bronze. He took his hammer away. Va-Sheva waited for the last sound to stop,

then lifted the lamp. Sarah tried her weight on the bound knee. Jean-Charles took her uninjured side, Kailan the other. I followed them towards the inner door.

Wardens met us beyond it. Va-Sheva sent one back to guard the radio and hard case in their recess. At the crossings she stopped others with a low word; one went downward and another ran ahead. Sarah kept pace beside the lamp, answering Va-Sheva's questions.

"How many bores?"

"Three active. One deep. Two shallow."

"How much time?"

"The case gives a date for reaching the Hall. Have it brought to Justice. I cannot certify how closely they have kept the schedule."

"Can you stop it from this side?"

"Not by meeting the bit. You may collapse a throat ahead of it, if you know the rock and can lose the chambers beyond. You may foul a water bore, but then you lose the water. You may let them enter a false void and close it behind them. I need a survey before I can tell you which."

Va-Sheva sent for the keepers of the north-western galleries and the oldest survey kept by Stone. She asked whether the deep reserve shared a wall with the lower wards. Sarah said her earlier route had not shown her those galleries. At the next crossing a warden brought a black marking stone. Sarah drew the ridge, rig and angle on the passage wall. Kailan placed the Hall and held the stone below it.

"The reserve is deeper," he said. "I cannot give you its depth."

Va-Sheva studied the marks, sent another message to Stone and wiped the drawing away with her sleeve. Black dust remained in the folds of the grey cloth.

"Justice will require the order of discovery," she told Kailan. "What you saw, what she measured, what the papers say. Keep those separate. I shall give the five Shield's reason for admitting you. I cannot give them yours."

"I will give it. Bring the case."

"With its guard. It will be opened before Justice."

Where the stair turned, Sarah and Jean-Charles had gone several steps ahead. Va-Sheva lowered her voice. I was one step behind Kailan with the recorder against my ribs.

"Elise wrote that you did not speak for eleven days at the house. Is it true?"

"Yes."

"Could you drink?"

"When she put the cup in my hands."

"Sleep?"

"Not enough."

Va-Sheva raised the lamp to see the next step. "I would have ordered the containment again."

Kailan stayed below her. She lowered the lamp a little.

"Do not ask me for more tonight," she said. "I need to keep you alive long enough to answer them."

She climbed after the others. Kailan waited until the space of one step had opened between them, then followed.

The route crossed an open stair above the common wards. Lamps burned over food stalls. A woman walked twelve children in pairs; the smallest held the back of the child's tunic ahead of him and dragged one sandal. A seller weighed roots in a hanging pan while two men disputed his weights. Someone beat dust from a mat over a rail and earned a shout from the level beneath. Water ran in a channel cut through the centre of the floor.

No one looked upward as we came onto the stair. I had spent two years comparing tool marks, copied signs and the mineral residue on objects Sarah put before me. Below us a man mended a pot with wire. He held its broken halves between his knees, passed the wire through a drilled hole and turned the pot to reach the other side. His cup stood outside the circle of fragments at his feet.

At a table under three lamps, a baker pressed his thumb into rounds of dough, turned each one and pressed again. The evening bread reached us before we crossed the centre of the stair: yeast, warm grain and the scorched flour at the edge of an oven. I knew charred cakes from sites nine thousand years old. I knew the pits in which the grain had been stored, the querns on which it had been broken and the changes in human bone after people began to eat it every day. The baker struck flour from his hands and called to a child to carry six loaves home.

The recorder knocked against the rail. Several faces lifted. Va-Sheva caught my sleeve before it struck again.

"They do not know," she said. "They will not learn it from you on a stair. Walk."

The child with the six loaves had stopped beneath us. One loaf slipped against his chest; he trapped it with his chin and laughed. I drew the machine close under my coat and walked. At the upper turn the stalls disappeared. The smell remained for twelve steps more.

The first blow took the stair sideways.

Stone struck my shoulder. The recorder drove into my ribs beneath my coat. A lamp went out below; another rolled in a yellow circle until a hand caught it. Then the sound arrived through the floor: one flat concussion, a single force driven into the Mountain without the patient interval of the five-stroke sounding. Dust fell from the joints overhead. Far inside the rock, worked stone ground against worked stone.

Sarah put both hands on the wall. "A charge. Down a shallow bore, close enough to break a void or test what breaks around it. North-west, near the surface. What lies there?"

Va-Sheva had turned toward the sound. She stood with the lamp held clear of the wall.

"What lies there?" Sarah repeated.

"Faith," Va-Sheva said. "A Faith passage. The road to the Hall."

She ran. Jean-Charles went with her and the nearest warden. Sarah called for a lamp, a plan of the north-western arc and the keeper of Stone. The ward children below had begun to cry. The seller's hanging scale knocked against its post with each movement underfoot.

Kailan put his palm to the wall. I put mine beside it. A tremor travelled through the stone, stopped, then returned deeper and slower. Grit moved under my fingers. From beyond the turn came a sharper failure and Va-Sheva shouting for the passage to be cleared.

I lifted the closed recorder toward the grinding and felt its motor through the case. A warden set his lamp beside Kailan and ran ahead. Kailan took it. We ran after the others.

Chapter 19

Seal

Mountain - inside the Greater Seal

In Noxius

(Paul): — Fresh reel, Kailan. We have reached the Mountain.

— Yes.

— You said you would take the account back when we did.

— I said I would.

— Then take it.

— Is the machine turning?

— It is.

— Then what follows is my own account, in my own words, from the Justice road where Justice received us.

I took the account back where the Justice road began. At my trial Ka-Elun had led me through Faith's Labyrinth. This time we came through Justice's quarter. Va-Sheva brought Sarah, Paul and me to a low door dressed as an ordinary joint in the stone and struck it once with the heel of her hand. Ka-Leth opened it from

within. Sa-Tavan stood behind him with a slate and a covered tablet of wet clay. Another charge struck along the Faith road while Ka-Leth looked at the three of us. Dust ran from the joint above the door and lay white across his shoulders.

"They enter under my hand," he said. "If the rooms refuse them, the hearing does not happen."

Before the five could hear us, Justice had to admit us. There were five rooms between that outer door and Justice's door into the circular vestibule, each no larger than a cell and each holding one problem cut into its stone. I had not known they existed. Sa-Tavan broke a red wax seal at each latch before Ka-Leth opened it.

The first was *the balance of scale*. Blocks of unequal size lay carved against the weights they carried, and a beam leaned false across the wall. One loose stone weight stood on the floor. Ka-Leth reckoned what each block was worth, ignored its apparent size, and set the weight into the one notch that brought the beam level. The first door released us deeper into the Justice road.

In the second room, *the nearest truth*, the wall gave a sequence:

1 1 -1; 3 2 1; 7 5 -1; 17 12 1; 41 29 -1; 99 70 1.

A square and its diagonal were cut beneath it. Ka-Leth entered two hundred and thirty-nine over one hundred and sixty-nine. The second door gave before the next strike reached us.

The third was *the false witness*: one wolf among a thousand sheep; a test that named the wolf nine times in ten and falsely marked three innocent sheep in a hundred; the true weight of guilt upon a sheep it marked. Ka-Leth set ten over three hundred and forty-three.

"That is barely three in a hundred," Paul said.

"A true mark is rare because the wolf is rare," Sarah said. "The innocent marks overwhelm it."

Ka-Leth kept his eyes on the door. "Justice asks what a sign proves, not how frightening the sign appears." The stone withdrew.

The fourth, *the reconciled record*, gave four clerks' remainders: counted by sevens, six left; by elevens, eight; by thirteens, three; by seventeens, five; and the whole below seventeen thousand and seventeen. Ka-Leth worked that one on Sa-Tavan's slate while the Mountain took three more blows. Dust loosened from the lintel. At the second blow Va-Sheva looked back toward Faith. She did not ask him to hurry. He tested the number against all four clerks, entered four thousand nine hundred and sixty-nine, and the bolts went back.

The last room was *the forecast*. The wall gave two, five, five, eight and nine for five years, then required the straight judgment through them that made the errors least and the value at the seventh year. Ka-Leth entered one hundred and twenty-six over ten. The fifth door opened into the circular vestibule. Beyond its broad arch lay the bridge and the five separated seats.

Behind us, the five doors stood open along the Justice road. The other four Keepers had entered by their own arches. Across the gulf waited the five people who would decide whether almost every other life in the world should be spent. The great Gate of the Hall remained shut behind their seats. The ruling belonged in the antechamber.

Only then did Ka-Leth convene the hearing. Before the first testimony, Sa-Tavan counted Paul's recorder, two reels, notebook and pencil. Ka-Leth allowed the machine to turn under Shield's provisional custody; nothing it carried could leave before Justice disposed of it. Shield bound my hands before the same five offices that had tried me. Paul and Sarah stood unbound beside me, which was not law, and was Va-Sheva's doing. Jean-Charles stood with Shield's wardens along the wall.

Five human beings sat isolated in a dark large enough to lose a shout. The token-flame that Faith keeps threw their shadows across the gravure. The shadows shifted whenever the Mountain was struck, a deep flat knock coming up through the floor into the soles of my bound feet.

The five were older than the last time I had stood before them, and one I had helped to make. Ka-Raedin of Light sat under the dark aperture that is Light's, my Keeper, the man whose ascension I had watched from beneath the pillar, in whose office I had served until I pulled the cord I was told to leave. He kept his eyes on the central stone when I entered.

As at my trial, Justice opened first and would return last to rule. "You were sent out under seal," Ka-Leth said, "to determine whether the Enemy Within was real. The council that condemned you granted Exception, wrote you an errand, and put you out of the Threshold with it in your mouth. That errand still stands. It has never been revoked, because no one believed there would ever be a finding to revoke it for." He let that sit. "Make your finding."

I made my finding. I kept it plain, the way Paul had taught me, and I gave them the camp: the trucks that struck the ground, the rig and the hole going down, the

men dug in on the ridges facing inward, the eye in the sky that owned it. I gave them the drovers' road Shield had let fall from memory and the enemy had come to straighten, as though handed a map. I told them the shape of the danger without yet its source, because its source stood at my shoulder in Outsider's clothes and I wanted the Mountain to fear the danger before it hated the woman.

They made me give it twice. On the second account Ka-Leth required quantities. How many men. I did not know; hundreds in the cells I could see, with the ring behind them larger than I could count. How deep the hole. Sarah answered that one, to the metre, and fixed the number to the day the hole would reach the Hall. Ka-Cheryn moved two fingers against her thumb, then lowered her hand. What could the eye see. Everything, I told them, that was not underground. And Ka-Dhavar of Shield said, low, that this was the first war in the Mountain's history in which the enemy could see the top of the board while the Mountain saw only the one square it stood on; and no one answered.

Ka-Dhavar of Shield spoke again before I finished. "I have said this table was under an eye for two years," he said, "and I was told I was seeing shapes in the dark, which is Shield's disease. The wrong tremors began before the bore. Our outer stations went silent in order. I take no pleasure in the shapes having faces now." He asked for the disposition of the ridge cells and no one asked whether he believed me.

Ka-Raedin of Light would not take my finding on my word. "Light does not act on a witness's fear," he said, still not looking at me. "Light acts on a thing seen twice, by two, and verified. This man has given us a picture, and a picture is a claim. I have built my whole office on the difference between a claim and a proof, and I will not spend the Mountain on the word of" — and here he stopped, and chose the wound — "on the word of the finest mind my office ever ruined. Show me the proof, and I am with you before Justice finishes speaking. Give me only his fear, and I will not name it sight."

Ka-Cheryn of Balance began counting. "Say it is all true," she said, heavy and slow. "Then I am already counting. I do not need to know whether we can shut the door; I need to know what is left of us on the day we open it again."

Ka-Elun of Faith, old now, laid her palm against the floor. "The stone is answering wrong," she said, and her voice was the same voice that had blessed a thousand mornings, gone thin. "I have listened to this Mountain speak for seventy years. It has one long slow sentence it says, that I was taught to hear before I was taught to read, and for a season now there has been another voice under it, striking, and the stone flinching, and answering, and I told myself it was the Mountain settling."

She looked at me. "You heard it too. As a child. You always had the ear, and Light took you instead of Faith, and I have wondered since whether that was the first mistake."

Ka-Cheryn spoke next. "Say we seal," she said. "Then hear what sealing is, since no one else at this table will say it. We have air for the whole population, turned and cleaned, for a long while but not without end. The living water is deep, but not endless. And the other water, the great reserve, is ballast, and the day we broach it for thirst is the day we unbalance the very thing it was laid down to balance. I have grain and oil and salt fish against the lean years, and I know them to the sack, and I can feed our people behind a shut door for a measured time, and at the end of that time, if no help has come, and none is coming, we do not open the door onto a rescued world; we open it, if at all, onto whatever the outside has become while we lay buried, or we are a tomb that took a long while to fill." She turned her heavy face to Justice. "I do not argue against the Seal. I tell you only that there is no safe answer left in this Mountain tonight. We are left to choose which loss we count first."

"You have told us what is at the gate," Ka-Leth said. "You have not told us how it found the gate. A thing eleven thousand years hidden is not stumbled upon by soldiers with a drill. Someone drew them the map. And you have brought into this chamber, unbound, against every law I hold, two people of the outside, and you have set one of them at your shoulder as though her word were worth a Veil's, and I will now ask the question you have been arranging the room to keep me from asking. Who is she."

I could have answered; I had it ready, the whole of it. But Paul spoke first, from where he stood with the little machine still turning in his coat.

"Ask her, Keeper," Paul said. "I have recorded her account. There are things in it I would want explained if I were you, but let her finish before you begin."

So they asked her, and she told them. I will not set it down again; you have had it from her already.

"What did you want when you left?" Paul asked.

"More," she said. "I have wanted the whole of it every day since. I am on this side of the table because another hand reached it first."

Ka-Cheryn of Balance made a low sound in her chest. "You let an Outsider say the word *whole* in this chamber," she said to Justice, "and did not have her struck down where she stands." "I let her say it," Ka-Leth answered, "because she is the finding: the thing the Beast was made against, telling us there is now a worse one

at the gate. Strike her down and we blind ourselves to the only mind that has ever mapped the mind that hunts us. Justice keeps her breathing. Justice will reckon what she is owed on the day there is a world left to owe her in."

Va-Sheva spoke then, once, from where she stood along the wall, because a Veil does not speak in the sealed chamber unless an office bids her, and Ka-Dhavar of Shield bid her. "I brought them in," she said. "The breach is mine. I will answer for it after, if there is an after. I vouch for the hands of the Outsider they call Jean-Charles. Worked beside them, against smugglers. They did not once reach for the thing they stood next to. I do not vouch for the woman. Only this of her: everything she has told this chamber, I have set against what Shield already knew, and it has not failed one test. That is worse than if it had." She gave a low word to a warden then, and sent Jean-Charles out with him toward the torn seam, to see how far the breach had opened and whether the far gate would still answer the Seal; the warden came back within the hour, and Jean-Charles did not. She stepped back to the stone.

"And the men at the gate," Ka-Leth said, when she had finished. "Are they your hand."

"They were," she said. "They have my grids, my methods, my notation and the parts of Horizon that leaked. They are not under my control. I came because they took the thing from me, and because I know what they will do next: what I would do." She looked at the five of them, one to the next. "Hate me later. Now use me."

The proof Light demanded came from the Shield recess while she was still speaking. A warden set the objects on the stone before Ka-Leth: the flat hard case Jean-Charles had taken off the desert, the field instrument for speaking across distance, and the single page with the service mark in its corner.

Paul read the marks, countersignatures and handling entries aloud, then separated what he could authenticate from what Sarah alone could interpret. Sarah read the operational vocabulary and translated it.

There was a cell for the drilling, a cell for the reading of what it struck, a cell for the men on the ridges, and a cell walled from all the others for what the orders called the assets. And the assets were people, and the people were us. There was a schedule for the taking, and a protocol, a whole careful page of it, for keeping taken persons alive and lucid under questioning. And there was a line she read to them twice that set aside resources for the preservation of the primary control personnel, five in number. And a second line for the securing of the central asset intact and the prevention of its actuation by the incumbent operators. "The

incumbent operators," she said, and let it lie in the chamber a moment. "That is what they have called you, in a room in a language none of you will ever hear. It is the phrase a man uses for a hand he intends to lift off a machine and replace with his own. They are not here to destroy you."

Ka-Leth did not rule then. He set both hands flat on the stone, and was quiet.

"I can find the condition met," he said at last. "I cannot rule upon it. Justice would have to weigh the threat, the stores, the aim, the law and Faith's timing together. No office may lawfully receive another's part."

"Then the law has beaten us," Ka-Cheryn said, "over nothing, at the end."

"The law has a door in it, opened only twice before my time: the Threshold Exception. It admits a witness who belongs to no Kahir, holds no key, turns no valve and gives no order. The witness may receive what the offices may not hold together." Ka-Leth looked at Sarah, then away. "All five hands must unbar it. I have named it. Grant it in your own voices, or refuse it."

"Light grants it," Ka-Raedin said, "and God forgive me for the door I am helping to open." "Shield grants it," said Ka-Dhavar; "the door is mine to keep, and I unbar it." Balance was slower. "Balance grants it," Ka-Cheryn said at last, "for I cannot make an honest count while the whole is kept in pieces, and I will not refuse the one door that might let it be counted at all." "Faith grants it," said Ka-Elun, and laid her hand flat to the floor. And Ka-Leth set his own hand on the central stone. "Justice grants it. Record five grants, each under its own office. Do not record the whole as Justice's. Their agreement admits the witness; it gives no Keeper custody."

Va-Sheva crossed to Paul, took his right hand and turned the palm up to the lamp. Under the grime of the crossing lay the mark I had cut beneath the tree, still pink and knitting. "The ascended mark," she said, "set by a Veil of Light." No Veil had the right to put it into an Outsider's hand. She released him. "The law says the Threshold opens to a mark set in the hand. It is set. Not for the tunnels; he entered by the seam as we did. For this hour, and no other. He accepted our last door into his own hand knowing what it was." Ka-Leth looked from the mark to me.

The mark was mine. "When you cast me out, you placed me beyond the wall Shield knows how to keep. In the outside house I found the danger named in our oldest warning: not the beast before the gate, but the trusted hand inside it. I had no office there, so I made one of a single man. I placed Paul Morgan in Shadow and told him to look inward. He found the eye watching my instruction, followed the

man who carried its record and brought back the face of the man who received it. We know my instruction was stolen. No one in this chamber may yet name whose hand opened the road. But the warning came because he looked where Shield could not. He holds no key here. He has already done the work for which your law now needs him."

Ka-Leth turned to Paul. "You belong to no office, hold no lever of this place and never shall. You have taken accounts that would not touch and laid them beside one another until their agreement could be tested. Each Keeper will tell you, alone, the thing his office may tell no other. You will hold all five and tell me how they fit. You will act on none of it and decide nothing. Will you take it?"

Paul looked down at the machine hanging from its strap. "I will hold it and touch nothing. The reel will hold it too."

"I bind both under the Greater Seal," Ka-Leth said. "The witness does not leave while it stands. The reel is not copied and passes into no outside hand. You are admitted, not owned. Take the depositions."

The five rooms were cleared and shut again. Sa-Tavan took the Keepers into them in the order Justice named, returned alone, and brought Paul to each door. At every threshold he counted the recorder's two reels, Paul's notebook and the pencil in Paul's hand; when Paul came out, he counted them again. He made no copy. The deposing Keeper left by the same road and returned to the separated seat before the next was called. No Keeper heard another's deposition. I remained bound in the antechamber and heard none of them then. I know the words because the machine carried them into the same small room where Paul and I now sit; the reel remained under the Seal, as Justice ordered. What lay around those words—the rooms, the hands, the movements of the machine—Paul gave me before I began: only what he saw and did. Only Paul and that reel travelled the whole road.

Ka-Cheryn received him in the balance of scale. The beam had returned to its false lean and the loose weight stood again on the floor. Paul set the machine between them.

"Balance deposes the count," she said. She gave the living roll, the grain, the oil and salt, the daily draw of the air works, and the two waters: the shallow flow the wards could drink and the great reserve whose mass belonged to the deeper engine. She named the point at which thirst would force her to spend the reserve and the point at which doing so would alter the balance of the Mountain itself.

Paul asked, "Which number is certain?"

"The people. The stores, within the ordinary error. The last day is a forecast and I will not have Justice record it as a promise."

He marked the distinction in his notebook before he lifted the machine.

Ka-Raedin waited in the nearest truth. Between them the square and diagonal remained cut into the wall, with two hundred and thirty-nine over one hundred and sixty-nine still set in the stone. He gave Paul Light's survey of the buried surfaces, the fixed path through the Earth and the far break against which that path ended. He named what could be destroyed and what could be recovered from the sky.

"Can the aim be made false without moving the Mountain?" Paul asked.

"For a night. Not for a patient enemy."

"Is that proof?"

"No. It is the nearest truth I can give without letting a hope call itself a fact."

When Paul returned to the antechamber, Ka-Raedin followed him through the same doors and did not look toward me.

Ka-Dhavar stood in the false witness. Paul had just heard that a marked sheep held only ten chances in three hundred and forty-three of being the wolf; Shield was required to tell him which signs above the Mountain were evidence and which were fear. Ka-Dhavar gave him the ridge cells, the aircraft, the captured outer stations, the inward-facing guns and the disposition around the bore. He separated what his wardens had seen from what Sarah had inferred and from what the seized orders proved. Then he named the hour at which the ring would be complete.

"How much of your conclusion rests on the woman?" Paul asked.

"The depth and the method. Not the presence, the ring or the taking of our stations."

"And the hand inside her house?"

"Indicated. Not proved. Shield does not condemn a man to make a pattern clean."

Ka-Leth received him in the reconciled record. Sa-Tavan waited outside; even Justice's own recorder could not hear the deposition Justice was forbidden to keep whole. Ka-Leth gave Paul the Cataclysm law, the possession condition and the division of the five offices. He separated the ruling from the later act that would put the order into the machine, and named the point after which the sequence would belong to no human hand.

"Does a finding permit the firing or command it?" Paul asked.

"It commands it."

"By a later hearing?"

"No later hearing may reconsider the same act. Justice rules once, then records what the offices do under the ruling."

Ka-Elun waited last in the forecast, her bare palm against the floor and the five-year sequence above her head. She did not give Paul a diagram. Faith's part had never been written. She recited the measure as it had been taught to her, a prayer whose pauses carried the timing: when to let the first proving stroke fall, how to hear the true return among false noise, how long to wait, and how the returned phase called for the next.

"*When the stone answers in the third measure, and not before, let fall*," she said. "The words are exact. A changed breath is a changed instruction."

Paul checked the reels through the clear window. "Then I will not paraphrase it."

"You may have to understand it. You may never perform it."

"Those are different things."

"Faith has survived by pretending they are not."

From the antechamber we saw Paul return through the broad arch. After Balance he asked Sa-Tavan for a second page and marked every figure by its degree of certainty. After Light he stood under the token-flame and checked the recorder against his notes before he would enter the Justice road again. After Shield he asked Va-Sheva to confirm that the captured case had not left her office's custody; she confirmed it and nothing more. Justice kept him longest. Faith returned through the arch without him, crossed to her separated seat and put her hand to the floor again while he remained alone in the forecast, listening back to the exact pauses of her prayer.

At the fifth return he carried all five, and the recorder carried their voices. Its strap had pulled his collar crooked; five headings filled the open page in his hand and no writing crossed from one to the next: number, sight, threat, law, heard return.

Ka-Leth asked how the five fit. Paul set the machine on the central stone where they could see its reels turn. "First we count the roads out. Any road you cannot close remains open."

Before he began, Paul looked across the five. "Who was the Beast supposed to deter?"

Ka-Dhavar said, "No Outsider was ever to know it existed."

Paul wrote the answer beneath Shield and went on. He made them take the weapon apart in words. Balance said that breaking the deep works broke the city's well and hearth. Light said that burning the marks could not burn the sky from

which the aim could be recovered, nor could the fixed antipode be turned aside or harmlessly spent. Shield said that killing the five bought only the time required for their trained successors to be taken. Evacuation ended against the children, the open desert, the armed ridges and the eye above them.

Sarah stood. "Then use me. By Thursday I can put proof on desks in six countries. My records, my name and my money. A thing the whole world is watching cannot be quietly taken by one service. I will spend everything and go to prison for how I obtained it."

"And on Friday," Ka-Leth said, "your proof gives every state standing to enter the race you began alone. The least scrupulous reaches us first."

Sarah sat.

"There is one man with standing," Sarah said. "He will hear me."

The captured field instrument lay beside the hard case. A Shield warden ran its cable into the torn Faith passage and coupled it to the enemy's line inside the breach. Sarah lifted the handset and spoke a string of figures. The small voice of the outside entered the sealed hearing.

"Roger. Call them off."

The answer was courteous and old. It spoke her name across the line and asked where she was.

"Close enough to feel your men drilling. Call them off."

He said he would not and could not. *What is under the mountain, Sarah?*

She did not answer. The sweep from the desert floor moved through the rock beneath us, blind and tuneless. The Mountain returned five ordered notes and the slower figure under them. Ka-Elun put her hand to the floor. The enemy was sounding the stone, narrowing toward the note by which the deep works answered.

"There," Roger said. "If it were nothing, you would have said so and gone home to your lake. Your silence is the first honest answer I have had. The world is not to be held by one house or one hidden people under one rock. You taught me their law over dinner twenty years ago: *let no one hand hold the whole*. It is the truest thing your mountain ever thought, and it condemns them as surely as it condemns you. Place the thing in ours. Ours is plural. That is not the breaking of their law. It is the keeping of it."

"And when I say no?"

"Then we come regardless. If the hill is empty, France has spent money and goes home. If it is not, France is in a race it will not lose. There are three thousand people in this operation, and armed posts on every ridge, while I do not know.

When I know, there will be fifty thousand, and behind them a hundred. No power turns back a frightened continent after it learns there is a god in a hole it did not elect. This is not a threat. I have only to be patient, to be right and to outlast you. I am two of those three already."

Sarah held the handset against her ear. "Do you know what follows if you continue?"

"I know that whatever is done tonight, you will have done it and not I. Come in out of the sand, Sarah. It is nearly over."

"You cannot divide the whole by drawing borders, Roger. I have given you no answer. You helped bring those men here; whatever we do next, you will have your share in it," Sarah said.

The line died. The sounding sweep crossed the chamber again, and the Mountain answered it.

"There is your negotiation," Sarah said. "Roger Martinez dies; the direction survives him."

Waiting ended at the branch already opened through Faith, eleven days ahead of the central bore. The fact of the Mountain was lost, Ka-Dhavar conceded; the orders to take its operators alive proved that its working was not.

Paul rested both hands on the stone. "Then wreck all of it together. Drown the deep, destroy every mark, kill the succession and bury the instructions. Mean the refusal. Perhaps the working dies in the ruin. Perhaps it costs them a century. Not one harbour burns tonight, and you leave the uncertainty to them instead of giving certainty to the dead."

Ka-Raedin looked at him. "It might hold. No one has run that ruin. My bound is no better than one chance in five that the working dies with us; at least four in five that the state above recovers it without our law."

The five offices remained silent.

No one asked me. My errand ended when I made the finding, and the rope at my wrists stated my standing more plainly than Justice could have done. I wanted Ka-Raedin to close Paul's road. I wanted one office to produce a fact that made the choice clean, and when none did, part of me blamed Paul for having found it. He had done exactly what I brought him there to do.

"One chance remains," Paul said.

Ka-Leth made the offices answer it. Shield could not keep the force above from testing the ruin. Balance could promise no survival if the deep water were lost or fouled. Light would not raise its bound. Under Faith's palm another sounding sweep returned the five notes. "The enemy is learning," Ka-Elun said.

Paul turned to Sarah. "You are the only other person here who knows what a state can recover from a ruin. No better than one in five. What do you call it?"

"A chance," she said. "I spent sixty-six years rebuilding a road from five faint strokes, and the state above has my work. Do not record me as neutral. Do not record that as certainty."

Ka-Leth did not ask Justice aloud. Sa-Tavan uncovered the wet clay and waited.

Ka-Cheryn turned to Sa-Tavan. "Put the numbers in the record and put my name against them. Balance has just returned a ward count of five thousand and eleven. Outside are more than eight thousand millions. Write that I knew the count when I said yes."

Paul spoke before Sa-Tavan lowered the stylus. "My brother's son is called Daniel. He is eleven. I promised to teach him to swim. He has never heard of this Mountain. Put one name beside the larger number."

Paul spoke toward the machine. "One road remained open, and the Mountain did not disprove it. I think you are preparing the worst act human beings have ever done. I cannot swear your fear is false. Leave both statements beside each other."

Only then did Justice rule.

"There it is," Ka-Leth said. "An enemy who comes to destroy the Mountain is Shield's to fight. This enemy comes to take the five, the mechanism and the key. The possession condition is met."

He put his right hand upon the wet clay. "Justice finds the possession condition met. Cataclysm is lawful. Under a finding of this degree it is not permission but command: the five offices will perform their parts, and no later fear or office may reopen this ruling. Let the record show the denial road and the count against us. Let it also show the order."

Sa-Tavan of Justice, who had set my exile into the record with the same hand, took up the clay and set down every word. I stood bound and watched a man I had known write out, calmly, in an unhurried hand, the lawful reasons for the ending of the world.

The charge that killed Ka-Elun came while Sa-Tavan was still pressing the ruling into the wet clay, before the words were dry. The blow was sharper than the others, nearer and above us. A sound came down the Faith passage with none of the grinding of stone on stone in it: stone letting go of stone along a line cut true a hundred generations before any of us. The roof at the passage mouth, where Faith's seat stood nearest of the five, came down over her. Whether the charge had been aimed along that road or merely found it, the hearing could not know.

Shield was moving before the dust, Va-Sheva first, throwing herself and two wardens at the collapse. I was moving too, my bound hands useless. A corner of the same fall caught Paul's leg where he crouched over the machine; he went down, made no sound, and kept the reel turning. We got stone off her, and it was not enough. Ka-Elun of Faith, who had heard the enemy's voice under the Mountain's own, lay in the ruin of the road to her Hall. Her eyes searched the dust until they found me. I put my bound hands against the side of her face. She did not look toward her station or the fallen passage. She looked only at me. She said, so low that only I and the machine in Paul's coat could have caught it, "You should have been Faith." Then she was gone. Va-Maera, the elder Veil of Faith, was dragged living from the same stone, both ears bleeding; for those days she answered no voice and followed no hand. Faith's younger Veil had not received the final instruction or the note beneath the note.

I had watched her rise into her office when I was fifteen and believed my brightness made me good; I watched her leave it under a fallen roof with the outside pouring in through the wound.

And Ka-Raedin of Light, who an hour before had asked me for a thing seen twice by two, stood in the dust of the fallen passage and looked up at the outside light coming down grey through the wound. And he said, to no one, in a voice with the whole of the office gone out of it, "There is my second witness."

Ka-Leth kept his eyes upon Sa-Tavan's wet clay while Ka-Elun was covered.

"The ruling stands," Ka-Leth said when Ka-Elun had been covered. "Sa-Tavan has it in the clay. Faith alone can hear the returning stroke and say the note back, and Faith lies under that stone. We will find the note or die in the search for it. Shield. Raise the Greater Seal."

Ka-Dhavar bowed his head once. "Raise the Seal."

I had never seen the Greater Seal and I pray the earth I never see its like again. It is the Mountain deciding to become solid, gates dropping in sequence down every route from the Hall of Cataclysm to the far Threshold, each one a slab the height of three men falling into a throat cut to hold it, the sound of them going down running away from us into the dark like a giant pulling the world shut behind him. Shield had drilled it for eleven thousand years and never done it in earnest, and the wardens moved through it white and perfect. Va-Sheva stood at the centre of the

sequence calling the gates down in an order she had learned before she could read. It was the most terrible competence I have ever watched, and I loved her for it.

The ward reports later entered on Paul's reels gave what happened below us. Some people ran toward the deep wards where the drills had taught them to shelter. Some ran toward gates already down, beat their hands against the cold slabs and were gathered up by wardens and turned back weeping. A bell that had rung nothing but the hours for a thousand years began ringing a thing that was not the hours. In the common wards, where the evening bread had been rising an hour before, thousands of people heard the warning at the bottom of their prayers arrive as bells, gates and wardens' orders.

There was one gate they held: the last before the outer folds. The warden Va-Sheva had sent toward the torn seam returned alone; Jean-Charles did not. "The sequence has reached us," the gate warden said. Va-Sheva asked how long the slab could hang without fouling the gates behind it. He held up one hand, fingers spread. She spent four of them. At the last she raised her arm to close. Jean-Charles came through the dark at a dead run with a hand's breadth to spare, and the slab fell behind him upon the desert, the enemy and the sky. He was filthy, torn and empty-handed. He did not say where he had been after the warden turned back or what he had done there. He stood in the sudden stone silence, looked at me without smiling, and said, "I am the last thing that will ever come in from out there. Whatever we are now, we are all of it there is going to be."

Va-Sheva laid her hand flat on his chest for the length of one breath, over the heart, the way Shield counts a living man, and said, "Then you are Mountain now, until you die. There is nothing else left to be." Jean-Charles nodded once.

Sarah turned her face from them. She had put the safe-house questions and internal-source annex into the case against him. She had not put proof there. Va-Sheva named him Mountain, and Sarah said nothing.

We went up, after, to where the Hall opens and the Pendulum still swung, to a high slot cut for the Festival light, the one place from which you can see the last of the day. The offices went to it without speaking, the survivors of them, to watch the world they had just chosen to leave.

The Seal had closed every route but not yet the crown. Through it remained a thin wound of evening sky over the desert. Shield drew the stone across. Gold narrowed to a thread, then the stone met stone. The Pendulum swung on in the dark. Around me, no one spoke.

Paul's machine was still turning. I heard the patient reel drawing down the Pendulum and the breaths around it, a small outside thing at work in the sealed Mountain.

Chapter 20

Beast

Paul had not changed the reel. It carried the five Justice rooms, the ruling and the Greater Seal. In the small room behind that Seal, he turned the page of his notebook and asked how long the machine had waited after the law commanded it. Nine days, I told him. Then I gave him the Hall.

The Hall of Cataclysm is not the Hall of Ceremony. I had lived my whole life in the Mountain and never known there was a second hall, lower and older. I came to it with my hands unbound. The free hands meant they had decided to use me.

It lay beneath the deep reserve, past a Shield gate that Ka-Dhavar opened with a thing he wore against his skin and a word he said to no one. The chamber had the inside shape of a bell. The air froze above a warm floor; the Mountain's heat had been gathered and sent down through it. A single shaft fell through the centre, a throat cut beyond the last worked stone. Around it, at the points of a star, stood five raised stations inside shielded embrasures. Polished quartz showed each operator the throat, the falling water and every other pair of hands. The offices had entered by separate roads and doors. Here they stood in one room. The four surviving Keepers occupied four stations. Faith's held a low stone bowl, a listening instrument and no Keeper. Ka-Elun was dead under the fallen roof. Va-Maera breathed in the deep wards with her hearing gone and her mind beyond every voice.

We had been sealed nine days. The wards rationed, the air turned and turned again, and the wounded from the Faith passage lay in rows. Above us the enemy kept drilling.

The Hall had been worked during those nine days. Balance crews had opened channels which had remained packed with clean grease since the previous readiness. Shield had set timber shields before the five embrasures and removed them one at a time to inspect the quartz. Light's survey lamps burned in galleries cut along the walls. At Faith, three low under-priests had brought every listening stone and drum they knew how to use and arranged them around the empty plinth. Their instruments disagreed by widths that would have meant nothing in a prayer and death in a firing.

The workers stayed with their own pieces. A Balance woman with two fingers missing polished a gauge until it reflected her eye. Two Shield wardens tested a blast door, marked its closing time and tested it again. A boy of Light carried Ka-Raedin's tables in a waxed skin and never opened it. No one crossed from one station to another. When a tool was needed across an office line, it was placed on the floor between the star points and collected by a second hand. The four Keepers could see one another.

At Faith the low under-priests knew how to tend the instrument, wind the paper drum, replace a stylus and recite the public answer. Each had been trained toward the office through one narrow duty. None had received the last instruction from Ka-Elun. Va-Maera might have carried it, but Va-Maera lay above us with blood dried inside both ears and no response to her own name.

"We cannot fire it," Ka-Cheryn of Balance said, "and we cannot fail to fire it, and I have been standing here for an hour unable to move for the truth of both." She turned her heavy face to me. "The Beast needs five hands. We have four. The fifth office listens, and no living ear carries its last instruction."

I said, foolishly, that the law had already ruled it.

"The law commands it," she said. "It cannot put the missing hand on the machine."

They taught me the Beast by making me help prepare it. No complete instruction existed in ink. Balance held the water and the heat; Light held the standing-place; Faith held the interval; Shield held the lower gate and the recoil; Justice held the order and the upper gate. Each office kept its own prayers and working tables.

Balance began beside a wall on which five glass columns stood empty. Behind them, sunk into the rock, were five pressure wells and five great pistons. Their

rods passed upward through the roof. Ka-Cheryn laid her palm against the first column. "The water that keeps the people alive does not come here," she said. "Put that in your account before anything else. In the hearing I called them the same water because breaking this quarter breaks the Mountain around both. They do not share a pipe. The Life Reserve has its pipes. This is the war-reserve. If the Beast drinks the cup in the wards, we have built it wrongly."

The war-reserve lay laterally through the Mountain, divided among flooded faults, lined cisterns and pressure chambers. Five risers forced it into a load chamber over the Hall, one load at a time. Ka-Cheryn took me to a gallery in the chamber wall. The room was an eighty-metre cube above the shaft, its floor one black gate. Five floats rested against five scales.

"Five hundred and twelve thousand tonnes when those marks stand level," she said. "One full load. Every one must be whole. The five drops of the readiness calibration are smaller. If the firing proceeds, full loads continue at Faith's interval for five days. When the firing ends, two parts in five of the reserve have fallen. Three remain."

I asked how anything in the Mountain could raise that weight.

Five accumulators surrounded the chamber. Their stone counterweights had been lifted a hand's breadth at a time across years. When Balance released them, the weights drove pistons against the wells and water climbed until the five floats reached one line.

"That raises the first," Ka-Cheryn said. "Nothing raises the first for us. We saved the work."

The deep stroke would raise the next. Water falling through the centre met engineered hot rock miles below the Hall. A governed part of the returning steam and pressure drove the five pistons and lifted the next load during the interval.

The fire was nowhere near the floor on which we stood. Ka-Cheryn took me to one of the five shielded embrasures and made me look through its polished quartz into the shaft. The light failed long before the shaft did. Below the last worked stone it continued for miles, down to the conversion place.

"Were it near," she said, "we should be having no conversation, and this Mountain would be a bowl in the sand with a story attached to it."

She put five small counters on the sill. "These are the calibration drops. They fall into the side chamber and return the answer without opening the deep place. After the fifth, Faith says whether the answer is true. Justice then has a fact on which to rule. No full load falls before that ruling and the final word."

She swept the five counters into her palm. "Afterward the deep place is flooded, broken and cold. The water for another firing remains. The machine to spend it does not. The heat will return when the Earth returns it. I have no useful number for that. Picture a debt which no child alive can inherit because no line of children reaches its due date. There is one firing in this machine. One."

Then she made me feel the first feeder wheel. She set my hands upon the worn iron and opened it less than the width of a nail. Pressure took the wheel. My shoulders struck the rim and I hung on it with my full weight while water climbed a finger in the glass. Ka-Cheryn closed it with one arm after letting me fail against it.

"Balance is given to the patient and the strong," she said. "Never to the clever. You will touch no wheel during the firing. But when you say the word, remember that there is water behind it."

Ka-Raedin spread the survey tables beneath a lamp. A line drawn from any point upon a sphere through its centre reaches the point opposite. Waves leaving the source divide, weaken and follow many roads. A part of that spreading gathers again toward the antipode, smeared by the Earth that carries it. A hand chooses where to stand when it lets go.

That choice had been made before the first gallery was cut. The Mountain stood opposite a far ring where the crust was thin and broken. Light's registers carried more than the standing-place: they held the far arc's own slow accounting, segment by segment, and the offices had watched several of those segments run past the span in which the record said each had failed before. The Beast could never supply the energy of the catastrophe it promised. Its design attempted to release strain already stored there, in ground the Mountain had spent an age persuading itself was overdue.

The ground moved beneath every generation, almost a quarter-metre in a year, thirty paces in a century at the far mark. Light carried that travel through sunk points, sight-lines, sky tables and the equinox ray which entered the Archive shaft once each year. The office stated where the Mountain stood now, what point stood opposite it, and whether the far break still lay inside the convergence.

"The Veil's Chamber taught you to expose an error," Ka-Raedin said. "This is its use. We keep a position true across time."

He needed me before either of us wished it. Nine days of the enemy's patient hammering had shifted or buried half the sunk marks of the upper galleries, the fixed points eleven thousand years of measuring had carried forward without a

break. Ka-Raedin took me down a stair behind the station to the master mark, a plug of dark stone set into the living rock with sight-lines cut away from it in five directions, and showed me that two of the five no longer agreed with the tables. From those marks alone we could no longer say whether the Mountain stood where the record said it stood; without a new measurement, Light could not place the far break inside or outside the firing convergence.

We took the position again from the surviving three lines, the equinox mark and the old tables. I worked in the cold with Ka-Raedin holding the lamp. The three lines closed a small triangle of error. I gave him the standing-place within a pace. The indicator at the master mark returned green. Ka-Raedin read the green mark twice.

Faith's station remained empty. Balance could raise and measure the water. Light had verified the standing-place. Neither office could name when the second load must follow the first.

A stroke returned through the rock in more than one form. The fast body-wave carried news of the deep fracture. Under it came the slow breathing mode of the whole Earth, too small to do the breaking and precise enough to expose whether the source had coupled true. Faith listened to both through the tuned stone. From the echo's shape she judged whether the shattered deep place remained open; from the slow return she judged the phase in which another blow would reinforce the first. A load released late met a wall closing under the weight of the world. A load released early entered rock moving against it. The true interval lay a little beyond twenty minutes and had to be heard afresh after every stroke.

"A Faith is trained from childhood to feel the phase of the prayer as you and I feel a held breath," Ka-Raedin said. "There is no one left who can feel it. Without that ear we cannot time the strokes."

Sarah had been silent since we came down into the cold. She stood with Paul at the edge of the lamplight, two Outsiders in the one place no Outsider had been meant to stand.

"Play me the echo," she said. "On your stone. Let me hear one stroke and its return. I have spent sixty-six years listening to exactly this and calling it my life's work, and I never once knew it had a name, or a hall, or a dead priestess. Play it for me."

Three Keepers objected to an Outsider laying her ear against Faith's stone. Ka-Leth asked whether any of them could supply Faith's answer. No one spoke. He entered the necessity in the wet clay and pointed to the plinth.

The calibration apparatus had a side chamber cut away from the deep interface. Its test water struck the wall of an empty cavity, hard enough to send a regional signal and too weakly coupled to open the hot rock. Ka-Cheryn allotted the first cavity stroke. She set the calibration measure in the small gate and released it. The floor struck the soles of my feet. Sarah held one palm against the tuned stone. The direct pulse crossed the drum. A little beyond twenty minutes, the low return drew itself under it. Her fingers opened against the rock.

"That is it," she said. "That is the tail I cut away from the bomb at Reggane. I heard it at twenty-seven and spent sixty-six years trying to put the five marks and that low line in the same body." She looked at the empty Faith station. "Every succession. Five cavity strokes to prove the machine without opening the deep place. Then one period for the coupled return. I called the return noise because I had no instrument broad enough to see the Earth breathe under the source."

She put both hands on the stone. "I can hear the phase. I can separate your charges from theirs. I cannot promise I know what your priestess knew about this one throat. Give me her words and someone who can hold them against the trace. I can be part of your dead woman."

Sarah could read the live return and distinguish a deep source from the enemy's surface charges. She lacked the local grammar by which Faith separated an open fracture from one already closing.

Paul held the missing local grammar. Ka-Elun had given it to his reel in the forecast room: the complete prayer, the pauses between its clauses, the features of the answer by which Faith delayed or advanced the next stroke. Her office had preserved the instructions in liturgy because a book could be taken. The low under-priests knew the public responses and the names of the marks. Paul had the private continuations in her voice. He set his headphones over one ear, listened to one clause, stopped the reel and asked the under-priest what part of the instrument the words named. By lamplight they returned the prayer to an operating sequence.

The first rehearsal failed. Ka-Cheryn released a second cavity stroke. Sarah called the return at the beginning of a broad rise. Paul called it nine breaths later, on the third small inflection inside the rise. I watched the line cross the drum and could make neither call answer the words Ka-Elun had used.

Paul moved to kneel beside the plinth. His injured leg folded under him and he caught the stone with both hands. “I believe that is broken,” he said through his teeth.

Sarah kept her fingers on the trace. “There are two hundred and six bones in the body, Mr Morgan. Attend to the other two hundred and five.”

He played the clause again. The under-priest marked three features in chalk beside the drawing: the direct return, the closure riding behind it, the slow whole-Earth phase beneath both. Sarah had called the slow rise. Paul had called the closure. The prayer required the interval where the closure still fell while the slow line rose. Their calls had been answers to different questions.

“Give me the words while I have my hand on the stone,” Sarah said. “Do not translate them into a time. Tell me what the dead woman tells you to look for.”

On the third cavity stroke she named the falling edge. Paul gave Ka-Elun’s corresponding clause. I set a line on the drum where the two agreed and carried it across to Balance’s refill indicator. The true window was narrower than either of them had called alone.

Ka-Leth tested that distinction before he allowed the preparation to continue. He sent Sarah behind a screen with an old drill trace, gave Paul a different section of Ka-Elun’s prayer and turned the Faith drum so I could see its line without seeing their hands. Sarah named the three returning features from the trace. Paul named which feature the prayer required. I marked the common interval. Then Ka-Leth exchanged the trace for one containing a surface charge laid over an authentic calibration return. Sarah separated the directions; Paul rejected the charge because its closure clause was absent; I withheld the mark until the lower line arrived.

“If she lies?” Ka-Leth asked.

“Paul’s clause fails to meet her line,” I said.

“If he gives you a false clause?”

“Her physical features do not answer it.”

“If you lie?”

Ka-Cheryn answered from Balance. “Then none of the three will move my water. Faith names a window. The offices still act.”

Ka-Leth made Sa-Tavan enter that answer, then dictated the composite’s authority. “Sarah reports the live return. Paul supplies the recovered instructions. Kailan marks where the two coincide. Sarah and Paul may be heard; neither has a vote. Kailan speaks for Faith. His is the fifth and final assent. Sa-Elian keeps Faith’s

place and repeats the report. Sarah and Sa-Elian may withdraw the interlock together. Neither releases it alone."

Paul asked the under-priest his name. The young man looked toward Justice before answering. "Sa-Elian."

"Your hand may stop this?"

Sa-Elian looked at the dark bar which crossed the Faith linkage. "Until the word."

"And after the word?"

"My hand must take the bar away, if the phase is true."

"Must by law, or must by machinery?"

Ka-Leth said, "By law. Do not make him hide inside the iron."

Sa-Elian swallowed. "By law. The iron does not know the law."

Paul wrote the distinction in his notebook.

"Do you understand what you are asking me to become," I said to Ka-Raedin, my own Keeper, the man whose office I had broken.

"Yes," he said. "You pulled the cord because you saw an error outside your office and could not leave it there. I helped break you for crossing the line. Tonight Faith's line is empty. We need a man who can keep every station in sight while each hand remains its own." He touched the old Light token at his breast. "You were right about the wall. I am sorry. Be the eye, Kailan."

Relief moved through me before the shame. The four Keepers waited. I said yes.

They bound Paul's leg between two split boards. The bone had held, though the joint had swollen against his trouser and would take little weight. He refused the sleeping draught because it would blur Ka-Elun's pauses. Sa-Elian found a low stool for him at Faith's plinth. Sarah cut the swollen cloth away with a small pair of instrument shears, inspected the binding and said that he would keep the leg if he stopped behaving as though owning two made either disposable.

"You gave me a count of two hundred and six," he said. "I inferred redundancy."

"A textual scholar should know that recurrence and redundancy are different things."

Paul conceded this and checked the reel again.

Ka-Leth took the Justice station. Sa-Tavan stood beside him with the wet clay and Paul's recorder. Five bars crossed the linkage in a star. Until the first load passed the Lower Earth Gate, any station could leave its bar in place and keep

the machine still. Afterward Shield could contain what had begun, but no hand could return it.

The three cavity strokes already fired belonged to the calibration sequence. Ka-Cheryn allotted two more. On the fourth, the composite held: Sarah named the returning features, Paul spoke Ka-Elun's corresponding words, and the line I carried to Balance crossed its indicator inside the permitted width. The low phase returned beneath them in the expected shape. Ka-Leth marked the stroke true.

Before the fifth, a runner reached Ka-Dhavar from the upper Faith wards. Blood had dried down one side of his neck. "They are through the first ward," he said. "They have charges inside the passage."

An inner Shield leaf around the Beast-quarter was still travelling through its stone housings. The Greater Seal had closed the lawful roads nine days before; this smaller containment gate crossed the damaged Faith approach inside it. Its last leaf required another interval to seat. If the soldiers reached the machinery before it closed, a charge against a pressure gallery or either central gate could end the firing and the Mountain with it.

Jean-Charles stood at the Hall door with a Shield blade he had no traditional right to carry. He looked at Va-Sheva. She gave him two wardens and the runner. He said something to her in French. She answered by putting her hand once against his chest, over the place where she had counted him alive in the desert. Then he went up toward Faith.

Ka-Cheryn released the fifth cavity stroke. It entered the empty test chamber and sent its narrow signature under the Mountain. Sarah listened with her forehead against the stone. Paul followed Ka-Elun's voice on the reel. The return came true. Faith's low under-priest began the public response and failed on the second word. Paul supplied it. The under-priest finished.

Paul replayed the final private verse twice. On a clean page he marked every word, breath and pause against the drum's divisions. Sa-Elian checked the marks while the voice ran a third time and corrected one breath with a dot of red chalk. Paul wound Ka-Elun's deposition to its leader, placed it in its tin and gave the tin to Sa-Tavan, who sealed it under the Greater Seal. Then Paul threaded a fresh reel for the Hall. The dead Faith's voice left the machine. Her measure remained open beside the live drum.

The readiness calibration ended there, as it had through the whole record: five small strokes and the Earth's low answer. In the wards above, people who had been counting waited for silence.

Ka-Leth required each office to enter what the calibration had established. Balance entered the measured drops whole; Light entered the standing-place true; Shield entered the deep route containable; Faith's composite entered the answer authentic. Justice compared those findings with the Cataclysm ruling and declared its conditions met. It was lawful to prepare the first full load. The ruling did not release it. Every office could still refuse, and the final words had not been spoken.

The ward record Paul later gathered said no one above had been told that a full load was already rising. The Cataclysm ruling had been read through the wards before the Greater Seal fell, and Ka-Elun's death had been named. No messenger had told them whether the four offices could obey. When the fifth cavity return faded, no public response came down the stairwells. The old silence held.

The inner Shield leaf continued to close. The first gunfire I had heard inside the Mountain came down the Faith passage in short hard blows. Dust lifted from the Hall floor. Va-Sheva listened at the wall and gave Ka-Dhavar the distances as the wardens sent them. Jean-Charles and the first party held the turn above the broken prayer room. Then they gave it. They held the next stair. The gate moved across its last hand's breadth.

A warden came through with one arm hanging. Then the runner. Jean-Charles came backward between two others, firing once up the passage. A shot struck him under the ribs; he stayed upright until they had dragged the barricade after him. Ka-Dhavar called the last count. They crossed the threshold. Va-Sheva seized Jean-Charles by the belt and pulled him clear as the outer leaf entered its bed. Stone met stone with a sound in the roots of my teeth. The next charge struck the far face and reached us as a dull pressure.

Jean-Charles lay on his back under the Hall wall. The warden cut his clothes away from the wound and stopped when he saw it. Jean-Charles looked across at Va-Sheva and raised two fingers. She returned one, then crossed the floor and put her palm over his heart, the way Shield counts a living man. He closed his hand once around her wrist. He had died before Balance raised the first full load. The gate he held remained shut.

Balance raised the first full load.

Ka-Cheryn freed the five accumulator teeth in a walking sequence. A blow passed round the Hall as each counterweight took its burden. The stone rods descended too slowly for the eye to follow and the five pressure columns began to rise. Water climbed the glass indicators. Above us, beyond the roof, it entered

the empty load chamber through five risers with a continuous concussion which made the lamps tremble.

The floats did not rise together. The third ran a hand ahead; Ka-Cheryn bled pressure from its well and opened the fifth until the difference closed. A crack appeared in the wax line of the first gauge. Sa-Tavan held a fresh mark beside it while Balance compared the water level against the redundant float behind the column. The glass held true behind the broken wax. She kept filling.

During the rise Ka-Cheryn could still vent the wells and lower the water into the reserve. Justice's upper gate remained shut. Shield's lower gate remained shut. Each office watched the others' hands.

At the upper mark the five floats levelled. Ka-Cheryn shut the feeder gates in order, isolating the load chamber from the reserve. The deep water ceased hammering in the risers. The weight remained above us, five hundred and twelve thousand tonnes held by the Upper Load Gate.

The four Keepers took their stations. Ka-Cheryn wrapped both hands around Balance's interlock. Ka-Raedin fitted the Light token into a slot before him; red passed through its aperture and laid a thin line across the survey mark. Ka-Dhavar turned the Shield key until the indicator for the Lower Earth Gate rose from black to white. Ka-Leth uncovered Justice's final grip.

Sarah stood at Faith's place with one hand on the tuned stone and one around the fifth interlock. Paul sat below the plinth, his injured leg bound straight, the fresh Hall reel turning beside Ka-Elun's marked prayer and the live drum. I stood where all five stations and the four indicator banks entered one sight. I had no lever.

Va-Sheva reported the recoil galleries clear. The wards along the throat and the return passages had been cleared. The inner blast doors were seated. Behind her, Shield had covered Jean-Charles and set him beside the Hall door he had lived long enough to close.

Balance, Light, Shield and Justice gave their assent. Faith's was still mine to give. None moved.

Ka-Cheryn looked at her grip. Ka-Raedin's red line trembled with his hand against the token. At Faith, Sa-Elian's fingers lay under Sarah's around the bar. Ka-Dhavar watched the indicator of the gate he could leave shut. Ka-Leth stood with his mouth slightly open, breathing through it.

I asked what happened if I withheld the final words.

"The order remains," Ka-Leth said. "The first load can be lowered. The enemy continues against the Seal. We stand here under a lawful command which we have failed to execute."

"Can Justice compel me to speak?"

"Justice can punish silence. It cannot turn silence into assent."

Paul said, "Then the word remains yours."

Ka-Leth looked at him. "The ruling is mine."

"The ruling has no throat." Paul touched the recorder. "He does."

Sa-Tavan stopped over the clay. Ka-Leth told him to enter both statements. The stylus moved. No gate moved with it.

Across the Hall, five interlocks remained closed. Sarah and Sa-Elian kept separate hands upon Faith's bar. The water stood in the chambers above us.

I looked toward Va-Sheva. She stood beside the covered body at the Hall wall. She did not nod. She gave me no Shield sign. Both arms hung at her sides.

I wanted one of those hands to open. I kept the five stations in sight.

"Let them fall," I said.

> *In English*
>
> — No.
>
> — Sarah?
>
> — Not *Homo Absconditus*. I was wrong.
>
> — *Coactus*, perhaps.
>
> — No. Compelled men still speak the word. They are *Homo Noxius.*
>
> *In Noxius*
>
> — What did she say?
>
> — She has changed her name for your kind.
>
> — To what?
>
> — I have not yet decided how to translate it. Continue.

In the Hall, Ka-Cheryn pulled Balance's bar first. The heavy linkage withdrew from the centre and exposed one point of the star. She kept her eyes on Paul as she did it.

Ka-Raedin turned his token and drew Light's bar. The red line remained across the centre mark.

Ka-Dhavar pulled Shield's bar with his right hand and kept his left on the lower-gate wheel.

At Faith, Sarah placed her hand over Sa-Elian's. He was shaking hard enough to make the bar ring in its guide. She waited until he looked at her. Together they drew it outward.

Ka-Leth remained last. The other four points stood open around Justice's dark bar. He looked at Sa-Tavan. "Record that Justice had the last mechanical refusal."

Sa-Tavan pressed it into the clay.

Ka-Leth drew the fifth bar. The completed linkage settled with a deep metal knock. Red light passed through Ka-Raedin's token and struck the centre mark. Justice's upper release descended. High above us, the Upper Load Gate began to move.

At first the load showed itself as a white seam along the gate. The seam widened. Water crossed the whole floor of the chamber and entered the throat. Through the quartz I saw a wall moving downward, solid at its centre and torn to vapour at its edges. The fall continued for more than a minute. The Hall leaned under the transfer of its weight. Air struck the observation window and made its thick setting groan.

The Shield indicator counted the head of the load down the shaft. Ka-Dhavar held the Lower Earth Gate open. A second indicator followed the tail. Between them, five hundred and twelve thousand tonnes passed beyond every worked floor of the Mountain. When the head crossed the lower gate, a white tongue of stone withdrew from the dial. The clean abort was gone.

Ka-Dhavar said, "Committed," and Sa-Tavan entered the word.

The deep place received the water.

The floor lifted. Every lamp went out in the same instant. A blow entered my body through the bones of my feet and reached my teeth before the sound came up the shaft. The sound continued after breath had run out of me, a pressure too low for the ear alone. In the darkness the five station indicators burned dull red. Shield's lower-gate sign turned from open to closed as the tail passed and Ka-Dhavar sealed the returning pressure beneath us.

Steam struck the five radial galleries. The Hall filled with the impact of pistons taking work. Around us, Balance's columns began rising again. The first stroke was breaking the hot rock. Its own pressure was lifting the second load.

Above the Hall, the Mountain had counted five readiness strokes and waited. The first full stroke went up through the wards as the forbidden sixth. A sound travelled down the stairwells after it, thousands of voices without a single word I could distinguish.

Va-Sheva later gave Paul's reel the account from the deep wards. At the sixth blow, the public response had begun by habit and broken apart. Some people went to their knees. Others stood. A woman of Faith continued the readiness prayer although its prescribed ending had passed. A child asked whether Faith had counted wrongly. Nobody corrected either of them. The ward lamps swung, water lifted from the ration cups, and the wardens held the doors while the sound from below ran through thousands of bodies.

No seventh count followed in the wards.

Sarah called for light. The under-priest relit the lamp at Faith's drum. The direct return had already scored its hard mark. Behind it the line showed an irregular tail, wider than the cavity strokes. Water had entered new cracks. Sarah laid two fingers on the paper without touching the ink. Paul read Ka-Elun's clause from the marked page. I followed the closure edge against the rising slow phase and Balance's five fill marks.

"The mouth is open," Sarah said. "It is closing from the low side."

The second load rose on steam from the first. One pressure well lagged. Ka-Cheryn opened its return passage and took flow from a well running high, keeping the five columns within the width of her line. She had to fill the chamber, isolate it and report the measure before Faith's true window arrived. The counterweights which had raised the first load remained at the bottom of their strokes. There was no stored work left with which to begin again.

Paul counted Ka-Elun's marked measures in breaths. Sarah watched the live line. I watched her fingers, his mouth, Ka-Cheryn's floats and the Shield indicators. The permitted interval came into view while the fifth float was still below its mark.

"Balance," I said.

"I see it." Ka-Cheryn put both hands on the fifth well. An attendant joined her. The column rose. The low side of the return line began to curl upward.

"Closing," Sarah said.

The float touched the mark. Ka-Cheryn shut the last feeder. "Whole."

Ka-Dhavar opened the Lower Earth Gate. Ka-Leth released the upper sequence already commanded. Sarah spoke the phase. The second load fell.

It entered a wound made by the first and broke it farther. The recoil took one of the quartz windows white for a breath. Behind it I saw nothing of the fall. The lower gate closed behind the tail. Steam returned harder through the five galleries and drove the pistons for the third load. On Faith's paper the echo came back with two torn shoulders where the first had carried one. The open interval narrowed.

At the third interval an enemy charge reached the inner Shield leaf at nearly the same moment as the returning deep echo. Two marks entered Faith's paper together. Sarah called the nearer one false. Paul called the prayer's third feature on the same mark. I saw the Mountain's surface charge arrive from above while the fill indicators still carried the slower motion from below.

"Wait," I said.

Ka-Leth held the upper sequence. The true return rose under the false one four breaths later. Its closure edge was already steep.

"Now," Sarah said.

The third load fell inside the last third of the window. This time the floor moved sideways. Sa-Tavan's clay slid from the Justice desk and Paul caught it against his chest without stopping the Hall reel. A crack ran across the plaster above Balance and ended at the stone. Deep below, the third stroke drove water through the shattered interface and enlarged the source again.

The fourth load filled faster. Pressure from the third stroke struck all five return pistons evenly. Ka-Cheryn stood with her hands free for several breaths before the true phase. She looked at the idle counterweights, the full indicators and the number four turned into Justice's clay.

"This is the throat," she said.

The fourth fall darkened the Hall. The upper chamber emptied. The Lower Earth Gate closed behind it. The whole pentagon of stations shifted against its anchor grooves and returned. A lamp broke at Light. Ka-Raedin held the survey token in its slot while glass fell over his hands. The red line stayed on the centre mark.

The return from below came broad and broken. It showed a deep place held open under water and pressure, its fracture larger than the source that had begun it. Sarah followed the closure edge. Paul had reached the last private verse of Ka-Elun's prayer. The words did not end the firing at five. They returned to the continued measure: hear the road, fill the chamber, let the next load fall inside the true interval.

Steam lifted the last load. Condensation ran from the return galleries in gutters beside the Hall wall, hot enough to smoke in the cold air. Balance's attendants

moved among the five valves with cloth around their hands. One return seal began beating. Ka-Dhavar sent two Shield wardens under its guard to tighten the dogs while the pressure was still upon it. One worked on his knees, each blow of the seal throwing his wrench from the nut; the other caught it and held it on the iron while he turned. The beating shortened and stopped.

The last five floats climbed. Sarah's knees gave under her at Faith's station. Ka-Raedin moved toward her. She struck his reaching hand away and let Paul put his shoulder under her arm without taking her palm from the stone.

"If anyone carries me out of this place before the line is done," she said, "I will come back and kill him after the world ends."

Paul held her upright. "That would require a degree of mobility not presently in evidence."

She laughed once. Blood appeared at one nostril and ran over her mouth. She wiped it on her sleeve.

The fifth measure reached whole. Ka-Cheryn isolated it. No next chamber began to fill. The five return pistons waited at the tops of their strokes.

On the Faith drum the closing edge descended toward the whole-Earth phase. Sarah spoke each feature as it arrived. Paul answered with Ka-Elun's words. Their two accounts met. I carried the point across the five stations. Light's red line held. Shield's lower gate opened. Justice released the final upper sequence.

"Now," I said.

The fifth load fell.

The first four had cut its road. Half a million tonnes entered the shattered, flooded source and opened the mouth through which the firing would continue. The conversion chamber answered with the heat the first four had exposed. Pressure drove into the Earth. The Hall left the soles of my feet. I struck the floor on one shoulder and saw the lamps, wet clay and Paul's recorder above me for a moment before they came down.

The Lower Earth Gate closed behind the load's tail. Return pressure entered the five galleries and drove the pistons into the next lift. Justice's fifth full-load counter settled. The machine admitted a sixth load, and then another, at each true interval.

No one spoke while the lamps were relit. Ka-Leth recovered the wet clay from beneath his station. Sa-Tavan pressed the fifth gate marks into it and set the stylus square beside them. Ka-Cheryn checked the five return valves, one by one. Then

she sat on the warm floor with her back against Balance's station and rested her face in both hands.

Paul checked that his recorder still turned. Its casing was dented where the clay had struck it. I asked why he kept it running through the quiet.

"Because the quiet is part of the act," he said. "A record which keeps the fire and removes the tired old woman on the floor is another kind of lie."

Sarah remained at Faith's stone. The fifth outgoing body-wave needed about one interval to reach the antipode. A new rupture there would need another passage home to the instrument, though the whole-Earth diagnostic phase would return on its own measure. We waited beneath the deep ringing while the sixth load rose.

Sarah touched the last drying line from the fifth stroke. "I spent sixty-six years wanting this room," she said. "I have it now."

The drum drew the diagnostic return first, a slow phase-coherent rise beneath the local noise. Sarah compared its shape with the five previous traces. "The coupling held," she said. "That is the answer your Faith listens for. It confirms the source. It does not tell us what the far crust has done."

We waited again. The enemy continued striking the inner Shield leaf at irregular intervals. One charge arrived through the roof and printed its shallow signature across the drum. Sarah marked it with a short vertical stroke and kept watching.

Then a second line began from another direction. It entered below the range of the enemy charges, climbed through the drum's scale and continued onto the clean paper Paul fed beneath the pen. Sarah took her hand away so that no movement of hers could enter the instrument. The line came from the antipodal quarter. It carried a new source larger than any in her retained record.

"That is observation," she said. "A rupture has begun at the far point. Its first movement exceeds the range of this drum."

The line thickened. Smaller returns appeared beside it, spaced along the far arc. She watched them accumulate before she spoke again.

"What follows is my forecast. Enter it under my name, not the instrument's. A rupture of that size can trigger the neighbouring faults around the ring. Say the whole of it against me first: I have watched a natural shock many times larger than ours ring this planet end to end and start nothing great on the far side of it. A blow the size of ours should do nothing at all. It is the ground it fell on that frightens me. The sea floor will move. Coasts will take the water. If the arc continues, enough fire and ash will enter the air to make a winter first there and later here. I cannot

show the whole of that future on this paper. I can show you that we have opened its first fault."

Sa-Tavan wrote while Paul recorded her. Ka-Leth watched the line leave the drum and cross the spare sheet.

"It is done," Sarah said. She looked at the hand she had taken from Faith's stone. "We have struck the far side of the world."

The far rupture reached our bodies after the ink received it. A slow swell passed under the Hall, lifted the floor and settled. Another followed. Quartz sounded in the five embrasures. The water remaining in Balance's columns climbed their glass and fell. The movement diminished and did not cease.

Paul stopped the recorder he had carried into the Hall. The enemy's next charge came faintly through the sealed roof. Beneath it, the Earth continued its low motion.

The reel stopped. The firing did not. Balance changed crews without closing the reserve feeders. Faith changed hands without surrendering the line. Shield worked the gates until the count ceased to belong to any single waking mind. Every twenty minutes, for days, another full load fell. Each fall reopened the deep road before the weight of the Earth could close it; each return raised the water that followed. When at last Ka-Cheryn shut the feeders, two parts in five of the war-reserve had passed through the throat and three parts remained. The machine below was flooded, broken and cold.

Chapter 21

Vigil

Behind the Greater Seal, Paul set the Hall reel aside and opened the wooden case at his feet. The reels he had made during the Vigil stood in it by day, each tin marked with the hour, the place and the people within hearing. He asked what happened after the firing. Where I was absent, I use those reels and the Shield audit Va-Sheva admitted to this record. The rest I saw.

The enemy above us took four more days to die.

Their charges stopped first. On the second day after the firing, the patient thudding that had been the roof of our lives for a season ended. Shield's listeners heard no drill and no blast. The other sounds continued: long movements through the ground, each arriving from a different quarter. Sarah entered every direction and hour on Faith's drum and refused to call it more than a sequence. Whether the far rupture was setting its neighbours failing, or the whole arc had stood ready and begun, the paper could not tell her. On the fourth day she stood with one palm against the listening stone while a shallow movement passed through it from directly above us.

"The camp is gone," she said. "The ground opened where it stood and closed again. They are under it."

No charge came after that.

Already dead, Jean-Charles did not enter the living count for those first four days. Shield had carried his body out of the Hall after the firing, with the wardens he had brought back through the closing leaf. On the fifth day one of those

wardens found me in the deep. His clothes were stiff with dust and dried blood. He pointed me toward a stretcher and took the other end.

The person on it was a woman from Faith with stone driven through one thigh. Someone had splinted the leg with two pieces of a prayer bench and a strip torn from a shirt. We carried her through a gallery whose floor rose and fell under the long returns. At every movement the warden stopped, put two fingers against her throat and waited for the count to settle. She asked whether the Beast had fired. He told her it had. She asked whether the outside was dead. He said he did not know. When we reached the deep ward, Va-Sheva took the woman's wrist and assigned her to the row nearest the water. She gave us another stretcher.

The rows filled the old instruction hall. The living lay under the five office figures cut into its walls; the dead were carried beyond the last lamp and entered by Justice before they were moved again. Oren worked there with the washing hands. He had carried lamps and tended Light's glass when Sela and I were young. Now he cleaned dust from mouths, changed the cloth beneath broken bodies and spoke each person's name when pain took it away from them. When a return shook grit from the roof, everyone who could raise an arm held a cloth above the face beside them.

Behind us, piped light moved through the unbroken shafts; the air wheels turned; the two waters ran in their separate pipes; heat climbed out of the deep works into the crowded wards. The prayers of my childhood had names for each mercy. In the sealed Mountain they were parts of one machine keeping the people alive.

Balance and Shield fixed the lock at ninety days. The air could be turned and cleaned for that long without an outside intake. The stores could feed us. Shield's old record allowed the world above the same time to finish its convulsing before a high vent was opened by the width of a finger and the first air was drawn into a testing cell. On the ninetieth day they would taste the sky. If the result killed the test life, the Seal would remain and Balance would issue the next count.

Ka-Cheryn read the order once in the largest common ward. A man at the rear asked how long the stores lasted after ninety. She gave the figures by ration: one hundred and twelve days at the first issue, one hundred and forty-six after the oil cut, longer if the sealed mushroom beds took and shorter if the deep wards kept filling. A woman asked what happened when the figures met zero. Ka-Cheryn said, "We reduce the issue before the stores reach that figure." Another voice asked whether the Keepers had known this day would come. Ka-Cheryn looked at the

ninety strokes behind her and said, "They knew enough to leave a count. They did not leave me your answer." The ward took the ration without blessing it.

The order was posted in every ward. Beneath the ninety strokes a kitchen hand had set a bowl on the floor and written the day's ration beside it: lentils, salt fish, one measure of oil for twelve. People stood reading the end of the world while steam from the lentils clouded the lower half of the stone.

The children were moved out of the upper wards first. The break through Faith had severed their warm-air route, and the cold reached their sleeping rooms. The Mountain had drilled that movement at the Festival of Equal Light and called it a game. On the true day the children joined hands by height and went down singing the evacuation order to its festival tune. One little boy lost his place, ran back for a carved animal and was caught by a girl no older than ten, who put the animal inside his robe and sang him into the line again.

At the Festival five hundred hands had made a race of the loaves: warm boards passed from the ovens to the Hall, the prize to the team that spilled none. The same relay now ran through the crowded galleries to the deep wards. Bread, water and rolls of filter cloth travelled hand to hand. Sela stood at a turn where two chains crossed, sending food down one passage and the wounded up another. When I stepped into the way, she pushed a bread-board against my chest.

"You still stop in the middle of a passage as though everybody else were scenery," she said. "Take that to the third ward."

I knew the voice before I knew the face. The corner of her mouth had the same small curve it had carried when we were young in Light. I took the board. By the time I returned she had moved twenty people and had no hand free to greet me.

The water-listeners worked beside the great pipes in shifts. I had passed them all my life: old men and women with one ear against stone, murmuring figures. During the lock each call went to Balance, which set the levels and movement of the Life Reserve against the drink, food and heat of the wards. Every morning Ka-Cheryn struck one mark from the ninety and wrote beside it the day on which each store would fail if its issue continued unchanged.

The air had its listeners too. At the Festival the Ventsingers stood in separate galleries and sent long notes into the stone. A far throat returned each voice; where the returns met they made chords no one had written. In the second week, after Shield divided the cracked passages around Faith, one of those notes came home thin and late. Two voices that belonged beneath it failed to arrive. The singer stopped before the end of the count and called the vent-keepers.

They put me under Sa-Orin, an old keeper who cared where I had stood in the Hall only when my body blocked his wheel. The Ventsinger sounded the note again. Sa-Orin moved his head once, found the missing return and pointed at the fourth wheel.

"When I turn, you turn. If it kicks, let it take skin before you let it take the ward."

The iron moved a hand's breadth and struck back. I put both shoulders into it. Sa-Orin opened a bypass with his foot; stale pressure came through the joint and filled the gallery with the smell of sleeping bodies. Far through the stone, the lost voice climbed into the chord. People in the sealed ward began hammering on their side of the pipe. Sa-Orin held the wheel until their blows settled into the singer's count.

The blocked throat lay behind a cracked wall no warden could enter. Sa-Orin worked it through the sound. He sent the singer up by a tone, closed the second throat and listened to where the return roughened. I turned the wheel by widths he showed between finger and thumb. The first opening brought no change. The second made the far hammering frantic. He closed it at once, crossed to another wheel and made me hold the first against its pressure while he opened the third. The returning note divided, one part clear and one part beating against itself. He used the beat to balance the two passages until the stale breath came out past us and the hammering stopped. A woman on the ward side began singing the festival answer. Other voices joined her one at a time.

When Sa-Orin released the wheel, my palms remained closed around it. He struck my wrists with the wooden handle of his tool. "Open. You keep holding after the work is done and you foul the next turn." The iron had printed its rust and ridges into the blood.

On the third day of that work a boy of Light came down a lamp aperture with one arm bound against his body. The falling roof had crushed the other above the elbow. He tied a guide-line, a lamp-line and the knot that took the rescuers' weight wholly by touch. At Equal Light the attendants had raced at those knots blindfolded, behind their backs or with one hand hidden in the robe. The boy's fingers completed each turn inside the black aperture. He called the line safe and three wardens went down it.

Sela found me after the shift with blood dried across my palms. She washed them at a ration basin and picked iron grit from the split skin with the point of a sewing needle. Her own hands were scored by bread-boards and filter cloth.

"They said you died," she said.

"They were required to."

"I know what was required. I carried your death-loaf." She bound my right palm and began the left. "Do not give me the law of it. You are here and you are bleeding into the clean water."

She called me Kailan. I slept that night beside her in a passage crowded with other sleeping bodies, her back against mine and my bandaged hands held against my chest. In the days after, when our shifts ended together, we found each other. We were frightened and alive, and at first it was only that: two bodies keeping the cold and the dark from entering at the same place.

An old woman who had scolded me as a child kept the salt-fish account. She checked each barrel out of the cold store and checked the empty one back in, rejected a tally written in the wrong hand and made a Keeper wait while she weighed a disputed piece. Her figures remained square.

Somewhere in the fifth week Va-Maera of Faith came partway back. Her hearing was gone. The mind the roof had driven out of reach rose unevenly: she knew faces, lost them, knew the rites and sometimes lost the room in which she spoke them. She learned to watch a speaker's mouth and put two fingers on the speaker's throat when the light was poor.

On the fortieth day the tasting plate came in grey. The plate travelled through two shutters. Its outer face had stood in the sky; Shield closed that shutter before opening the lamped cell on our side, so the film could be seen through glass without sharing its air with a ward. Fine ash covered it from edge to edge.

The ashkeepers came from the shrine of the last burning. They named the colour, rubbed a measure under the cell glass and called for the filter fold prescribed after the grey fall. Kitchens boiled the old cloth in salt water. The bread relay carried it to the high vents, where the keepers packed each frame in the order their liturgy gave: coarse weave, wet wool, ash-char, fine weave. The outer shutters stayed closed. The new filters waited behind them for the ninetieth day.

The ash changed the ninety-day work. Every vent frame had to be opened from within, stripped and repacked before Shield tried the outside. There was too little fine cloth. The loom-halls cut funeral veils from their future issue; the kitchens gave up the charcoal kept for water; the washing hands saved the cleanest wool from the wound beds. The ashkeepers rejected any piece carrying oil because it would close the pores. Their liturgy supplied a short verse for that too. A girl at the packing table recited it while she held each cloth to a lamp and marked the greasy ones with black thread.

On the fiftieth day a woman entered labour in the relocated wards. The news travelled ahead of the child: a child, a child coming. When the girl was born, people left their work by pairs to look through the doorway and returned smiling to their wheels.

Va-Maera came to bless her. She laid two fingers against the infant's throat and felt the small cry before she began, speaking in the flat loud voice of the newly deaf.

"Be welcome into the count of the people; be kept in the dark and found in the light; may the Chains hold their count above you, and the Beast keep to its Hell, all the days that are given you; let every breath be whole—"

She stopped. Her eyes found Va-Sheva and held there. It was the ugliest look I had ever seen.

"Let no one hand hold the whole."

She gave the child back and asked the mother to say the chosen name against her fingers. It belonged to the dark season. Faith's naming table gave its old meaning: one who carries a light through it.

The outside reached us through instruments until the sixtieth day.

The ground came first. Sarah and the surviving hands of Faith marked new ruptures by direction and depth, a ring of failures running out from the far point. On the fortieth day the ash arrived. Temperature rods in the sealed upper galleries then began falling below every winter in Balance's record. The deep wards changed slowly; the outer stone changed by the week.

Va-Elise had carried in the call schedule for Sarah's stations and dead drops. In the early days some answered with a coded pulse meaning that a named hand still stood at its post. The pulse contained no report and allowed no reply. One station missed its hour, then another. Sarah crossed each call sign from the page. By day sixty none remained.

The open frequencies carried voices while transmitters still had power. States asked one another whether the event in the southern desert belonged to them. Soldiers on the ridges called posts which had gone under the ground. A municipal transmitter identified itself as Marseille and directed survivors toward the upper concourse at Saint-Charles. Beneath the repeated instruction, a woman read the names of children carried out of the flooded lower streets and the place where their families could find them. Her voice held through the first hour. In the third she began losing the line of names. Another person took the paper and continued. Then the carrier ceased.

In English

> *This is the World Service emergency bulletin: seismic ruptures are now confirmed along the Pacific, Mediterranean and East African systems; successive sea surges have destroyed or cut off coastal districts from Tokyo and Manila to Mumbai, Rio, Lagos and New York; apocalyptic volcanic eruptions around the Pacific have produced ash clouds which have closed airspace across four continents and surface temperatures are falling; the last combined national reports account for more than one billion people dead and three billion missing, with no current figures from most of the Pacific rim, the Indian subcontinent or the eastern Mediterranean; and anyone still receiving this service is advised to leave coasts, river mouths, damaged dams and unstable masonry, carry water and medicines, write each child's name on their clothing, and expect no organised relief, martial law was—*

— Turn it off.

One harbour called every vessel able to move and ordered it away from the quay before the next water arrived. A tug answered with the number of people already aboard and asked which channel the harbour would keep. The harbour gave a channel and repeated it. The tug called on that channel twelve minutes later. Nothing answered. It called until its engine noise went beneath the carrier.

A hospital transmitted a list of things required at its north entrance: oxygen bottles, diesel, blankets, anyone trained to stop bleeding. The voice added that the south entrance was under water and asked people to stop bringing the injured there. Half an hour later the list began again with oxygen. Sarah wrote the times in the margin. The final transmission was a porter telling an ambulance that the north entrance had also gone and directing it toward a school on higher ground. He gave the street twice. The second giving ended inside the number.

"That thread came through Geneva," Sarah said of another silence. "Geneva is gone, or dark, or drowned."

She marked the time. Afterward she sat with her palm on Faith's stone for the length of four turned glasses. The stylus drew an empty line beneath her hand.

The last recognised French state pulse belonged to the network Roger had answered for in the Hall. Sarah struck its call sign from her page and kept the pen against it.

"Do not join this to the camera," she said. "I never owned that eye or knew its receiver. This was the French liaison inherited from the elder Martinez and carried by his son. I fed Roger crumbs for sixty years and mistook delay for control. By the last call he had a state operation, my grid and enough of the Mountain to ask the right question."

She drew the pen once through the call sign.

"He may have died in Paris before this signal did. I have no grief to spare for him."

When the woman at Marseille lost the names, I cried. Sarah had written seventeen of them before the carrier failed. I copied those names onto a clean strip and could see each child beside the sound of her. Later she set before me the population carried by the frequencies that had gone dark: cities, coasts, countries. I sat with the number until the lamp burned low. No face came to it and no grief of the same size came to me.

Sela found me with the seventeen names. We had shared warmth and work by then. I read the names to her. Then I told her that the millions frightened me less than the seventeen, and that this frightened me more than either. She listened without mending me. When I was done she said, "I admired you before Light lifted you above us. I loved you before I had a name for it. Afterward I learned not to look when anyone could see." She held my face between both hands and kissed me first. After that we spoke, touched and sought one another without waiting for the cold. By the ninetieth day the wards had ceased trying to find one of us without sending for the other.

Ka-Cheryn kept another list beside the stores. I saw it once when I brought her the vent issue: steel; certain salts; the fine wire Light required; medicines that no hand inside the Seal could make. Beside each she had written years or decades. At the bottom one line carried no number: *the seed comes up a little wronger each planting, and the blood with it, and no register I keep will buy that back.* She closed the ledger when my shadow crossed it.

Paul resumed his recorder on the first morning after the firing. I told him I had accepted instruction under a stolen eye, returned, stood where Light needed an eye and given the final assent. He made me separate each act and give its source and hour.

"Give me your acts separately," he said. "Leave the others under their own names."

Sarah heard me and waited until I stopped.

"My grids and stations made the survey possible. My bargains gave France its route. In the Hall I read the return and helped time the strokes. Enter those under my name."

When I tried to answer, she raised one finger.

"And do not leave what we know in my hand alone."

The Keepers carried their accounts through the wards. Ka-Dhavar of Shield spent his free hours among the wounded, changing water and lifting bodies with his wardens. Ka-Raedin stopped entering the deep machinery unless an office duty required him there; he sent for me whenever Light's marks had to be read. Ka-Leth of Justice examined the law night after night, setting beside the ruling every smaller road Paul had offered and every sentence by which Justice had closed it. His clay filled three shelves. None of the tablets altered the command he had given.

Ka-Raedin brought me once to the empty Light station in the Hall. The five station lamps were cold. On his table lay the survey figures I had closed before the firing, my last useful work as a Veil beside the act it enabled. He asked me to verify them again. I found the same triangle, the same standing-place and the same antipode. He took the sheet back without looking at the result.

"An error would be a mercy," he said.

"There is no error."

He folded the sheet on its old creases and returned it to Light's case. "Then do not invent one for me."

Paul kept recording. I asked him once what use an exact record could have after the act had succeeded.

"I cannot repair the killing," he said. "I can keep the record exact. When Balance counts the survivors, that number goes under consequence, not cause."

He changed the reel, marked the day and set the machine turning again.

Va-Sheva ran Shield's survival count and its breach audit together. Once I found her at a closed vent with her palm flat against the iron, in the posture she used to count a living man.

"I am not listening," she said. "This is the one place in the Mountain where no one comes to ask me a question. I require one turned glass."

I left my glass on the floor beside her and went back to the vents.

On the sixty-ninth day she called Sarah, Paul and me to a Shield evidence room. Ka-Leth sat with wet clay. The captured annex was dated before Paul recorded my account and already named three details which, before that date, I had spoken together only to Jean-Charles at the safe house while Va-Elise telephoned from the next room: the three overlaid Shield seals, the soundless room's position beside that door, and the containment maintained until my departure. Its next leaf used Sarah's private name for the northern road. Va-Elise's compartment sheet excluded the air crews, vehicle leads and Amastan's part of the route; Jean-Charles alone had administered the Horizon corridor joined to the French liaison.

Va-Sheva kept the dated paper, the private details and the restricted corridor. She set aside the evidence from the instruction camera; it did not identify Jean-Charles as the source of those details.

Paul turned the Shield reel Va-Sheva had made during the nine days before the firing. Her recorded voice asked, "Do you dispute a mark?"

After the little dead interval in which he had read the leaves, Jean-Charles answered, "No."

"Did you give those details to the French liaison?"

"Yes."

"Did you know they were being assembled into a route toward this Mountain?"

On the reel his breath reached the drum before his answer. "I knew they wanted a route. I told myself the pieces were too small and the desert too large. Enter that exactly."

Ka-Leth entered it.

Shield closed or altered every route his answers confirmed. Justice entered only what the papers and his admission bore: his disclosures had supplied the assault with internal road knowledge. The owner of the camera, his orders and the hour at which he understood remained outside the proof.

At the end Va-Sheva returned the annex to its cloth. Paul let the reel continue. In the dead room preserved upon it, Jean-Charles had stayed seated.

"There is another question," he said.

"Yes."

"Ask it."

She put her palm on the table between them. "Shield has its answer. The other question is mine. This room would put its answer in my hand whether it was true or whether you gave it to stop the asking. I will not take that answer from you here."

He waited. She called the wardens and assigned him to the damaged Faith galleries under the two-hand rule. She did not withdraw the name she had given him at the closing gate. He remained watched and without a road of his own until he died holding the inner leaf against the men his disclosures had helped to bring there.

On the seventy-ninth day the Mountain opened a door held on no map.

Paul, Sarah, Ka-Leth and I were in the deep record passage, carrying the last ground traces from Faith to Justice. A low return moved under us. By then the great motions arrived farther apart and left less ink. This one passed, diminished and almost level. Beneath the passage came the sound of iron leaving a catch. Stone released stone. A counterweight fell through the rock.

We followed the sound to a blank wall. A cut opened in it from floor to lintel. Dust came out along the seam. The wall moved inward by the width of a hand, stopped, then travelled aside under its own weight.

Sarah held her portable drum against the jamb while Ka-Leth examined the exposed iron. A rod disappeared toward the Hall of Cataclysm. Five cuts marked its ratchet; the fifth stood driven home beneath the figure Justice had used for the final count. Behind it a weighted tongue had been held clear of its slot while the stone around it moved above a scored limit. The fifth full stroke had armed the rod. The weeks of ringing had prevented release. When the return fell below the score, the tongue entered and the counterweight dropped. No readiness rite and no unfinished firing could have opened it.

Ka-Leth went white. “There is nothing here,” he said. “I hold the whole record. Every door, every seal, every chamber. This quarter is rock.”

“Your record has a door cut out of it,” Sarah said. “Come and look at the cut.”

Cold air moved through the opening. It smelled of dry metal, old oil and stone which had held no human breath. Beyond the wall a stair descended past our lamps. Ka-Leth stood at its head with his clay in both hands and could not step onto it. Sarah set her instrument against the jamb and called for Shield.

Wardens arrived with Va-Sheva. She made everyone leave the seam, ran a chalk line around the moved stone and sent one person to watch the exposed counterweight while another inspected the stair mouth with a mirror on a rod. A third came carrying the longer lamp. Va-Sheva took it from him and gave it to Paul. No one said the finding in the evidence room.

“Does your record give it a name?” he asked.

Ka-Leth closed both hands over the clay. “My record says it is rock.”

Sarah remained at the threshold while Paul started his machine. Its reels turned beside the black opening.

"Mr Morgan," Sarah said, "you can wait for one competent person."

"The competent people kept no record of this door."

He went first.

I followed. The jamb carried a chisel measure I knew from no office, close-set and exact. Paul's recorder lamp moved down the stair below me. After a long moment, Justice stepped into the opening behind us.

Chapter 22

Clock

The stair ended in a chamber of moving iron.

Paul's lamp found the near wall and a column rising from the floor. Ka-Leth and I stopped on the last step. Sarah came down behind us, breathing hard; she had stayed at the upper seam while Shield examined the release, then followed before we reached the bottom. A low sound passed through the chamber, close to silence, with a faint regular roughness inside it. The wards called that sound the Breath of God. Here it came from teeth passing teeth.

Three old words had been cut beneath the last riser. Ka-Leth could carry each root into present speech: *six*; *cycle*; *archive*. Their order admitted two readings. He entered the marks in his clay and left both open.

Paul had brought paper gloves in his case. He returned them unopened. Ka-Leth carried the clay on which he meant to enter the first catalogue mark. The air smelled of old oil and dry stone. Along the floor, narrow runnels had carried oil away from the machine into covered jars. One jar was half full. A drop gathered above it, lengthened and fell while we watched.

The room could have fitted inside the Hall of Ceremony. Its centre was crowded by wheels: brass, iron, and a white stone polished by contact to the shine of bone. Quick wheels ran at the floor. Each drove a slower one; above them larger wheels climbed into the dark around a square central shaft. I watched one tooth approach its neighbour for so long that my eyes watered before they met.

In the room by the lake Paul had put a copy of it into my hands. He had built the wooden box from a child's set: no larger than a lamp, full of numbered gears. A turn made quickly at the bottom became a movement at the top too small to see. He told me to keep it and study it. Paul's lamp now ran over the same arrangement enlarged until its highest face disappeared beyond the light.

The toy's smallest gear had bruised the end of my thumb when I forced it. For three nights after the interview I turned its handle, marked the upper wheel with ink and waited for the mark to return. It never did before I slept. Paul had laughed when I accused him of giving me a broken thing. He had said that some machines require the operator to die before they finish a turn.

"I gave you this," Paul said.

He went down from the step. His recorder turned at his hip. Sarah followed him to the lower wheels and counted the teeth without touching them. Ka-Leth remained beside me with his clay held against his chest.

"There are recent tool marks," Paul said. He showed us the pale face of an iron pin and the darker oil around its collar. "Someone services the train from the other side of that grate."

The machine gave another low rough breath. Ka-Leth stepped down.

The quick train near the floor belonged to Light. I knew the service marks cut beside each bearing, the oil channels, and the white-stone teeth our millwrights recut when iron would have worn too fast. Generations of Light servants had tended those parts through a low opening from the adjoining works. A grate had kept their lamps below the level at which the upper mechanism could be seen. They heard the Breath, changed a wheel when its measure failed, and returned to the ward.

Two service tablets hung inside the grate. The newest carried Ka-Raedin's seal and the name of a millwright I had passed in Light that week. It recorded a worn pin, the number of the replacement and the measured play after fitting. The older tablet had darkened almost to black. The same columns had been filled by another hand.

The train rose to a broad face set at the height of a man. Its first ring carried twelve divisions. The next carried twelve of those, and the next twelve again. A narrow iron finger stood between two marks on the first ring and was still moving toward the latter.

Sarah read upward. "One step each year. A carry at twelve. The outer rings accumulate what the annual face cannot hold. This is the running count."

At the foot of the column Paul had uncovered five smaller registers. They lay side by side behind iron shutters, disengaged from the moving train. Each held a different fixed reading in the same base of twelve. A sixth shutter stood open over an empty register, with a fork from the firing mechanism poised above it.

He wiped old oil from the first latch. "These are captures. When the reset comes, the fork transfers the standing count into the next register and returns the live faces to their first marks. Five completed counts are held here. The sixth is still on the clock."

"Because our reset has not happened," Sarah said. "Your ninety days are still running."

Ka-Leth came down then. He set his clay on the floor and knelt before the fixed registers. Each shutter carried a Justice seal beneath its oil. None appeared in the record he held.

The upper face gave the years since the last return of the live train to its first mark: a little more than eleven thousand. The five iron registers held the earlier spans. Paul wrote each reading on the back of a paper from his case, converted the twelves, added the live face, and did it again from the beginning. Sarah made her own reckoning on the stone in chalk. Their figures met.

Ka-Leth inspected the catches before he allowed either of them to lift a shutter fully. The seals below the registers were unbroken. Each had been impressed after its figures stopped and enclosed beneath an iron lip which the next capture would drive over it. The oldest impression used a Justice sign none of us had seen. The newest was the old form of Ka-Leth's own office mark, its strokes still present in the one he wore.

Paul held his paper out to me. "The eleven thousand years are here. They are the last line."

Far above us, a narrow shaft went up through the rock. A dim point of sky stood at its end. Around the mouth of the shaft a curved scale had been cut into the stone, its divisions finer than the width of my finger. The service train carried a separate yearly cam toward it.

Sarah lay on her back to sight along the shaft. She shifted twice, asked Paul for his lamp, then sent him to shield every other light in the chamber. A star stood away from the old centre line, close to one of the fine side cuts.

"Light's Watch," I said. Candidates kept that watch once a year and called the star the Eye that never closes. We entered its place against the cuts and used the difference to correct the annual wheel. The upper train and the older side cuts had been withheld from us.

Sarah remained under the shaft. “The star has its own motion, and your axis rolls slowly beneath the sky. The apparent place comes round in about twenty-six thousand years. It cannot tell us by itself how many full rounds have passed. It can tell us whether the mechanical count has put tonight in the right part of the present round.” She asked Paul for his figures and compared them with the cut beside the star. “It has. The live clock, the five locked readings and the sky agree within what this stone can show.”

Paul checked the cut from the other side. “The clock was maintained by hands who could see the lower train. The completed readings were sealed by Justice. The Watch was performed by Light from above. No one office had all three.”

“That does not make fraud impossible,” Sarah said. “It prices it. Whoever forged this bought a lower train, a Justice seal and a Watch from above, and went on paying for them through several circuits of precession. If you wish to call that simpler than the age on the registers, you may. I do not.”

I asked her to say the sum.

She sat up. Chalk dust covered one shoulder of her coat. “Approximately one hundred and forty-five thousand years from the beginning of these registers to tonight. The uncertainty is in hundreds, not tens of thousands.”

Paul turned his paper toward the lamp. The first captured span was much longer than the others. The later registers varied by thousands of years; none matched the eleven thousand on the living face. The sum held.

The number remained on the stone between her and Paul. I remembered the man in the red cap whose pictures Paul had shown me during my first captivity: a canyon opened layer by layer, each low bed older than the one above it. *These immense periods of time baffle the imagination*, the man had said. I had watched his small figure descend through the painted rock while I sat in a world eleven thousand years old.

Under my hand the column turned. The sound travelled upward through the wheels and entered the shaft.

“My oldest city is younger than most of these registers,” Paul said. “When the first people in my history raised walls, this mechanism had already ended one count and begun another.”

Ka-Leth found the firing count. It stood low on the far side of the column, geared to the same buried rod that had opened the stair. The figure from the Cataclysm gravure was cut above it. Its drum had six positions. All six had advanced.

Sarah removed the cover and traced the linkage with the end of her chalk. "The fifth full stroke armed the road above us. The firing advanced this drum at once. The same mechanism held the counterweight while the Earth rang above its score, then released it on the seventy-ninth day when the return fell below the mark. The year faces wait for the ninetieth-day reset. The firing count does not."

Ka-Leth read the drum. "Six."

Paul looked from the six marks to the five fixed registers and the live face. "Five completed cycles, and the sixth firing now. That is the stair inscription. The Archive of the Sixth Cycle."

Ka-Leth turned the drum back toward himself as far as its stop allowed. Each advanced mark had sheared a small copper wire and trapped the broken end beneath the next tooth. Six wire ends lay in order. The last was bright. The others had darkened separately under their covers.

"Each firing opened this circuit once," he said. "No hand returned it."

Around the wall behind the clock were five low doors. Their joints had been invisible under a skin of grey dust. The lamps showed them once the air from our movement disturbed it: five office signs cut near the floor, one sign to each door.

The Sixth Cycle mark appeared again above those doors. Beneath it five hands had been cut around an empty centre. There was no god-sign in the centre and no place prepared for one.

Sarah crossed first to Shield's. It had no handle. A shallow iron tongue stood withdrawn beside the mark, linked through the wall to the counterweight above. She looked at the office signs again.

"Bring them," she said.

Shield cleared the stair again. The Keepers came down with their office hands: Ka-Cheryn of Balance; Ka-Raedin of Light; Ka-Dhavar and Va-Sheva of Shield; Ka-Leth already waiting for Justice. Faith came in the care of Sa-Elian, with Va-Maera between him and a ward servant. She could walk, though the fall had left one side slow, and she read our mouths when the chamber's noise swallowed speech. A Shield warden carried the long lamp and stopped at the six on the drum.

The stone pins had withdrawn from all five doors when the upper counterweight fell. The office hands opened the doors bearing their marks. Behind each lay a room a person had to stoop to enter. The walls were close-written from floor to ceiling. There were no histories and no names. The first line in every room began with the same words in the old technical liturgy: *On the day after Cataclysm, begin.*

The air inside them smelled of stone and nothing else. Tools waited in wall sockets: a plumb line in Balance, shutter gauges in Shield, two voice drums in Faith, a sight and spare star scale in Light, blank clay frames in Justice. Leather and fibre had gone to powder. Stone, metal and the written order remained.

Balance's room gave the order of the sealed springs, the deep fire and the reserve cells. Beside each gate it required a Shield clearance that did not appear on Balance's wall. Its grain issue ended at a Faith sign. The instruction resumed three panels later with quantities for children not yet brought into the wards.

Ka-Cheryn read the first column aloud, then stopped at the ration she had issued on day one: lentils, salt fish, one measure of oil for twelve. The wall continued into the pressure limits she had used through the Vigil. She put her finger beside both. "The day-one issue is here. The pressure limits are here. We followed this table before we knew it existed."

Shield's room began outside those children: how many the deep shelters would carry; which surface mouths must be buried; which inner roads must be opened as the air cleared. Its list of doors used Balance's pressure states in place of dates. A line near the floor ordered the first company of children transferred when Faith gave the word, but the word itself had been omitted.

Ka-Dhavar found the chalk-line procedure Va-Sheva had used at the hidden stair. The old wall gave the same separation of clean and unproved ground, the same two-person watch over an unknown opening, the same rule that no returned company carried a road alone. Va-Sheva read ahead to the surface-mouth list. Several names had survived as dead places in Shield scripture. Their purposes had not.

Faith held the word. Va-Maera sat against the wall while Sa-Elian read the old forms into her sight. The room specified the first gathering, the first burial, the first blessing of a child born after the ash. It gave the words that child was to hear: the Mountain had always stood; the world outside had ended in the first sin; the offices were God's five mercies; the Beast lay bound below. At three points the text broke around an empty Light figure. Faith could teach the day once Light had declared what day it was.

Va-Maera put her fingers against Sa-Elian's throat as he read the blessing. It was the one she had given the child on the fiftieth day, down to the place at which the infant had cried. Her hand fell from his throat. Sa-Elian continued alone until the wall instructed him to teach the children that no earlier gathering had occurred.

Light's room carried the service train we had just seen, the annual Watch and the setting of the live year face. It ordered the old sky readings brought to Justice before the clock could be returned to its first mark. The page on the trueing of the higher faces ended in a Balance quantity. Ka-Raedin put both hands on that gap and called for Ka-Cheryn. She read him the measure from her own room. Neither had known the other possessed half of a single instruction.

Another panel listed the service train by tooth and carry. It matched the divisions Paul had chosen for his toy, except that the last three wheels climbed into periods longer than the whole age of an Outsider life. Paul read them twice and entered them beside the figures he had taken from the faces.

Justice's room was the last. Ka-Leth entered it alone, then called us in. Five ledges ran around its walls for the five office records. The writing ordered each account copied only to its proper ledge. No complete account of the firing was to be assembled. When the last living witness of the previous count died, the sealed ledges were to pass into the permanent liturgy and the new current record was to begin at the first day after Cataclysm.

At the height of Ka-Leth's face one sentence had been cut deeper than the rest: *Where a true cause belongs to a sealed charge, enter the lawful condition and close the cause.*

Below it the wall gave the order for the captured cycle register. Justice was to witness the fixed number, seal the shutter and enter in the public chronology a first year for the new count. The completed register would remain in the hidden room. The public record would begin at one.

He read it twice.

"I ruled the Cataclysm lawful under a record I believed complete," he said. "This wall proves the omission was ordered. The judge before me may have ruled another firing under the same omission. Five times, perhaps."

He touched the deeper sentence. "I used these words without ever reading them."

Ka-Leth entered the live count, the five fixed registers, the stellar check and the drum at six. Paul gave his figures, Sarah their tolerance, and each office identified its reset instruction. Va-Maera marked that the Faith wording was the blessing she knew. Beside these Ka-Leth entered the enquiry he had closed and the silence he had ordered from his Candidate.

"The next Justice may call this tablet holy and never read it," he said. "I can still deny him the clean record. Let him inherit the hole with my hand around its edge."

Va-Sheva stood in the Shield doorway with her palm against its list of surface mouths. “We watched the desert,” she said. “This room held the second Shield order.” She looked at Ka-Dhavar. “Shield cannot seal against Shield.”

The warden set the long lamp down. No one answered her.

Sarah walked once around the five open doors. At Shield she stopped before the list of companies sent toward the surface after an ending. “The roads Amastan inherited,” she said. “Some of them began here.”

Va-Sheva read the line she indicated and entered it on the Shield copy. The warden carried the lamp to the next reader.

Sarah set the six firing marks beside five abrupt scars in southern ice and deep-sea mud, then refused the resemblance as proof. “I cannot tell you which dead centuries are yours. Six firings are already enough.” The offices copied their reset rooms under separate seals; the whole instruction could still be read only by five voices together.

The first line in each of the five rooms was followed by a block of formal words. The office text began after it. Ka-Raedin called the block foundation liturgy. Its marks were older than the technical script and worn smooth where no hand could have reached them. Copies of the same passage ran around the base of the clock, broken by numbers for the teeth and bearings.

Ka-Leth ordered the copies compared before anyone attempted a translation. Sa-Tavan called each stroke from Justice’s room. Ka-Cheryn answered from Balance, Ka-Raedin from Light, Sa-Elian from Faith, and Va-Sheva from Shield. The words agreed. Their small errors moved: three Light strokes sat outside their rows; a reversed hook stood upright in Faith; a Balance gap reappeared four measures later at the clock. A millwright might miss one cut. Five office walls and the clock repeated the displacements in a sequence.

I marked the altered strokes in chalk. They drew a narrow path through the formal words and the maintenance numbers. Paul followed with his paper. The official passage had no speaker. Its verbs were commands, and every act appeared without a hand behind it. The displaced marks supplied a first person.

The path doubled back twice and crossed from the last line of Shield to the first bearing number on the clock. Read by office order, it broke into noise. We followed the calls between the rooms—Balance to Shield, Shield to Faith, Faith to Light, Light to Justice—and the displaced letters held.

We worked from wall to wall. Paul knew how a tongue changes its sounds. The Keepers carried the oldest surviving liturgy by heart. Between them the smuggled line became readable.

Let it be recorded, by the one who will not be recorded elsewhere, that what follows was chosen and not received; that a mind stood behind it; and that the mind was mine.

Sarah read Paul's rendering. "A defence."

"A declaration," Paul said. "We do not know the case yet."

The displaced line continued around the deepest ring of the column. At its end the writer gave one word from the root-tongue. Its strokes read in the same order from either side, ending and beginning on the same upright cut. Paul sounded it once. I sounded it again in the form the Mountain had kept.

Ka-Raedin searched the oldest prayers and found the root used twice: once for the last man to leave a dead house; once for the first man to enter a new one. The later scripture had divided the meanings into separate words. Here they occupied the same figure.

Ravar.

After the name came a short direction. The first line directed its reader to an account set apart and below. The way could not be written.

We searched the base. Shield sounded the stone and found the same depth behind every blow. Balance tested for moving air. Justice measured each joint already visible. Ka-Raedin took the long lamp and read the floor a hand's width at a time.

Paul examined the direction for tool measurements and found none. Sarah tried the clock's sequence—six, five, the captured spans—as positions along the base. They ended at solid stone. Va-Sheva placed wardens at both stairs and forbade anyone to force a cut. Nothing above the floor showed whether the hidden road had opened through any earlier firing; a broken catch could have buried its account for the sixth.

There was a shallow recess beyond the last of the reset rooms. The old liturgy crossed its back and ended at a plain field of stone. Ka-Raedin directed the lamp along each cut, changed the aperture and polished the glass. He found tooling, mineral flecks and the grey skin left by age. He gave the lamp to me.

I began as he had begun. I closed the aperture, set the edge of the beam against the first cut and walked it across the field at a measured rate. Every mark remained

a mark. Ka-Raedin corrected my wrist once. On the third passage he told me the surface held no writing and moved toward the next wall.

Outside, windows admitted weather, glass doubled a face, lamps were carried without measures, and sunlight scattered wherever it pleased. In the recess I moved the lamp past Ka-Raedin's last true position, where Light's examination would have ended. A small pale defect crossed the stone against the movement of the beam. I had no word for what it did. When I returned the lamp to the taught line, it disappeared.

I named the old order under my breath: source, edge, object, cast light, returned light. The pale defect stayed outside it. I opened the aperture. It faded. I narrowed it and moved the lamp sideways. It crossed a second mineral line and stopped.

I showed Ka-Raedin the movement. He named the mineral fleck beside it and three shallow tool strokes. Sarah changed position twice and asked me to begin again. The stone remained stone to her. The defect moved when I lowered the lamp. It approached one cut while the light went away from it. At my direction Sarah passed one finger across the aperture; the pale defect split at its shadow and joined when she withdrew it, though the stone remained blank to her.

Ka-Raedin took the lamp back and reproduced the positions from my hand. He changed eyes and angles with the patience he had used in the Veil's Chamber, then returned it. I asked him to watch the mineral line while I moved the lamp. "Backwards," he said. His finger followed the pale defect across the stone. I lowered my cheek to the floor.

I followed it. The position required my shoulder against the floor and the lamp turned nearly back toward the room. At the end of the movement the pale point entered the final upright stroke of Ravar's name and went out.

Something behind the stone released.

The clock lost one beat and recovered it. Dust lifted from the base in a straight line. Shield drew us back before the seam had widened enough for fingers. Ka-Dhavar watched the buried hinge through a mirror while Ka-Cheryn listened for a change in the service train. Neither called a fault.

A seam opened around the plain field. The slab came toward us on a buried hinge. Cold air moved out of a stair descending below the clock.

Ka-Raedin looked from the open stone to the lamp in my hand. He put his hand on my arm and removed it again.

"What did you see?" Paul asked.

"A pale place that moved the wrong way."

"What made it?"

"I do not know."

I went down before the others. The air grew colder before I reached the bottom. At the bottom was a small room, its walls cut from floor to roof with lines close enough to darken the stone. The first lines carried the same hand as the hidden declaration above. They began with a man alone at the bottom of the world.

At the centre stood a low stone table with an empty lamp socket and no image upon it. This room contained no office mark. Each wall began at the same height and continued around corners without yielding to the divisions above. Paul held his lamp close to the first cuts. Their depth had kept the innermost strokes sharp.

Three fields had been chiselled back to rough stone. Under Ka-Raedin's lamp the blows crossed the old mineral skin and carried a younger skin of their own. Paul measured the surviving intervals: seven quatrains, five and five. The wounds were later than the account and older than any living hand.

I did not call up. After a time Ka-Raedin came down. Paul followed with the recorder, then the offices one by one. Sarah came last. We stood around the walls with our lamps raised, and Paul set a fresh reel in his machine.

"Record the source," Ka-Leth said.

Paul looked at the moving reels. "The machine and the named witnesses for the Clock chamber. The wall for what follows."

He spoke the day, the place below the Clock, the witnesses and the first visible line into the machine. Then Ka-Raedin set the lamp in the central socket. Light spread over the four walls. The cut account began.

Chapter 23

Ravar

A man tells the truth only at the bottom of the world,
where the dark and the deep have taken every ear but his.
I have come down to that bottom, and set the truth down here
by the one whose name no book hereafter is to keep.

This I did not inherit; this I did, with my two hands.
A mind once stood here, and stood well, and now is gone.
We were the summit of the earth, the warm land and the cold;
we had named the lights of heaven, and set them in our songs.

Our dead went down still holding the small things they had loved.
We wrote little; we kept the whole world alive in men,
and in that keeping lay the one flaw of us all.
A house of loyal skulls stays loyal only while they last.

We were losing, and I was the first to say the word.
No war had come: no blade, no siege, no king thrown down;
no one struck us; we were undone by an open door.
For there is a warmer kind of man than we had been,

more numerous, and lower, and their fires never go out;
a people is held not by its walls, nor by its gods,

but by whether its daughters stay, and whose the children are.
And ours would not stay. They went at dusk to the low fires,

to a wider room, where a woman might be more than one thing;
no one drove them, no one carried them; they went in gladness,
and bred into the warm kind, and our summit thinned in theirs.
And we called it goodness, and it was the shape of our end.

My father saw it first, and gave the older answer:
a people never lives by being loved; break them.
He held the metal and the men, the gold to do it,
and had feared longer than I; long fear turns to iron.

I said no: their slaughter would be forever our stain,
and a thing so bloodily won is never worth the winning.
We argued all the years away across one table,
and I won cleanly, and it did no good at all.

Her name was Ithe. I set it against my own rule,
for a record missing the true thing is the lie twice.
She was of my rank, my people, raised as I was raised,
the most complete soul I have known, and never praised.

She carried my child; my father's house would live through her.
An enemy desired my father's road and my line.
They reached her in her sorrow: bought, frightened, or lied to;
and from her mouth drew out the watch on one held pass.

A woman of the old death-craft kept the poisons;
Ithe went to her; the child was ended in a night.
Did she choose it, hating the door-less room I built?
Or was she a blameless lamp they bore through the dark?

Her hand had sent the answer outward from our wall,
but not what hand would take it, nor what death it bore.
I had her own living answer still before me.
I did not ask her, though the answer stood at hand.

The warm and mine might yet lie down in peace and go on.
I'd argue it all again, alone, my father dead,
and change nothing. So I did not ask. I let her stand

guilty; I asked her nothing; and all the world said guilt.

The enemy that used her words reached my father too,
that same night; they killed him in a pass he loved, lightly held.
I stood above his body and said only: you were right.
And under the grief, deep in it, there lay a relief.

It was mine alone: the war he wanted died with him.
I had Ithe put to death. I gave the word, and watched.
I told myself I killed the guilt. I killed the question.
For the dead cannot be asked; I had chosen not to.

So I turned to the one I could still reach: the craft-woman;
I burned her, and it warmed me; we could not let this go.
Then every woman of that craft, in every valley,
I took and burned, and set the first fire in her name.

You cannot burn a knowing from the world; it is taught again.
Another woman learns it, another fire, another year.
What cannot be destroyed may still be broken apart,
and kept so that no one hand may hold the whole again.

He was dead, and all he held came to me alone:
the metal and the men, the buried knowledge, the estate.
I, who refused his war, held all he would have used,
and I raised no army; an army, in the end, loses.

His answer had been a war. Mine would be a story,
and a story, told long enough, outlasts every army.
I gathered those who knew the stone, the springs, the lights,
and those whose hands could shape the making of hard things.

And each I kept to his one knowing, and no more:
the stone-hand blind to the water, the water to the light,
so the whole stood in no one head a hand could reach,
the law the fire had taught me, laid now in the living work.

And soldiers too, for a work so dear must wall its mouth;
I emptied my father's house, and turned its face to the south.
And I took children. Set that down. It is the worst seed.

A place to outlast its own making must be young,

and peopled it with children told it always had been.
I said that they were saved, and they were; and also this:
they were the first of a new kind of people on the earth,
raised to tend a thing they must never grasp, and kneel to it.

The road south took the better part of a year; I lost them
to the heat, to the sand, to the slow leak of a dead land.
Each loss I set down in a reckoning, and did not mourn.
We passed the last green, the last water mine had drunk.

We passed the last mark of a people, and reached the waste,
a waste beyond the wanting of all things born alive.
A man swallowed whole returns not the one who went down;
the waste gave me back a maker, a task I had not sought.

And someone, truly, had reached into my house and killed;
both things were true. Grief did not invent a single fact,
but taught the wound to speak in sentences, each one true;
and a grief that tells you only true things, you follow.

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‹¢Nəɪσ±[υ§£βλʁɳ‖ðθß×?ξ¿·ζɣðʃ†Ðœ...ɣ¥¤φ¬γÆøм»ʎρʜʏ÷¶ŋƒSØʉ‡
ζ?Øɐɪ•Ð3мxʃŒøʏ»¡ʜNÞʁ«¢υʉ‰£φ¶θγæσ§†...÷·Æ‹ʎρ¤ʟδ‡Ʃ¿ʒɳξπ¬‖ρ
ɳßÞœнÆ[›pλəøŋʔʒξ...þ‡ɲ¡ɪʉʟ›±ʌæ¤Ø‹‰·θυ£ζƒ‖ɣγмŒɐÐNȷ÷ʎ×¢ʁ¶
λ›Nʉнʏ3ʃØʎ[«¥ɪ£·ɐмβ•þæɪ‡œ¿‹†Œφ¬ʒ¤σðɣ?ρ÷υɣɳʌəφ...‖Ðʁ¶Æɳθζ

ɲÐ»‖ζ¬§·ф‰ʏðɪʍσ¡¥±θ¶ʒ£×Œ÷¤ξʌNæʃpðɳγə?«ßβØϚʟ•φʒþʊλ‹Þ[ⁿᵓ
ϰƒζβ‖Æσþ×ʒØɥÐʊ?ɲʍ÷ə...ŋʒ«pð•ʟπøÞ¶ʜðɳθNɔß»ʁρ†ɣ‹¡£¿‡γ¤ΔϚʌ§
‰ʒ‡¿ðȼσœ¤ð›¶ʍʒ»æξþ...θ«[•Þφλ±‖πʏφɪ÷ƒ†ζϰɯß¥ʊβγ?Ϛ‹ʌɐəɣØʟŒʃ
?†ɣ£ƒ§»øʒ¬ßξ¿ʊœæ...[¢ʁπʟϰ×ŒʃɯþɳϚσλ÷ʍ¡±‰¤Ø›ρ‹N¥γðæÆŋ‖ʌʎφф

•σρ¿æφθβɐßϰɪρ·†Ϛ»‹œ£ʏØʁʎÆ«ζ¥ɳʟ¬ʌ?¶±ʍʒɲð‖ξ¡ð×[‡γλ...əŋʒÞ¤
¥γðØ¿§ʌNȼp[ʏβßœ¤ϰ‖əξÞɲ...ʜ¬φʎɥσ‰ʟþƒø·Ϛ†θλʁʔɐɪŒʍ÷ʒ‹ðɳ«•æÆ
ʔʏɣð•¢Ðζœfφß¥ʌŋpπ¡ʒσʟ[æ¤‡ϰɲð»£ρɐ¶·‹ʍ‖ξʃþN‰Œ§λÞÆβʒ×¿əu
ʒ†ζŒ¡øʔθɳ»ʏγ‰φβ¬⌈ɒɥþʒ‹p§¿ɪɲæɳϚʎ×±Ø[£ðπσ...¥ɐ÷ßδʜÐΦ¢υə‡Þ¶

p[Ϛɳƨ÷øφπλ«ðδυ£ʁ¿¡Æʃ‡Ðʌœɛʜ‖¶...§•Nϐß¬ə‹ʒφþɪɲ×ƒ¤ɐρξɣŒʔθγÞ›
·ξʒæÆʌßφ¢ʍ×¬Ϛ±ɪþπ›£ØNəʃp‰§ðγ»ʉσÐρ[ʏ¥«ʒɣβ¤‹ŋʔɐʎ...÷ɲθɳ]ø†
ð‹ʍʜ¤·æρθ±†γɣ×Æ...¿Œʏσ÷ʌ¶ØÞʁ¥ʒʃ‡Ðɲ»§¬əœζßʒ•ʉ£«βɳπɒðλφʎ[ʔ
ɳθæ¶ʃ×ƒ±ð•§¬λʎ‰φ«Þ»ɲɣ›ζ...[ƨɛ÷ØɪϚ‖þ]·ø?Œ‹ξðȼʏ‡ʜ†Æ3¥¡œʌρʁ

The grey stone fed my people; the Earth was the amplifier;
at one far scar, all roads within the globe returned;
and deliberate insertion was possible;
one gift could warm a house and loose the stored world's fire.

And I told myself, in that same bright year, a lie:
that this hand I had learned to lay upon the world
was a hand I would hold still, and never learn to close;
that it would only ever be a thing of defence.

Do not take the building for a wonder; those who came
called it the masonry of God; that is the first lie.
It was labour, and mine: the greatest ever raised,
done by the living, one by one, and it cost their lives.

We learned the work by failing. The first great press we built,
built to prove the deep hand answered, killed its builders.
They died for what none knew: what water, flashed to steam
inside a shut and airless place, will do to men.

A fault beneath a stair took off a hundred in an hour.
A wall let go one night, a shift drowned, and we lost ten years.
We never learned to meter water till enough men died;
and every gain was bought, and I was the one who bought it.

You will want a single number; I have one, for I kept count,

kept it true; the one plain virtue I claim with no lie.
More than forty thousand came down that road while I breathed,
and fewer than a third would climb it back into the day.

Some twenty-seven thousand stayed in the rock they cut,
in flood, in fall, in steam, in the slow grind of the land;
and each is a line in the ledger I keep to this hour.
I built the greatest refuge on a floor made of their bones.

When a chief came white with word of a hundred more lost,
I asked him first whether the work they died on still held.
Then I did the thing that let them work and never rise:
I saw that no one of them could wholly understand.

I stood at the gallery mouth and watched the broken borne out,
and kept my face still, and said nothing, and fixed the drawings.
I watched the hour a chief's love died, and let him cease,
and turned my eyes to the cold work; he went; I stayed.

At every gallery the blind hands met and parted;
the well-man drank beside the gate-man, neither knowing
their water and their iron were one divided hand;
I alone could name the creature beneath their work.

Five works there were, because no one work could bear the whole;
I broke the labour first, and after broke the names;
five heads received five burdens, each beneath my hand,
and none could see the shape their several labours raised.

The first head died with lime set white upon his lungs;
his boy received the keys, the slate, the unfinished sum.
He copied how the old man spat before the outer gate;
within two years the spitting had become a sign.

A clerk brought two slates joined that foretold a fall;
I broke one in his sight and praised his proper silence.
The roof came down three weeks thereafter, with forty men;
I entered each beneath the work that owned his death.

A woman hid her brother when the levy came;
I knew her name; I had eaten once beside their fire.
I sent him to the deepest gallery, her to grain,

and kept their kin thereafter as two separate sums.

I learned to speak of lives as measures, not as names;
the work returned my language colder than I gave it.
A man once begged me for his daughter, and I asked
which gallery; he struck me then, and I was glad.

After a fall, the miners touched the living wall
before descent, to ask the dead within for leave.
I had not taught it. I observed the lost half-hour,
then placed the touching where the shift could be reviewed.

A child once crossed the ground I kept from every foot;
an old man drew her back and said a god slept there.
I needed only emptiness; he gave it breath.
I let his answer live. The child knelt down at once.

‰þ¥÷θØźə£ɐʏʔæÆ…фλʁÐ•ɲıɳÞßıʃi¶ξNπɪʞ«‹ɣ‡›Œδβp‖§φ×нм»ʌfρŋ
ʅ†ɐŋɜнλœγɣπ•±кʕʔðɪß·ja‖ɳp¿φ‹¤þ£ÐÆ¶Nυ‡×ð§÷ɯfɪ¬нʌʃ¢æθ«ø»
×œøργ‖§ʕ¢ʃɲɪζəм…ŋɪ¬ʏжÞʔʌθ‰β¶ʒþʜ‹Øжð÷NɸðƉfpʁ¥‡ʞφʒ£ɣυ±«н
‰ом¶ʜβæ¥ʕ‹»‡ɐßf•φʃ¤ɜəɸλθσŋðɳɣʌʒн¢«¿þ§×ʔʁØÞŒÆʏ‖Nρ·υ;ζð†œe

Þɲ‰ɸþнɳζNɜ·ʁ«əмʌʔʕʌÐ¶œ‡ʏ•æ¡÷‹ŋɣðŒßθξʒʃɸÆʅ¥…»ʞp§υɪ×λ£fø
¤Œδ‹¬ξ¿ρ‰θþʕðŋɜæζ†ɳfʞ×ø¡«мυ•ʁʏʒ‹ʌ¥ʔÆσß¶ɸN‡…ɾəλØ±ʃнʌ‖£
×øɸ•мɳξρ‰þ¤ʌɳ¡ʔœØ»«ðʅÞÐɐπɸ¿‹ßɪλ‖æʏ£Æpɲɣβ†θδʁɜн›υf…Œʌ÷ʒ
ζʏðȼɳ§‰ʕβн£ŋρ×›¶ƒɣʃ«ʒʔ¬·¿ɸʌŒØæγ÷ʃɲ±þɸÐмα¤ɪ•λ‖»‡ʁðNυσœʞ¡

ɸλÆρ¿ə‖θþξ‰ʔʌ¤ðɳʅн›Œ±н«Øpυπ§»æβ÷ɻɜʒðʁ¬σʕÞɪøɣʏ‹†γ¡ɲœ•¢ƒ
мŋ‰»‹ʁɐ÷ɪʔα¤σʌρ£æÆ‡±φ×нɜλ¡ŋɪʏÐ$¥π£ðβδÞ¬ʞнɪə…Nυγζθɣ Œ·ʕ«ß
·¢ργφƒ£нNʌʕυʅÆÞ÷ɸœмpßÐσŋδŒ†•π¡ξ«§ɪʏʒ∫Ø¶¥¿øðζ¤ɲ‡ʞβ×‰þʁŋ
•÷¢‖Ð¶øə£‹¤ρƒн›∫ðʌмβ†ζнɪ¬р¿Ælɣθσʒυ¡þɸʔπɪ»ŋ¥ɐ«ØŒɸʒ§œʕŋ‰

βσN‰əɪ·Øʁн»‹Æ÷¶ʔøæʌ†ʏɲÞπ×±«p¬ɸ£ʌ…ŋ§ɣlðδ∫δ¡н›ʒœƒɐŋßÐɸθ•
§ɐʒðÐɣ¿ʁ...‰нøÆʌßØpʅмβƒʒŋþ÷ʏζ·‖±‹›Nɪ¡«¥Œʔ¤ə×ɪʊ¶£»ɸλδɸ¢æ†
æʌ×±ʏƒ¢£ɪθðмŒþʁʕ»¬§ð…ʌʊ¤ʔə‹∫‰pɐɲ·σɸNρ•γ‖β÷πʁн‡ʞøλÆ¶Øɣ
ðʕυ…ø±ʁσ»ɪßɪŋ‰∫¿¶ɣλƒʌʒγ‖‹¬ɸ§πÆʒʔβʌρœþŒ¤ʅpæʁɐ¥†ɲ×£ə•ɸ¢м

¶ʅ‡βɐ‰»ʒøнρ·ʁʔɪŋæpʕ¤ɜʌʃ×ð÷υɸɲɳδσʏζλÐмθ›‖γØþ±ɣ‹œ•ξ¬ɪʌʏн¿
ɪθþßŋ‡ɲσʒʒδ¤p‹æ‰ɐ£¢¬λʏ•÷ʌ×Œɜə±ɸ?¶›«γβÞʊɪʁнðɣøπ…ɸÐʞƒ¿Ø
›θɐ±ŋpØʅ×ξмNj¡βðɳÆʌλɪλɪδσ•ɸ†§ʔ÷ζρπγɯʏÐʒ‖ʕœɣʞæ¿ʒßυŒ·…¤ʁ‡ɸ‰
Œ¬θœнσɪπə‰«ɣɸφʃ±Nʔpʁ÷ʌ¥¤¿ŋβðɳ†þɜ›ρßƒʅÆζʌ§æɛɐ»×ØÞø‹ʞλ‡Ð

A boy once asked where his dead father's father lay.
His mother pointed to a wall I had not opened,
and answered, Underneath; she had been six when brought.
I heard the past begin in one unnecessary mercy.

One actor I had paid to bless the measured grain
forgot my words, and spoke of mercy in the stone.
The mothers kept his phrase; within a year I heard
my hired liar pray it when he thought himself alone.

A daughter born below accused her gathered mother
of lying when she spoke of rain upon her lifted face.
The child defended the dry world that I invented
against its final witness. I did not correct her.

Alone, in the build's worst nights, I carved their first wall:
a murdered brother at the oldest gate of time,
a fleeing man, a woman carried after him through dark.
I carved no name of Ithe there, and thought the lie complete.

Yet every blow fell differently beneath my chisel.
I could not cut her choosing or refusing there.
The stone received the question better than I had;
it kept her mouth half-open. I had closed it once.

One boy who read it asked me: Did the woman choose?
His teacher struck him. I watched dust rise between them.
I had designed the wall to end the outer world;
instead it kept alive the question I had killed.

What names they later gave the killer and the bride,
the lifted hand, the flight, I cannot know or order.
I cut my wound in stone and thought it would obey;
a wound survives its owner by becoming theirs.

At one new prayer I laughed; the kneeling woman heard.
She rose, and would not bend again when I came near.
That night her sleeping-place was empty; none would speak.
I had built silence long before she entered it.

The two great walls I finished under opposed light;

one held the first black rain, one held an unborn dawn.
A mason called the darkness mercy; I struck his face.
At sunset I returned and found a lamp before it.

Why keep a written record, when what I was lay hidden?
More than one answer is true, and the true ones give the lie
to one another. I kept it first in hope to be known:
the least of the reasons, the one that shames me the most.

I had made sure that no soul in the work would ever know
a mind had once been there; and then I could not endure
to vanish in it wholly, and leave no heir behind.
I wanted one to see the hand; and vanity outlasts grief.

And so I hid a road below, closed to my own age,
a door the weapon's waking would unfasten once.
It would be late; the ash would already fill the sky.
I laid my name beneath it, not the reader's path.

I did not know the reader's people, tongue, or god;
I knew the Mountain would not keep one shape forever.
A wall endures by cracking; through some crack, perhaps,
a hand unlike my own hand would reach the buried name.

The end of the long build was the cruellest of all,
and I did it cleanly, for I had grown far too old,
had lost the power to feel the thing that I now spent,
and gone so wholly cold that I did not flinch at it.

The thousands whose hands had cut the great work from the stone
could not go free, bearing its pieces through the world;
for knowledge divided stays safe only while divided,
and hands set free will always seek their fellows out.

What I did to keep them from that meeting made me tremble;
and that I will not write, nor copy, here in the stone.
That account is long, and kept, the worst page that I own;
I have set it well apart; I ask you leave it alone.

Believe this much: I could not loose the whole alive,

and could not make that choice with my own unguarded hand;
I willed it through the hands of others, turned away,
and let them sort the living from the ones who knew.

Some of them went out, sworn hard, and scattered wide, and watched;
and some stayed on to labour deep in the sealed new world,
and these were told they always, always lived below;
and some among them would not go, and never went.

And the great gates shut at last against the waiting world,
but not yet past the final trial I had designed.
Inside them lived a people, several thousand souls:
the work's first seed, their children, and the ageing actors.

On the first grey morning of that newly sealed-in world,
they woke, and rose, and went about their given offices,
and said their prayers, and knelt around the empty forbidden ground
that none of them might ever tread; and I stood there among them.

The children born below knew nothing of a world above them,
that stood above them in the light, nor could be found there;
and they in turn would teach their children so, and hand
the whole lie down; and I watched it draw its first breath.

I stood among them, old and finished, and I did it,
and saw that it was good, in the grey morning light.
God, God forgive me now for everything I have done.
It was the most beautiful thing that I have ever seen:

a whole new world, awoken in the early grey light,
a whole new world at dawn that fully believed itself
to have always been, and never once to have begun.
And yet I would not trust it on faith, but had to see.

¤¬ɥʟυÆ±ð¶þʕ†Øλσəðp«‹•ʅ›¥γ3φNɆŒʔ¢ɪʌ¿нʎ÷ʁÞ‡‖ßθνζœŋɣ3æø§‰

‡γ3φ‹ζ.ʎʁÐ¤¬ɪßξ×Nʌнɥʃπʃ†ðρ»¿±÷[φɲ•3¡Œʔðəмɲ.ŋɐλυ¢Øθœɣβ‖‰

3æξʌмπøÐ$ρ•ʎɛ¿ß¬‡pβн›×ɣ†ʅŒʕ¢ʁðÞ‖ƒNʃ...ʔн‹ɲφþɥ¤±÷ζνυλɐ·σÆθ

φмʃ±ʁƒʅÐðð›υØpɥζɻ¬‖ʟœ†ρÞφ§πɐʒ¢Œɲγλ»¥ɳ3·¤ø¡ʎÞ‡ÆʌγβнׯNξ‰

ɣʕʎ‹ʏðœ¬ɲÞ¡†π‖±¢υβÞŒŋø¿•ζƒəʒ·н‰ʟ¶∫3Ð...λ›ρ‡¥£γæɪØ§ʌφɐß?σ

pʏ¶ɳÐ•ʁ÷ʃʔρθœƒ¬Œσʃøʇʎ±[λмɲн‖Øðɪ×¿υÞɥ›æə¤πφɣ§ß»þʒðн‰«ξ‹

¢±γÞʎ¬æÐʞðŒʁȝ†‰ø¶ɐɳ×ȝπʅɯʃρυœ¿θ¥ðNjØə»σɣŋ...ß«?þ‡βʁφ‖vʃξ
ʜʎσȝɲ÷¿•ʁÞργφ§Njðʁ‖φθмυȝʌØʟʅχβʏœ×«›...¤‡±ƒ‹¥ɪʞπ¬»¢Æ†ζ?‰ɐ

øρÆ¡ɐʃɪʁÞδʌ«ζмφœ‹÷±þÐŋ·ξʜ?π»ʁ£β‡ʃ†υ...ß›ɳφNˬ¶¤ʏØλ×ðϵ‖ʞ¿σɲ
ʃʜ·›ƒ¥•Ø‰ʏø‹ɲ£м§ɣʞß¬λθȝ±Æ¶ʎπ×»ρβ«¿σþ¤?‖ʅɪ¡ð‡Ðɳɐζðʃŋξp
Nð÷¤ɲð¿υ¬Þζʃφ?ʏ±ɳ†pʎ[æȝρʌøȝ¥ʞÐ·ɣσþß»Æ¶...›γмλ•×π¡ʜŋ‰ƒ£‡θ
ð?¡ɪʏ¥ɐυ÷φ»ȝØ₁‖¿γмʁ«ζ¬ʁʅ±¢¶•...ÞøŒ§œ·×ʞÐðσʌNˬ£ȝξŋ†βƒπʃɲəρ

×ßβʞ‖ʁζ‡Nɪɐʏσ¢ργʎȝŋʁ†¡π¿φœ·Æʌʃ¶ξ¥ʃð‹Øʔɪəʾɳρ«þ±•¤£ø¬υɲȝ
×†•ƒ›ʏ¡мŒ‰¬υʌɲ£ξØρσɣNɐ‡φ»ʃʌʁ§ŋʌ¢ðpʃœ[ȝɪγəʁßÐ¤ζ·¥βæʞφÞÆ
ʔðƒ†υγ£βøʁ¿ȝζ±φ×ɪæσß‹ρɪp§ʃɪʁ¥ŋ‰‡φɳ¡•Ævδ÷ʎɣξŒþ›[ə¬θʃÐNмȝ
Æɐ[σə†•÷ʞ¬œʏ±·‖?ɳØ‹ƒмʌŒζ¢æπρʃðɪÞλø‰ɪ¶›βȝÐγ«ʃþ¤ʁ×υʌɣφ‡ȝ

ζæ¬φøʃ£ʁ•ðβ«‖pγȝN...ρπλʟ·Þəɪƒ›§‰Ð±ȝÆ¥ʜðθσм¶÷?þŋ¤ʌ¢ʞ†Œɲʅʃ
ɳδπƒ¢ɣφʁθ£•pŒ·þ‡[ȝN×ȝɐφ¥÷¬±¿σɔɣγ...ʃ%‰ζλ?Ð$æʜÆ«м†‹ɲ¶ʃŋξ»›ʃ
ɳðʃφ[ξʁθʃɯ×ʏ...ζ¿ʌυ¤ƒŒρβλNʃ‖¥ȝ†πþ»Þð«Æ?§φ¢‹ÐʎσɪʟɳØȝ£ʞ¶æßγ
ß«‖φʎ‡ɪ¡ø¿Ð¬ξλʏ£ʜ‰ŋ•ɐ?ʌɣÞπδζþβυ·×¤ʟθȝ¢NœφÆəŒмʞɳ÷ƒ†¶pØ›

Before the closing of this writing I shall go,
alone through the mouth, into the ash my hand has made;
I shall look, and not look away, and not return,
for no maker should be kept beside the god he fashioned.

The five will wake tomorrow, each behind his wall;
they will lift the weights, unseal the wells, take up the watch.
I leave no grave below, no relic for their knees;
the world I ended is the only tomb I own.

I stole fire from the gods and made my people deathless;
I bound its keeping to a chain of mortal men.
The knife shall find the liver; Light shall rise again,
and every dying hand shall leave the fire in another.

So here I set it down entire, at the last, and sign:
I was Ravar, last and first, the maker of you all;
my father the outside killed; my child the outside took,
and I condemned the one I loved before I asked.

I chose certainty, and would, so wounded, choose it again.
Go far slower than you mean to, with your cold verdict.
For in the setting-down of all of this, I have come
to say the one thing I built the Mountain never to say.

The fire lay in the Earth; the law outlives my bones;
the hands were many; mine the word that gathered them.
Tomorrow I shall walk the ash and face the deep;
and this is the last name of my making: I am the Beast.

Chapter 24

Whole

Here the ordering hand changes. Paul assembled the account through Ravar's last line: my testimony, Sarah's confession, the live reels, the records of the five offices and the writing on the shrine wall. What follows is mine, written for the outside from what I witnessed and from the reports that later reached Horizon.

We gave Ravar silence in the cold of the shrine, with all that survived of the last wall read and the great clock turning above us. Paul marked the three chiselled fields in his pages and attempted no missing word.

Ka-Raedin turned from Ravar's wall to me as he spoke. "Aye. The Mountain has carried the breach since before any Keeper took office."

"The road opens only after a firing," Sarah said. "Whoever used that chisel came with a surviving five — or under their seals."

"They did not silence Ravar," Paul said. "They edited him."

Ka-Leth looked at the damaged measures. "For safety or obedience. The cuts do not tell us which."

Before we left the wall, I said a thing to Paul I could have said to none of the others. "Do you know what he makes me think of? Your Basquiat. The dinosaur king in the corridor at the house. I cannot tell you why." Paul, who had made me explain every word I gave him, glanced at Ravar's final line. "No. Ra," he said, so quietly I thought the words had escaped him. Then he looked at me. "Now I regret not seeing the painted coffin beneath the ridge."

"The *V* is no mirror. A beam reflected on one at best." I answered.

Ka-Leth gathered his tablets and led us back to Justice's low room. Eleven days remained before the reset shut the five office rooms, the clock and the shrine. We had to test the Beast and place the account.

I asked Va-Sheva to meet me before Justice convened. She came without Ka-Dhavar, and stood while I sat. The child did not yet show beneath Shield's dark cloth. Her hand went once to where it would. I meant to make her explain Jean-Charles, account for him, give me a cause I could place beside Ithe. Before I finished the first sentence, she stopped me.

"You want an account of him. You want it to settle your own." She sat, not close. "I loved you. I contained you to keep you breathing, and I grieved you while I did it. I did not choose a life beside you. You joined those acts and called them one. I could not live inside that."

"And Jean-Charles," I said, because I could not help it. "You know what he did."

"His dying cleaned nothing. The man at the gate is still dead. I chose him." She let the words stand, then rose. "I will carry what I do not know. I will not cut the dead open to manufacture a verdict. Do not make this child your reason. My choice is not yours."

I let her go. I returned to Justice without asking her again.

The five offices gathered in Justice. Ka-Leth set Ravar's wall, the six cycle count and the present firing as three separate claims on wet clay. Paul placed his ordered pages beside them. Sarah laid the old Horizon register on the fifth ledge and kept her hand on it.

"Reverse Horizon," Sarah said. "Preserve the outside account in more than one place and bring it back before another trigger."

Ka-Dhavar put Jean-Charles's field radio between them. "You ask us to give the whole to the hand that found us."

"Give Horizon the cause, the six endings and the duty of return, not the firing craft. The account below opens only after the Beast. If the next warning begins in that stone, the next world is already ash."

Paul objected. "Too clean. Somebody will read that distinction as permission. Write down what was kept back and whose hand kept it, so the next reader can see the shape of the hole. Leave the absence visible."

Va-Maera could not hear the room. Sa-Elian repeated each answer where she could read his mouth, and she wrote her question with one slow finger: *Who keeps the keepers of the warning?*

Sarah read it. "No one. Divide the copies, the money and the return roads. Horizon failed under me while I was alive and watching it. Build from that."

Sela stood against the wall beside the box. Until then she had spoken only when asked to identify a seal. "Who carries it? Not the ruling: the box. Somebody lifts it, walks it out and has to be alive at the far end. Nobody here has said whose back it goes on."

Ka-Dhavar answered from Shield. "Bring an army and Shield closes. Bring a Keeper and it becomes scripture. Bring an Outsider and Justice calls it theft."

Sarah looked at me. "Someone who can be accused of all three."

Ka-Leth ruled. "A warning after the act is a witness. We keep that witness below. A warning that can precede the act must leave under charge to return. Horizon will take the outside account under the seals of the five, preserve it, teach its danger and bring it back before the next trigger. The cause will travel with the warning. Justice will not close it again. Failure begins if the record is first read below."

Before the impressions were made, Paul asked, "If the outside answers the warning, which office receives it?"

No Keeper answered.

Va-Maera wrote once more with her slow finger before the clay had set: *Was any law broken in the firing?*

Ka-Leth read it aloud and answered for Justice. "None."

Five separate impressions closed the ruling. Sarah's hand received no place among them.

Ka-Leth had carried the fourth cycle's closing tablet up with the six-count, and when the impressions were dry he read it, because Justice reads what stands nearest a new ruling. A hand from a cycle whose name we do not hold had ruled that the craft stay divided and the cause be written down whole. It had kept both below.

"Their ruling closed there," Ka-Leth said. "Ours will carry the cause one step farther."

Sarah asked how many of the six had stopped at that same step. Ka-Leth counted the tablets he had brought and gave her the number, which was three.

Before they lifted their hands, the five agreed that the outside account would open with a declaration addressed to Sarah and signed in their common name: *The Mountain*.

Ka-Cheryn would not let Justice close there. She asked whether the thing could simply be taken out. In eleven days the offices tested what could be removed. Flooding the throat returned water to the hot rock; draining the reserve killed the wards; breaking the sighting instruments left the sky; erasing Faith left an answer an Outsider had already recovered. When Shield closed the shared air branch for less than a minute, the lamps dulled and a child began coughing. Nobody proposed the test again.

Ka-Dhavar answered from Shield. "Say a cut existed, and Balance found it tomorrow. Then I stand in the Hall and tell the people that the thing their grandmothers were born to keep is gone, that the offices they entered at twelve have no work left in them, and that the Mountain is a hole in rock with a spring in it. They would not go out. They would find a Keeper who said it was still down there, and follow him, and in a hundred years they would be doing all of this again over an empty chamber."

"We have eleven days of failed tests," Ka-Cheryn said. "I will enter those. The enquiry stays open."

One fragment of the firing craft stood outside its office. Ka-Elun was dead. The roof had left Va-Maera deaf and broken in the body, but alive; Paul alone had heard the missing criterion during the firing, the note beneath the note by which Faith distinguished a true return from a counterfeit. In the room of Faith he faced her and spoke each interval while she held two fingers against his throat. She stopped him, corrected the third mark from memory, and made him begin again.

When they finished, Va-Maera pressed his fingers to the side of her neck and spoke the sequence back. She could never hear it again. She could teach a hearing Veil what to wait for and how to know a false answer. Paul returned the fragment inward, to the surviving mind of Faith. Sarah's copy withheld the measures needed to reproduce the firing, named the exclusion and carried the warning. Ravar's damaged fields remained in it.

Va-Maera asked for a child of Faith with an undamaged ear. A girl came from the wards, still wearing the grey wrap issued after the roof-fall. Paul sounded two returns into a small bronze bowl: one true, one fractionally short. The girl chose the wrong one. Va-Maera made no sign of disappointment. She placed the

girl's fingers at Paul's throat, then at her own, and began with breath, pulse and vibration. The lesson continued after we left.

"I told you our women were freer than yours," I said to Paul. "When we spoke of Eve. I was wrong. I counted the women who could command me. Their rank told me nothing about who could choose a lover, bear a child or refuse to bear one."

"You asked who wrote our gospel," he said. "The prayer those mothers kept came from the actor when he forgot his lines. Ravar did not write it. Then the actor began praying it himself. Why do men fight for their servitude as stubbornly as though it were their salvation?"

"Maera has earned her authority. That girl needs what she is teaching her. Ravar needed women to stay and bear the children who would keep his work alive. I cannot tell you which of our rules he made. The mothers could make prayers of their own and still teach their daughters the life he wanted from them."

I had praised Sheva's refusal for what it had made of me. When she chose Jean-Charles, I went to her for an explanation of who I was to her.

An order can make people want the life it requires of them; their wanting staffs its offices and guards its doors. It rewards obedience with shelter, respect and power over others, until they measure freedom by how far they can rise within it. Their authority is real. To gain more of it, they must become better at keeping others within those same rules. They teach their children to seek it too, wanting them safe and respected. Each advancement gives them more to defend, more to lose by questioning. They can learn to govern other lives without seeing who has determined the terms of their own. What began as a demand upon them becomes what they believe they owe one another.

The outside account could leave on paper and Paul's surviving reels. An inside witness could be cut beside Ravar before the reset made its stair a wall. Ka-Leth and Paul prepared two versions in Justice's stone hand: a bounded record Justice reckoned could be cut in three days, and the complete causal account.

Paul read the short account aloud. "Listen to it," he said. "I have kept the dates and the machinery and somehow left us out. Someone looking for a reason we had no choice could use this. Ravar could have used it." Ka-Leth took the pages and entered the rejected alternative, the five assents and Paul's work at Faith. "These stay in," he said. "This account can name you and let you leave." Paul read the additions. "Yes."

Ka-Dhavar marked the escape line on the floor. Finish the bounded text and Shield would bring Paul out. “If you stay longer, cross when I call you,” he said. “Leave the tools.” No office asked for more.

Paul stood over the two sets of pages for a long time. At last he put the bounded version into my hands. “Keep that road open,” he said. “I have not chosen yet.”

He told me he was afraid. He told me of the narrow flat full of books he had meant to see again; of his brother’s son Daniel, whom he had promised to teach to swim; of a Thursday game of chess with Urs, left standing on the board since March, which both men had been losing on purpose for a year. He did not want to die in a cold room at the bottom of the world. He said this without shame, and made me promise that no account would call the fear a test he had passed.

I told him I wanted him to take the shorter road. I told him the future reader was hypothetical and Paul was not; that we had already killed the world for abstractions; that no record could earn another body. He thanked me for making it difficult.

Before the first day ended he began the complete wall. Sa-Tavan cut beside him from the agreed pages and corrected his grip on the chisel. I read the finished lines back while Paul checked them against his copy.

On the fourth night I found him asleep against Ravar’s first wall, the chisel still closed in his hand. On the fifth he asked Sela to describe the ward at day forty because his reel had failed under the stone-fall. On the sixth, the skin split across his thumb and Sarah bound it. On the seventh he spent three hours recutting one line after discovering that *we could not stop* had replaced *we did not stop*. “*Could not* is already pleading for us,” he said. “The wall gets *did not*.”

On the eighth, Ka-Dhavar came with the route open and his hand on the marked line. Paul stopped. He washed the stone dust from his face, ate the bread Sela had brought and walked as far as the line. “The wall already records the firing and our parts in it,” I told him. “The rest is in your pages. Leave it there.”

“I want it here too,” he said.

He returned to the wall. By the last day his hands shook too badly to hold the pages, so I turned them for him. The offices came down at the hour Balance had fixed. “Put it down. You can still come,” Ka-Dhavar said. Paul looked at the open road. “I know.” He set the final strokes while the counterweight began to move.

The final passage was his own name. He first cut it smaller than the others, then recut it at the same depth as mine.

I took my place beside Ka-Dhavar because Paul asked it of me. At the house by the lake he had asked me to take him into the Mountain; I had warned him I

could not answer for what it would do with an outsider who saw its whole. Now, through the narrowing gap, he put his hand flat against mine as Va-Sheva counts a living man.

"Get it to Sarah," he said. "All of it. Do not let them tidy me out."

Then the stone met the stone. Paul was alone with the account in the dark. The counterweight continued through the walls. Above us the reset opened water to the lower wards, drew air through the sealed city and returned the year faces to their first marks. The five office doors closed. The road to Ravar disappeared. The Mountain kept Paul.

The sound travelled upward after the door vanished: weights taking load, distant water, five shutters seating one after another. In the wards people cheered when the air strengthened. A woman brought her newborn into the corridor and held him toward the returning lamps. Sa-Elian began the first-day blessing. Va-Maera stood beside him, reading his mouth, and did not stop him.

Ka-Leth carried the tablets from Justice into the permanent record. By sunset a lamp had been placed before the sealed Archive road. Nobody ordered it.

I wanted to tear it down. Ka-Leth stopped my hand. "The lamp violates no ruling. Leave it."

We left it burning.

Before Paul took up the chisel, he wrote a dedication on the first leaf of the outside account and gave me the closed box. After the reset I set it before Sarah in the presence of the five offices. She opened it and showed me the dedication.

> *To Sarah Blackwood.*
> *You entered because we could not keep you out.*
> *You leave because we have chosen to let you go.*
> *Between those two acts lies the peace of our kinds.*

Sarah waited until all five seals were back on the box. Then she called me to the record table and put the retained Horizon register beneath my hand. "My father left me an empire that believed itself to be mines, laboratories, companies, houses and obligations," she said. "I made its hidden part into Horizon. Most of the visible empire is paper in the ash. The hidden part was built to outlive states, and enough of it still answers. Urs holds what remains of movement; this register is the authority he will recognise. I am ninety-three. It requires an heir."

She pushed the register across the stone. "You inherit Horizon, Kailan, and whatever remains of Blackwood with it. Not to possess the Mountain. Preserve

Paul's manuscript outside it. Teach its danger before the world writes over it, and bring it back before the next trigger. If the first warning comes from the stone below, Horizon has failed. That door opens only after the crime."

"Before you answer: my roads brought the state to this Mountain."

"My word answered it."

"Then we enter both names."

"Yes."

I put my hand over hers on the register. "I accept it," I said.

"Naturally," Sarah said. "You have been trying to inherit my empire since the morning you entered my house and began telling me what I had misunderstood." But she left her hand beneath mine a moment longer.

Before we left the lower wards, Ka-Raedin asked whether I would take Light's road again and complete the search for the Keeper's chamber.

"I cannot. I hold the outside account."

"Then Light's chain ends."

"The chamber is inside the great reserve. That much I found at Blackwood. A drowned passage leads to it. What I did not know was what it held: a sphere touched by the pale metal from the Bowl of the Last Prayer. Did you teach yourself to swim?"

He looked once toward Balance's wall.

"Horizon carries the outside chain," I said. "Light's remains yours."

Ka-Raedin wrapped the old gold thread around his hand. "I will find the water."

Sela had already put her pack beside mine at the south doors. Sarah looked from the two packs to us. "I assume she is part of the inheritance."

"No," Sela said. "He is part of mine."

Sarah inclined her head.

Sela tightened the rope around both packs, tested the knot and made me do it again when mine slipped. She would keep the water tally because I forgot to drink when thinking. I would carry Paul's box on the steep ground because her left knee had never healed straight after the fall. If either of us wished to turn back, we would say it before making silence into consent.

Va-Sheva chose to stay, and Justice granted her leave to bear her child in the Mountain. Jean-Charles had died holding its inner gate. She came to the south doors with Ka-Dhavar on one side and Ka-Maera — Va-Maera newly risen as Keeper of Faith — on the other.

Ka-Maera put two fingers against Va-Sheva's throat and her other hand over the life beneath the dark cloth. What she spoke was almost too low for me to hear. I caught the old stations only: the Eye Above named first, the Beast Below answering, the Stone Between; then an appointed boundary, that through which a thing would continue, and mercy not interrupting justice. The order troubled me. I had heard it before, or words close to it, but by then I had spent too many hours in Faith's halls and heard too many prayers to place which one had returned.

Ka-Dhavar drew his Shield blade, laid it flat across both palms and lowered his head. "Shield concurs with Faith."

Va-Sheva looked from Faith to Shield. "I understand."

Then she put her palm once against my chest, counted me among the living and went back into the Mountain between them. I did not follow.

At the first bend she looked back. Her eyes passed me and settled on the light from the open south door falling across the floor. Then the stone took her from sight. I believed Ka-Dhavar had agreed that she and the child must remain within the appointed boundary. I did not understand why he had drawn the blade, or why Va-Sheva had answered without looking at me. I have not written what came after, because I did not witness it. I record the prayer, the blade across his hands and her answer. It is all in the past now, and I will not reread my own story.

Years after we left, the forest began to return. I did not see it rise. The ashkeepers charted it at the high slots, season by season, and their copies came to Horizon late by the old road. The second and fifth years passed over bare ground. Then came a grey-green stain, scrub, and much later something a child could call a tree.

The first report reached us on a strip of cloth carried inside a water jar. The ashkeeper had drawn the old horizon line in charcoal and marked seven shoots where the western ground had held none. Sarah read it twice. She asked whether the scale was reliable, whether the keeper had mistaken salt brush and whether the pump records survived. Two more reports arrived before she let herself believe it.

She did not smile. She put the cloth beside Edward's Horizon register and said, "One useful thing. At last." By then her hands could no longer close the clasps on Paul's box. Sela did it for her.

The reports named buried water, seed-caches and pumps without a state to own them. One damaged ledger reached us stiff with salt. Its last complete entry read: *Opened before the appointed year. Thirty-two at the gate without water. Seed counted after the living.* Beneath it, another hand had entered nineteen names and two births.

A later packet carried three lines copied from a survivor's flour sack: *The woman from the north showed us how to roof the seedlings. She died before the first leaf. Her name was Meriem. Keep it with the well.*

No order travelled intact. A cache opened early and was eaten. One pump drew salt. Two guides disappeared with the seed they carried. Elsewhere people who had never heard Sarah's name found the marked wells and did the work because water and shade were useful.

Faith stood beneath the gravure and said the promise had been kept: God had remembered the forest and made the desert withdraw. The people wept and repeated the promise. Beyond the gravure, human hands carried seed between marked wells.

The outside account passed from Sarah's hand into mine and from mine into divided hands. One keeps the reason, another the sealed route; neither holds the complete return until it is due. Paul's engraving waits until the act is complete. If the next hand first learns the truth there, we have already failed. The box beside me carries his first leaf and the impressions of all five offices.

On the morning we left, I stood beneath the Pendulum in the reconsecrated Hall among people who still knelt before it as the face of God weighing the world. The reset had returned its slow count. A lamp burned below the road that no longer appeared in the wall.

I knelt one last time in the posture my people used to count grief, terror, gratitude and time.

The great disk crossed, turned and crossed again. I rose before it returned.

At the south doors Sarah waited with Paul's box upon an animal. Sela stood beside our packs. A man of Amastan's line had already turned toward the road. Sarah looked once at the Mountain and then at me.

"Well?" she said.

I went out with them. Behind us the Pendulum continued without my witness.

Keep your distance. Live.

The Mountain.